BUSINESS SERVICES SECTOR IN POLAND 2026

REPORT

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FOREWORD

For years, ABSL annual reports guided the business services sector in Poland, accurately predicting structural shifts from the rise of virtualization to the current pivot toward productivity-led growth.

Today, the industry has become a signaling sector for the entire economy. Sitting at the forefront of the AI revolution, it provides a blueprint for how technology is redefining global business. We are witnessing the end of simple headcount expansion and traditional labor arbitrage. The defining metrics of success have shifted to value density, specialized expertise, and capability arbitrage.

This new era is marked by a profound leap in productivity: while employment growth is stabilizing, with a potential decline in the coming years, export value reached a record USD 48.4 billion in 2025.

The global economy has entered a phase of permanent geostrategic fragmentation and macroeconomic volatility. Against this backdrop, Poland remains a premier European destination for business services. Its position as a stable, “friendshoring” hub within the EU and NATO provides a distinct competitive advantage for organizations seeking to relocate advanced operations closer to core markets.

To advance with this premium positioning, leaders must possess the vision to “know the unknown” – anticipating systemic shifts before they fully manifest. The most profound of these is the redesign of work driven by Artificial Intelligence. However, while AI adoption is widespread, strategy is moving significantly faster than execution and actual value capture remains elusive. The sector’s future competitiveness will be determined by how rapidly organizations can bridge this execution gap.

The objective of this report is to equip decision-makers with a comprehensive analysis of these market-shaping trends, offering the insights necessary to drive full-scale operational transformation. We believe the core risk today is no longer external, but internal – it lies in the ability of organizations to adapt their operating models at the pace demanded by technological dynamics.

I invite you to use this analysis as an indispensable compass for future direction and transform our organizations into strategic nodes within global operating models. The next phase, transitioning toward GenBS and AI-augmented operations, requires a decisive shift from legacy structures. I encourage you to apply these insights to convert technological potential into measurable business results. It is time to advance to a model that delivers greater long-term value and cements Poland’s global position.

Mariusz Mulas

Member of the Board & Vice President,
Business Intelligence ABSL Poland

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Poland as a key business services hub

Poland has moved beyond its emerging status in business services and now serves as one of the core European business services hubs. With over **2,179 centers and 500,500 employees,** it accounts for **7.8% of enterprise employment and 6.1% of Poland's GDP.**

Knowledge-intensive services account for 58.2% of the workload. Mid-office functions represent **63.4% of operations,** whereas back-office participation has declined to 33.3%. Trends towards **upskilling and upgrading remain strong.**

In addition, expanding the scope beyond service centers more clearly demonstrates the importance of knowledge-intensive business services (KIBS). It provides a more comprehensive view of the business services industry (BSI).

In 2024, Poland employed approximately 0.92 million people in KIBS and 2.58 million in the broader BSI, making it one of the largest systems in Europe. It means that in Poland, roughly 51% of KIBS employment is delivered through centers, compared to 45% in the EU on average. Centers account for 1/5 of BSI employment, compared with 1/6 in Western Europe.

> Poland combines a full European scale with an above-average level of organizational concentration of KIBS. A larger share of KIBS delivered through specialized centers than in other EU countries indicates a highly structured, scalable Polish system and a strong orientation toward process execution.

> **Productivity is not everything, but in the long run it is almost everything.**
>
> **Paul Krugman**
> Nobel Prize in Economics

The sector is a major export engine and overall productivity driver

In 2025, the sector (by sector, we mean specialized business services centers) generated **USD 48.4 billion in exports,** equal to **36.9% of Poland's commercial services exports.** The key markets include **Germany, the U.S., the UK, the Netherlands, Switzerland, and France.**

Gross value-added (GVA) is not only a size indicator. It shows how much value is generated internally, with increasing GVA per employee indicating progress in the value chain towards greater ownership and higher margins. Estimated **sector GVA is USD 30.1 billion,** with **GVA per worker at USD 65,200,** or **27.9% above Poland's average GDP per worker.** At the same time, **exports per worker** increased to **USD 96,700.**

At this stage of the sector's development, productivity is rising faster than **headcount.**

High innovation intensity vs. aspirations for technological leadership

The sector exhibits high levels of innovation activity relative to Poland's benchmark. 80.4% of surveyed sector companies report innovation activity (2023-2025), compared to 26.6% of service firms in Poland (GUS 2025), indicating a significantly higher level of innovation in the sector.

43.8% of firms report the continuous (permanent) introduction of changes, 21.9% position themselves as initiative-taking leaders, 28.1% act as followers, and 6.2% report no meaningful changes. This **pattern is structurally linked to the location of decision-making and ownership**. Most strategic functions, product ownership, and core R&D are anchored in headquarters outside Poland, which limits the scale of frontier research and globally leading innovation. The number of globally significant dedicated R&D centers remains limited, and only a small share of firms operate at the technological frontier.

> **As a result, the sector at this stage of development excels in process optimization, digital transformation, and service enhancement. However, it has a relatively small footprint in breakthrough innovation and globally leading R&D.**

We are a mature sector already

Despite the growth, we are clearly in a mature phase. Employment increased by **1.8% year-over-year,** or **8,860 FTEs.** Growth remained positive but markedly slower than in previous years. Of the 8,860 new jobs, 3,240 were created by 50 new centers launched in 2025 and Q1 2026. The remainder came from organic growth in centers established before 2025. The inflow of new centers is no longer the primary driver of growth. The peak in the number of new entries occurred a decade ago, and since then, new investments have slowed. **50 centers have been established in 2025 and the end of Q1 2026.**

The growth is more organic, internally driven, and in terms of FTE, at this stage, mostly driven by reinvestments. The new entrants are smaller in FTE terms, more compact, and specialized. In the end, the sector's net turnover, gross value added, export value, and productivity continue to rise. Headcount has grown as well, but at a much lower rate. Maturity does not mean stagnation. There has been a shift from labor scaling to productivity scaling, which we have discussed over the last three years.

The sector's main operating model has shifted from expanding capacity to maximizing value from existing resources. This includes more complex processes, higher value per contract, stronger integration with global operations, and a focus on strengthening capabilities through the acquisition of new skills, thus enabling the ability to efficiently perform the most complex processes. We acknowledge that rising skill requirements at the entry level make it increasingly difficult for juniors to enter the market.

Concentration of growth in Tier 1-2 hubs

Growth is concentrated in the largest sub-national hubs. Warsaw has accelerated and **overtaken Kraków in total FTEs, confirming its position as the sector's primary growth engine.** At the same time, the expansion model has shifted. New investment and capacity growth are now driven primarily by Tier 1 cities, while Tier 2 cities play a supporting role. Lower-tier locations (Tier 3 and Tier 4) attract only limited new activity and are no longer scaling at a meaningful pace in the current phase.

The distribution of activity confirms a multi-city model. Location quotients (LQ) highlight strong concentration in selected hubs, with Kraków **(LQ 3.4),** Wrocław **(2.7),** and Gdańsk **(2.1)** significantly above the national average, while several large cities remain below 1.0. The largest hubs have the greatest ability to serve diverse vertical industries, a capability sought by incoming investors.

> **Technology alone is not enough. You need to convert it into changes in the way you run your business.**
>
> **Erik Brynjolfsson**
> Stanford Institute for Human-Centered AI

> **Every company is a software company. You have to start thinking and operating like a digital company.**
>
> **Satya Nadella**
> CEO Microsoft

AI is changing the economics of the so-called signaling sector

The sector is undergoing a structural shift driven by AI adoption and rising productivity. For many, **business services are perceived as a signaling sector for the potential impact of the AI revolution on the broader economy, as we are at the forefront of it.**

Automation is broadly adopted, with an average declared automation rate of processes within centers at 24.4%, but its impact remains uneven, with a median at 20%. A **clear gap persists between tool deployment and use and full transformation of processes, governance, and operating models.**

AI adoption is already widespread. **84.4% of centers use GenAI, 76.5% use IPA/RPA, 50.8% use predictive analytics, and 35.2% report early use of agentic AI.** The technological trajectory is shifting from **generative AI toward more autonomous, agent-based systems,** increasing both capabilities and uncertainty about potential impact over a longer horizon.

This changes how value is created. Clients increasingly pay for outcomes, value, and creativity. Routine tasks are compressed through automation. Demand is shifting toward roles that combine domain expertise, data, and technology.

The adjustment varies across roles and functions. Some roles are reduced or redefined; others are expanded or newly created. **The net effect will depend on how quickly organizations redesign processes and decision structures, not only on the speed of technology adoption. We expect the sector's total headcount to be compressed by 10 to 15% by 2030, driven by greater value offered to clients and improved productivity.**

Strategy is moving faster than execution

AI- and digital-led transformation is advancing, but execution remains uneven. **80.0% of firms increased spending on automation and digital tools over the last 12 months; 57.0% moved toward higher-value services, and 54.5% accelerated reskilling.** At the same time, productivity gains from AI, both in Poland and globally, remain modest: **39.4% of firms report only moderate improvement; 28.4% say productivity merely keeps pace with rising costs, and only 9.0% achieve gains that clearly exceed cost growth. The gap between ambition and realized performance is now visible.**

At the strategic level, the direction is clear. Organizations are moving toward more integrated, data-, analytics-, and AI-enabled operating models. This is consistent with the broader transformation of operating models. By 2030, **70% of centers expect to operate beyond traditional GBS structures,** with **digital and analytics-led models rising to 49.7%** and **AI-augmented models to 22.3%. GenBS is emerging on the horizon.**

At the operational level, however, progress is slower. **Most firms are still transforming within existing structures.** The shifts observed in the ABSL Transformation Cube confirm the pattern. In Q1 2026, managers assess current maturity at around **3.5 for automation,** compared with **4.7-4.8 for virtualization and personalization.** By 2030, all three dimensions are expected to converge only gradually, at around **5.8-5.9,** indicating **steady evolution rather than rapid disruption.**

Three factors explain this execution gap. First, organizations optimize existing platforms instead of redesigning them end-to-end. Second, integration remains difficult. The main barriers to GenBS transition are **cultural resistance (30.7%), integration with global systems (28.5%),** and **funding/ROI uncertainty (26.3%).** Third, management assumptions remain too incremental relative to the scale of structural change already underway.

The result is an evident mismatch. Firms invest in AI, automation, and reskilling, but the operating model often changes more slowly than the technology stack. This is why the sector shows broad transformation activity without corresponding system-level productivity gains at this stage. The wider use of agentic AI can start the accelerated phase of transformation.

> **The strategic implication is straightforward. Scale alone is no longer enough. The next phase requires stronger execution, deeper process redesign, and faster movement toward data-, analytics-, and AI-enabled operating models – the GenBS we discussed over the last two years. Without that shift, rising costs will erode competitiveness faster than productivity can restore it.**

Poland's position scale achieved, capability still constrained

Poland's business services sector has reached significant scale and functional depth. The sector gradually expanded higher-value activities, with over **65% of centers increasing their service scope** and a growing shift toward knowledge-intensive functions – currently at 58% and mid-office roles (64% share).

At the same time, the growth model has changed. **43.5% of the sector's firms expand within existing markets, while only 5.4% enter new ones,** confirming a shift from geographic expansion to capability deepening. Most centers serve clients in Europe or the US, but their global reach is evident through time-zone advantages.

We have to remember, however, that this expansion takes place within globally integrated structures. Advanced functions are increasingly performed in Poland, but **decision-making, product ownership, and strategic control stay largely outside the country.**

As a result, Poland combines scale and operational capability with a more limited role in shaping global business and technology strategies. **The next phase depends on translating capability into greater decision scope and ownership.** Without this shift, further growth will remain constrained by rising costs and global competition.

Poland as a leading nearshoring location in a fragmenting global economy

Poland is a leading European location for the business sector not only because of its scale and capabilities, but also because of its position in an increasingly fragmented global economy.

The shift toward **nearshoring, friendshoring,** and **allyshoring** is strengthening Poland's role as a trusted location within the EU and NATO frameworks. In an environment shaped by **geostrategic fragmentation,** companies are prioritizing regulatory alignment, political stability, and supply chain resilience over pure cost considerations.

> **Poland is not by any means cheap; at this stage, it offers good value for cost and the ability to service the most complex processes.**

Poland benefits directly from the global reconfiguration. **EU membership, institutional stability, and integration into European value chains** position Poland as a natural destination for the reallocation of complex, knowledge-intensive services closer to core markets.

This creates a structural opportunity. As global delivery models rebalance, Poland can capture a greater share of advanced functions, provided it continues to strengthen capabilities, productivity, and technology integration and aligns the center's operating models accordingly.

Over the past three decades, Poland has achieved one of the most successful economic transformations in Europe and globally, combining sustained growth with structural convergence toward advanced economies. It has emerged as one of the largest economies in the EU and a key contributor to European growth, with strong dynamism across manufacturing industries and services. As a result of its evident success, Poland has recently been invited to the G20 meeting. Despite its location on NATO's Eastern flank, Poland simultaneously offers a **high degree of economic and geopolitical security,** anchored in EU and NATO membership and internal security, reinforcing its position as a stable and reliable location for long-term investment.

Growth will continue. The question is what kind of growth we want to achieve

Looking ahead, the sector will continue to expand, but the form of that expansion will differ materially between our scenarios for 2026-2027. For details, look at the next section of the report.

Throughout all three scenarios, one conclusion remains consistent. The sector's trajectory is no longer determined by how many people it employs, but by the type of work it performs and how effectively it is organized. Growth continues, but it is, to a greater extent, defined by **productivity, complexity,** and **integration,** not by the former holy Grale of headcount expansion.

In the **baseline scenario,** growth remains steady but more selective. External demand is sufficient to support strong export expansion, particularly in knowledge-intensive business services, while employment stabilizes and then gradually declines. Productivity becomes the primary driver of growth, supported by incremental technology adoption and gradual upgrading of service portfolios. Poland strengthens its position through value density.

In the **adverse scenario,** growth becomes constrained by external shocks. Demand weakens; investment slows, and firms shift into defensive mode. Employment declines more visibly, while output per worker continues to rise, largely due to cost pressures and workforce compression. The sector remains resilient in revenue terms, but expansion is uneven and increasingly efficiency-driven rather than demand-driven.

In the **constrained transformation scenario,** demand remains relatively supportive, but the ability to convert it into productivity gains is limited. Barriers to scaling AI and redesigning operating

> **The essence of strategy is choosing what not to do.**
>
> **Michael Porter**
> Harvard Business School

> **We are stubborn on vision, but flexible on details.**
>
> **Jeff Bezos**
> CEO of Amazon & Blue Origin

models slow down transformation. As a result, both exports and output per worker grow at a solid pace, but below potential. Employment declines moderately, reflecting partial adjustment.

The real risk is internal. What can we do about it?

The main risk to the sector is not external. It is not driven by recession, geopolitical fragmentation, or competition from other locations. The core risk lies in the ability to **adapt operating models at the pace required by technological and cost dynamics.**

Although firms are investing in automation, digital tools, and AI, productivity gains are inconsistent and often do not offset rising labor and operating costs. This highlights a structural gap between adopting **technology and transforming operating models.**

As a result, **divergence is growing between firms rather than countries.** Organizations that redesign processes end-to-end and fully integrate technology into their operating models will achieve significant gains. Those who add new tools to existing structures will realize only incremental improvements.

The issue is now one of positioning, not just efficiency. The sector has demonstrated its ability to scale. The next phase depends on translating **capabilities into ownership, integration, and measurable business outcomes.**

This challenge is amplified by Poland's sector's structural position. In many cases, **decision-making, product ownership, and strategic control remain outside Poland,** limiting local leaders' ability to shape operating models directly.

This does not eliminate agency but changes its nature. **Competitive advantage now depends on capturing scope and not simply scaling teams.** Leaders in Poland should focus on owning end-to-end processes, delivering measurable performance improvements, and positioning their operations as essential within global structures.

In practice, this requires moving beyond incremental optimization to achieve **process integration, establish clear accountability for outcomes, and develop domain-specific capabilities that are difficult to replicate elsewhere.** Leaders must also build credibility through consistent delivery, including lower cost-to-serve, shorter cycle times, and reduced operational risk compared to other locations.

> **There is no ambiguity in the strategic direction. We will either remain a highly efficient execution platform or evolve into a model that creates, orchestrates, and captures greater value within global organizations. In the long run, we also have to cooperate with stakeholders to accelerate the birth rate and growth of domestic service providers, speeding their internationalization and scaling.**
>
> **The outcome of this choice will define our sector's long-term competitive position.**

REVIEW OF GLOBAL TRENDS – BUSINESS SERVICES AT THE EDGE OF SYSTEMIC TRANSFORMATION

We operate in an environment marked by heightened uncertainty and unpredictability. The global economy faces multiple simultaneous shocks, creating a poly-crisis scenario without a single dominant driver of change.

The global business services sector has demonstrated resilience and is doing better than most sectors. Nonetheless, it is experiencing structural transformation driven by technological factors such as the exponential growth in AI, demographic challenges leading to talent shortages, environmental constraints, operational challenges such as data management, and growing political and geopolitical fragmentation. This transformation requires a new operating model in which value is driven by coordination, intelligence, ongoing reinvention, and adaptability.

Below are the ten most significant trends, identified through ABSL Business Intelligence (ABSL BI) insights and a review of key industry reports.

1. AI as the Operational Core of Service Delivery

The widespread adoption of AI tools is already evident, yet enterprise-wide scaling remains limited (ABSL, 2025; Deloitte, 2025; SSON, 2025; McKinsey & Company, 2024). What is changing now is not the level of adoption, but the role AI plays in the operating model. **AI is moving into the center of service delivery, not as an overlay, but as the logic that shapes how work is done.**

A shift is visible in how processes are being redesigned. Organizations are no longer optimizing individual tasks; they are **restructuring entire workflows,** compressing decision cycles, reducing handoffs, and embedding intelligence directly into execution. The result is faster throughput, more consistent output, and tighter alignment with business outcomes.

The underlying driver is structural. **Service demand is outpacing workforce capacity.** Declining deployment costs and broader accessibility make AI viable on a scale. However, the primary constraint **is not access to technology, but the ability to integrate it across fragmented systems,** inconsistent data, and unclear ownership structures. Here lies the real boundary.

As a result, the sector is diverging. Firms that achieve integration move into a new category, with AI embedded in operations and compounding benefits over time. Without integration, AI only enhances individual components, leading to stagnation in overall performance and a decline in competitiveness.

2. The AI Productivity Paradox

Despite rising investments in AI, **productivity gains remain uneven and often fall short of expectations** (Deloitte, 2025; PwC, 2025; Brynjolfsson et al., 2023). The expectation that AI will translate directly into productivity improvements is proving incorrect. Investment is rising, and tools are improving, yet outcomes remain inconsistent. **AI does not automatically generate efficiency gains at the system level.** In many cases, it enhances individual tasks without changing how the broader process operates.

The reason is structural. Most organizations deploy AI into workflows that were never designed for it. Legacy processes, layered governance, and fragmented accountability dilute impact. Efficiency gains at the task level fail to scale.

It creates a paradox as organizations invest more but see limited returns. Over time, it becomes a strategic risk as costs rise without corresponding gains in output or value.

Productivity, therefore, becomes conditional. **It depends not on adoption, but on redesign.** Firms able to reconfigure how work is structured, including decision rights, process ownership, and data flows, capture meaningful gains and operational efficiencies. Those that do not transform technology risk persistent inefficiency and a gradual loss of market position.

3. Data and Infrastructure as Challenges

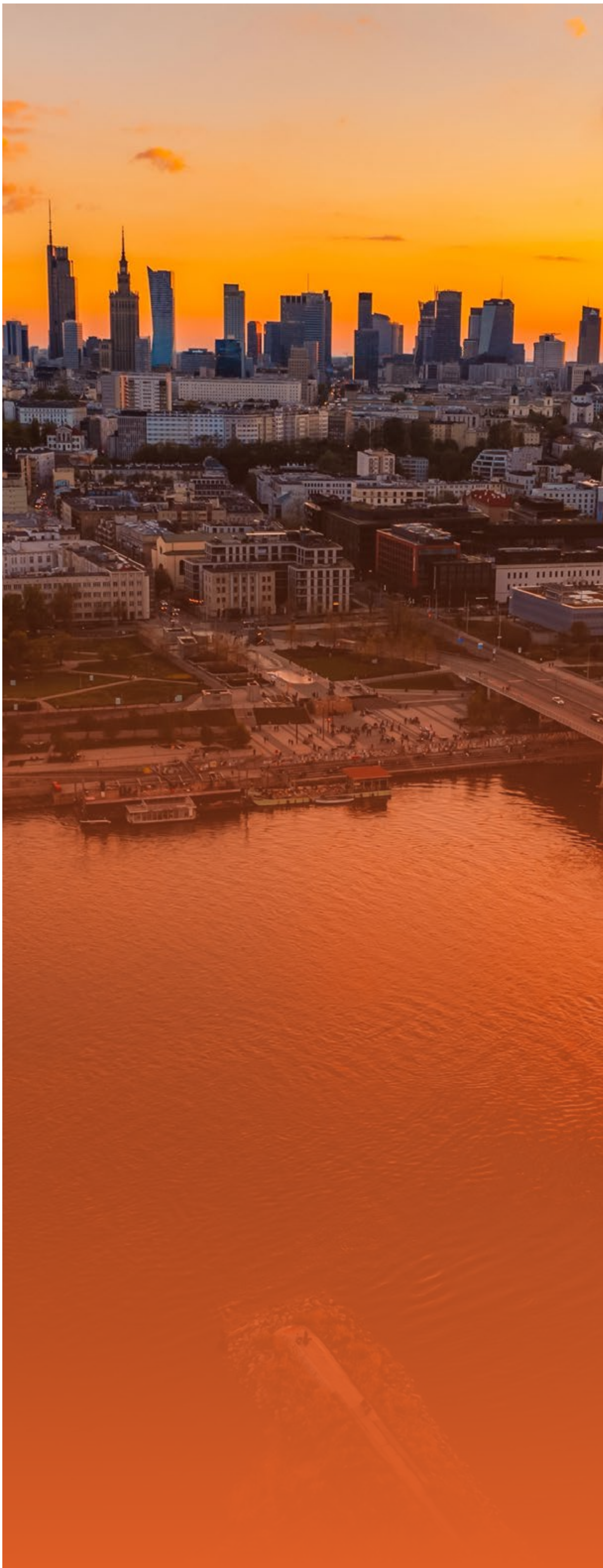
A minority of organizations report high data readiness and fully integrated architectures (Gartner, 2025; Deloitte, 2025).

Data remains fragmented, inconsistent, and difficult to access. Legacy systems persist as architectures have evolved incrementally. Under traditional operating models, these inefficiencies were manageable. The AI era will make them more visible and, in turn, more costly.

Scaling AI requires capabilities that most organizations do not yet have integrated. It requires scaled, efficient data ecosystems and infrastructure capable of supporting continuous, high-intensity computation. Legacy systems, siloed data, and rising computational demands constrain scalability and expose previously hidden structural weaknesses.

Competitive advantage is shifting toward execution. Not the models or algorithms themselves, but the ability to deploy them consistently and at scale within the enterprise matters.

Resolving these constraints accelerates learning and execution. Where they persist, performance remains structurally limited, leading to slower growth, weaker innovation, and a gradual loss of competitiveness.



4. Talent as a Structural Driver

Persistent shortages in AI, data, and digital skills are reported globally, alongside rapidly shortening skill lifecycles (Mercer, 2025; Deloitte, 2025; OECD, 2024). The labor model that supported the sector for decades is breaking down.

AI is reshaping task structures. It reduces demand for routine, standardized work while enlarging the need for advanced capabilities such as data engineering, model integration, domain interpretation, and system coordination. **Talent is no longer a variable input that can be scaled up or down. It becomes a limiting factor for growth.**

A structural imbalance emerges. **Entry-level roles decline. Skill requirements increase. Traditional career pathways are weakening, reducing organizations' ability to develop talent internally.** Over time, the risk is not only a shortage, but a structural break in capability formation.

Organizations may find themselves without a sustainable pipeline to build future capabilities.

The response cannot be limited to hiring. It requires redesigning how capabilities are built and deployed. The move is from roles to capabilities, and from static job definitions to fluid, evolving skill sets aligned with AI-enabled work.

5. Fragmentation and Resilience in Global Delivery Models

Increasing diversification of delivery locations and supply chains is observed (EY, 2025; ABSL Europe, 2025). The role of business services is expanding beyond its traditional scope.

Historically, GBS structures prioritized efficiency through standardization, cost reduction, and scale. The approach is no longer sufficient. **Efficiency remains essential, but resilience is now equally important.**

Geopolitical tensions, regulatory fragmentation, and ongoing supply chain disruptions are prompting organizations to distribute operations across multiple locations. As a result, **multi-location delivery models are becoming standard. They enhance resilience and continuity but also increase operational complexity.**

Simultaneously, AI is reinforcing the shift. As it requires integration across processes and functions, **business services become the natural coordination layer of the enterprise.** They connect workflows, consolidate data, and enable consistent execution spanning key global hubs.

GBS is evolving from a delivery unit to a platform that orchestrates processes, data, and capabilities. Its role now focuses on enabling coordination and integration.

The change is driven by centralized data and processes, as well as the adoption of AI. As these elements converge, organizations can manage workflows end-to-end, instead of in fragmented segments. Governance structures are also evolving toward integrated ownership and cross-functional accountability.

The result is the emergence of new operating models, including GenBS (ABSL Europe, 2025), where value is created through integration. In these models, GBS becomes a core layer of the enterprise architecture, shaping how work flows and how decisions are made.

The transformation is reshaping the role of Global Capability Centers (GCC). GCCs are shifting from functionally aligned delivery hubs to integrated capability platforms within global operating models. Their mandate now includes ownership of end-to-end processes, data domains, and AI-enabled solutions. It demands stronger architectural capabilities, closer integration with headquarters, and a shift toward product- and platform-thinking. GCCs that adapt become critical to enterprise transformation. Those focused solely on functional delivery risk losing relevance.

GenBS will not replace GCCs but will likely incorporate them. Alternatively, GCCs will either evolve into nodes within GenBS or remain delivery units with decreasing strategic relevance.

6. Transformation from classic to Platform-Based & AI-Driven Models

GBS organizations are gradually assuming transformational roles and integrating cross-functional processes (SSON, 2025; EY, 2025; ABSL Europe, 2025). It reflects a deeper structural change in how the function operates within the enterprise.

7. A Hike in Complexity

Organizations progressively operate on multiple platforms, vendors, and delivery models (Deloitte, 2025; SSON, 2025). The operating environment becomes structurally more complex.

Hybrid models, multi-cloud architectures, layered AI systems, and distributed teams significantly increase coordination requirements. Execution becomes less predictable, and dependencies multiply. **Complexity is no longer a side effect of scale. It becomes a central variable shaping performance.**

The growing complexity directly translates into higher costs and inefficiencies. **As systems, tools, and providers proliferate, the ability to coordinate them effectively determines whether investments generate value or remain underutilized.**

Managing complexity is therefore emerging as a core capability, on par with technology and talent.

8. Vertical Specialization as a Source of Competitive Advantage

Demand for industry-specific capabilities is growing, particularly in regulated sub-sectors (ABSL, 2025; EY, 2025). It reflects a structural shift in how value is created in the sector and by the sector to its clients.

Competitive advantage is moving away from scale alone toward domain depth. As services become more complex and gradually shaped by AI, the ability to understand industry context becomes critical. Models, data, and workflows do not operate in isolation. Their effectiveness depends on how well they are aligned with regulatory frameworks, business logic, and sector-specific constraints.

It elevates domain knowledge to a core capability, not as an add-on, but as a prerequisite for designing, deploying, and scaling AI-enabled services. In particular, generic solutions fail to deliver in regulated industries. Without a deep understanding of context, organizations cannot ensure compliance, interpret outputs correctly, or embed solutions into real operational environments.

The underlying drivers are structural. Regulatory pressure is hardening, industry processes are becoming more complex, and AI systems require high-quality, context-rich data to function effectively. It reinforces the need for specialized expertise embedded within business models.

As a result, **the market is splitting. On one side, high-value, specialized services built on deep industry knowledge and tightly integrated capabilities. On the other hand, commoditized delivery focused on standardized processes with limited differentiation.**

Investments in vertical specialization allow for the capture of premium segments, strengthen client relationships, sustain margins, and maintain the current market position. Those that remain generic will face intensifying price pressure, declining margins, reduced relevance and market share, and, ultimately, the gradual erosion of their competitive position.

9. From Generative AI to Agentic AI

Emerging use cases of autonomous, multi-agent systems are already being tested (Gartner, 2025; SSON, 2025). This represents a transition that goes beyond incremental adoption of AI tools and generative aspects of AI.

AI is moving from content generation to execution. The change is not about producing outputs, but about performing tasks, coordinating actions, and driving processes forward. **With the rise of agentic AI, systems are no longer limited to supporting human work. They begin to carry out tasks independently.**

The already ongoing transformation affects work at every level. At the task level, AI autonomously executes repetitive, rule-based activities. At the process level, AI agents coordinate actions across systems, data, and other agents. At the functional level, domains such as finance, HR, and customer operations operate with AI shaping how work is executed.

The change is enabled by integrating models with APIs, enterprise systems, and workflows. AI agents can now access data, trigger actions, make decisions within set boundaries, and adapt to changing inputs. **Tasks that once required human coordination are now managed through continuous, machine-driven flows.**

The implications for business services are fundamental. The sector has traditionally focused on system-wide management tasks and processes. **Agentic AI reduces manual coordination, shortens process cycles, and shifts execution from human-driven to system-driven.**

> **Human roles change significantly, with a focus on supervision, validation, exception handling, and system design. The emphasis moves from performing activities to managing outcomes.**

The use of an agentic AI model will allow talent to move toward higher-value work, improving efficiency and strategic alignment. Legacy models, by contrast, will constrain scalability and competitiveness.

10. Cybersecurity and Post-Quantum Cryptography (PQC)

The focus on AI-related risks and future cryptographic threats is evident (Gartner, 2025). Security is moving into a different role within the enterprise. It is now embedded in the operating model and no longer functions as a separate layer. **As AI systems are integrated into workflows and decision-making, risk exposure shifts to the core of operations.**

AI creates more ways for systems to be accessed and connected, making them easier to attack. Advances in quantum computing challenge the durability of existing encryption standards (NIST, 2024). It creates a forward-looking risk that cannot be addressed solely with the current architecture.

A fundamental redesign of security is needed. **Protection should be integrated within data, models, infrastructure, and processes, not just at the perimeter.** Organizations must also prepare for post-quantum environments by replacing or upgrading cryptographic methods.

As a result, both cost and complexity increase significantly. Security evolves into a continuous, system-wide capability.

> **Centers need to act early to build resilience into their architectures and proactively manage emerging risks. Those that delay face growing vulnerabilities, higher transition costs, and intensifying exposure to regulatory and compliance pressures.**

Beyond cryptographic risk, hybrid classical-quantum computing may enable significant advances in optimization and simulation, especially in logistics, risk modeling, and complex system design. It creates early, though uneven, opportunities for business services to enter higher-value analytical domains.

The probability-impact matrix for the global industry

Table 0.1 presents a structured assessment of the key risks and transformation drivers shaping the business services sector, evaluated along two dimensions: probability of occurrence and potential impact on the sector (assuming the risk occurs).

The matrix is designed to prioritize factors that are both likely and consequential. It is not aimed to provide an exhaustive list of all possible risks – only the top scorers are shown. It therefore focuses on structural forces that are already influencing operating models or are expected to do so in the near term.

The matrix highlights a clear concentration of risks in the high-probability, high-impact quadrant. These include AI as an operational core, the productivity paradox, data and infrastructure challenges, and talent shortages. Together, they define the industry's immediate operating environment and constitute binding constraints.

TABLE 0.1 | **The probability-impact matrix**

		Probability	Impact on the sector
1.	AI as operational core	Very high	Very high
2.	AI productivity paradox	Very high	Very high
3.	Data & infrastructure	Very high	Very high
4.	Talent as a key driver	Very high	Very high
5.	Fragmentation & resilience	Very high	High
6.	GenBS transformation	High	Very high
7.	Complexity	High	Very high
8.	Vertical specialization	High	High
9.	Agentic AI	Medium	Very high
10.	Cybersecurity & PQC	Medium	Very high

Source: ABSL BI assessment. Probability and potential impact are assessed on a 5-grade scale. Only trends with the highest overall impact are presented due to prioritization.

A second group comprises high-impact yet less certain developments, such as agentic AI and post-quantum cryptography. These are not yet operational bottlenecks but represent strategic inflection points that may significantly reshape the sector over time.

Other factors, including fragmentation, GenBS transformation, and growing complexity, occupy an intermediate position. They are already material, but their full impact depends on the speed and scale of AI adoption and integration.

Several risks identified in the matrix are not independent but emerge as second-order effects of AI scaling. In particular, complexity, operating model transformation, and resilience challenges intensify as organizations integrate AI across fragmented systems.

This **reinforces the central role of AI as the primary driver of both disruption and structural adjustment in the sector.**

The risks described above are internal to the operating model. Additional risks exist outside the framework.

Emerging Disruptors and Black Swans

Beyond the ten core trends, the sector faces a narrower set of disruptors that are less visible in day-to-day transformation agendas but potentially decisive for operating models over the next three to five years. These risks do not primarily concern AI capability. They concern the conditions under which AI-enabled business services can be delivered enterprise-wide: **electricity availability, cross-border data governance, concentration in upstream digital infrastructure, and the stability of the junior talent pipeline.** These obvious challenges are intensifying. **Data-center electricity demand is rising sharply, creating potential capacity and cost limitations on AI scaling** (International Energy Agency, 2025). At the same time, cross-border data rules and AI regulations, such as the EU's AI Act, are becoming more restrictive and economically consequential.

We observe a gradual increase in fragmentation and growing operational complexity (OECD, 2025). Reliance on a small number of dominant cloud and infrastructure providers also introduces systemic concentration risk, with potential cascading effects in the event of a disruption (ENISA, 2025). In parallel, AI exposure remains highest in entry-level and clerical roles, raising the possibility that short-term productivity gains could undermine long-term capability formation and talent pipelines (International Labor Organization, 2025; World Economic Forum, 2025).

For the business services sector, the strategic implication is straightforward. **The next phase of advantage may depend less on who adopts AI first and more on who remains operable given the challenges ahead.** Firms that can regionalize data architectures, reduce dependence on a single upstream provider, protect early-career capability formation, and secure resilient access to power and digital infrastructure will be structurally better positioned than firms focused solely on workflow automation. These disruptors are not yet the dominant story of the sector. However, they are credible candidates to become the next one.

Concluding remarks

The transformation underway in the global sector is **more than technology adoption. It is about the evolution and transformation of the core operating models. AI accelerates the process, but it does not determine the outcome.** The decisive factor is how organizations respond, how they redesign work, integrate systems, and build capabilities.

The sector will not transform uniformly for sure. The distance between leaders and laggards will deepen as organizations move at different speeds and with distinct levels of structural readiness.

It is already clear that **productivity gains from AI depend on the fundamental redesign of processes, decision structures, and workflows.** Most organizations could fall short of expected gains, as adoption without a deep transformation will not scale.

Competitive advantage is thus shifting. Transitioning to new operating models is essential for maintaining relevance in a changing environment. Centers that adapt will gain efficiency, innovation, and strategic positioning. Laggards risk stagnation and marginalization.

> **The main direction is clear by now.**
> **The ability to walk the path is not.**

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MACROECONOMIC TRENDS AND OUTLOOK

This part analyzes the changing macroeconomic environment affecting the global and European business services industry, with a focus on Poland. It identifies the structural forces that ultimately shape the industry, operating models, and competitive positioning through 2026-2027.

The chapter first outlines global and regional macroeconomic trends, then examines how these trends affect the business services industry. It concludes with an assessment of the implications for Poland, highlighting key risks and opportunities.

Introduction

In 2026-2027, the global economy is shaped less by post-pandemic normalization and more by the interaction of three forces: weaker but still positive growth, deeper geostrategic fragmentation, and rapid technological restructuring fueled by the AI revolution.

The April 2026 IMF WEO moved from a standard baseline to a "reference forecast" because the war in the Middle East had already become a macro-relevant shock. Global growth is now projected at 3.1% in 2026 and 3.2% in 2027, after 3.4% in 2025, while headline inflation is expected to rise to 4.4% in 2026 before easing to 3.7% in 2027. This is not **a recession baseline. It is a slower, more fragile expansion with wider cross-country divergence. This is based on the assumption of a relatively short disruption in the Middle East, with no full-blown, prolonged energy crisis.**

Trade, investment, and capital allocation continue to expand, but more selectively and along strategic lines. AI-related investment, semiconductors, data centers, digital services, and selected security-sensitive industries remain the main growth pockets. At the same time, fragmentation, industrial policy, and friend-shoring continue to shift the balance away from pure efficiency toward resilience, control, and geopolitical alignment. **The Middle East shock has reinforced that shift by reintroducing energy security, maritime chokepoints, and political risk into the core macro outlook.**

The remainder of 2026 and 2027 is therefore likely to be defined not by a classic cyclical downturn but by a structural transition from labor-cost efficiency to AI-enabled, regionally resilient operating models. This matters directly for business services. Recent ABSL BI evidence suggests that **fragmentation is increasingly priced into services trade** and that its effect varies across service types. High-value, knowledge-intensive services are less constrained by physical distance than by governance quality, institutional fit, and escalation speed.
In that setting, Poland remains relatively resilient despite its proximity to the war in Ukraine.

Global Financial Stability

The macro baseline still points to moderate growth, but financial stability remains conditional. Markets have adjusted to higher interest rates, yet underlying vulnerabilities persist. Sovereign debt is elevated, asset valuations, particularly in technology-linked segments, remain sensitive, nonbank financial intermediation continues to expand, and the recent escalation in the Middle East **has reintroduced commodity-driven volatility and tighter financial conditions into the core outlook.**

The IMF's April 2026 assessment is more cautious than earlier in the year, reflecting not only structurally weaker growth but also **a shift from hypothetical to realized geopolitical shocks,** which are already influencing inflation expectations, risk premia, and capital flows. The key distinction for 2026–2027 is therefore not between stability and crisis, but between systems that can absorb repeated shocks and those that amplify them through fiscal fragility, institutional weakness, or dependence on external financing.

IMF Global Economic Outlook

According to the **IMF World Economic Outlook of April 14, 2026,** global growth is projected at **3.1% in 2026** and **3.2% in 2027,** down from **3.4% in 2025** and below the historical average of 3.7% in 2000-2019. The main difference versus January is that the Fund now treats the Middle East war as an already materialized shock. In the IMF reference forecast, the conflict is assumed to be limited in duration and scope. Even under that assumption, the 2026 projection was revised down, and inflation was revised up. In a more adverse energy scenario, global growth could slow to **2.5% in 2026;** in a more severe scenario, to around **2%.**

The structure of growth remains uneven. The **United States** is still relatively resilient, with growth at **2.3% in 2026** and **2.1% in 2027,** supported by consumption, technology investment, and still-solid labor markets. The **euro area** remains weak, at **1.1% in 2026** and **1.2% in 2027,** with **Germany** improving only gradually from **0.2% in 2025** to **0.8% in 2026. Spain** remains comparatively stronger, while **France** and **Italy** stay subdued. **China** slows from **5.0% in 2025** to **4.4% in 2026** and **4.0% in 2027; India** remains the strongest major economy at **6.5%** in both 2026 and 2027.

The IMF's macro message is therefore sharper than in January 2026. Growth remains positive, but the distribution of risks has worsened. Energy, trade, fiscal strain, and asset repricing remain the main downside channels. The most important upside still comes from AI-related investment and, later, potential productivity effects, but the Fund is explicit that these do not automatically offset the current war shock.

World Bank's Global Economic Outlook

According to the **World Bank Global Economic Prospects (January 2026),** global growth was estimated at **2.7% in 2025,** easing to **2.6% in 2026,** before edging up slightly to **2.7% in 2027.** This implies stabilization but remains below the pre-pandemic average. The World Bank stresses that the global recovery has been "*surprisingly strong, disappointingly uneven*" with advanced economies largely recovering per capita income losses while many developing economies lag.

The World Bank's January 2026 **Global Economic Prospects** remains directionally relevant in the new circumstances, but part of its energy and trade assumptions are now outdated. Its core message still holds. The global economy is stabilizing below its pre-pandemic pace; advanced economies remain weak; EMDEs continue to drive most of global growth; and downside risks dominate. Its estimate of **2.6% global growth in 2026** now looks more conservative than the IMF's April reference forecast, but it was prepared before the full macroeconomic consequences of the Middle East escalation could be fully integrated.

Overall, global trade continues to grow, but less efficiently. FDI still flows but is increasingly concentrated in strategic sectors and selected geographies. Strategic fragmentation now operates through governance, regulation, and strategic alignment as much as through tariffs or distance.

Prospects for global trade and FDI

According to the **WTO Global Trade Outlook and Statistics, March 2026,** merchandise trade volume growth is projected to slow from **4.6% in 2025** to **1.9% in 2026,** before improving to **2.6% in 2027.**

Commercial services trade remains stronger, but it also slows, from **5.3% in 2025** to **4.8% in 2026,** before recovering to **5.1% in 2027.**

A sustained energy shock linked to the Middle East conflict could cut merchandise trade growth by **0.5 percentage points** in 2026 and services trade growth by **0.7 percentage points.** Nonetheless, we can expect DTS to perform better, at least in the short- to medium-run.

The disruption in the Strait of Hormuz is not a symbolic risk. According to **UNCTAD, the disruption in the Strait of Hormuz compromises crude oil and LNG flows, with particularly severe consequences for Asia and Europe. At the same time, financial spillovers will likely hit developing countries through weaker currencies, falling stock prices, and higher external debt costs.** The issue is therefore broader than oil prices alone. It affects shipping, insurance, fertilizers, food systems, and confidence. **One of the previously identified downside risks has unfortunately materialized.**

Global FDI rose **14%** in 2025 to about **USD 1.6 trillion,** yet the rebound was narrow and distorted. Without conduit flows, growth was much smaller. Greenfield project numbers fell **by 16%, international project finance fell by 16% in value, and cross-border M&A fell by 10%**. Data centers and semiconductors drove a disproportionate share of announced value, while tariff-exposed sectors weakened.

Projections for Poland

Poland entered 2026 from a position of relative strength. GDP grew by **3.6% in 2025,** and the **NBP's March 2026 projection is for 2.9% growth in 2026** and in **2027,** with CPI inflation at **2.4% in 2026** and **2.3% in 2027.** This is a slower but still solid path, supported by EU funds and domestic demand, though it is weaker than in 2025. NBP has not accounted for the energy crises; we should expect higher inflation and slower growth in 2026, depending on the duration of the Hormuz disruption and the scale of the associated energy crisis.

The IMF still sees Poland as one of the stronger economies in the region, but it is exposed to euro area weakness, especially German weakness.

The main external constraint is not domestic fragility, but weak industrial demand in Europe and a less supportive external trade environment. The main internal constraint is that disinflation continues, but not in a way that fully removes cost pressure from services, wages, and financing conditions.

Poland's growth outlook rests on a resilient domestic base and sustained absorption of EU funds, which continue to support investment and demand despite tighter financial conditions. At the same time, the economy is increasingly exposed to external headwinds – particularly German industrial weakness, deepening trade fragmentation, and rising geopolitical risk premia – which may constrain export performance and elevate uncertainty.

Top 10 Potential Downside Risks for the Global Economy (2026–2027)

Escalation of geopolitical conflicts

the Russia-Ukraine war, Taiwan risk, and the already materialized Middle East shock can disrupt energy, trade, and financial conditions simultaneously, with escalation scenarios still open.

Middle East / Hormuz disruption (expanded scenario)

beyond the baseline shock, a broader regional escalation could materially affect oil flows, shipping routes, insurance costs, and global inflation dynamics.

Intensifying geoeconomic fragmentation

rising trade restrictions, industrial policy competition, and bloc-based supply chains continue to raise costs and reduce long-run productivity.

Policy volatility and regulatory unpredictability

abrupt shifts in tariffs, sanctions, industrial policy, and regulation increase uncertainty, delay investment, and amplify financial market reactions.

Technology-driven asset repricing / AI capex correction

a reassessment of AI-driven growth expectations could trigger not only equity corrections but also a slowdown in data-center investment and digital transformation spending.

Cyber and digital infrastructure disruption

attacks on energy, telecom, cloud, financial, or logistics systems could rapidly propagate, affecting both real activity and confidence.

Sovereign debt stress in EMDEs

refinancing risks remain elevated under tighter financial conditions and stronger USD dynamics.

Euro area industrial weakness

persistent underperformance, especially in Germany, continues to weigh on global trade and CEE growth.

Persistent services inflation and wage pressure

sticky cost dynamics, particularly in advanced economies, could delay monetary easing and sustain restrictive conditions.

Supply-chain concentration in strategic sectors

semiconductors, rare earths, batteries, and AI infrastructure- remains geographically concentrated and exposed to disruption.

Top 5 Upside Risks

Faster and broader AI-driven productivity gains

diffusion beyond frontier firms could lift potential growth more materially than currently assumed.

Faster global disinflation and earlier monetary easing

a quicker decline in services inflation could unlock investment and consumption.

Stronger euro area recovery

particularly through an industrial rebound in Germany and improved external demand conditions.

Scaled investment in energy transition and infrastructure

breakthroughs in storage, grids, or alternative energy could reduce structural cost pressures.

Stabilization and rebalancing in China

improved domestic demand and policy effectiveness could support global trade and investment flows.

TABLE 0.2 | **ABSL macro risks matrix**

Downside risks		**Probability**	**Potential impact**
1a.	Escalation of the Russia–Ukraine war	Medium	Very High
	Stalemate continuation	High	Medium
	Major escalation / NATO incident	Medium-Low	Very High
1b.	Taiwan Strait escalation	Low-Medium	High
2.	Middle East escalation (baseline shock already materialized; prolonged Hormuz disruption)	High	Very High
3.	Geoeconomic fragmentation	High	High
4.	Policy volatility and regulatory unpredictability	Very High	High
5.	Technology/AI-driven asset repricing and capex correction	Medium	Medium-High
6.	Cyber and digital infrastructure disruption	Medium	High
7.	Sovereign debt stress (EMDEs)	Medium	Medium
8.	Euro Area industrial stagnation	High	Very High
9.	Persistent services inflation and wage pressure	High	High
10.	Supply-chain concentration in strategic sectors	Medium	High
Upside risks		**Probability**	**Potential impact**
1.	Faster and broader AI-driven productivity gains	Medium	High
2.	Faster global disinflation and earlier monetary easing	Medium	High
3.	Stronger Euro Area recovery (incl. Germany industrial rebound)	Medium	Very High
4.	Scaled energy transition and infrastructure investment	Medium	High
5.	Stabilization and rebalancing in China	Low-Medium	Medium

Source: ABSL BI.

IMPACT ON THE INDUSTRY GLOBALLY AND IN POLAND

In 2026-2027, the global business services industry is shifting from broad-based scale to selective, value-driven expansion, directly reflecting the macro environment. **With slower global growth, weaker euro area performance, slowing trade growth, and persistent cost pressures, demand remains positive but uneven and more risk sensitive.** The recent shock in the Middle East, fragmentation, and higher interest rates reinforce a move toward resilience, productivity, and measurable outcomes.

1. From Cost Arbitrage Engineering

Slower global trade, weak European industrial demand, and higher capital costs are forcing a shift from cost arbitrage toward value creation.

Outcome-based delivery is gradually replacing FTE-based models as clients demand measurable ROI under tighter financial conditions.

AI-enabled analytics, compliance, and advisory services expand, while routine BPO activities face continued compression amid weaker growth in low-value trade and rising cost sensitivity.

2. AI and Agentic Automation under Tight Financial Conditions

AI adoption is accelerating, but within a more constrained macro context. **Higher interest rates and potential volatility in AI-driven investment cycles mean that AI serves as both a productivity driver and a source of financial sensitivity.** So far, the impact is visible mainly in productivity, not headcount reduction, but this is likely to change as adoption deepens.

AI amplifies divergence. Routine processes are compressed under cost pressure, while complex services benefit from integration and domain expertise. As a result, productivity gains concentrate in high-skill, institutionally aligned hubs, which are particularly relevant in a fragmented and uneven growth environment.

3. Fragmentation, Nearshoring, and Strategic Geography

With trade growth slowing and becoming more regionalized, and FDI concentrated in strategic sectors (AI, semiconductors, energy), location decisions are increasingly driven by risk and resilience. The Middle East shock reinforces the importance of energy security and supply chain stability, while fragmentation reshapes global business services models.

Nearshoring is therefore not about proximity alone. Institutional alignment, legal predictability, governance quality, and regulatory compatibility become the key determinants of resilience. For the sector, this increases demand for compliance, regulatory reporting, and risk analytics, while reinforcing a shift toward politically stable, well-integrated locations such as Poland.

Effects on Poland's Business Services Sector (2026–2027)

The global shift toward selective, value-driven growth will translate directly into Poland's business services outlook. **In the new global macro setting, demand remains positive but uneven and increasingly risk-sensitive.**

> Three structural shifts define the trajectory.
>
> **First,** the model moves from cost arbitrage toward value density, as clients under tighter financial conditions demand measurable outcomes.
>
> **Second,** AI acts both as a productivity driver and a source of divergence. Centers that integrate AI effectively move up the value chain, while others face compression.
>
> **Third,** strategic geography becomes more important, but primarily through institutional alignment.

For Poland, the outlook is balanced. The country benefits from nearshoring as well as allyshoring, strong digital and talent infrastructure, and continued movement toward advanced GBS, R&D, and technology functions. **At the same time, growth around 3% is increasingly exposed to weak euro-area demand, particularly in Germany, and to higher geopolitical risk premia.** As a result, the impact on the sector is to a large extent mixed – structurally supportive, on the one hand, but externally constrained, on the other hand.

Structural Strengths

Poland remains a key nearshoring destination within the EU, combining political stability, institutional alignment, and advanced digital capabilities. The transition toward higher-value, multifunctional, and AI-enabled GBS is already underway and aligned with global trends. Expansion into analytics, advisory, and digital CoEs strengthens the sector's position. Crucially, Poland's advantage is increasingly visible when productivity is adjusted for coordination risk. In complex services, institutional fit, escalation speed, and compliance reliability matter more than nominal labor costs.

Structural Weaknesses

Constraints are, nonetheless, becoming more binding. Labor market tightness and wage pressures persist, particularly in IT and advanced analytics. Exposure to the euro area industrial cycle remains the main external risk. At the same time, **persistent services inflation and higher interest rates limit investment flexibility,** while rapid AI adoption increases the likelihood that productivity will grow faster than employment. Additional uncertainty stems from global policy volatility, which may affect investment pipelines and, in turn, investment projects, including both new investment plans and reinvestments.

THREE SCENARIOS FOR POLAND'S BUSINESS SERVICES SECTOR (2026–2027)

Scenario analysis is a core element of ABSL reporting and a well-established reference point for understanding potential sector trajectories. It is not intended as a precise forecast, but as a structured framework to support strategic thinking, planning, and anticipation of key risks and opportunities.

The scenarios presented below are based on a combination of survey data, observed sector dynamics, and the current macroeconomic and geopolitical environment, including projections from leading institutions such as the IMF and its WEO. They incorporate key drivers shaping the sector, including global demand conditions, cost dynamics, AI adoption, and structural transformation of operating models.

This approach reflects a long-standing practice in ABSL reports. Experience shows that while no single scenario materializes fully, the framework consistently captures the direction and boundaries of sector evolution, providing a robust basis for decision-making.

Probability:
~55%

Baseline: Fragile Growth + Controlled AI Transition

The global environment remains stable enough to support continued expansion, but without returning to pre-2022 dynamics. Growth is positive but uneven, with the euro area still underperforming and external demand constrained, particularly through Germany. The Middle East disruption proves temporary, and financial conditions gradually stabilize without a full easing cycle.

In this setting, the business services sector in Poland continues to grow, but not through scale. Demand remains solid, particularly for knowledge-intensive and digitally enabled services, and exports expand at a strong pace. However, hiring slows significantly. Firms focus on extracting more value from existing operations.

AI plays a supporting but not yet transformative role. It enhances productivity, shortens process cycles, and enables gradual upgrades to service portfolios, but does not fundamentally redefine operating models at scale within the horizon.

Quantitative outlook (2026–2027)

New centers: **35–45 annually**

Employment growth: **2026: 0 to +0.5%; 2027: -2 to 0%**

Services exports growth: **+8% to +10% annually**

Exports per worker:

- 2026: **+7.5% to +10.0%**
- 2027: **+8.0% to +12.0%**

GVA per worker: **+5% to +8% annually**

Productivity gains are real and broad-based, driven by a combination of moderate demand growth and incremental efficiency improvements. The sector shifts toward higher-value activities, but without a disruptive break from existing operating models. Poland consolidates its role as a stable, high-capacity business services hub within Europe.

Structural shift

- **Gradual erosion** of transactional BPO in favor of more analytical and compliance-heavy work
- **AI improves throughput and consistency,** but mostly within existing process architectures
- **Margins stabilize** as productivity gains offset limited headcount growth

Growth is no longer scale-driven. Revenue expands faster than employment, with value shifting toward more complex, knowledge-intensive services. Poland reinforces its position as a stable, high-capacity business services hub within Europe.

Probability:
~20–25%

Adverse: Geopolitical Shock + Defensive Automation

The global environment deteriorates materially. The disruption in the Strait of Hormuz proves longer-lasting, and additional geopolitical tensions, potentially in the Taiwan Strait in Q3-Q4 2026, further weaken trade, investment, and confidence. Inflation remains elevated, delaying monetary easing and tightening financial conditions.

Demand for business services slows, particularly in trade-sensitive and cost-sensitive segments. Clients postpone expansion, reduce discretionary spending, and prioritize efficiency over transformation. New investment activity drops sharply.

Under these conditions, firms adjust rapidly – but defensively. Automation accelerates not as part of a strategic redesign but in response to cost pressure. Headcount reductions become a primary adjustment mechanism, particularly in routine and transaction-heavy functions.

Quantitative outlook (2026-2027)

New centers: **10-20 annually**	
Employment growth: **2026: -2 to 0%; 2027: -4 to -2%**	
Services exports growth: **+4% to +5% annually**	
Exports per worker:	
2026:	**+4.0% to +7.0%**
2027:	**+6.0% to +9.0%**
GVA per worker: **+3% to +5% annually**	

AI adoption continues, including early forms of agentic automation, but its role is uneven. It is used selectively to replace labor instead of redesigning end-to-end processes. The tendency for the centers' closure, M&As, or exits could intensify.

Output per worker continues to rise, but primarily due to employment compression in place of strong demand or successful transformation. The sector remains resilient in revenue terms, but growth is defensive, uneven, and structurally constrained. Poland performs better than weaker locations due to institutional stability, but the overall environment limits expansion.

Structural shift

- **Accelerated decline of low-value,** transaction-heavy functions
- **Automation is used primarily as a cost-reduction tool**
- **Margin pressure persists,** partially offset by workforce compression

Output per worker increases, but largely due to declining employment rather than strong demand. The sector remains operationally resilient, but growth becomes defensive and uneven.

Probability:
~25%

Constrained Transformation: AI Frictions + Partial Adjustment

The macro environment evolves along a middle path. Growth is weaker than in the baseline but does not deteriorate into a full adverse scenario. External demand remains sufficient to sustain expansion in business services, although at a moderate pace.

At the same time, the expected transformation of operating models slows. Firms face persistent barriers to scaling AI, including fragmented data, legacy systems, governance gaps, and limited integration capabilities. As a result, the sector advances, but unevenly and below its potential.

This creates a specific tension. Demand supports continued export growth, but productivity gains are harder to achieve. Firms respond by combining selective automation with gradual workforce adjustments, and not by executing full operating model redesigns.

Quantitative outlook (2026–2027)

New centers: **30–40 annually**

Employment growth: **2026: -1 to 0%; 2027: -2 to -1%**

Services exports growth: **+6% to +8% annually**

Exports per worker:

- 2026: **+6.0% to +9.0%**
- 2027: **+7.0% to +10.0%**

GVA per worker: **+4% to +6.5% annually**

The sector continues to expand, and output per worker increases at a solid pace. However, the underlying driver is mixed. Part of the improvement reflects genuine upgrading, while part results from incremental efficiency gains and moderate workforce reductions. The absence of a full-scale transformation limits the upside in value creation.

Structural shift

- **Shift toward higher-value services continues,** but at a slower and uneven pace
- **AI adoption remains fragmented,** limiting system-wide efficiency gains
- **Margins improve moderately,** constrained by incomplete transformation

The sector expands, but below its potential. Output per worker rises, though driven by a mix of incremental improvements and selective workforce adjustments instead of full productivity breakthroughs.

Forecasts for individual locations

In light of the hard-to-predict changes in the macroeconomic situation, the ongoing restructuring and transformation in the centers, and especially the unpredictable impact of AI, we do not provide detailed employment forecasts for individual locations in Poland.

In our opinion, Warsaw has the greatest potential for further employment growth. Employment decreases are most likely in Tier 3 and Tier 4 locations, and the average change in employment in Tier 2 is "zero plus". Due to the decline in employment dynamics in the sector compared to previous periods, predicting the situation's development is subject to significant error. Changes in employment may result from specific conditions occurring in individual companies.

Throughout all scenarios, two patterns remain consistent.

First, **productivity grows faster than employment.** Regardless of the macroeconomic environment, the sector is moving away from scale-driven expansion toward output growth driven by efficiency, technology, and service complexity.

Second, **exports per worker increase structurally,** but for different reasons. In the baseline, this reflects successful upgrading. In the adverse scenario, it is largely a by-product of employment compression. In the constrained scenario, it lies somewhere in between. The key distinction is therefore not whether output per worker rises, but **why it rises.**

The most adverse outcome for the sector is not a macroeconomic shock alone, but a situation in which firms face cost pressure without achieving corresponding productivity gains. In such a case, employment declines without a proportional increase in value creation, limiting long-term competitiveness.

For Poland, the strategic question is no longer whether the sector will grow, but whether it will convert growth into higher-value activity. At this stage, we treat the base scenario as the most probable one.

POSITIONING POLAND WITHIN THE EUROPEAN BUSINESS SERVICES ECOSYSTEM: KIBS, BSI, AND CENTER-BASED EMPLOYMENT

The key definitions

To assess Poland's position in a European context, the report extends the traditional, center-based definition of the sector. It embeds it within the broader definition used by ABSL in the European Reports – business services industry (BSI). This approach allows for a more accurate comparison between countries, where business services are delivered not only through dedicated centers but also deeply embedded within firms.

Three analytical layers are used. **At the most granular level, center-based business services** refer to dedicated units such as GBS, SSC, BPO, IT, and R&D centers. These represent the operational backbone of the sector and remain the core of ABSL's database and measurement framework.

A broader functional layer is represented by knowledge-intensive business services (KIBS), which encompass activities that rely on professional knowledge, analytical capabilities, and domain expertise. These services are not limited to centers and can be performed across a wide range of organizational structures.

The broadest layer is the business services industry (BSI), which encompasses the full spectrum of business functions performed. In accordance with the ABSL definition, the ***business services*** **industry refers to a wider array of functions and processes essential to an organization's day-to-day operations, operational efficiency, and long-term growth. These services may be delivered internally or externally, in-house or outsourced, regardless of location or organizational structure.** Our definition focuses primarily on horizontal processes and functions but also incorporates selected verticals, such as IT services.

For the sake of conceptual clarity and consistency in categorization, we excluded from our definition of the industry services delivered within public sector institutions and those related to personal services and functions classified purely as physical labor (as per the blue-collar definition).

The three layers described above are nested. Center-based services constitute a subset of KIBS, which in turn form part of the broader business services industry. This structure allows us to distinguish between business services models, capability depth, and overall system scale, and to position Poland more precisely relative to other European economies.

TABLE 0.3 | **Estimates of employment in the business services sector and industry for Poland, EU-27, and a broader Europe (2024)**

		Narrow sense	Broad sense
2024	**Poland**	**EU27**	**EU27 + EEC + UK + CH**
Center-based business services	0 .47	5 .4	6 .6
Knowledge-intensive business services (KIBS)	0.92	11 .8	14 .9
Business services industry	2 .58	32 .5	40 .0
White-collar workers	7 .22	77 .6	92 .1

Source: ABSL BI estimates based on EUROSTAT's data.

Scale and structure: Poland in the European system

In 2024, Poland employed approximately 0.47 million people in center-based business services, 0.92 million in KIBS, and 2.58 million in the broadly defined business services industry. This places Poland among the largest business services systems in Europe in absolute terms.

At the same time, the country accounted for 7.22 million white-collar workers, confirming the growing weight of professional and knowledge-based employment in the economy.

At the EU27 level, employment reached 5.4 million in centers, 11.8 million in KIBS, and 32.5 million in the broader industry.

When extending the comparison to a broader European definition that includes the EEA, the United Kingdom, and Switzerland, total business services employment rises to approximately 40 million. **This more than proves the systemic importance of business services as a core component of advanced European economies.**

Poland's position is best understood through the internal structure of its business services system and not solely by its scale. The country operates at full European scale, with the share of business services employment broadly aligned with EU benchmarks (BSI), but its composition is distinct. Center-based employment accounts for around **18% of the broader industry (vs 17% in the EU)** and as much as **51% of KIBS employment (vs 46% in the EU),** pointing to a structurally stronger concentration of activity within dedicated centers. At the same time, overall knowledge intensity remains comparable **(KIBS/BSI 36% in both Poland and the EU),** but with a different internal logic: in Poland, knowledge-intensive activities are disproportionately organized within center-based structures, whereas in more mature European economies, they are more widely embedded. The result is a system that is fully scaled, but more centralized and delivery-oriented, with capability depth still closely tied to global business services models.

In Poland, similarly to other CEEs, a larger share of knowledge-intensive activities is organized within dedicated centers, whereas in core Western European economies these functions are more widely embedded.

Relative positioning of Poland versus European competitors

A country-level comparison shows that Poland holds a distinct position in the European business services landscape. Its industry is sizable, but its structure differs from both Western European economies and smaller, specialized service hubs. Location quotients indicate that Poland's KIBS intensity is slightly below the EU average, and the overall scale of its business services industry is also marginally lower relative to the economy's size. However, center-based employment intensity exceeds the European benchmark. **This combination places Poland among economies with strong specialization within global business services networks.**

> **This pattern is common in Central and Eastern Europe, where countries such as Czechia, Hungary, and Slovakia also show high concentrations of center-based activity. However, Poland stands out due to its scale. It combines a delivery-oriented model with the size of a major European market, making it a key node of the global business services industry.**

In contrast, Western and Northern European economies have a different structure. Countries such as Sweden, the Netherlands, Ireland, and the United Kingdom show much higher KIBS intensity, reflecting a deeper integration of high-value services and a stronger focus on advanced, knowledge-driven activities. Larger economies like Germany and France have a more balanced profile, with business services spread more.

Given the context, Poland can best be described as a system with rising knowledge intensity, clear **upgrading and upskilling, and climbing the value ladder.** It plays **a central role in executing and scaling business services in Europe,** but at least at this stage, hosts fewer high-value-added capabilities than leading Western economies, which mostly host the HQ. This pivotal shift is still ahead of us and an aspiration.

To achieve a clear comparison of employment levels and talent intensity, Table 0.4 evaluates three distinct layers of the business services ecosystem: business services centers, the broader Business Services Industry (BSI), and Knowledge-Intensive Business Services (KIBS).

The data is benchmarked for Poland, the EU-27, and a wider European regional average to highlight competitive positioning and workforce specialization.

The objective is to position centers within the overall services structure and assess whether they represent a more talent-intensive segment relative to the broader industry. LQ should be interpreted as a proxy for the skill and knowledge of intensity of employment, as it positions a given state relative to the EU-27 average.

The key point is not only the absolute size of employment, but also the relative differences in talent intensity across segments and geographies, highlighting the extent to which centers concentrate higher-value, knowledge-intensive functions compared to the wider services base, and informing the competitive position of Poland vis-à-vis its European competitors.

Structural interpretation

Poland's position demonstrates a unique development model in Europe's business services sector. **Large-scale integration into global systems has led to strong specialization in center-based employment and operational execution.** This is evident in the above-average concentration of centers (LQ 1.06), which is now Poland's core competitive advantage.

The lower relative intensity of KIBS (below 1 but close to one in 2024) is not a structural weakness, but a lagging indicator of a rapidly evolving model. **The role of KIBS is increasing as the sector transitions from execution-based delivery to more knowledge-intensive, analytics-driven, and higher value-added functions. This shift is evident in rising GVA per worker, greater export sophistication and exports value per worker, and a move toward mid-office and higher-complexity processes,** as shown in ABSL data.

Poland's upgrading path differs from traditional Western European service economies. Instead of being driven by headquarters functions, it is **based on the functional deepening of globally integrated business services platforms.** This hybrid model enables value creation within distributed structures, without relocating corporate control. The next stage involves **expanding the role of centers from execution to greater participation in value creation, innovation, R&D, decision-making, and transformational capabilities.**

TABLE 0.4 **Estimates of employment and LQ in business services centers, BSI, and KIBS for Poland, EU-27, and a broader Europe (2024)**

		Employment in 1'000s			LQ		
Country	**ISO**	**KIBS**	**BSI**	**CENTERS**	**KIBS**	**BSI**	**CENTERS**
Germany	DEU	2,450	6,683	1,069	1.01	1.00	0.96
France	FRA	1,633	4,637	742	0.99	1.02	0.98
Italy	ITA	1,238	3,757	601	0.91	1.00	0.96
Spain	ESP	1,204	3,328	532	0.98	0.98	0.94
Poland	**POL**	**916**	**2,574**	**476**	**0.93**	**0.95**	**1.06**
Netherlands	NLD	697	1,714	274	1.24	1.11	1.07
Romania	ROU	280	1,018	204	0.62	0.83	0.99
Sweden	SWE	473	1,027	164	1.57	1.23	1.19
Czechia	CZE	278	793	159	0.94	0.97	1.17
Hungary	HUN	247	704	141	0.92	0.95	1.15
Belgium	BEL	304	807	129	1.05	1.01	0.98
Portugal	PRT	285	778	125	0.98	0.97	0.93
Austria	AUT	248	721	115	0.97	1.02	0.99
Greece	GRC	192	633	101	0.79	0.94	0.91
Ireland	IRL	243	505	81	1.55	1.17	1.12
Denmark	DNK	184	485	78	1.05	1.00	0.97
Slovakia	SVK	141	384	77	0.94	0.93	1.13
Finland	FIN	195	439	70	1.31	1.07	1.03
Bulgaria	BGR	162	437	70	0.97	0.95	0.91
Lithuania	LTU	95	231	46	1.14	1.01	1.21
Croatia	HRV	100	258	41	1.04	0.98	0.94
Slovenia	SVN	54	155	31	0.95	0.99	1.19
Latvia	LVA	55	134	22	1.09	0.97	0.93
Estonia	EST	51	117	19	1.27	1.06	1.02
Cyprus	CYP	38	90	14	1.36	1.17	1.13
Luxembourg	LUX	25	65	10	1.34	1.28	1.23
Malta	MLT	20	52	8	1.13	1.05	1.01
Iceland	ISL	15	36	6	1.12	1.00	0.96
Norway	NOR	183	453	72	1.10	0.99	0.96
Switzerland	CHE	312	851	136	1.12	1.11	1.07
United Kingdom	GBR	2,574	6179	989	1.33	1.16	1.12
	EU27	**11,807**	**32,524**	**5,400**	**1.00**	**1.00**	**1.00**

Source: ABSL BI estimates based on EUROSTAT's data.

The concept and methodology of the report

214

The number of companies that participated in the ABSL nationwide survey in Q1 2026.

40.1%

The share of companies in the total employment of business services centers operating in Poland that participated in this year's ABSL survey.

200,495

The number of people employed by companies in Poland that participated in the 2026 ABSL survey.

"The Business Services Sector in Poland 2026" report provides comprehensive insights into the activities of the BPO/ SSC, GBS, and IT/ITO R&D service centers in Poland, presents the current state of the sector, and outlines the sector's growth directions.

The report adopts a **sector definition that includes the activities of business process outsourcing (BPO), shared services (SSC), global business services (GBS), IT, and research and development (R&D) centers located in Poland and employing 25 or more people. By "sector" or "our sector"** in the report, we mean center-based business services.

In this year's report, we also refer to a broader definition from ABSL's 2025 European report, which we use for the industry (or our industry). **The business services industry (BSI)** encompasses a wide range of functions and processes that organizations use **daily to manage and enhance their operations, increase efficiency, and drive growth. These services can be carried out internally or externally, in-house or provided by a third party, regardless of location or organizational setup.** Thus, in our understanding, the center-based business services sector constitutes the most significant and productive part of the broader industry. Its preparation was based on ABSL's internal database of business services centers in Poland (which currently contains information on over 2,100 centers and is updated regularly by the ABSL BI team) and the results of the annual ABSL 2026 managers' survey.

The ABSL BI team conducted the survey using the CAWI (computer-assisted web interview) approach in January-March 2026 (we assume that the results reflect the state of the sector at the end of Q1 2026).

The ABSL 2026 report concerns business services centers (the sector), whose parent companies have headquarters in Poland or abroad. Each entity was assigned to one of the primary types (BPO, SSC, GBS, IT, R&D), based on the dominant profile of its operations.

Contact centers providing services to external customers were classified as BPOs. IT centers were defined as entities that outsource IT solutions (e.g., system, application, or infrastructure maintenance, technical support) and develop and sell (implement) software for external customers (software development).

Rather than running many shared services centers and managing suppliers independently, GBS centers ensure full integration of global governance and provide services to locations that use all shared services and outsourcing throughout the enterprise.

Even when located in the same city, particular business service centers were treated as separate units for analysis. Accepting the geographic criterion, the requirement to be in two different places would have eliminated information about centers of various types (e.g., IT and BPO) that were in the same location. This year's report considers centers with an employee base of 25 workers or more. Direct comparisons with previously published ABSL reports should be avoided; it is better to rely on the information presented herein. The ABSL database is continually updated and includes data revisions for previous years. Because some values are rounded off, in particular tables or figures in the report, they may add up to less than 100.0%.

The unit of analysis in the report is a metropolis/ conurbation. GZM means Katowice together with the other cities of the Górnośląsko-Zagłębiowska Metropolis (Katowice & GZM) unless otherwise indicated. Tri-City means Gdańsk, Gdynia, and Sopot.

Classification of cities and metropolitan areas according to ABSL

Tier 1

Kraków, Warsaw and Wrocław

Tier 2

Katowice & GZM, Łódź, Poznań, Tricity

Tier 3

Bydgoszcz, Lublin, Rzeszów, Szczecin

Tier 4

Białystok, Elbląg, Kielce, Olsztyn, Opole, Płock, Radom, Tarnów and others

In the report, we also utilize the notion of knowledge-intensive business services (KIBS). We define KIBS in line with Schnabl E. and Zenker A. (2013) as "enterprises whose business operations rely heavily on professional knowledge and that provide knowledge-intensive services primarily to other businesses". KIBS are thus private or public organizations whose value-added is based primarily on professional knowledge and expertise and who supply services to other businesses or the public sector. From a statistical perspective, **core KIBS refers to divisions J62, J63, J69, M70, M71, M72, and M73 of the NACE rev.2 classification of activities.**

The report can be downloaded free of charge in PDF format, in both Polish and English, from the Reports section of the ABSL website: absl.pl/en/reports

This report could not have been prepared without the information obtained from respondents to the nationwide ABSL survey. We sincerely thank company representatives who took time out of their busy schedules to complete it. We are also grateful to the representatives of local governments and investor support institutions for their support of this project.

We want to thank the co-authors of this report, particularly our strategic partners, who shared their expert knowledge and data, significantly enriching the report's content. Experts from Colliers wrote the real estate market analysis section, and representatives from Mercer and Randstad contributed to the labor market section. We also extend our thanks to the OPI, or the National Information Processing Institute – National Research Institute, an important partner of ABSL annual reports, for providing data on the academic and higher education sectors.

Last but not least, we would be grateful for any opinions and comments on the contents of this year's report, so that we can enhance the quality of future editions and adapt them to the needs and expectations of the centers' managers and new investors.

ABSL BI team

Abbreviations

ABSL	Association of Business Services Leaders
AGI	Artificial General Intelligence
AI	Artificial Intelligence
AMER	North, Central, and South America
AML	Anti-Money Laundering
AP	Accounts Payable (common in finance functions)
APAC	Asia-Pacific
BCP	Business Continuity Plan
BFSI	Banking, Financial Services, and Insurance
BI	Business Intelligence
BoP	Balance of Payments
BPI	Business Process Improvement
BPO	Business Process Outsourcing
CAGR	Compound Annual Growth Rate
CEE	Central and Eastern Europe
CET	Central European Time zone

CoE	Center of Excellence
CSRD	Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive
CXO	generic term for corporate executives
DEI	Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion
DIB	Diversity, Inclusion, and Belonging
DL	Deep Learning
DTS	Digitally Traded Services
EA	Euro area / Eurozone
EBOPS	Extended Balance of Payments Services classification
EMDEs	Emerging Market and Developing Economies
EMEA	Europe, the Middle East, and Africa
ENISA	European Union Agency for Cybersecurity
ESG	Environmental, Social, and Governance
EU	European Union
F&A	Finance and Accounting
FDI	Foreign Direct Investment
FTE	Full Time Equivalent
FX	Foreign Exchange
GBS	Global Business Services
GCC	Global Capability Center
GDP	Gross Domestic Product
GenAI	Generative Artificial Intelligence
GenBS	Generative Business Services
GPT	Generative Pretrained Transformer
GUS	Główny Urząd Statystyczny (Statistics Poland)
GVA	Gross Value Added
GVCs	Global Value Chains
HQ	Headquarters
IEA	International Energy Agency
ILO	International Labor Organization
IMD	International Institute for Management Development
IMF	International Monetary Fund
IoT	Internet of Things
IPA	Intelligent Process Automation
KIBS	Knowledge-Intensive Business Services
KPO	Knowledge Processes Outsourcing
KYC	Know Your Customer
LAC	Latin America and the Caribbean
LLMs	Large Language Model(s)
LQ	Location Quotient
ML	Machine Learning
NACE	Nomenclature of Economic Activities
NAIRU	Non-accelerating Inflation Rate of Unemployment
NATO	North Atlantic Treaty Organization
NUTS	Nomenclature of Territorial Units for Statistics
NLP	Natural Language Processing
OECD	Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development
p.p.	Percentage point(s)
PPS	Purchasing Power Standard
PQC	Post-Quantum Cryptography
QC	Quality Control
QE/QT	Quantitative Easing/Quantitative Tightening
QoQ	Quarter on Quarter
R&D	Research & Development
RAI	Responsible Artificial Intelligence
ROI	Return on Investment
RPA	Robotic Process Automation
RTO	Return to Office
SQL	Structured Query Language
SSC	Shared Services Center
UI	User Interface
UN	United Nations
US	United States of America
VC	Value Chain
WEF	World Economic Forum
WEO	World Economic Outlook
WFA	Work from Anywhere
WFH	Work from Home
YoY	Year on Year

Poland – key facts

Poland is the sixth-largest economy in the EU and has been one of Europe's leaders in economic growth over the past decade. It has the largest economy in Central Europe and has been leading the way in growth and development since its economic transformation commenced in 1989. One of the essential branches of the contemporary Polish economy is the business services centers sector, our sector, which continues to grow in significance, as illustrated by its increasing share in employment and GDP.

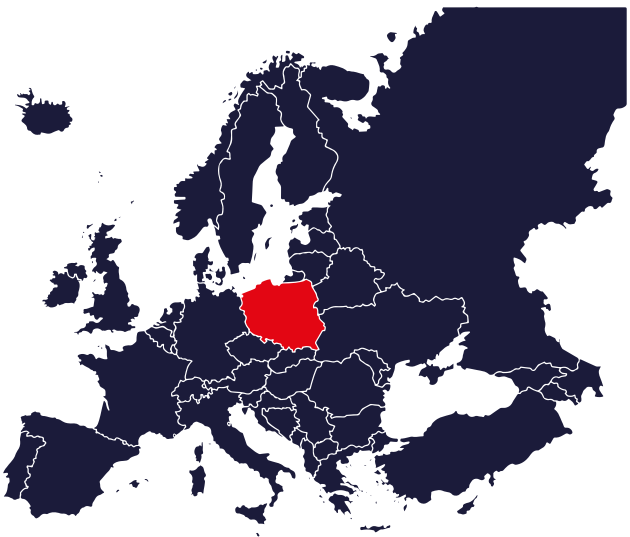
In recent years, the sector's growth has enabled Poland to strengthen its position as one of the prime and mature destinations in the EMEA region and globally. Poland is one of the prime locations for new investments in BPO/ SSC, GBS, IT, and R&D centers.

Language: **Polish**

Currency: **Złoty (PLN)**

Number of cities with more than 100,000 inhabitants: **37**

Poland in international organizations: **EU** (2004), **NATO** (1999), **OECD** (1996), **WTO** (1995), **UN** (1945).



EUR 918.4 billion

GDP in nominal prices in 2025 (6th largest EU economy, EUROSTAT)

+3.6%

GDP real growth in 2025 (Statistics Poland)

37.489 million

Population of Poland in 2024 (Statistics Poland)

81.0%

GDP per capita in PPS in 2025, in terms of the EU-27 average

103.0

Consumer price index (CPI) – March 2026 (year on year, Statistics Poland)

EUR 24,570

Nominal GDP per capita in 2025 (EUROSTAT)

EUR 17,130

Real GDP per capita in 2025 (EUROSTAT)

3.2%

Unemployment rate (February 2026, EUROSTAT)

50th position

in World Talent Ranking 2025 (IMD World Competitiveness Center), 36th in 2024, 44th in 2023, -14 positions YoY

36th position

on Global Talent Competitiveness Index 2025 rankings (INSEAD), +1 position

52st position

in World Competitiveness Ranking (IMD World Competitiveness Center), 41st in 2024, -11 positions YoY

USD 345.3 billion

Value of the inward FDI stock in Poland at the end of 2024 (UNCTAD, World Investment Report 2025)

USD 12.7 billion

FDI inflows in 2024 (UNCTAD, World Investment Report 2025)

PLN 4.2267

EUR exchange rate at the end of 2025 (NBP)

PLN 3.6016

USD exchange rate at the end of 2025 (NBP)

1

STATE OF THE BUSINESS SERVICES SECTOR IN POLAND AT THE END OF Q1 2026

Overall characteristics of the sector

At the end of Q1 2026, more than 2,179 business services centers (+2% YoY) and 1,303 companies (+2.3% YoY) were operating in our sector in Poland. They employed 500,500 people (+1.8% YoY).

In Q1 2026, the SSC/GBS segment led with the highest employment, accounting for 180,600 individuals across 523 centers. The IT segment followed, employing 158,900 people at 990 centers. The BPO subsector employed 82,900 at 310 centers, while R&D employed 56,600 in 282 centers. On a smaller scale, the hybrid/other model contributed 21,500 employees (74 centers).

Forty-six centers were established in 2025, and four in Q1 2026. These newly established 50 centers created 3,240 jobs.

Chapter content developed by: **ABSL**

As in previous years, foreign-owned centers dominated new investments (94.0% share in the number of centers). Foreign-owned centers accounted for 96.8% of total employment in these new centers. Most new jobs were created in Tier 1 (47.9%) and Tier 2 (45.0%) cities.

The most significant number of new centers was established in Tricity (10), Warsaw (9), Poznań (7), and Łódź (6). In terms of jobs created by new centers, the top three destinations were Warsaw (34.1% share in workplaces generated by new centers), Tricity (16.2%), and Katowice & GZM (10.2%).

The number of centers in Poland continues to increase. However, the new establishment's dynamics are declining. It is important to note that despite this slowdown in new investments, total employment in the sector has maintained a long-term upward trend. This is predominantly driven by organic growth in existing centers.

The growth in the number of centers occurred in two distinct waves. The first followed Poland's accession to the European Union, and the second came after the 2008 global financial crisis, as international corporations sought to optimize costs through large-scale outsourcing. The peak year for new center establishments was 2015, with 147 new centers. Since the beginning of 2025, 50 new centers have been established through the end of Q1 2026, compared with 59 in 2024, 81 in 2023, and 109 in 2022.

This sustained slowdown signals a structural shift. The sector is continuing its transition beyond its rapid expansion phase toward a more mature model, where growth is driven less by new entrants and more by scaling and transforming existing operations.

As of the end of Q1 2026, most firms (73.2%) operated a single center in Poland. In turn, 12.8% of firms ran two centers, while 10.6% operated three to five centers nationwide. Only 0.8% of respondents operated ten or more centers, often covering diverse types of centers. The market's largest operator now runs 24 centers in Poland.

IT centers remain the most common type, accounting for 45.4% of all centers. SSC/GBS follows these at 24.0% and BPO centers at 14.2%. R&D centers represent 12.9% of the total. As in previous years, hybrid/other model centers make up the smallest share at 3.4%.

From 2016 to 2026, the distribution of centers by type remained largely stable, with no significant changes in the number of entities. However, employment trends differ. SSC/GBS centers now account for a much larger share of total employment, while BPO's relative importance has decreased.

This indicates a qualitative shift in the sector. Growth is now focused on advanced, integrated operating models (SSC/GBS), while transactional BPO activities are becoming less significant. Strategically, this confirms a move toward higher value-added, knowledge-intensive services.

Key facts on the business services sector in Poland at the end of Q1 2026

6.1%

The estimated share of the sector in Poland's GDP at the end of Q1 2026 (5.7% in 2025)

7.8%

The share of the sector in the total employment in the enterprise sector in Poland (7.6% in 2025)

2,179 centers of **1,303** firms

The number of BPO, SSC / GBS, IT, and R&D business services centers in Poland

50

The number of business services centers that began operations in Poland from the beginning of 2025 until the end of Q1 2026

USD **30.1** billion

Estimate of GVA in the sector in 2024

USD **48.4** billion

The estimated overall value of the sector's exports in 2025 (USD 42.3 billion in 2024)

36.9%

Estimated share of the sector in the overall value of commercial services exports in 2025

USD **65,200**

GVA per worker in the sector in 2024, which is 27.9% above the mean GDP per worker in Poland

USD **96,700**

Mean exports per worker in the sector's centers at the end of Q1 2026 (USD 86,000 in 2025)

57

The number of countries from which centers operating in Poland originate

Germany, the **US,** the **UK,** the **Netherlands, Switzerland,** and **France**

The sector's export destinations with a value exceeding USD two billion, with a value for Germany exceeding USD six billion

63.4%

Share of mid-office process work in the sector's centers at the end of Q1 2026

58.2%

Share of knowledge-intensive work in sector's centers at the end of Q1 2026

24.4%

Mean reported automation rate at the end of Q1 2026 (20.0% – median automation rate)

500,500

The total number of jobs in business services centers at the end of Q1 2026 (84.5%, foreign-owned)

16.5%

The share of foreigners in overall employment

1.8%

Year-on-year increase in the number of jobs in business services centers in Poland (+ 8,860 FTEs in absolute numbers)

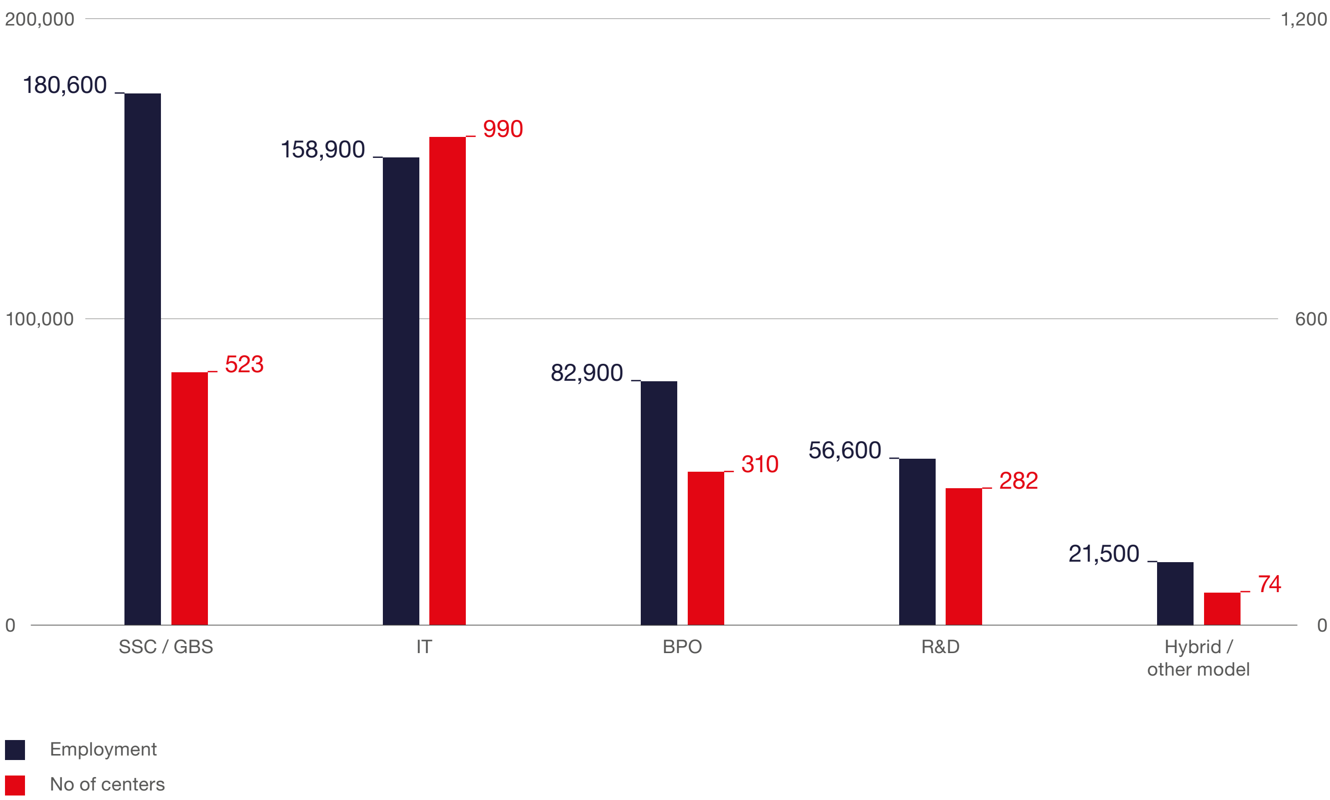
9

The number of locations where business services centers employ more than 10,000 people. Two cities with employment exceeding 100,000 jobs – Warsaw and Kraków

13.0 million m^2

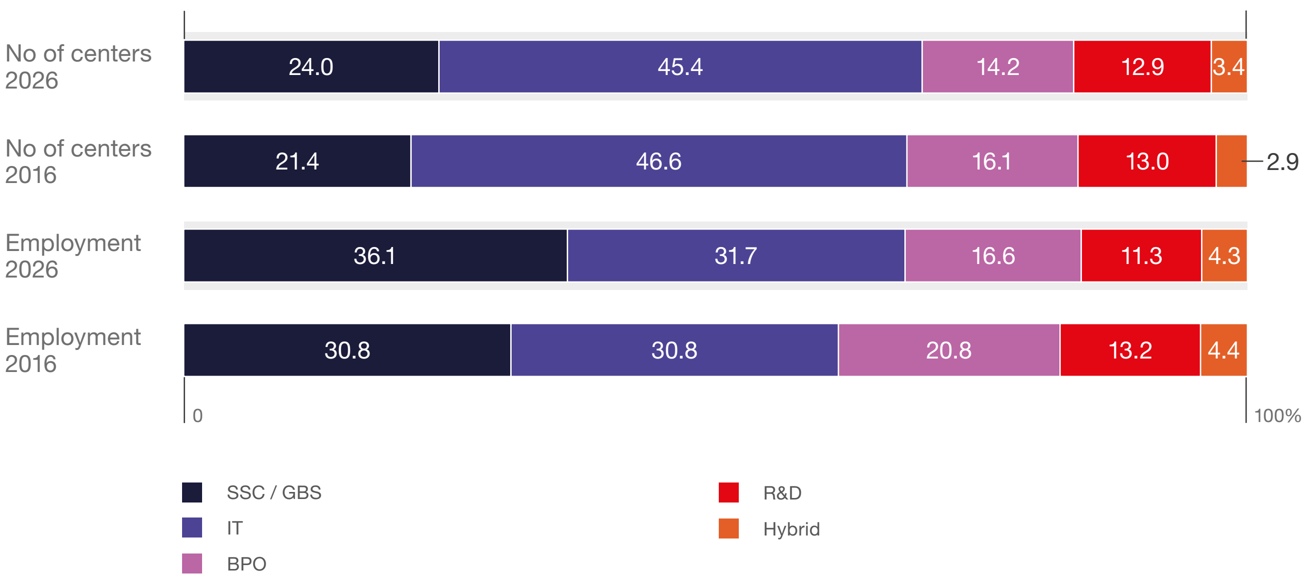
The total modern office supply in Poland at the beginning of 2026

FIGURE 1.1 | **Employment and number of centers by center type** (at the end of Q1 2026)



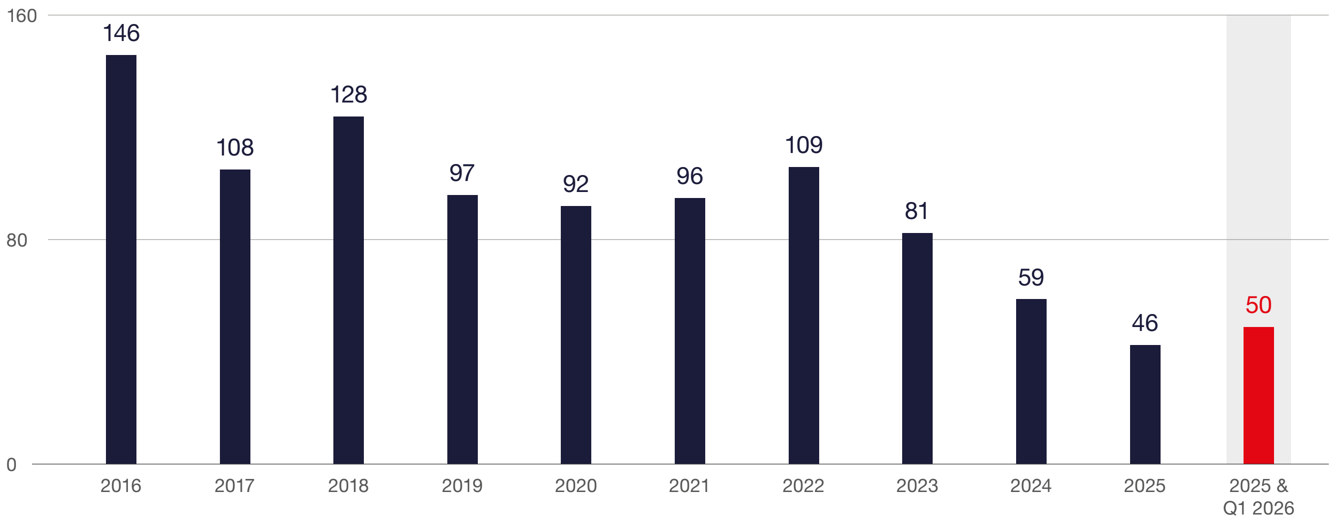
Source: ABSL business services centers database.

FIGURE 1.2 | **Distribution of the number of centers and employment by type** (%) (at the end of Q1 2026, compared to 2016)



Source: ABSL business services centers database.

FIGURE 1.3 | **Number of centers opened by date of establishment**



Source: ABSL business services centers database.

The number of centers and structures of new investments

As of the end of Q1 2026, **Warsaw** further strengthened its position as the largest hub, **reaching 448 active centers.** Other major locations remained stable in the top tier, with **Kraków (319), Wrocław (259),** and **Tricity (231),** confirming a mature and highly concentrated market structure. The second tier continues to be led by **Poznań (174), Katowice & GZM (165),** and **Łódź (139),** all maintaining solid scale but without material acceleration. Tier 3 cities remain significantly smaller, including **Lublin (80), Szczecin (71), Rzeszów (53),** and **Bydgoszcz (51),** reinforcing the persistent structural gap between leading and emerging locations.

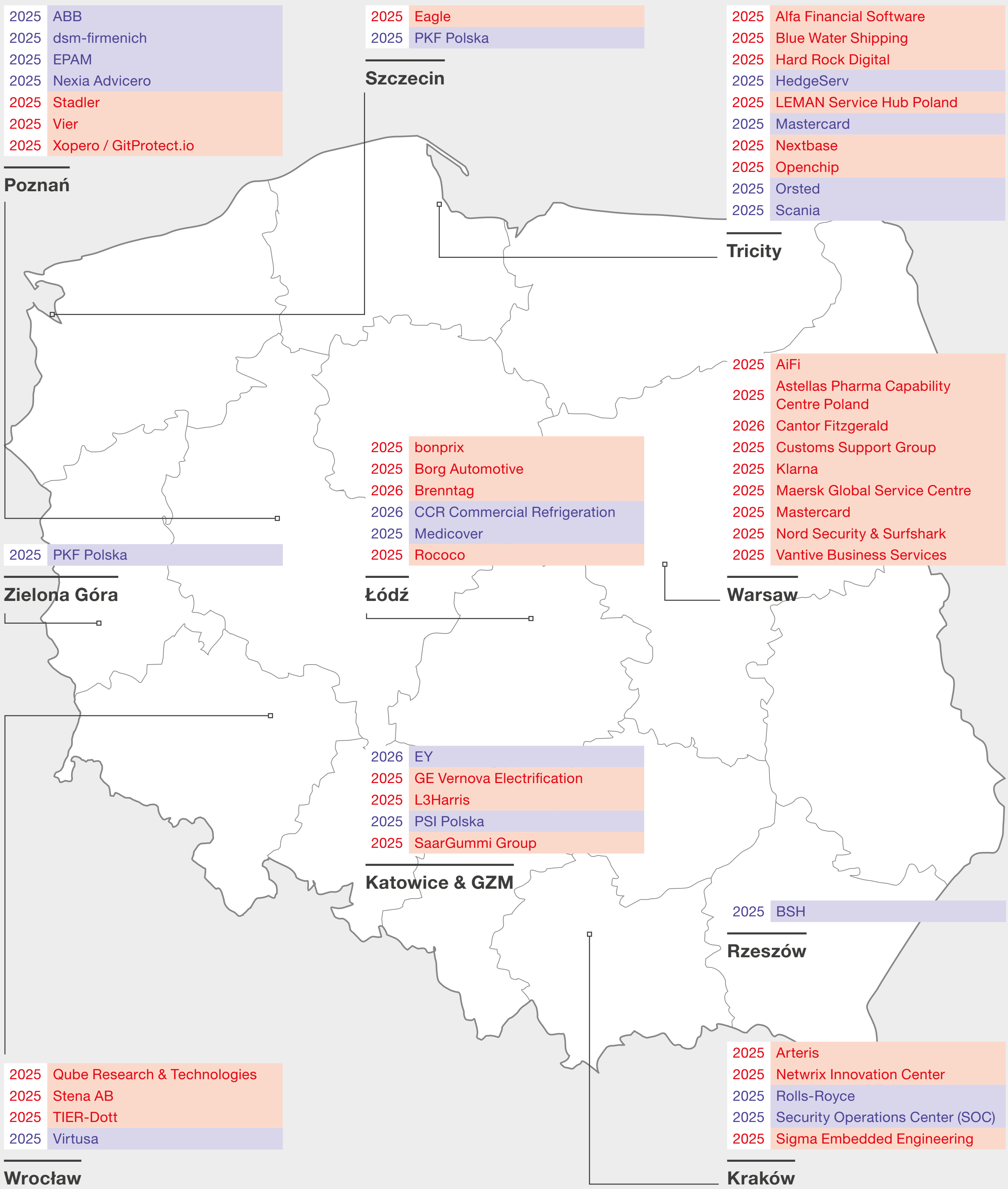
New investment activity in 2025 and Q1 2026 remained below the peak levels observed in earlier years, confirming the ongoing structural slowdown in new center establishments. However, the market is not stagnant. Investment continues to be broadly distributed across major Tier 1 and Tier 2 locations, with particularly strong inflows into Tricity (10 new centers), Warsaw (9), Poznań (7), Łódź (6), and Kraków and Katowice & GZM (5 each).

Investors continue to favor established ecosystems, but expansion is now focused on incremental, capacity-driven growth **within existing hubs.** Tier 1 cities (Warsaw, Kraków, Wrocław) and Tier 2 cities remain dominant, while the **number of locations attracting new investments has narrowed further,** concentrating activity in a select group of proven markets.

During 2018-2021, up to 17 cities attracted new projects. By 2024, this number had declined to nine, and early 2026 data show no significant **re-expansion of the geographic footprint.** This reflects a structural consolidation of location choices.

> This marks a critical shift in the sector. **Poland has moved from extensive growth driven by new locations to an intensive phase focused on scaling, upgrading, and optimizing existing hubs.**

FIGURE 1.4 | **Selected new investments in particular business service's locations in Poland** (2025 and Q1 2026)



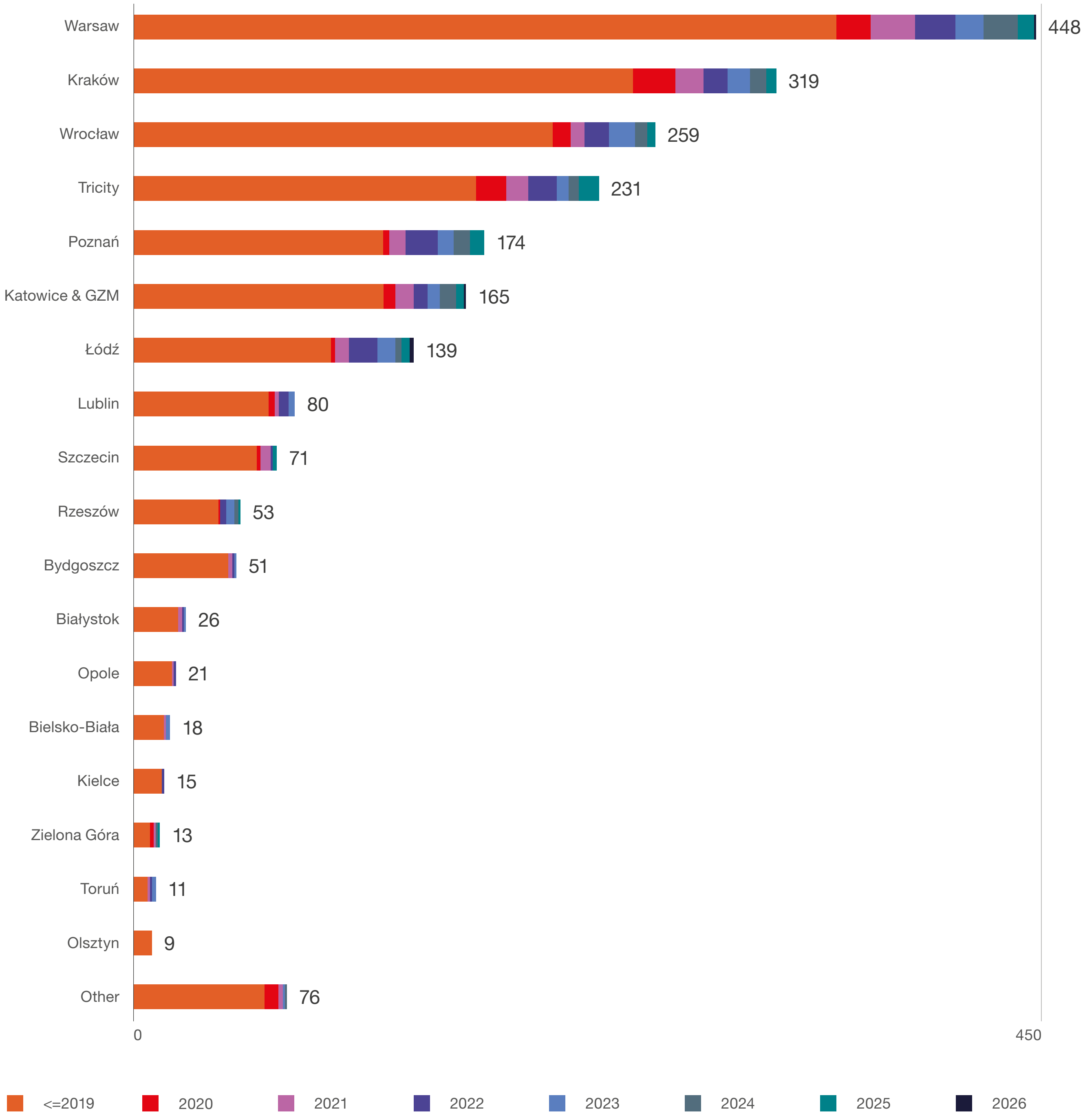
New investors = first business services center established in Poland

Recent investments by existing investors = another business services center opened in Poland

Source: ABSL business services centers database.

FIGURE 1.5

The number of active centers in the most important locations in Poland at the end of Q1 2025, by year of establishment



Source: ABSL business services centers database.

Mergers and closures of the centers

Based on updated data covering the period 2016-Q1 to 2026, we have identified approximately 81 centers that were either closed (51) or acquired (30). This marks a visible increase compared to previous editions of the report, driven primarily by a higher number of closures in recent years.

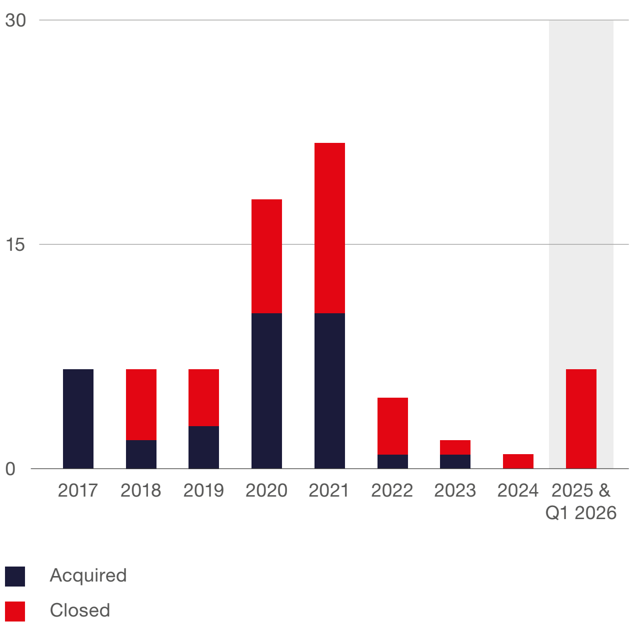
In terms of employment, the impact remains concentrated in earlier years, particularly around 2020-2022, when both acquisitions and closures affected the largest number of employees. In total, the employment impact remains skewed toward acquired centers, which tend to be larger, while closures are more frequent but typically involve smaller entities. We expected this adjustment. It was already anticipated in the 2021-2022 ABSL reports as a natural consequence of automation, global restructuring, and the reconfiguration of business services models. The process is now underway, although at a slower pace than initially projected. The collective layoffs announced in 2024 at several large centers are feeding into employment dynamics in 2025 and 2026. The latest data confirm a rise in closures in 2025 and early 2026. The impact on total employment remained contained in 2025.

This reflects the underlying nature of the adjustment. In many cases, closures are linked to global M&A activity, portfolio restructuring, or the relocation of specific functions globally. These processes, nonetheless, tended to be selective at least for the time being. The impact of AI is growing, and the shift to agentic AI will accelerate over the next 24 months.

Simultaneously, a countervailing trend could become more visible in the coming years as geostrategic fragmentation grows. Alongside restructuring, there will be a growing number of reshoring and reinvestment cases, including the return or expansion of activities in Poland through backshoring.

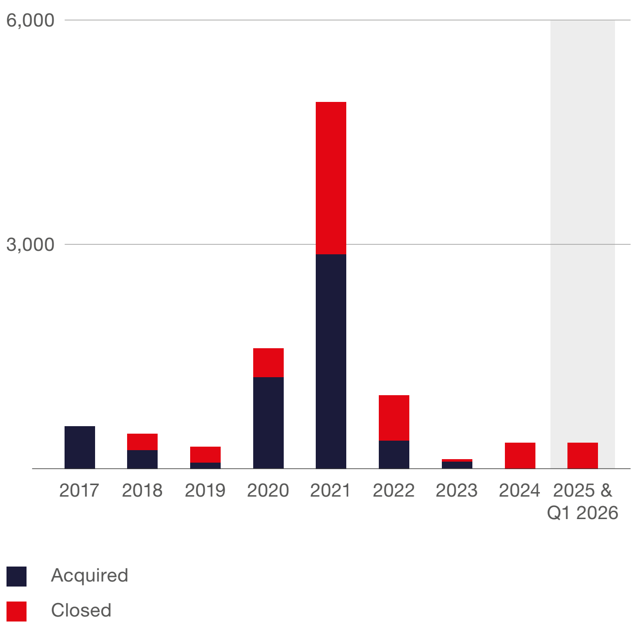
Taken together, these dynamics point to a gradual reconfiguration of the sector. The adjustment is selective, uneven, and structurally driven, with simultaneous exits, transformations, and new inflows shaping the system.

FIGURE 1.6 **Mergers and closures of the centers**



Source: ABSL business services centers database.

FIGURE 1.7 **Mergers and closures of the centers – reductions in employment levels**



Source: ABSL business services centers database.

Client base structure

The sector remains largely captive, with 76.4% of activity from internal group clients and only 23.3% from external sources. This demonstrates that Poland's business services model remains primarily based on GBS/GCC.

At the same time, the structure of external exposure reveals a clear shift. The distribution is highly polarized: around one-quarter of centers serve no external clients, while a smaller group generates 90–100% of its revenue from external clients. The limited presence of hybrid models indicates that the sector is not evolving gradually but rather bifurcating into distinct operating models. This bifurcation is a key signal of structural maturation. The sector is no longer homogeneous.

It differentiates between centers focused on internal efficiency and those operating as commercially driven, externally validated service providers. The latter group represents a new phase of development. Larger external exposure reflects a move toward higher-value, outcome-based services, stronger pricing power, and deeper integration into market dynamics. These centers are effectively transitioning from internal support functions to competitive service platforms.

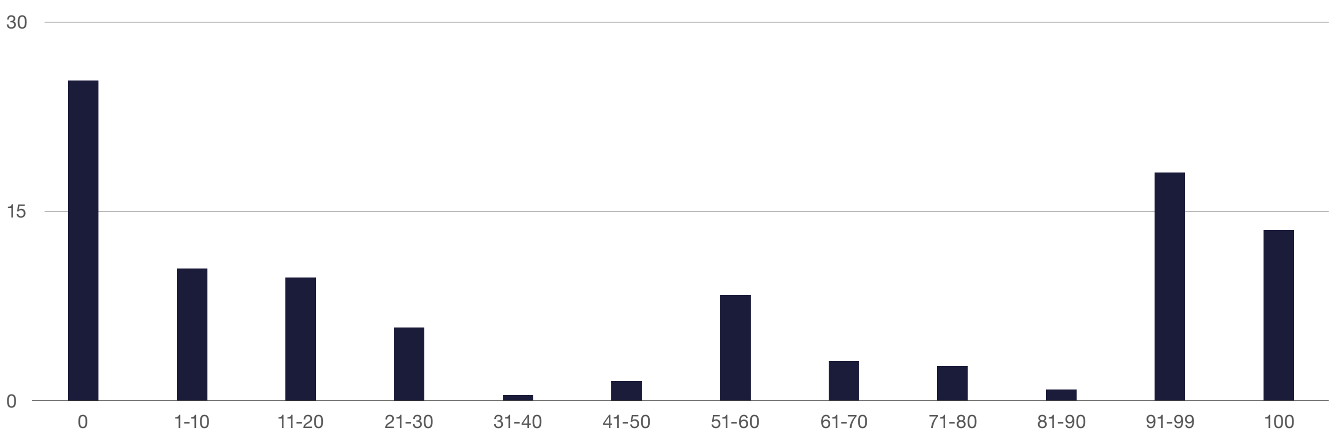
Centers that remain fully captive continue to play a critical role in global models, but their positioning is increasingly defined by cost efficiency, scale, and process optimization.

Taken together, this dual structure does not indicate a weakness. It reflects a maturing system in which different business models coexist, each aligned with distinct strategic roles.

FIGURE 1.8 | **Client base mix (approximate share of revenue or activity)** (%)

Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=202).

FIGURE 1.9 | **Share of external clients in centers' revenue**



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=202).

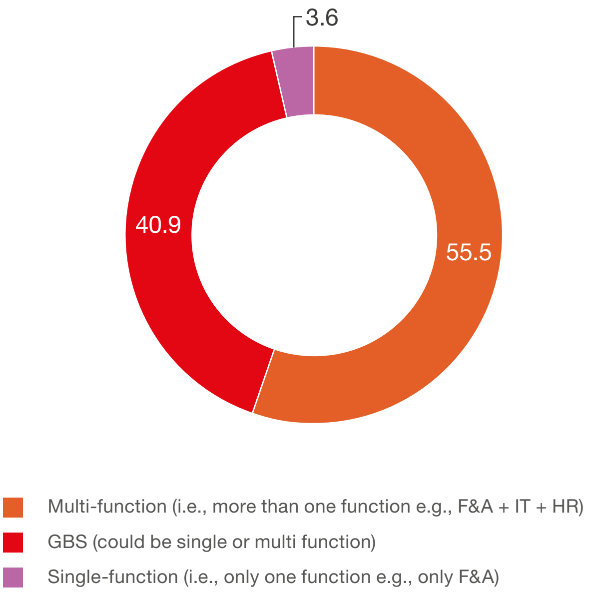
Services provided and operating models

Multifunctional model of operation remains the primary model, with 55.5% of centers combining functions such as finance, IT, and HR. These centers achieve scale by expanding their range of services and client base. The model is evolving. GBS structures now represent 40.9% of centers. This shift from functional aggregation to end-to-end process ownership improves alignment with business units, increases accountability, and positions centers more directly within transformation initiatives.

Single-function models have largely disappeared (only 3.6% of centers). This confirms that narrowly scoped delivery is no longer viable.

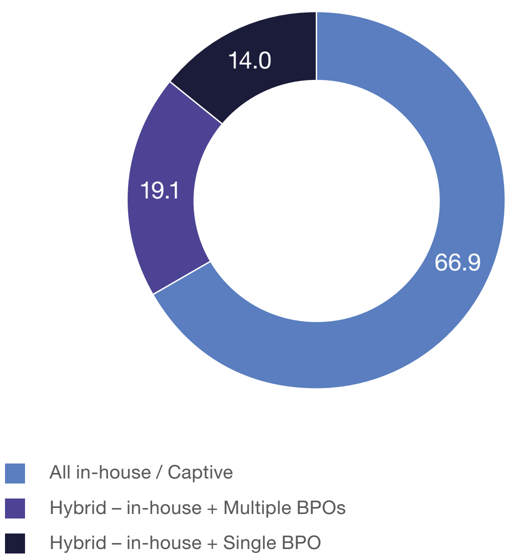
The in-house model remains dominant at 66.9%, driven by the need for process and data control in complex, regulated environments. However, **hybrid setups are gaining importance,** with nearly one-third of centers using external partners to extend capabilities and capacity.

FIGURE 1.10 | **Shared services operating model (SSC / GBS respondents only)** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=137).

FIGURE 1.11 | **How is your shared services operating model resourced? (SSC / GBS respondents only)** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=136).

Geographic range of services

Services delivered from Poland are primarily focused on Europe, with more selective coverage in other regions of the world. The sector is closely integrated with European markets. **Western Europe is the main destination (89.1% of respondents), reflecting strong ties with established EU economies.** Central and Eastern Europe (73.1%), Nordic countries (70.5%), and Southern Europe (69.4%) also play significant roles. The domestic market, Poland, is important, with 78.2% of centers serving clients in Poland, mainly due to multinational companies operating locally.

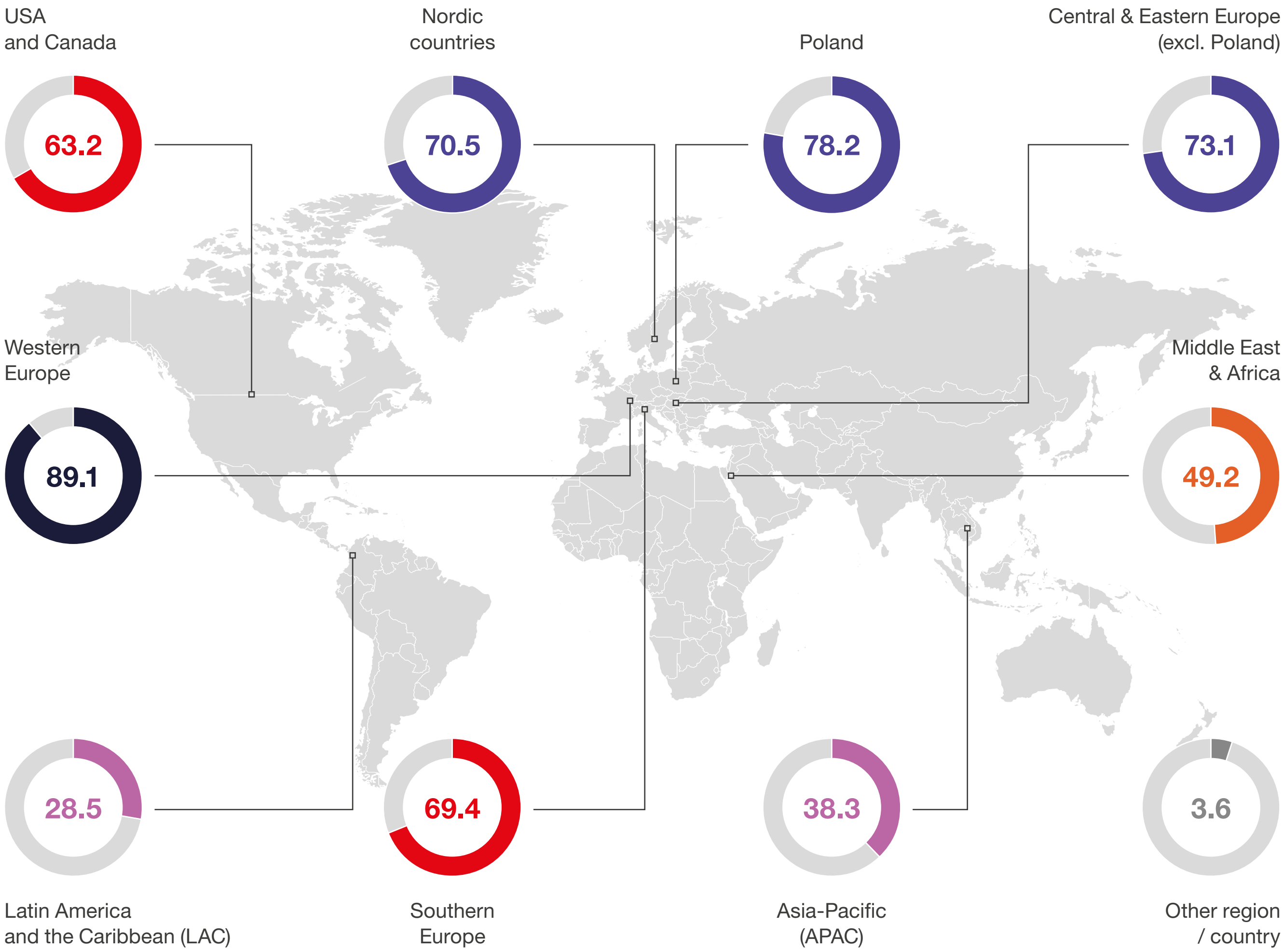
Outside Europe, North America is the only non-European market with significant scale (63.2%), demonstrating the sector's capacity to support transatlantic operations despite time-zone differences. Other regions, including the Middle East and Africa (49.2%), Asia-Pacific (38.3%), and Latin America (28.5%), play a secondary role.

Looking from the country-served perspective, service provision is concentrated in a small group of core markets. Germany (70.3%) and the UK (61.1%) are the leading destinations, followed by France (49.2%) and the US (38.4%). A second tier of European markets, such as Spain, Italy, the Netherlands, and Sweden, further demonstrates the Europe-centered distribution. Outside Europe, markets like Brazil and the UAE are less common, indicating gradual but limited global diversification.

This geographical structure aligns with the EMEA region's operational model. Poland's location in the Central European Time zone allows real-time collaboration with most European markets and efficient integration with Middle Eastern operations. Servicing processes in North America, though significant, often require extended hours or asynchronous models. Greater time zone differences limit operations in Asia-Pacific and Latin America, despite the sector's technical capability to serve these regions.

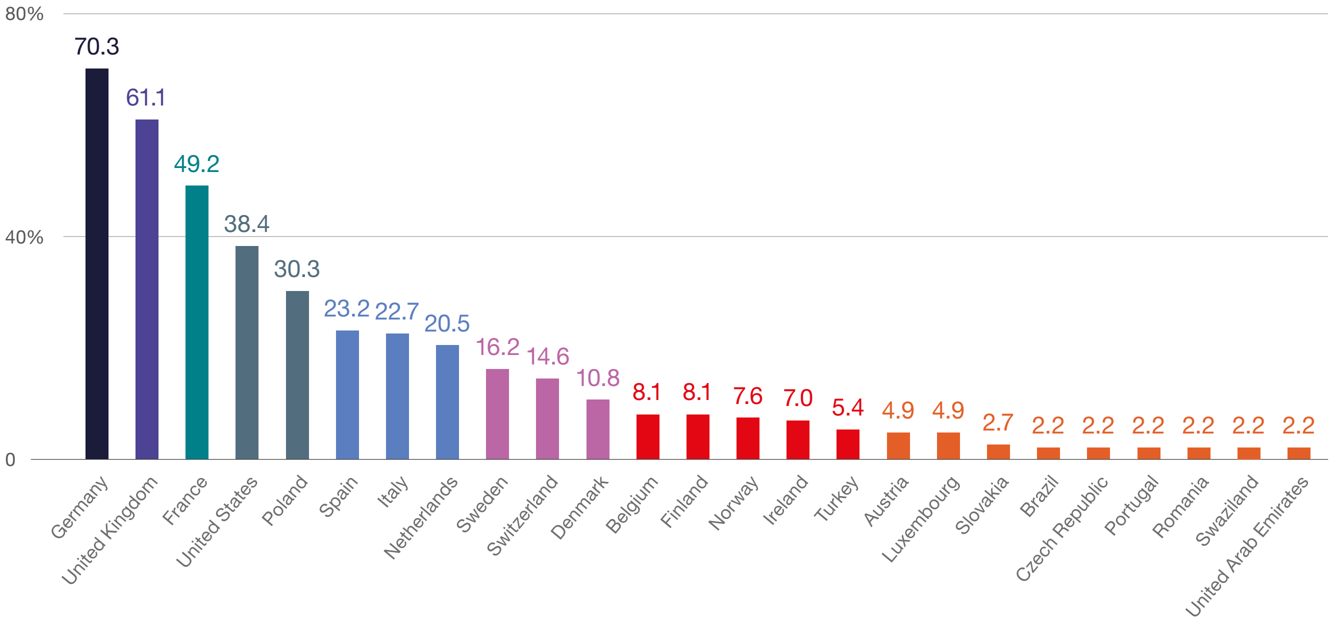
> **The sector functions as a European nearshore platform with global reach. Its geographic footprint is broad but remains structurally centered on Europe, where proximity, including cultural proximity and ties, regulatory alignment, and integration with client operations drive demand for services.**

FIGURE 1.12 | **The geographical range of services provided from Poland** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=193).

FIGURE 1.13 **The most important countries for which centers provide services from Poland** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=185).

Categories of processes supported

We would like to note that the list of processes has been modified compared with prior years, which may affect the interpretation of results.

The 2026 list of processes shows a clear broadening and rebalancing of the process landscape.

First, there is a visible shift from a functionally siloed structure (dominated by F&A, HR, and IT buckets) toward a more horizontal, capability-based taxonomy. New cross-functional layers appear, including data, analytics, process management, transformation, and AI, cutting across traditional domains.

Second, the scope expands materially into advanced and emerging capabilities. In 2026, we explicitly captured:

- **AI stack** (GenAI, ML, agentic workflows),
- **Data layer** (data engineering, governance, BI, advanced analytics),
- **Transformation layer** (change management, PMO, process standardization),
- **R&D and industry-specific work** (incl. healthcare, engineering).

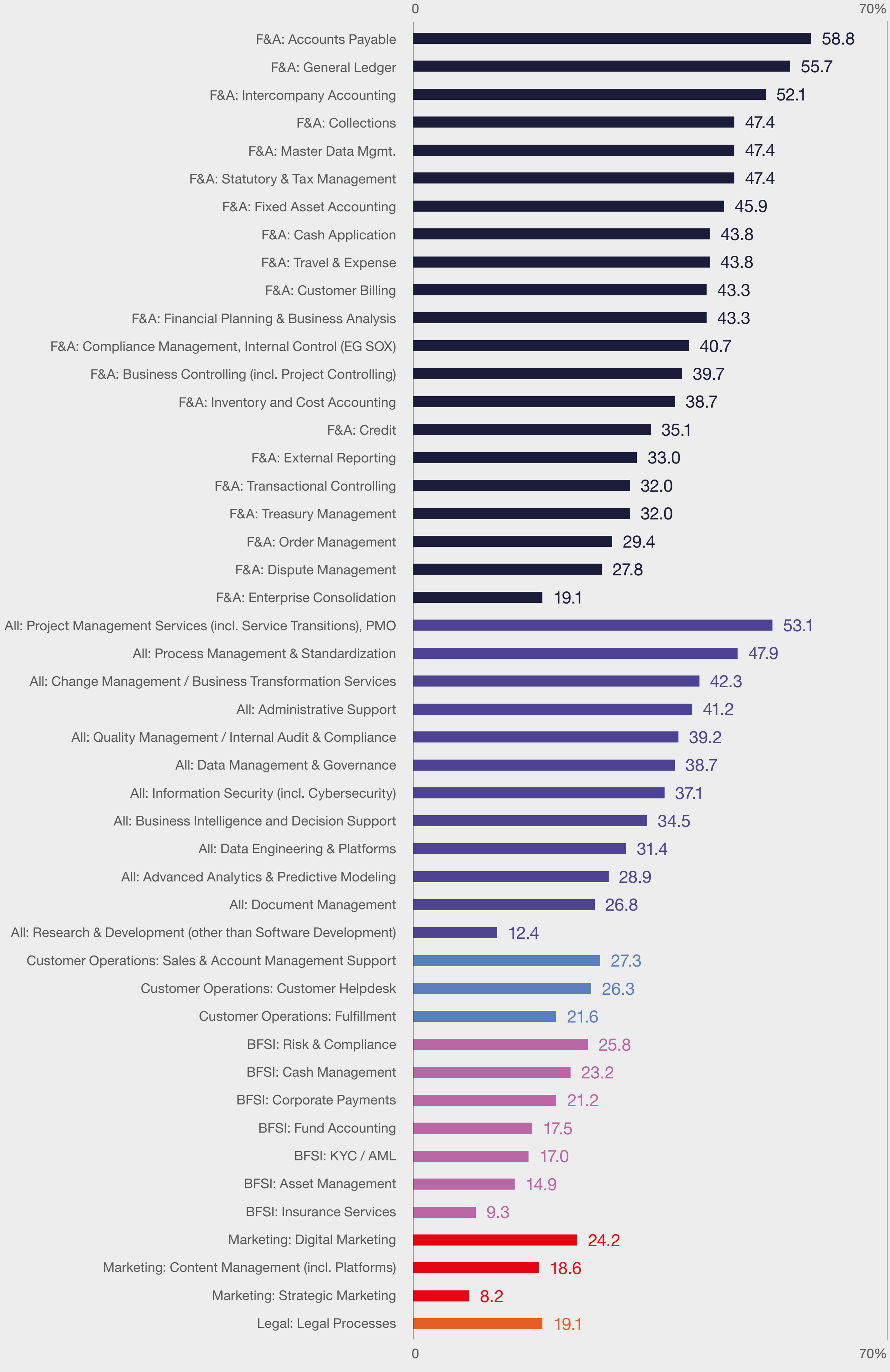
These were either fragmented or only implicitly covered in the prior classification. Third, traditional areas (F&A, HR, IT, procurement, supply chain) are still fully present, but now embedded within a much richer value chain, instead of dominating the taxonomy.

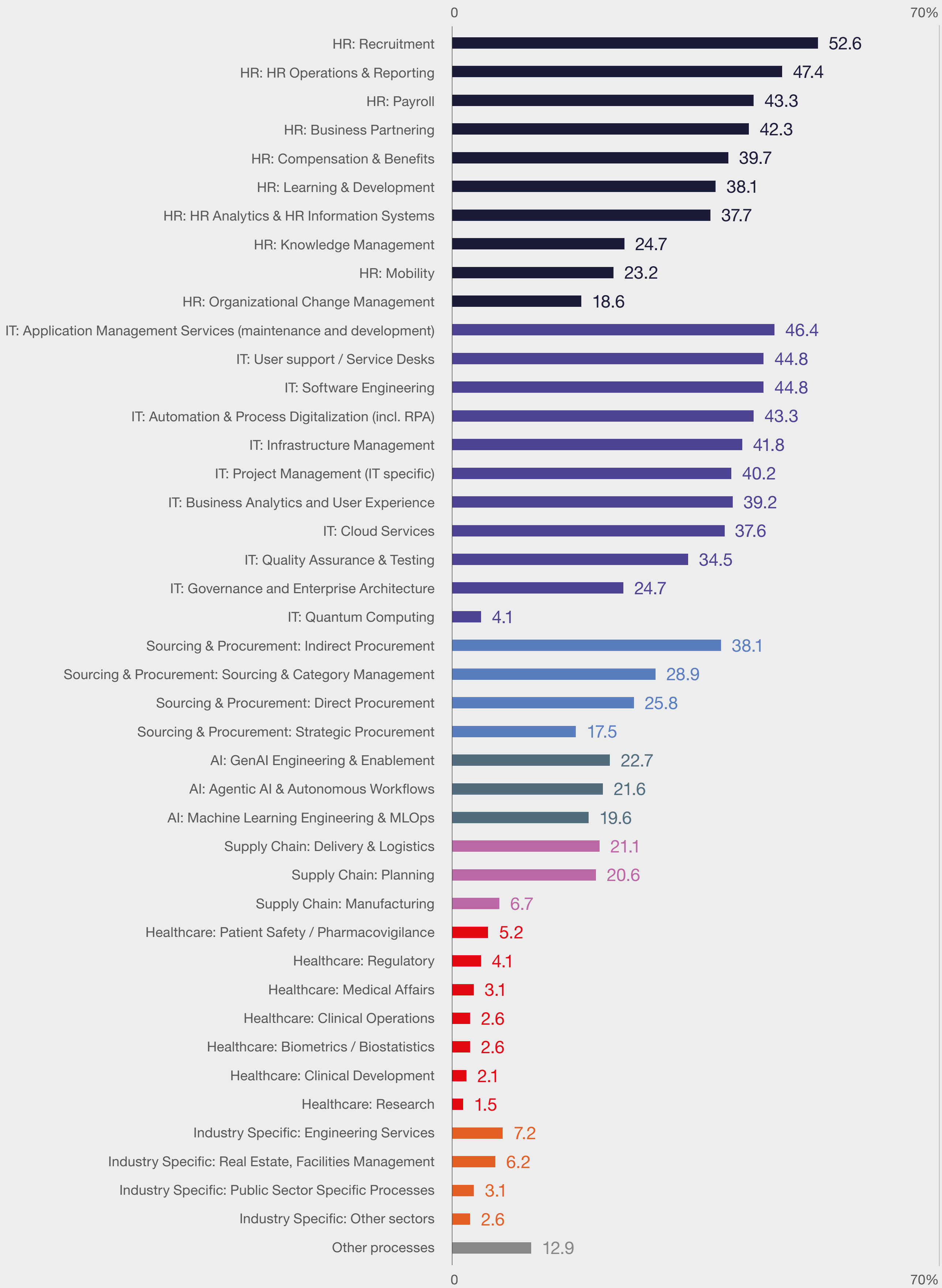
The total number of process categories increased from 80 to 90. We aim to review the list every three years.

Poland remains strongly anchored in current business operations and global structures. This should be understood as the sector's functional role within global organizations, not as a statement about the simplicity of work performed in Poland. **Many operational roles are already complex, analytical, and knowledge-intensive, even when they remain embedded in ongoing business operations.**

This reflects a model in which complexity is increasing within operational roles. However, we do not see a full shift toward strategic ownership of activities as of now.

FIGURE 1.14 | **Service functions provided by centers based in Poland** (%)





Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=194).

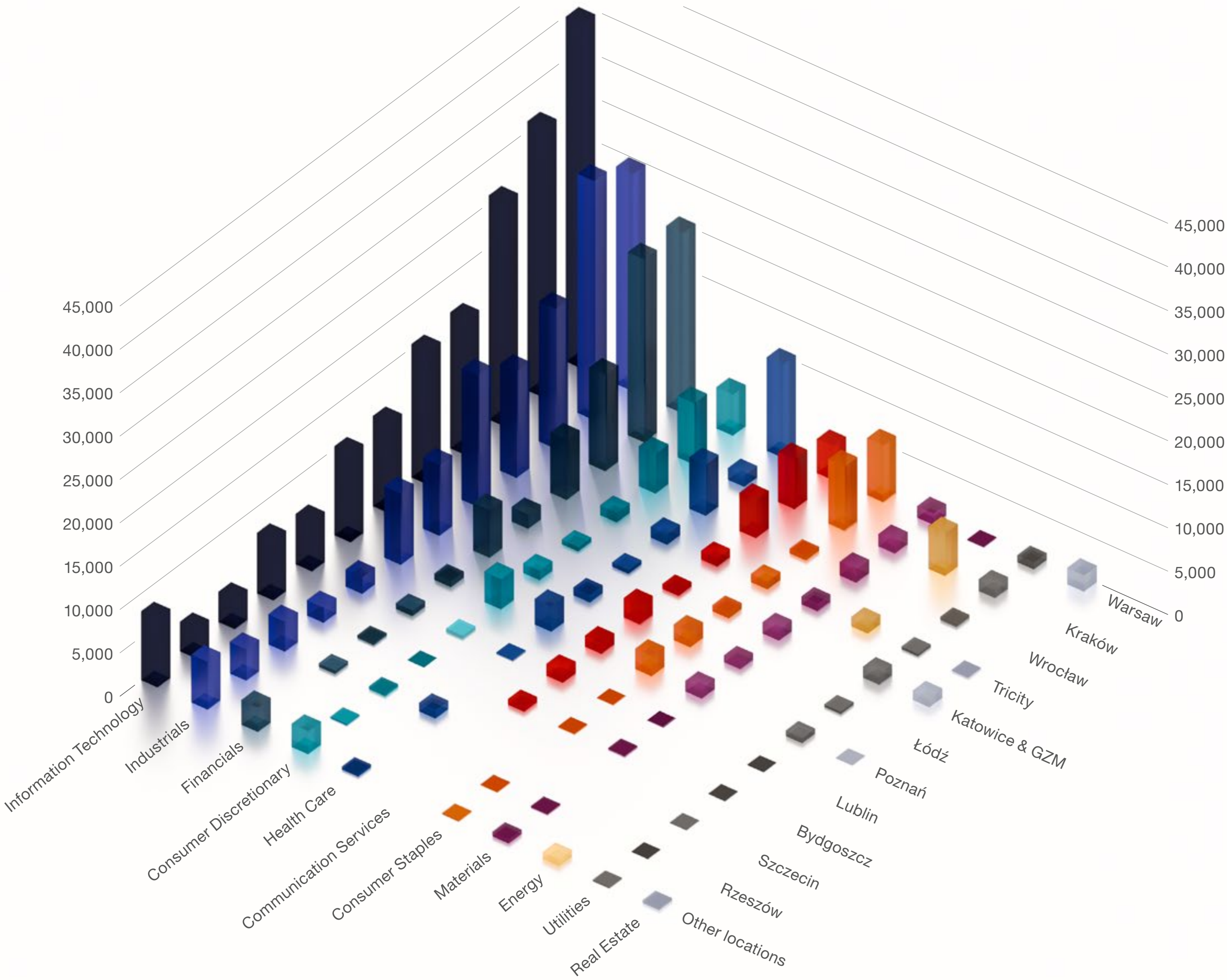
Vertical deep dive

The sector is shifting from broad diversification toward scale and depth in a limited set of dominant verticals. Data from 2026 confirms ongoing **concentration in three core pillars: IT, Industrials,** and **BFSI,** which collectively define the sector's economic foundation.

IT continues to serve as the primary anchor in all major locations, with Warsaw (over 40,000), Kraków (over 31,000), and Wrocław (over 26,000) operating at a significantly larger scale than other markets. This reflects not only scale but also a concentration of full-stack capabilities, including engineering, cloud, data, and AI enablement.

IT dominance is system-wide and not city-specific, showing Poland's position as a multi-city platform. Industrials and BFSI constitute the second structural layer, exhibiting distinct spatial patterns.

FIGURE 1.15 | **Employment by the main sector served and the location of the center**



Source: ABSL business services centers database.

Industrials are more evenly distributed across Tier 1 and Tier 2 cities, such as Kraków (approximately 28,000), Warsaw (approximately 25,000), Katowice (approximately 15,000), and Wrocław (approximately 16,000). In contrast, BFSI remains **highly concentrated in Warsaw and Kraków (approximately 21,000 each), with a marked decline outside these primary hubs.**

Beyond the top three verticals, the sector's structure becomes significantly less pronounced. Consumer, Healthcare, and Communication services represent **material but distinctly secondary layers,** with selective concentration, such as Healthcare in Warsaw (approximately 10,800) and Wrocław (approximately 6,000). All other verticals, including **Energy, Utilities, Real Estate, and Materials, remain fragmented** and below critical mass in most locations. In Tricity, for instance, we can see a relatively high share of Scandinavian investors, as well as a specialization in services for the maritime and aviation industries.

> The sector demonstrates a **replicated multi-vertical model across major cities rather than true vertical specialization.** Warsaw, Kraków, and Wrocław each host **similar vertical stacks** that differ primarily in scale.

Vertical embedding – what does the survey confirm?

In addition to this year's ABSL centers database, the survey provides further insights into the sector's vertical dimension in Poland.

Survey results confirm that the sector is servicing multiple industries. Activity is concentrated in a few core verticals: **BFSI (33%), IT/ICT, Health, and Pharma (approximately 23% each),** and **Automotive, FMCG, and Professional Services (approximately 18-20%).** These sectors have a strong demand for standardized, scalable functions in finance, IT, compliance, and analytics.

A long tail of industries shows significantly lower penetration (typically 5-15). It indicates that most centers operate across multiple sectors rather than focusing on deep specialization within a single vertical.

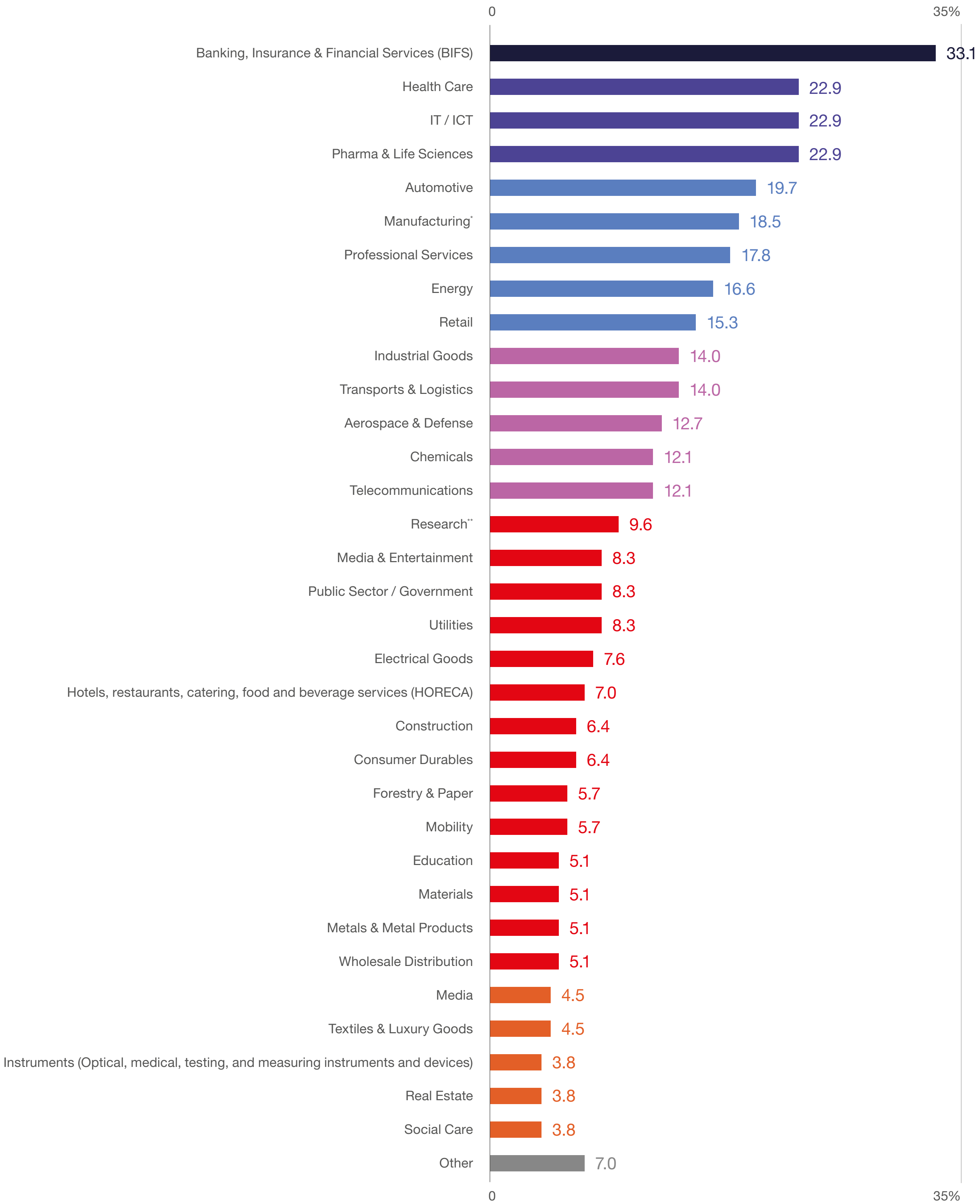
Within the leading verticals, the work is concentrated in transactional and mid-office processes, reporting, compliance, analytical support, and technology enablement functions.

There is limited evidence of end-to-end ownership of industry processes, operating models structured around specific verticals, or responsibility for business outcomes at the industry level.

> The sector in Poland is thus functionally integrated with different verticals but **only partially embedded in their core value chains.**

Just to illustrate the vertical focus practically, Tri-City, for instance, hosts a unique concentration of aviation and maritime service platforms, where traditional sector boundaries blur into integrated engineering, data, and software-driven capabilities supporting global transport and logistics systems. This includes aviation-focused centers such as Boeing (via Jeppesen), Lufthansa Systems, and Airbus, alongside maritime and offshore players such as DNV, Hapag Lloyd, Kongsberg Maritime, and Aker Solutions, increasingly complemented by hybrid digital platforms operating across both domains. For geographical reasons Tricity also hosts a larger concentration of Scandinavian corporations.

FIGURE 1.16 **Client industries (verticals) in which your center currently delivers services** (%)



* of food, beverages, and tobacco for fast–moving consumer markets (FMCG)
** in sciences, engineering, social sciences, and innovation development (R&D)

Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=157).

Value chain position – current role of centers

Centers have moved beyond transactional roles. Their focus, however, remains mainly operational and not strategic.

The strongest areas of engagement are:

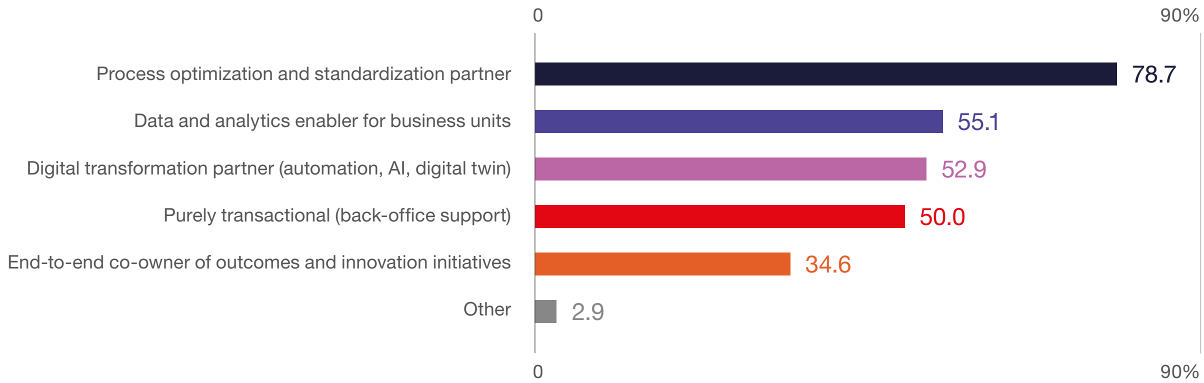
process optimization and standardization (78.7%),

data and analytics support (55.1%),

digital transformation enablement (52.9%).

At the same time, only **34.6% of centers act as end-to-end co-owners of outcomes and innovation.**

FIGURE 1.17 **To what extent is your center integrated into the core value chain of your clients within the industries you serve?** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=136).

Business impact – nature of value delivered

Centers deliver tangible, measurable value to their vertical clients. The impact is clearly concentrated in core operational outcomes. The most frequently reported outcomes include:

operational efficiency and cost reduction (77.5%),

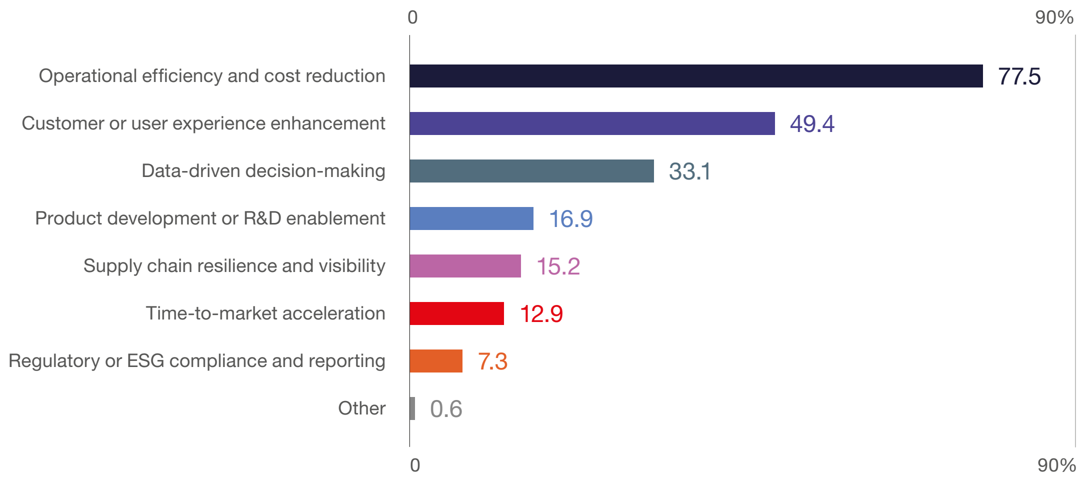
customer experience improvement (49.4%),

data-driven decision-making (33.1%).

More advanced or strategic contributions are less common but strategically significant. These include product development/R&D enablement (16.9%), supply chain resilience (15.2%), and time-to-market acceleration (12.9%). Their share is increasing as the sector gradually expands toward higher-value, transformation-oriented services.

The sector generates value mainly through efficiency and process improvements, with more limited impact, at least at this stage, on innovation and core business transformation. This would require a shift towards GenBS.

FIGURE 1.18 **Which business outcomes has your center improved the most for its clients over the past two years?** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=178).

The current maturity profile of technology in servicing clients

The adoption of technology and AI follows a layered structure – this will be discussed at length in Part 3, Technology and AI, of the report.

The dominant technologies in servicing clients are at this stage:

robotic process automation (38.4%),

standardized digital workflows (27.2%).

More advanced solutions are less widespread:

generative AI (16.0%),

advanced analytics/machine learning (15.2%).

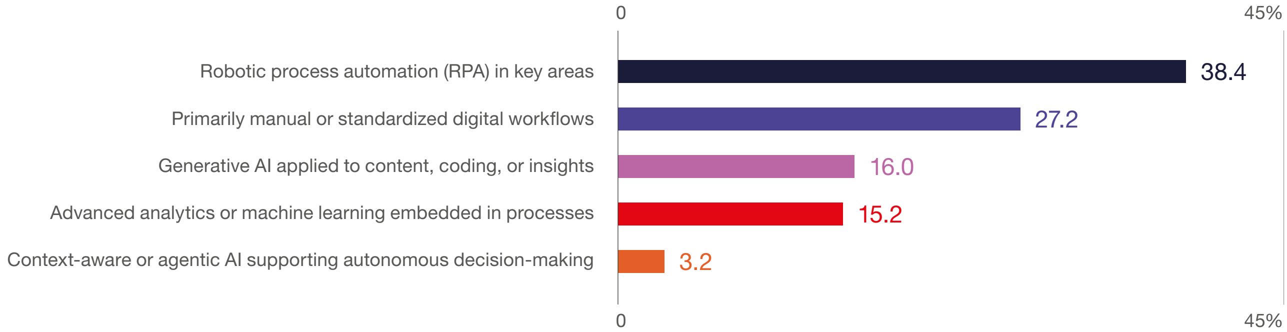
The most advanced capabilities, like context-aware or agentic AI (3.2%) remain at a very early stage of adoption.

Most centers continue to focus on improving existing processes. Technology is primarily used to increase efficiency, and full AI-driven process transformations remain limited.

We may be seeing a classic **S-curve transition from efficiency to transformation.** Firms have largely exhausted low-risk, low-CAPEX automation options such as simple RPA and workflow digitization. The next stage, involving GenAI and agentic systems, demands significantly higher investment, stronger governance, more data and compute resources, and the redesign of the centers' operating model to better serve clients.

Looking ahead, respondents clearly identify transformation areas that differ from the current operating model.

FIGURE 1.19 **Current level of technology and AI adoption in services provided to your client industries** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=125).

The most important expected drivers are:

AI-driven process reinvention (71.3%),

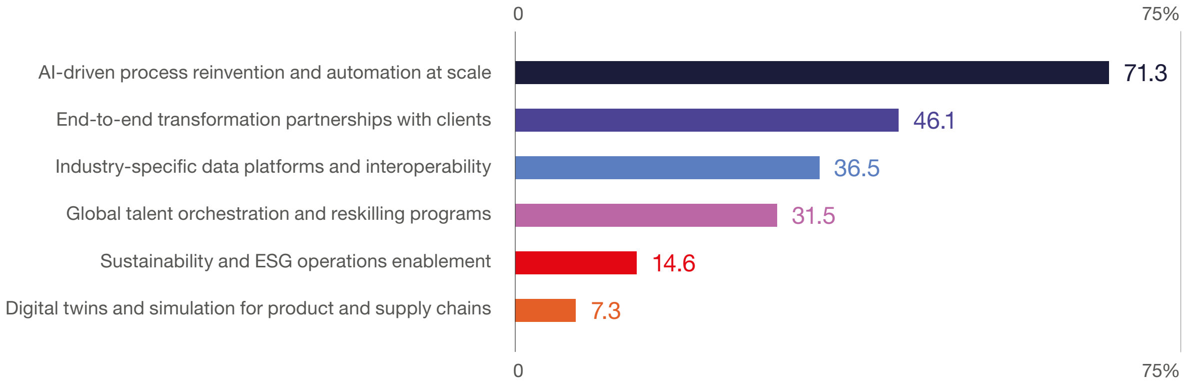
end-to-end transformation partnerships (46.1%),

industry data platforms and interoperability (36.5%),

talent orchestration and reskilling (31.5%).

This reflects a shift in expectations from process execution to broader roles in process redesign, data integration, and capability coordination. However, a clear gap exists between the stated direction and actual maturity in technology adoption and value chain positioning.

FIGURE 1.20 **Looking ahead to 2030, which of the following will most transform your client industries through center-delivered capabilities?** (%)



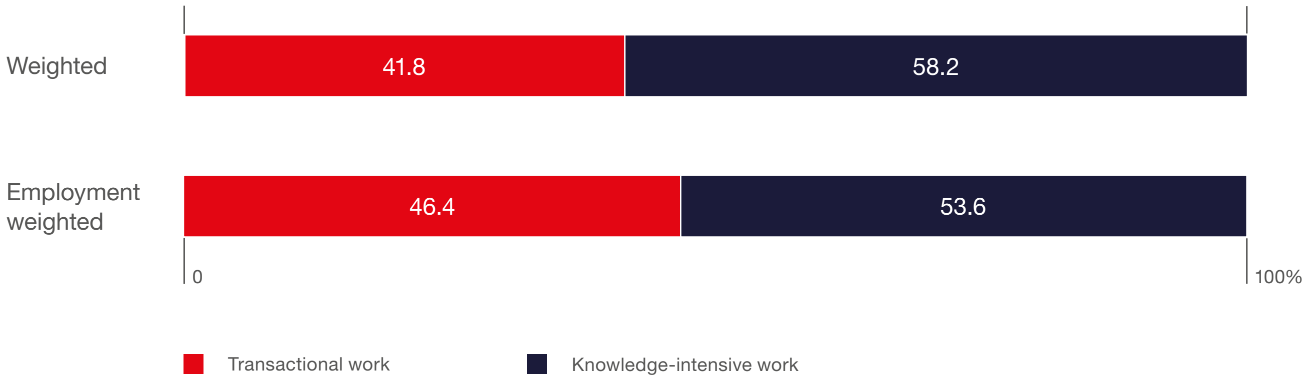
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=178).

Sophistication of processes

Poland's business services sector is evolving, with a steady shift toward more advanced operations. Respondents estimated the ratio of transactional to knowledge-intensive work. Transactional tasks require less than six months of training, while knowledge-intensive tasks require six months or more.

From that perspective, the sector operates at a high level of process sophistication. In 2026, knowledge-intensive activities account for 58.2% of employment (weighted) and 53.6% (unweighted), confirming their dominant role in the sector's structure. The data indicate that **the shift toward more advanced work is not only sustained but continues at the margin.** The increase in unweighted results suggests a gradual broadening of this model, beyond the largest and most mature operations.

FIGURE 1.21 **The estimate of the transactional vs. knowledge-intensive work ratio in your centers in Poland** (at the end of Q1 2026) (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=198).

Back-office, mid-office, front office functions

The structural shift is evident. **Back-office activities declined from 53% in 2021 to 33.3% in 2026. Mid-office functions increased from 46% to 63.4%, becoming the dominant segment. Front-office roles remain limited but stable at around 3%.**

Process categories in business services centers align with organizational roles. Back-office functions focus on administrative and transactional support. Middle-office roles handle more complex activities such as analytics, control, and governance. Front-office positions are client-facing and typically connected to headquarters-level functions.

This represents a sustained multi-year transition, not a temporary adjustment. The sector has gradually reduced reliance on transactional activities and reallocated capacity to more complex, expertise-driven functions. This demonstrates a continued process of upgrading and ongoing upskilling of work in Poland.

TABLE 1.1 | **Evolution of back / mid / front-office work at the centers in Poland**

	2026	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2026–2021
Back-office	33.3	42.7	43.7	51.4	51.7	52.9	-19.6
Middle-office	63.4	54.2	52.9	47.6	47.2	46.1	17.3
Front-office	3.3	3.0	3.4	1.0	1.1	1.0	2.3

Source: ABSL BI based on survey results 2021-26.

The complexity–value matrix: process-driven sources of competitive advantage

For the first time in this year's report, we classify all ABSL business services processes by complexity and value. **This matrix looks inside the work performed by centers. It complements the earlier analysis of processes and functions carried out in our centers by showing that a still delivery-oriented system can also include a large share of complex, high-value activities.**

In 2024, Amit Joshi of IMD Lausanne introduced a simplified 2×2 framework that maps business activities along two dimensions: organizational value and required complexity (or creativity). This framework was originally intended to prioritize AI use cases. High-value, low-complexity tasks represent the greatest near-term potential for automation, whereas high-complexity activities rely on human judgment.

Expanding upon this conceptual foundation, we have developed a more granular, 3×3 matrix to represent the structure of business services processes more accurately. This enhanced framework enables finer differentiation between operational and strategic activities, prevents oversimplification of mid-range processes, and supports a more precise assessment of transformation potential, automation exposure, and value creation pathways.

This extension is substantive. It better reflects the reality in which most sector processes are neither entirely transactional nor wholly strategic, but occupy an intermediate space characterized by semi-analytical, cross-functional, and partially standardized activities. Accurately capturing this middle layer is essential, as it is the primary locus of transformation through productivity gains, task recomposition, and partial automation.

The complexity dimension describes how work is performed, spanning from standardized, rule-based tasks with high repeatability to analytical, judgment-intensive activities that require advanced expertise and domain knowledge. As complexity rises, processes become less codifiable, increasingly context-dependent, and more reliant on human decision-making.

The value dimension represents the business impact of activities, ranging from transactional support focused on efficiency and cost control, through operational processes that enable and stabilize core performance, to strategic contributions that shape decision-making, innovation, and competitive positioning. Higher-value activities are generally associated with revenue generation, risk management, or strategic planning and entail greater organizational visibility and accountability.

It is important to note that these two dimensions are not fully correlated. Not all complex activities are high value, nor are all high-value activities highly complex. This differentiation produces a varied process landscape in which the positioning of activities

TABLE 1.2 **ABSL'S complexity-value matrix**

	Low Value (Transactional)	**Medium Value** (Operational)	**High Value** (Strategic)
Low Complexity (Standardized, Rule – Based)	**Routine processing, data entry**	**Standard reporting, monitoring**	**Scaled insights delivery**
Medium Complexity (Semi – Analytical, Cross – Domain)	**Exception handling, support**	**Analysis, coordination**	**Business decision support**
High Complexity (Analytical, Judgment – Based)	**Specialized support tasks**	**Advanced analytics**	**Strategy, transformation**

Source: ABSL BI.

determines their strategic relevance, susceptibility to automation, and potential for further development.

The adoption of a 3×3 matrix yields three principal analytical enhancements.

First, it facilitates improved quantification. For example, each cell can be assigned distinct AI impact coefficients, enabling estimation of full-time equivalent (FTE) changes.

Second, it captures the heterogeneity within the middle segment, where most adjustments result from productivity gains and partial automation instead of complete substitution.

Third, it offers a more accurate depiction of transition dynamics, illustrating how work shifts within the matrix from lower to higher value and from lower to higher complexity.

A key step in our analysis was the classification of processes performed in the sector in Poland into three levels of complexity and value, conducted by ABSL BI in collaboration with an expert panel.

Low-complexity processes are highly structured, repetitive, and rule-based, requiring limited judgment and minimal domain knowledge. They are easily codified and highly automatable. Medium-complexity processes combine structured and unstructured elements, requiring analysis, contextual understanding, and cross-functional coordination. High-complexity processes are non-routine, expert-driven, and judgment-intensive, often involving ambiguity and significant business impact.

From a value perspective, low-value processes are transactional and cost-focused, supporting operations without directly contributing to competitive advantage. Medium-value processes enable business performance and operational effectiveness, often supporting decision-making and coordination. High-value processes are strategic and transformational, directly linked to innovation, competitive positioning, and long-term value creation.

Using detailed survey data from the ABSL 2026 study and applying the true employment weights, we estimated the distribution of total FTE employment in Poland within the matrix.

Employment structure by complexity and value (at the end of Q1 2026)

At the end of Q1 2026, employment in Poland's business services sector is strongly concentrated in medium- and high-complexity activities, which together account for nearly 80% of total employment. High-complexity roles represent the largest segment (40.0%), closely followed by medium-complexity functions (39.7%), while low-complexity work accounts for 20.3%.

TABLE 1.3 | **Estimate of employment in the sector by complexity-value** (at the end of Q1 2026)

	Low Value	Medium Value	High Value	Total
Low Complexity	92,400	9,400		**101,800**
Medium Complexity	23,600	166,800	8,050	**198,450**
High Complexity		56,350	143,900	**200,250**
Total	**116,000**	**232,550**	**151,950**	**500,500**

Source: ABSL BI.

TABLE 1.4 | **Estimated structure of employment in the sector by complexity-value** (at the end of Q1 2026) (%)

	Low Value	Medium Value	High Value	Total
Low Complexity	18.5	1.9		**20.3**
Medium Complexity	4.7	33.3	1.6	**39.7**
High Complexity		11.3	28.8	**40.0**
Total	**23.2**	**46.5**	**30.4**	**100.0**

Source: ABSL BI.

From a value perspective, the sector is anchored in operational work, with medium-value processes accounting for 46.5% of total employment. A substantial 30.4% of employment in high-value, strategic activities shifts towards more advanced, knowledge-intensive services. Low-value, transactional work still accounts for 23.2%, a remaining but declining cost-driven component.

The structure reveals two dominant pillars. **The largest single segment is medium-complexity, medium-value work (33.3%), forming the operational backbone of the sector. Alongside this, high-complexity, high-value activities account for 28.8%, highlighting the growing importance of advanced analytics, transformation, and strategic functions.**

Low-complexity work remains largely confined to low-value activities (18.5%) and has minimal presence in higher-value segments. This confirms that as value increases, so does the required level of complexity, and that the sector has limited overlap between standardized processes and strategic functions.

The sector has progressed beyond a low-cost model and now remains structurally anchored in the operational middle. Future competitiveness will depend on the sector’s capacity to transition this middle-tier core towards even higher-value, strategic activities.

The sector's foreign trade

Poland's business services sector is a major contributor to the country's export capacity. It is highly integrated into global value chains and is both internationalized and export-oriented. Superior productivity is the main driver of exports, while foreign ownership brings valuable experience in serving international clients. Most centers operate as "superstar firms," accounting for a disproportionate share of total exports.

Melitz (2003)[1] shows that productivity largely determines a firm's ability to enter export markets; more productive firms self-select into exporting. Exporting in itself does not necessarily increase productivity (i.e., there is limited evidence for "learning by exporting"). Mayer & Ottaviano (2008)[2] further show that exporters differ significantly from non-exporters: they are larger, more productive, pay higher salaries, use more capital, employ more skilled workers, and generate higher value-added revenue. These "happy few" dominate export volumes, with a highly skewed distribution, and are thus significantly concentrated in a small number of firms.

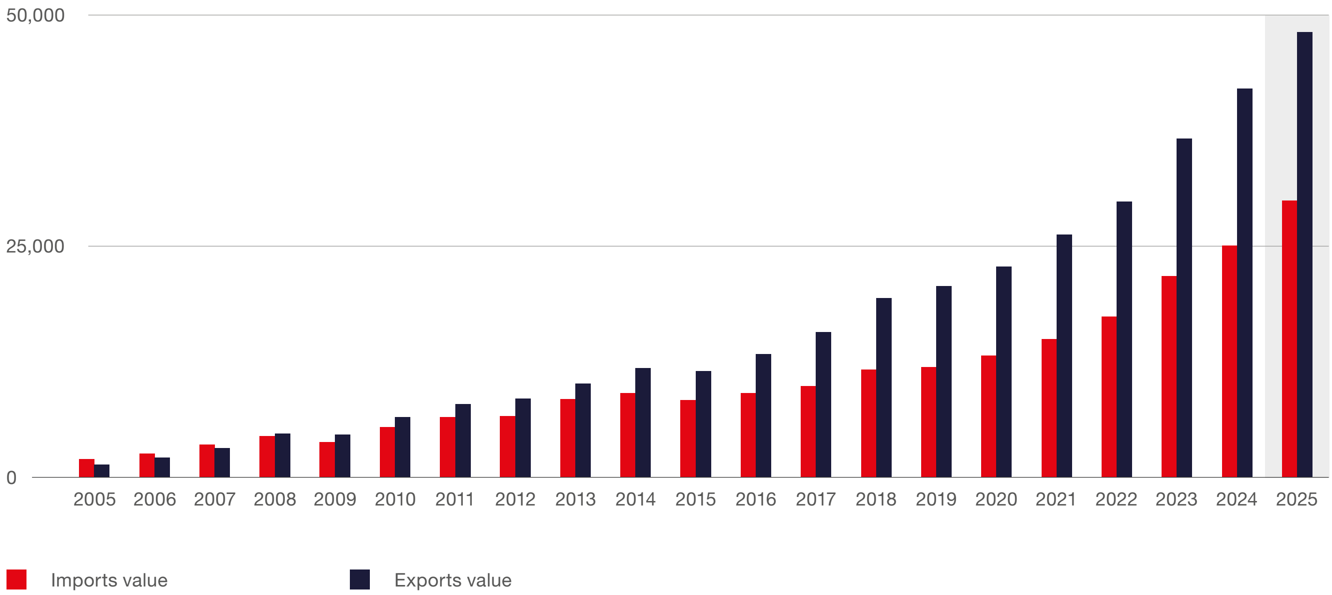
We estimated the value of Poland's business services exports and imports using the WTO's TiSMoS database, WTO commercial trade in services data, and quarterly balance-of-payments data from the National Bank of Poland.

This process involved mapping NACE rev. 2 sector activity classifications to the EBOPS classification used in the TiSMoS database. To clarify the definition of KIBS, we applied the Schabel and Zenker (2013) approach for consistency with other studies using NACE rev. 2. We then aligned the authors' indicated activity areas with the relevant EBOPS groups.

We used the National Bank of Poland balance of payments data for 2018-2024. Switching from WTO to NBP data increased KIBS import and export estimates for 2018 and 2019. We then adjusted these estimates to reflect the sector's actual contribution.

[1] Melitz, M. J. (2003). The impact of trade on intra-industry reallocations and aggregate industry productivity. Econometrica, 71(6), 1695-1725.
[2] Mayer, T., & Ottaviano, G. I. (2008). The happy few: the internationalization of European firms: new facts based on firm-level evidence. Intereconomics, 43(3), 135-148.

FIGURE 1.22 | **The value of services imported and exported by the business services centers in Poland** (USD million)



Source: ABSL estimates based on WTO TiSMoS database & NBP Balance of Payments data.

By the end of 2025, ABSL BI estimated sector imports at USD 30.1 billion and exports at USD 48.4 billion. Exports grew by 14.5% year-over-year, while imports rose by 19.4% (14.7% and 15.0% in 2024, respectively). The trade surplus exceeded USD 18.3 billion (USD 17.0 billion in 2024). The sector has maintained a growing surplus since 2008, surpassing USD 10.0 billion for the first time in 2021.

According to ABSL BI estimates, **the business services centers analyzed in this report account for at least 75% of Poland's total KIBS exports,** validated against EUROSTAT's export data by firm size.

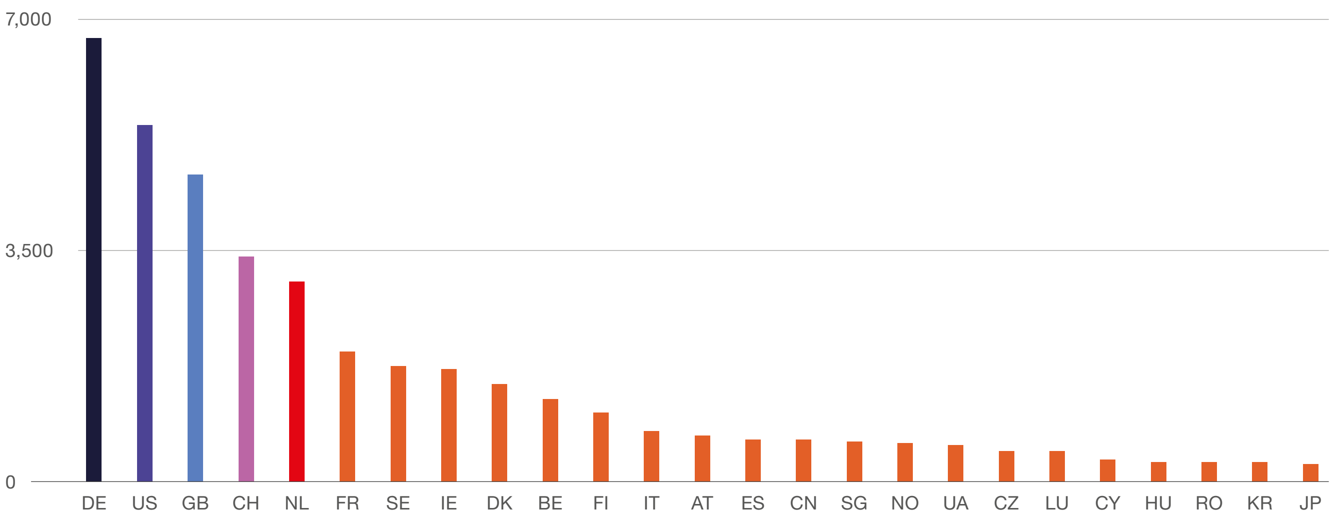
In 2005, the year after Poland's EU accession, the sector accounted for 7.6% of Poland's commercial services exports (29.5% in 2019). In 2020, amid the COVID-19 pandemic, it rose to 34.4% before dropping to 31.5% in 2022. The share increased to 35.6% in 2024 and **reached 36.9% in 2025.**

Poland's overall exports of commercial services from 2005 to 2025 had a CAGR of 10.4%. **Over the same period, exports of business services had a CAGR of 19.4%, nearly double that.**

It resonates with global trends, where services exports are stronger than merchandise exports, and digitally transferred services (DTS) grow substantially faster than overall commercial services.

According to the WTO-OECD Balanced Trade in Services (BaTIS) dataset, **six countries played a crucial role in Poland's business services exports in 2024. These were Germany, the US, the UK, the Netherlands, Switzerland,** and France, with the value of exports exceeding the USD two billion benchmark. Exports to Germany reached 6.7 billion, to the US USD 5.4 billion, and to the UK 4.5 billion. For the Netherlands and Switzerland, they were above USD three billion. For France, they just breached USD billion, and are close to 2 billion for Sweden, Ireland, and Denmark. These countries were followed by Belgium and Finland, which both exceeded USD one billion in 2024.

FIGURE 1.23 | **Poland's exports of business services in 2024 to top 25 destinations** (USD million)



Source: ABSL estimates based on the WTO-OECD BaTiS dataset. TiSMoS database & NBP balance of payments data.

Given productivity's central role in driving centers' competitive potential, we present updated data on **mean export per worker,** which ABSL uses as a proxy for the sector's productivity, for the fourth consecutive year.

Please note that minor revisions in this year's result from historical data adjustments made by the ABSL BI team in Q1 2026.

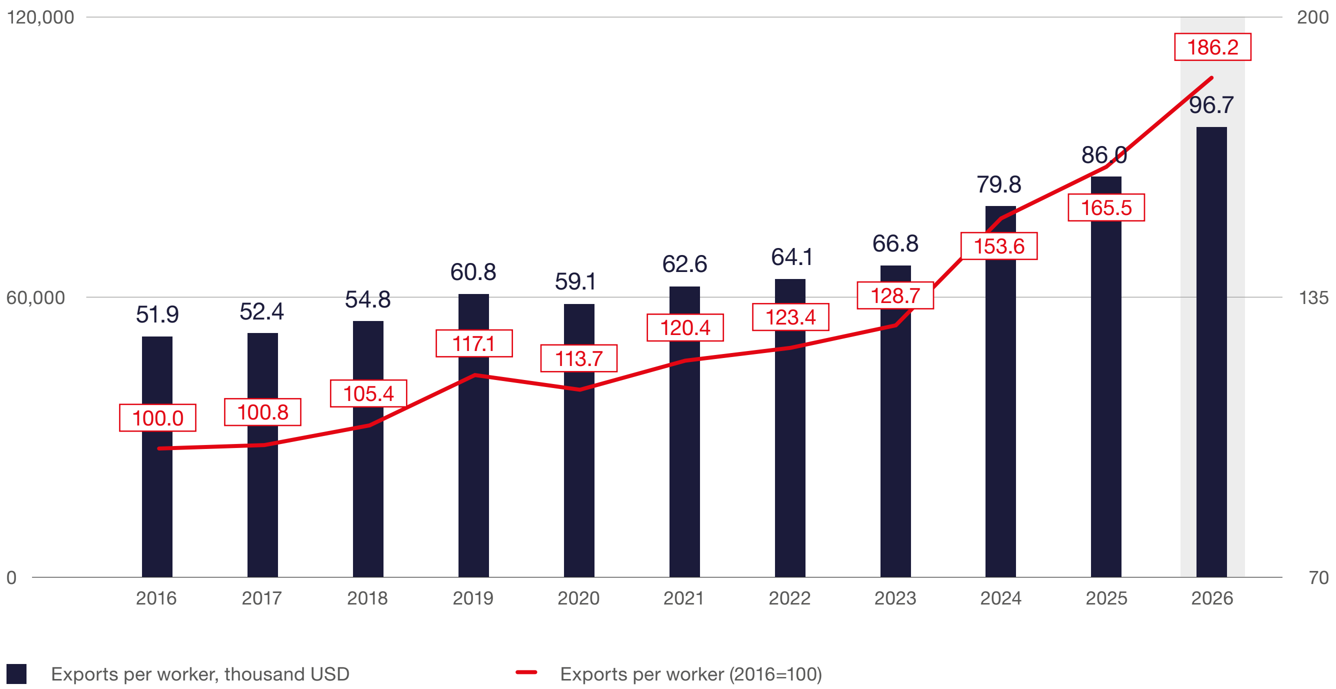
NBP balance of payments data are provided with a one-quarter delay, as using Q4 data from the preceding year is more rational than forecasting changes in export values to arrive at Q1 estimates. Thus, the value of exports per worker is now calculated as the value of exports in the preceding years (Q1-Q4), divided by the headcount in modern business services in Q1 of the current year. This constitutes an adjustment in the methodology vis-à-vis preceding editions of the report.

In Q1 2025, mean exports per worker in centers exceeded USD 86,000, up 65.5% since 2016. By Q1 2026, this has risen to USD 96,700, marking an 86.2% increase since 2016.

Exports per worker show a clearly cyclical but structurally shifting pattern. A strong pre-COVID acceleration in productivity (peaking at 11% in 2019), followed by a sharp pandemic-driven contraction (-2.9% in 2020), and then a volatile recovery phase. Post-2021 dynamics are no longer smooth; the series reflects shocks to global supply chains, price effects, and shifts in export composition, culminating in an exceptional spike in 2024 (19.3%) and subsequent normalization in 2025–2026 (7.8–12.5%). This could indicate a transition from a stable, volume-driven growth regime to a more unstable, price- and structure-driven productivity pattern.

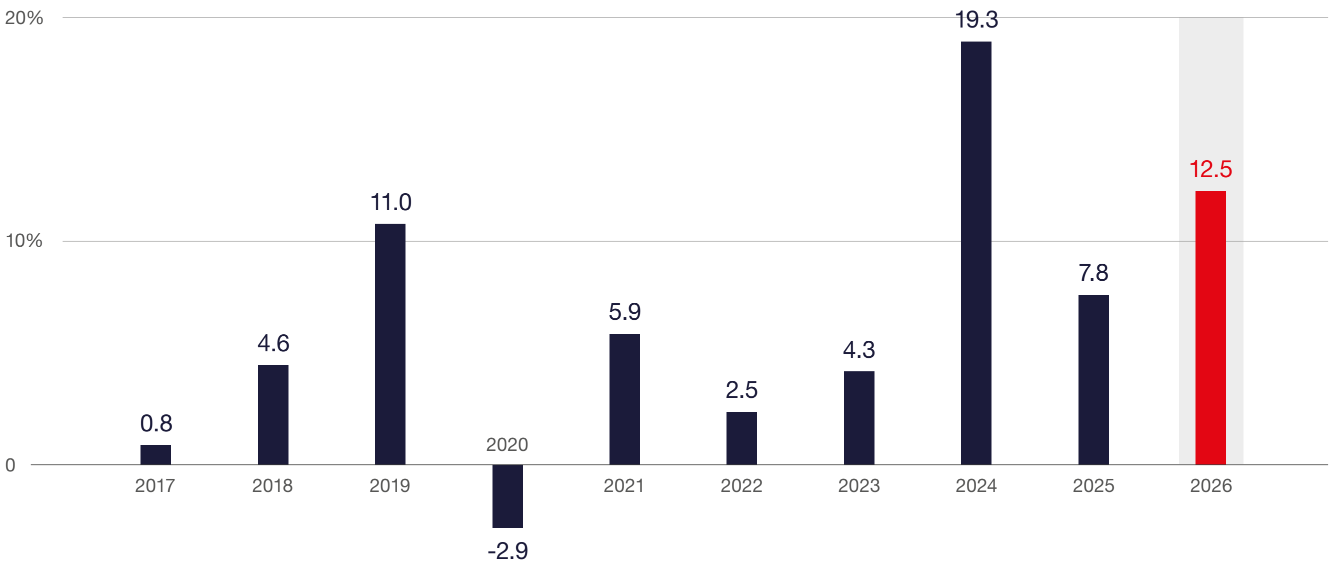
The upward trend reflects a **substantial increase in productivity and value added, driven by workforce upskilling and a shift toward more complex, knowledge-intensive services.** This reinforces Poland's position as a leading nearshoring hub in Europe. Export growth above global benchmarks indicates strong alignment with structural trends, particularly digitalization, servitization, and deeper integration into global value chains.

FIGURE 1.24 | **Exports per worker in the sector, thousand USD** (2016–2026)



Source: ABSL estimates are based on the NBP balance of payments data and the ABSL dataset on centers.

FIGURE 1.25 | **Exports per worker YoY %** (2017-2026) (%)



Source: ABSL estimates are based on the NBP balance of payments data and the ABSL dataset on centers.

From employment scale to value leadership

> **Poland's business services sector has reached 500,500 jobs across over 2,100 centers and an impressive share of Poland's GDP, estimated at 6.1%.**

Similar to last year's report, we showcase the sector's potential for value creation. Due to the nature of publicly available data, we can show estimates of net turnover, gross value added, and per-worker values only for 2024.

Differences between aggregate-based and SBS-based indicators are minimal due to the close alignment of the ABSL sector definition with the Eurostat KIBS 20+ population.

Between 2021 and 2024, net turnover in these enterprises, according to ABSL BI estimates and based on Eurostat's data, **grew from USD 41.8 billion to USD 67.1 billion – a 60% increase.** More importantly, **gross value added (GVA) rose from USD 17.8 billion to USD 30.1 billion, a 69% increase, outpacing both turnover and employment growth (which increased by 26%, from 366,400 to 462,200 workers). The value of exports in 2024, for comparison, stood at 36.9 billion USD, or 79.200 USD per worker.**

> A clear and consistent productivity hierarchy is evident. **Business services centers outperform the national average, with GVA per worker exceeding economy-wide productivity by over 25%, confirming the sector's higher value-added profile.** Exports per worker also remain well above GVA per worker, highlighting the sector's strong external focus and high tradability.

The persistent gap between exports and GVA per worker shows that much value creation is tied to externally delivered services. However, the gradual narrowing of this gap suggests Poland is capturing more value locally, in line with the tranistion toward more complex, knowledge-intensive, and integrated service models.

As a result, **value creation and export capacity in Poland's business services sector are concentrated in center-based operations, reinforcing their position as one of the most productive and competitive segments of the economy.**

Methodological Note

The ABSL BI estimate of net revenue and GVA is based on Eurostat's Structural Business Statistics (*Enterprise statistics by size class and NACE Rev. 2 activity*) for 2021–2024, with a focus on NACE M and J activities relevant to our sector. Only enterprises with at least 20 employees were included, in line with ABSL's center-based sector definition of 25 or more employees, with adjustments made as needed. GVA and turnover were converted from EUR to USD using the end-of-year exchange rates published by the National Bank of Poland. Worker numbers are sourced from ABSL's main centers database. Export figures follow the methodology outlined in the previous section and use NBP BoP data. GDP per worker was calculated by dividing Poland's nominal GDP by the economically active population (Eurostat, 2024) and converting the result to USD.

TABLE 1.5 | **Comparative productivity benchmarking** (2024)

Indicator	**Value** (USD per FTE)	**Source & Definition**
GVA per worker (20+)	**USD 65,200**	Eurostat SBS, KIBS firms, 20+ employees adjusted to the center's cohort
Exports per worker (centers)	**USD 79,800**	ABSL estimates average exports per worker in our sector centers
Net revenue per worker	**USD 145,200**	Eurostat SBS, turnover per FTE, 20+ KIBS enterprises adjusted to the center's cohort
GDP per worker (Poland)	**USD 51,100**	Calculated from Eurostat GDP and labor market statistics

Source: ABSL BI estimates are based on the Eurostat Structural Business Statistics (SBS) database, ABSL center database NBP FX, and BoP data. Eurostat data is currently available for the period 2021-2024 and is internationally comparable.

Employment in the sector

In Q1 2026, Poland's business services centers employed 500,500 people. We observed a YoY increase of 8,860 jobs (1.8%), with 88.9% of this growth concentrated in Warsaw, Katowice, GZM, and Kraków.

Over 2021-2026, the sector's employment CAGR reached 6.4%, with the highest mean rate of growth in Poznań and Warsaw (9.9% each), Katowice & GZM (6.9%), and Wrocław (5.9%).

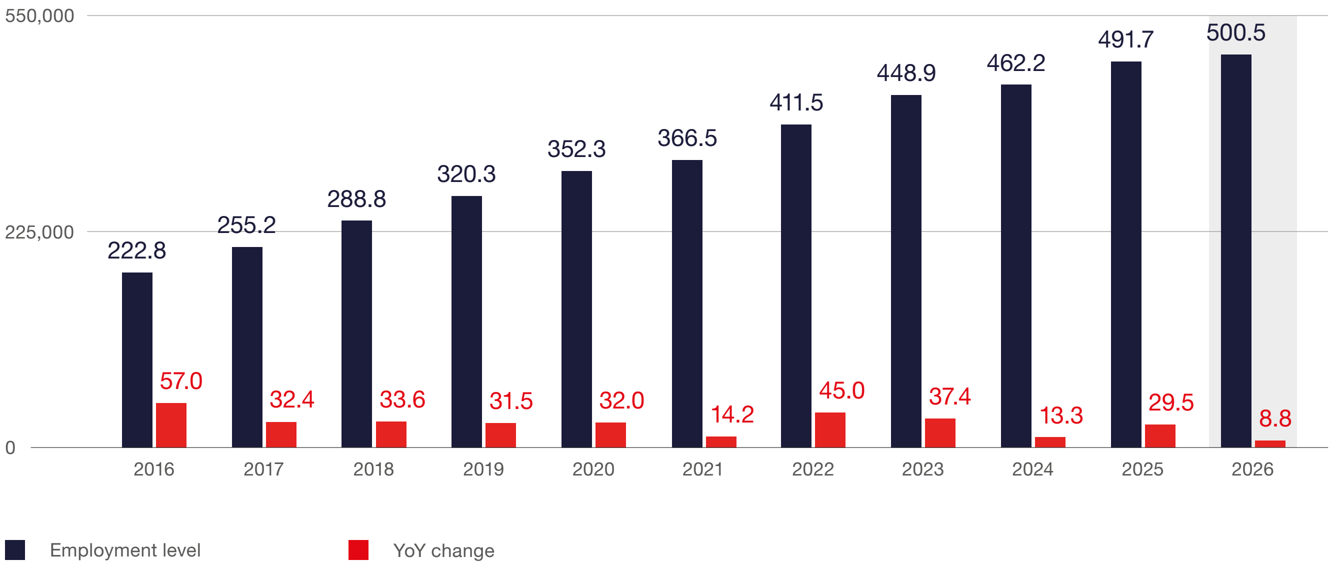
We would like to stress that, due to ongoing updates to the ABSL master database, including changes to previous years' employment data, direct comparisons with previous years' scenarios should be avoided.

The character of the employment changes is clear, however. For the first time, **the sector reached over half a million workers** (between the baseline and adverse scenarios formulated in the previous ABSL report). The YoY employment dynamics slowed to 1.8%, close to the adverse scenario (up to 2%).

Meanwhile, total employment in Poland's business enterprise sector declined by 0.8% (Q1 2026 vs. Q1 2025), making the 1.8% growth in the business services sector significant. The YoY employment dynamics for the period 2017-2026 show the centers sector's superior position compared to the business enterprise sector overall.

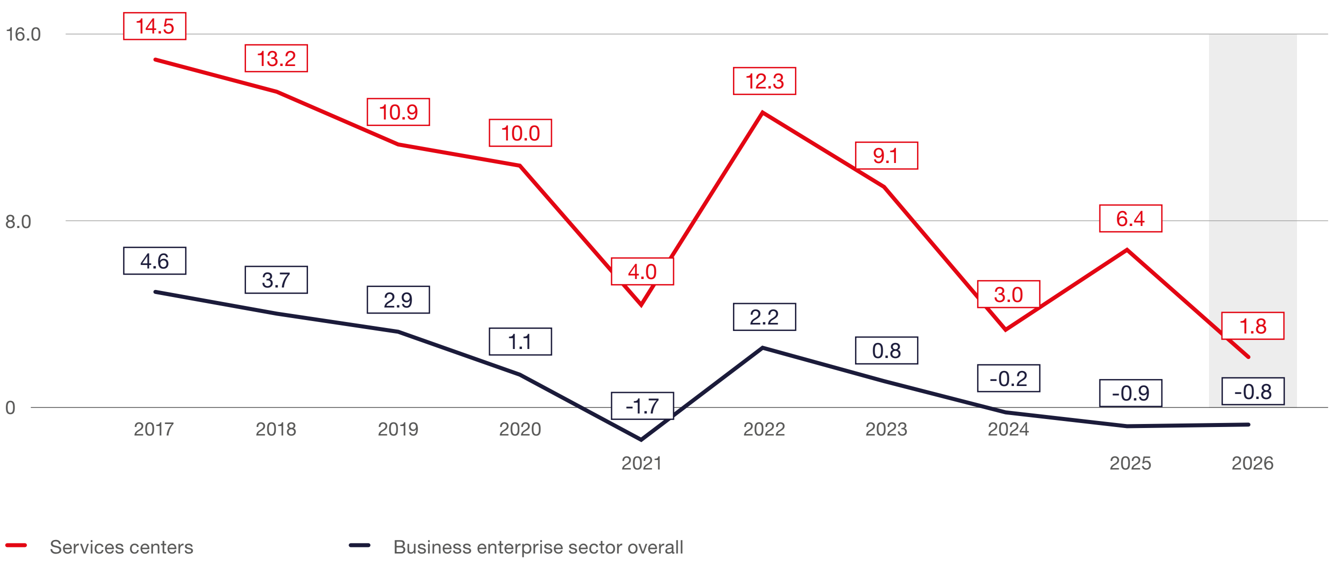
The sector's share in total business enterprise employment increased to 7.8%, up from 7.6% in 2025. Of the 8,860 new jobs, 3,240 were created by 50 new centers launched in 2025 and Q1 2026. The remainder came from organic growth in centers established before 2025.

FIGURE 1.26 **Employment in centers in Poland** (in 1,000 FTEs, 2016-2026)



Source: ABSL business services centers database. Headcount information has been rounded to the nearest hundred.

FIGURE 1.27 **Employment dynamics in centers in Poland vs. the business enterprise sector overall** (YoY percentage change in FTEs, 2017-2026)



Source: ABSL business services centers database and Statistic Poland.

FIGURE 1.28 | **Selected BPO, SSC / GBS, IT, and R&D business services centers in Poland**

Accenture Operations
Alten
Arla Foods
Atos
Boeing
Capgemini
Cisco
Columbia Pictures Corporation
DNV
DXC Technology

ERGO Technology and Services
Fortum
GlobalLogic
Helprise
Intel
ISS A/S
Jit Team
Kemira
KMD
LEO Pharma

Link Group
Lufthansa Group
Metsä Group
Noble Drilling
Nordea
Prudential International Assurance
Ricoh
Scalo
Sii

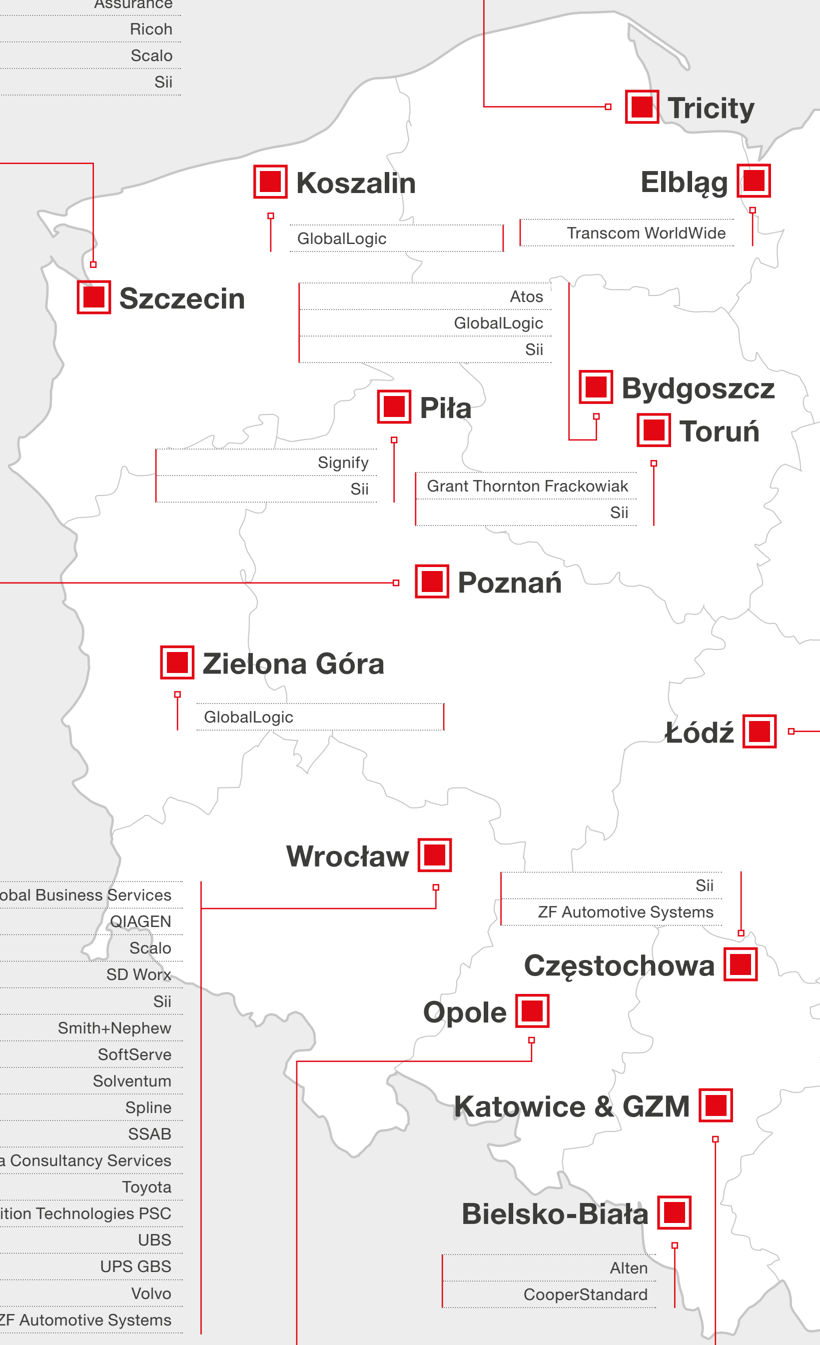
SoftServe
State Street Bank International
Swarovski GBS
Tata Consultancy Services
Transcom WorldWide
WNS Global Services

Concentrix
GlobalLogic

Metro Global Solutions
Sii

ADM
Arvato
Atotech
Beiersdorf
Capgemini
Carl Zeiss
Carlsberg
Computacenter
DFDS
Enea Centrum
Exide Technologies
FIS Technology
Franklin Templeton
Grant Thornton Frackowiak
GSK Services
Haleon
IKEA
John Deere
LyondellBasell
MAN

Mars
McKinsey
Miele Global Services
Next Technology at "FlexDev"
Onwelo
ProService Finteco
Raben
REHAU
Revalize
Roche Informatics
Rockwool
SD Worx
Sii
SKF
Tata Consultancy Services
Transcom WorldWide
Transition Technologies PSC
Żabka
Wipro



3M Service Center
Alten
Aryzta
Atos
AXA XL
Becton Dickinson
BNY
Boehringer Ingelheim
BSH
Capgemini
Chain IQ
DeLaval
Deviniti
DXC Technology
EY
FIS Technology
Fortum

Fresenius Kabi
Fresenius Medical Care
Gates
GlobalLogic
Grant Thornton Frackowiak
Hewlett Packard Enterprise
HP Inc.
Infor
Infosys
LAPP Business Services
McCain
Merck
Nokia
Olympus
Onwelo
Paragon Services
Parker Hannifin

PPG Global Business Services
QIAGEN
Scalo
SD Worx
Sii
Smith+Nephew
SoftServe
Solventum
Spline
SSAB
Tata Consultancy Services
Toyota
Transition Technologies PSC
UBS
UPS GBS
Volvo
ZF Automotive Systems

ArcelorMittal
Alten
Capgemini
Concentrix
Danone
EY
GlobalLogic
Grant Thornton Frackowiak
Hager
HAVI

ING Hubs
Intel
ista Customer Service
ista Technologies
Koch Business Solutions
KPMG Audyt
LIPTON Teas and Infusions
Orange
PwC
Rockwell Automation

Scalo
SD Worx
Sii
Soflab
SoftServe
Spline
TMF
TUV Rheinland
Vattenfall IT Services
Vialto Partners

Capgemini
PwC

Warsaw

Accenture Operations
AkzoNobel
Alcon
Allfunds Bank
Alten
Amadeus
Amway
Arcus SI
Arvato
Ascendion Engineering Solutions
Astellas Pharma Capability Centre
Atos
Aviva Services
BAT
Baxter
BNP Paribas
Boeing
Boston Scientific
BSH
Capgemini
Circle K
Cisco
Citibank Europe
Clifford Chance Global Services
Colgate-Palmolive
Columbia Pictures Corporation
Concentrix
Connectis
Danone
Dentons
Deviniti
DLA Piper
DSV
DXC Technology
Elekta
Equatex
ERGO Technology and Services
Execon One
EY
FIS Technology
Franklin Templeton
Goldman Sachs
Grant Thornton Frackowiak
GSK Services
Haleon
Hays Outsourcing
Helprise
HP Inc.
Infosys
ING Hubs
ISS A/S
Jit Team
JP Morgan
JTI GBS
KMD
Link Group
Linklaters
L'Oreal
LTIMindtree
MARGO Consulting
Mars
Mercer
MMC Group Services
MSA Safety
Nexdigm
Nordea
Onwelo
Orange
Orsted
Paragon Services
Point72
Procter & Gamble
ProService Finteco
Prudential International Assurance
Publicis Resources
Reckitt
RITS
Roche Informatics
Rockwool
Scalo
SD Worx
Sii
Societe Generale
Soflab
SoftServe
Standard Chartered
Stryker
Tata Consultancy Services
TMF
UBS
UPS GBS
Vantive
Velux
VFS Global
Virtusa
Wella
WNS Global Services
Zimmer Biomet

Olsztyn

Citibank Europe
Transcom WorldWide

Białystok

CERI International
Execon One
Sii
Transcom WorldWide
Transition Technologies PSC

Adaptive Group
Arvato
Atos
Beko
BSH
CERI International
Commerzbank Aktiengesellschaft
Flint Group
Fujitsu Technology Solutions
GlobalLogic
Infosys
Nordea
Onwelo
Philips
Sii
Solar
Takeda
Tate & Lyle
Transition Technologies PSC
UPS GBS
Wella

Kielce

ProService Finteco
Transition Technologies PSC
WNS Global Services

Lublin

Arcus SI
Capgemini
Concentrix
Onwelo
Orange
ProService Finteco
Publicis Resources
Sii

The map presents only selected business services centers owned by companies responding to the ABSL survey in Q1 2026. If you want to enhance your visibility and contribute to the next ABSL survey, please contact research@absl.pl.

Source: ABSL business services centers database.

Rzeszów

Boeing
BSH
Grant Thornton Frackowiak
Jit Team
Sii

Kraków

Accenture Operations
Alten
Ascendion Engineering Solutions
Atos
BNP Paribas
Brown Brothers Harriman
Capgemini
Cisco
Computacenter
Concentrix
Danish Crown
DXC Technology
Dyson
Ecolab
Euroclear
GlobalLogic
HAVI
Heineken
Helprise
HN Global Business Services
HSBC Service Delivery
IAG GBS
IG Group
Infosys
International Paper
Jit Team
KFS
Kimberly Clark
Link Group
LTIMindtree
Lufthansa Group
Lundbeck
Mercer
Novocure
Onwelo
Orange
Pegasystems
PepsiCo
PMI Service Center Europe
Pontoon Solutions
QVC Group
Sappi
Scalo
Shell
Sii
SoftServe
Spline
State Street Bank International
StoneX Financial
Sylvamo
Tata Consultancy Services
UBS
Verisk Analytics
Volvo Cars

TABLE 1.6 | **Employment in the sector and the number of centers by country of origin** (2026)

Country (or region) of origin	Employment	Share in overall employment (%)	No. of centers	Share in the number of centers (%)
United States	141,700	28.3	457	21.0
Poland	77,700	15.5	615	28.2
United Kingdom	52,800	10.5	175	8.0
France	52,100	10.4	153	7.0
Nordic countries*	47,400	9.5	202	9.3
Germany	37,000	7.4	182	8.4
Asian countries**	25,000	5.0	104	4.8
Switzerland	18,000	3.6	62	2.8
Netherlands	17,600	3.5	64	2.9
Ireland	12,000	2.4	34	1.6
Other European***	4,500	0.9	39	1.8
Belgium	2,800	0.6	17	0.8
Spain	2,600	0.5	10	0.5
Ukraine	2,500	0.5	22	1.0
Canada	1,900	0.4	13	0.6
Italy	1,600	0.3	9	0.4
Luxembourg	1,500	0.3	6	0.3
Austria	1,100	0.2	5	0.2
Other non-European****	700	0.1	10	0.5
Overall	**500,500**	**100**	**2,179**	**100**

* Nordic countries: Denmark, Finland, Greenland, Norway, and Sweden.
** Asian countries: China, Hong Kong, India, Israel, Japan, Qatar, Singapore, South Korea, Turkey, and the United Arab Emirates.
*** Other European: Belarus, Bulgaria, Czech Republic, Cyprus, Estonia, Greece, Hungary, Iceland, Lithuania, Malta, Portugal, Romania, Slovakia, and Slovenia.
**** Other non-European: Australia, Brazil, Mexico, and South Africa.

Source: ABSL business services centers database.

Employment in the largest centers

Over the years, we have observed a growing number of centers in Poland with headcounts of 1,000 or more FTEs. In 2026, this number stands at 92. These centers collectively employed 171,160 people, accounting for 34.2% of the sector's total employment. Entities with foreign-owned capital were predominant among the largest centers operating in Poland. Only three of them are domestic companies. Among centers employing at least 1,000 people, 74.0% (126,700 employees) were in Tier 1 cities, while 20.0% (34,200 employees) were in Tier 2 locations.

Functionally, 45.2% (77,300 employees) worked in SSC/GBS centers, and 24.2% (41,300 employees) were employed in IT centers. There are fifteen major investors in Poland, each employing at least 5,000 people. Collectively, they account for 98,100 employees (19.6% of the total workforce). Among these prominent investors is one Polish company: Comarch.

The sector seems to be evolving toward a hub-and-scale model, dominated by large, foreign-owned centers in Tier 1 cities.

TABLE 1.7

Employment and number of centers established in 2025 and Q1 2026 (by countries where headquarters are located)

Country of origin	Employment	No. of centers
United States	822	14
United Kingdom	460	8
Germany	405	7
Sweden	390	4
Denmark	310	5
Netherlands	300	2
Others	555	10
Overall	**3,242**	**50**

Source: ABSL business services centers database.

TABLE 1.8

The largest investors in Poland in terms of headcount in business services centers at the end of Q1 2026

Investor	HQ location	Number of employees at centers
Capgemini	France	11,000-13,000
UBS	Switzerland	8,000-11,000
Sii	France	6,000-8,000
Nokia	Finland	6,000-8,000
Citigroup	United States	6,000-8,000
EPAM Systems	United States	6,000-8,000
Comarch	Poland	6,000-8,000
Nordea	Sweden	5,000-6,000
State Street	United States	5,000-6,000
Accenture	Ireland	5,000-6,000
HSBC	United Kingdom	5,000-6,000

Source: ABSL business services centers database.

Location of business services centers

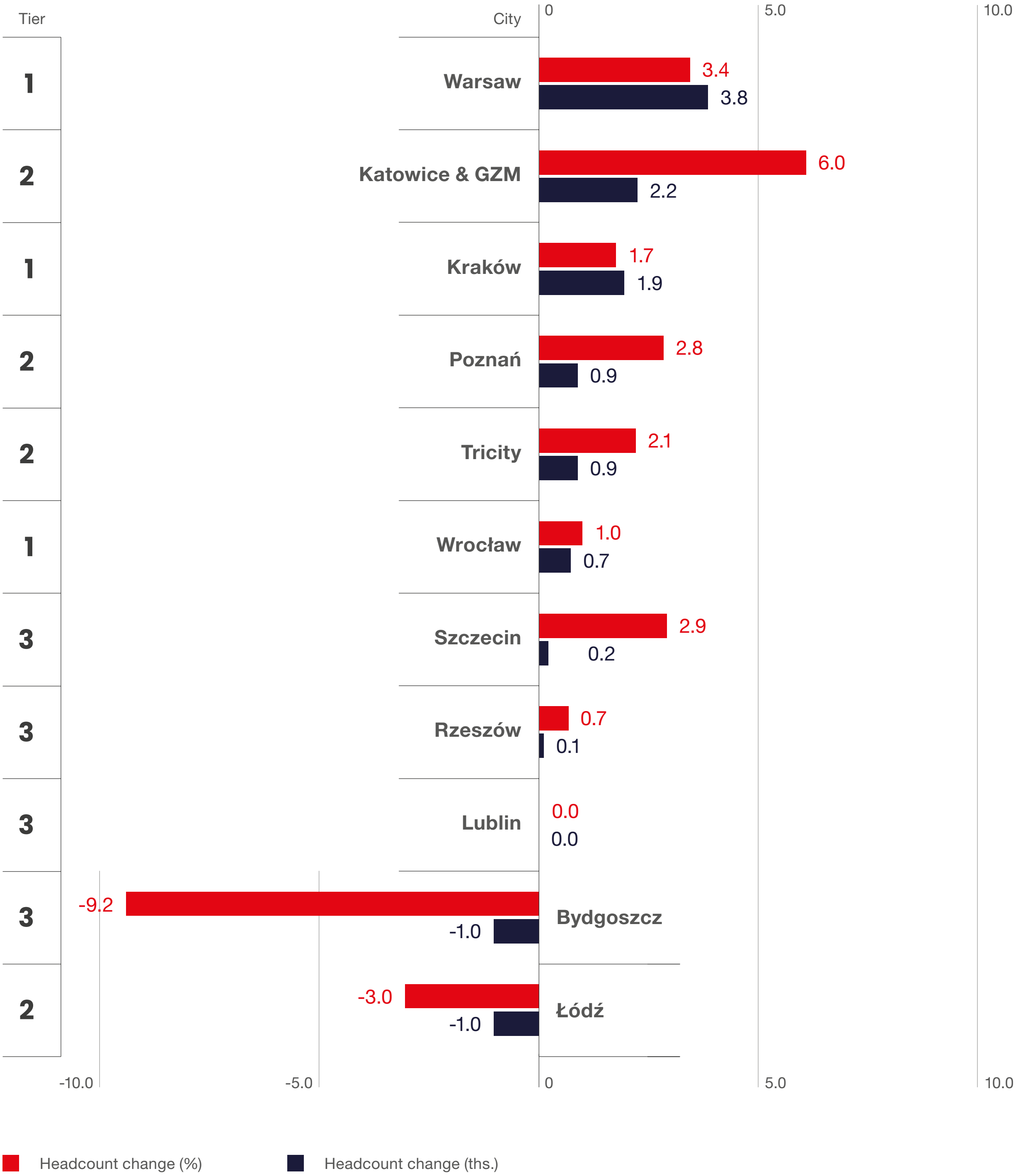
As of Q1 2026, business services centers operated in 95 locations across Poland, including 23 cities where employment exceeds 1,000. However, the sector's dynamics remain fluid, with job numbers fluctuating due to consolidation, talent shortages, and shifting business models. The top three cities were Warsaw, with 116,700 employees; Kraków, with 110,000; and Wrocław, with 71,100. In 2024, Kraków and Warsaw were level-pegging, but as expected, Warsaw became the main hub due to its stronger dynamics since the COVID-19 pandemic.

The sector grew by 1.8% YoY, with notable employment increases in Katowice & GZM (+6.0%), Warsaw (+3.4%), Szczecin (+2.9%), and Poznań (+2.8%).

The sector in the current phase is consolidating around a limited number of large, competitive locations, with Warsaw emerging as the primary anchor and Tier 2 cities selectively capturing spillover growth. **Nonetheless, compared with other CEE locations, Poland has the largest and, at the same time, a polycentric system, offering a number of attractive locations within one country.**

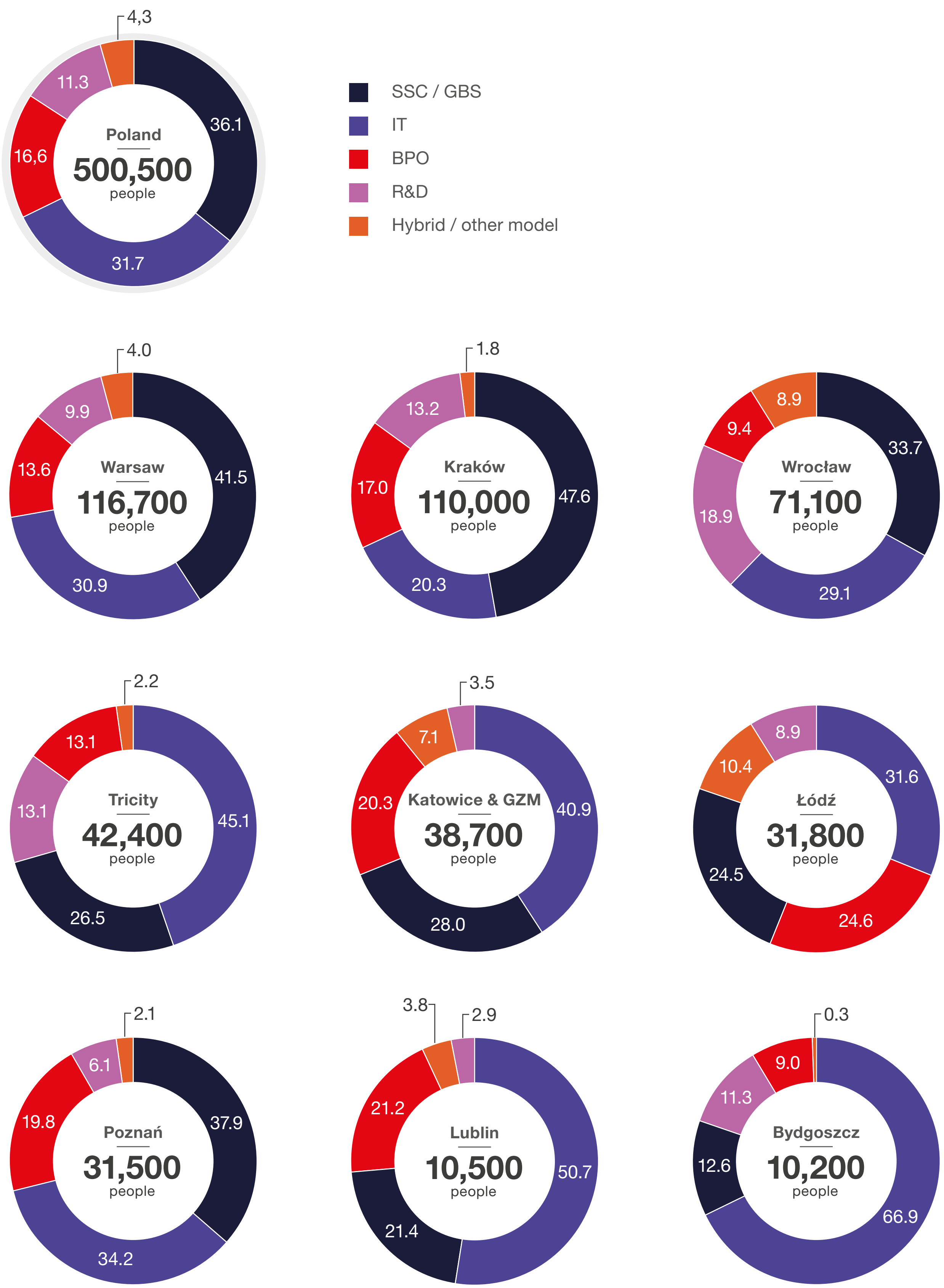
FIGURE 1.29

Changes in employment (in Tiers 1, 2, and 3 locations) between Q1 2026 and Q1 2025
(percentage change and absolute change in headcount)



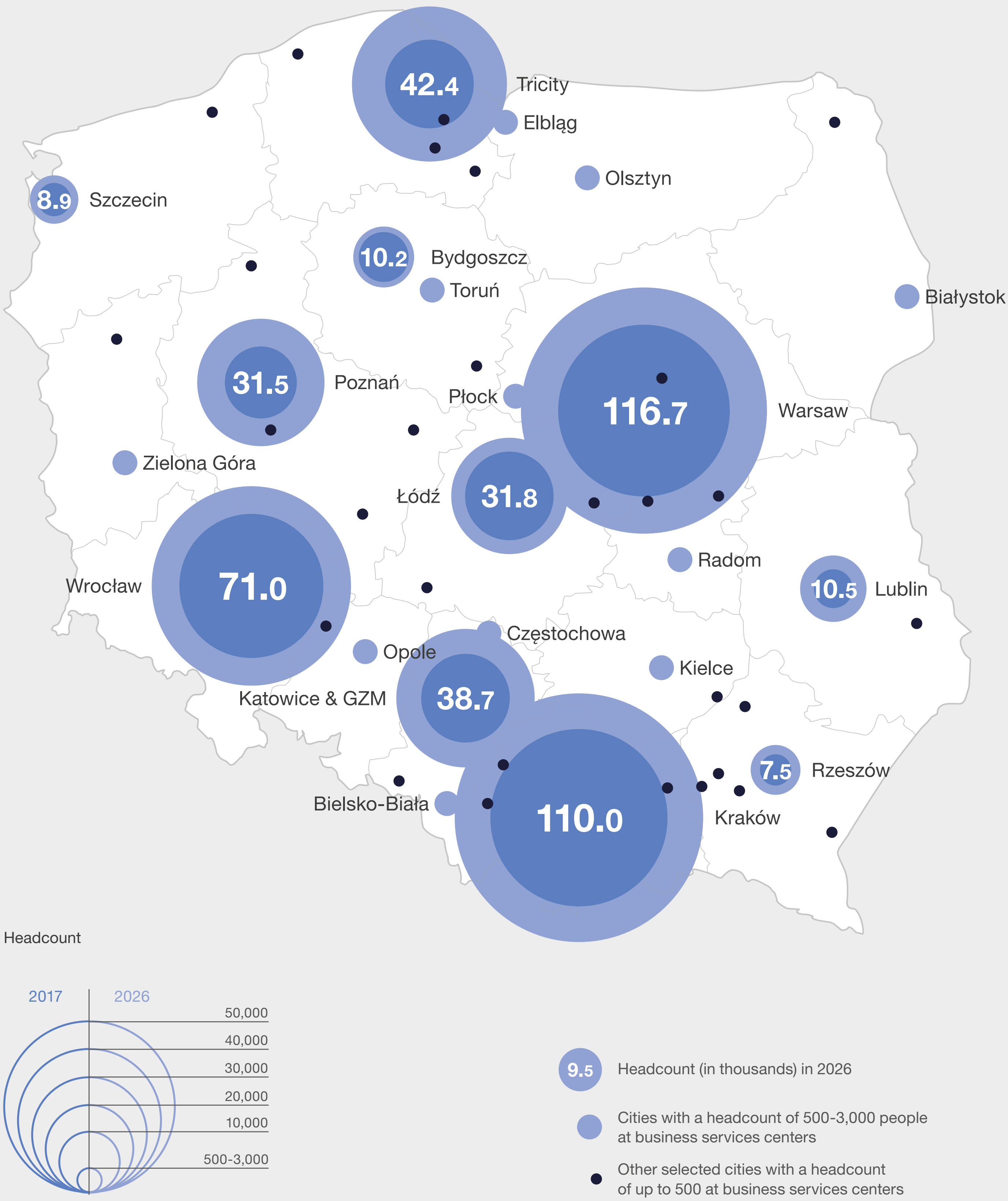
Source: ABSL business services centers database.

FIGURE 1.30 **Employment structure of selected business services locations (with employment exceeding 10,000) by type of center** (according to the dominant profile of operations, Q1 2026) (%)



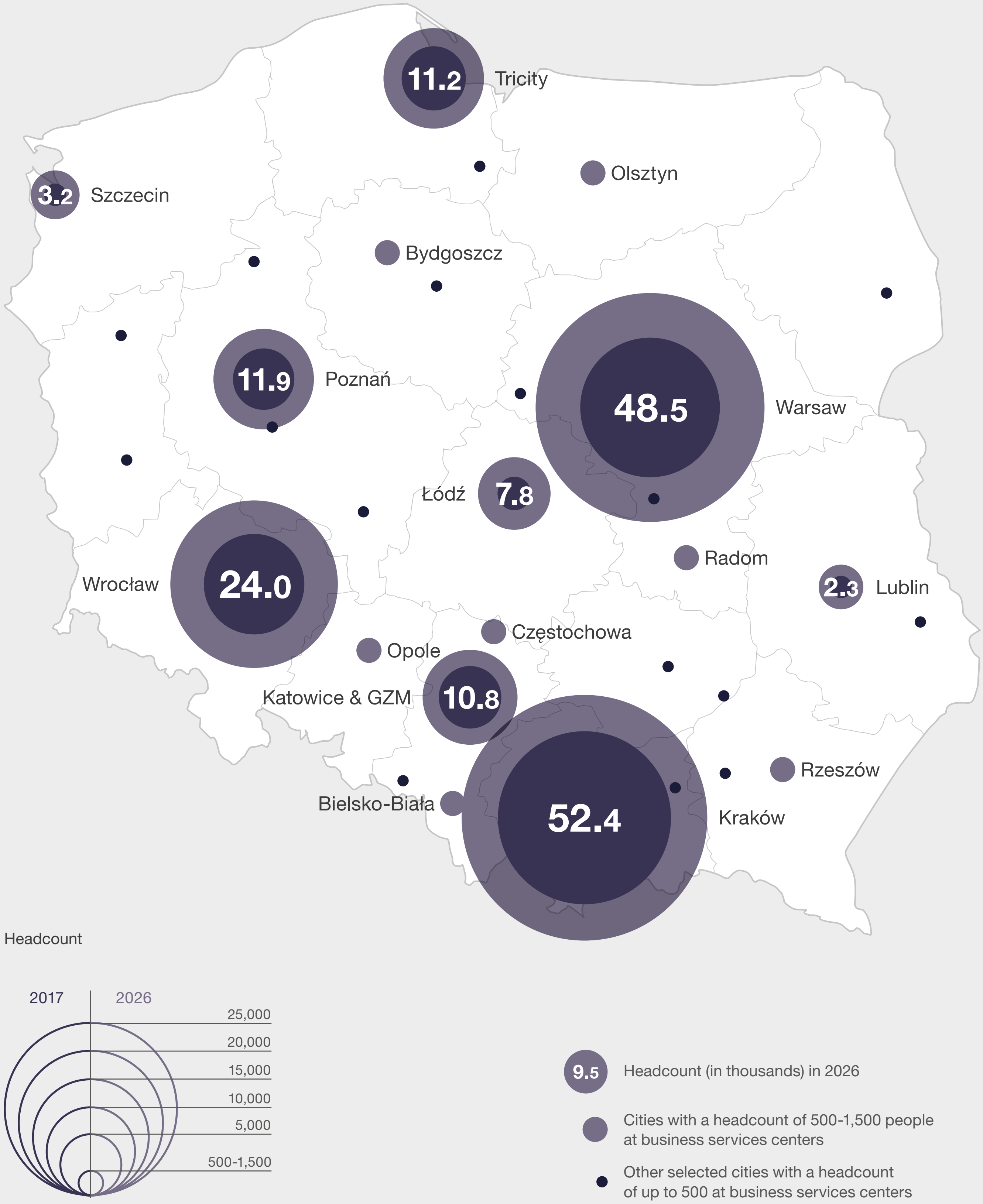
Source: ABSL business services centers database.

FIGURE 1.31 **Headcount in business services centers by location**



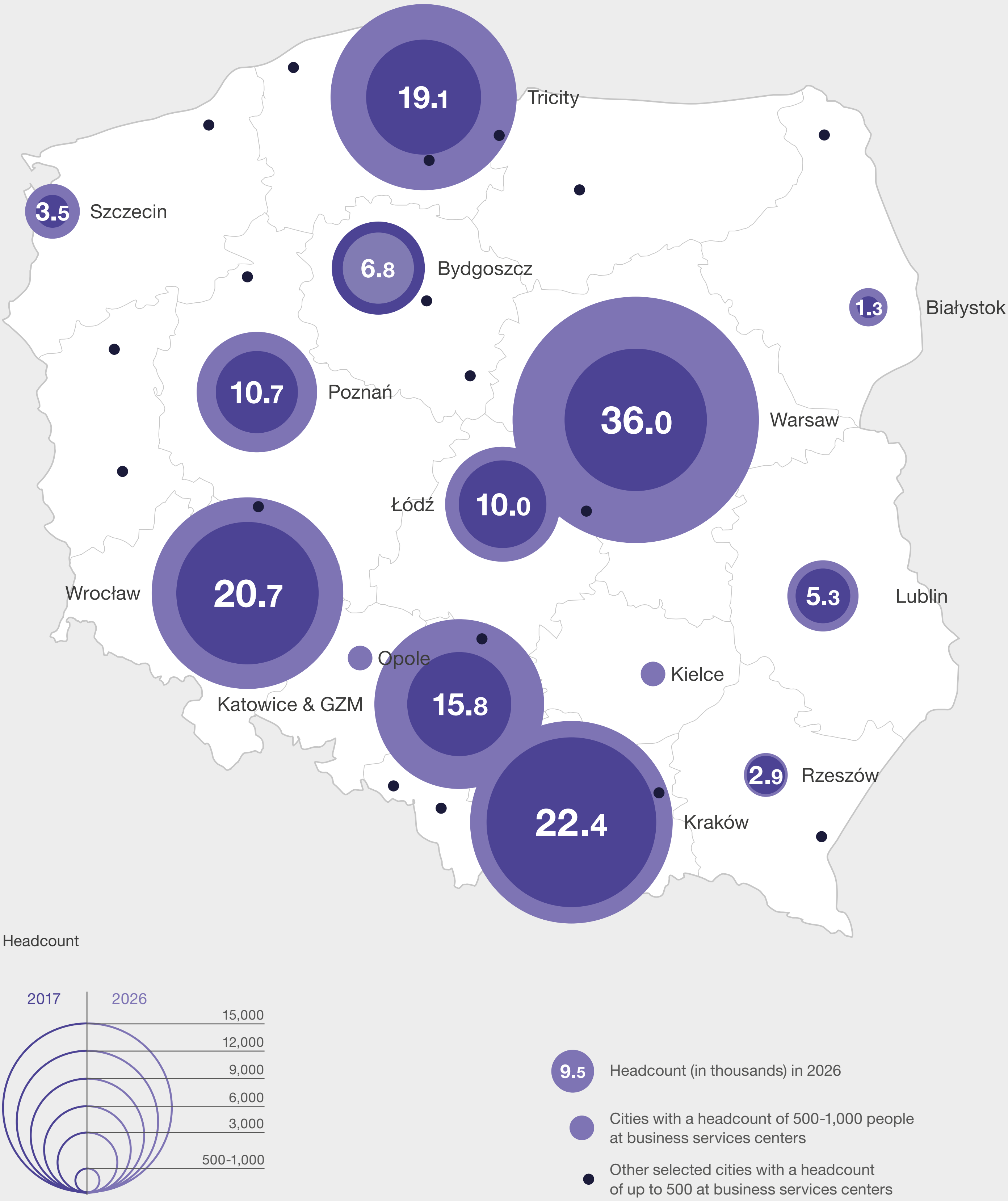
Source: ABSL business services centers database.

FIGURE 1.32 | **Headcount in SSC / GBS centers by location**



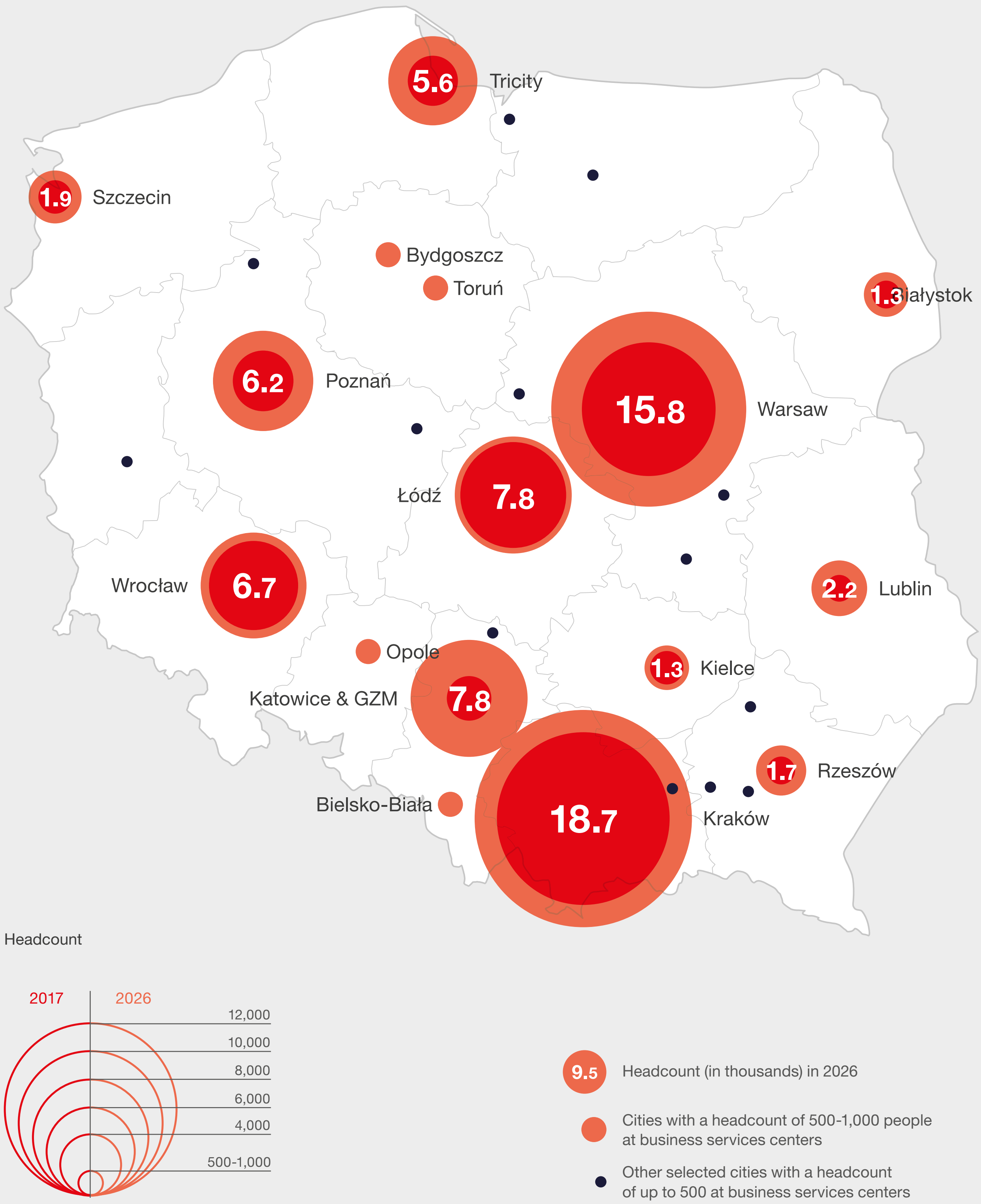
Source: ABSL business services centers database.

FIGURE 1.33 | **Headcount in IT centers by location**



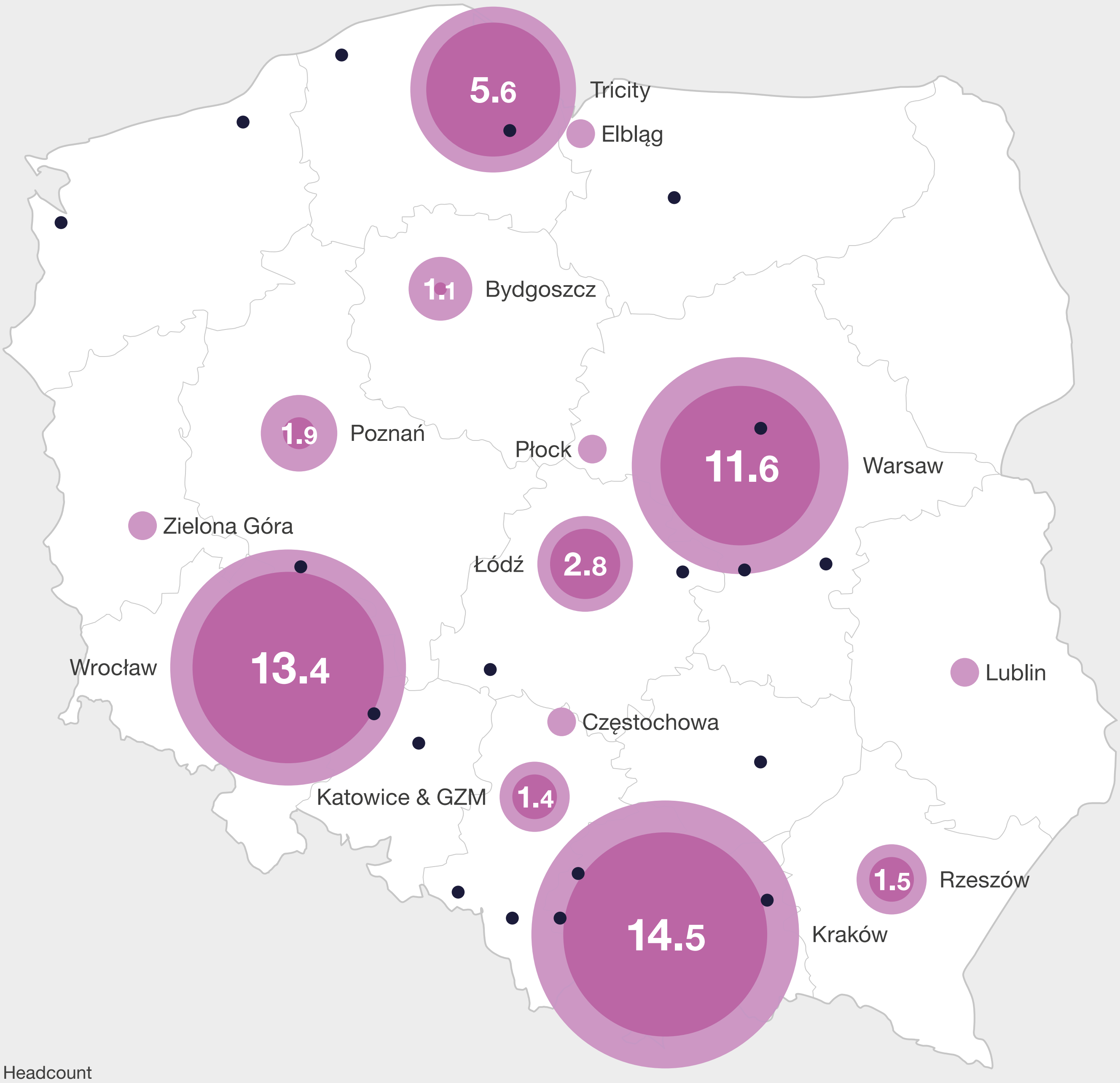
Source: ABSL business services centers database.

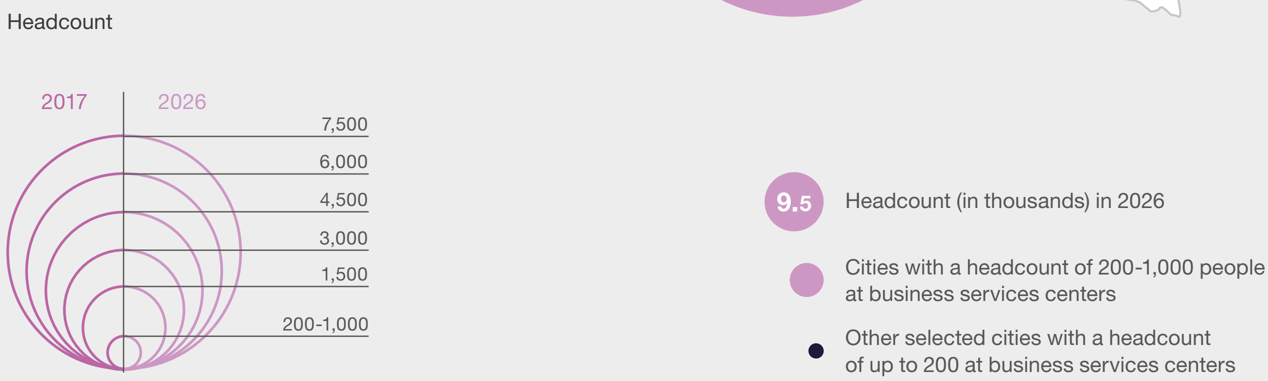
FIGURE 1.34 | **Headcount in BPO centers by location**



Source: ABSL business services centers database.

FIGURE 1.35 | **Headcount in R&D centers by location**





Source: ABSL business services centers database.

TABLE 1.9 | **ABSL cities' profiles**

	Number of employees in business services centers in Q1 2026	Accumulated job growth in the sector (CAGR) 2021–2026	Number of jobs created since 2021	Number of business services centers (Q1 2026)	Number of centers employing a minimum of 500 people (Q1 2026)	Number of new centers established in 2025 and Q1 2026	LQ	Dominant HQ*
Warsaw	116,700	9.9	43,800	448	70	9	1.00	USA
Kraków	110,000	5.8	26,900	319	51	5	3.48	USA
Wrocław	71,100	5.9	17,700	259	38	4	2.76	USA
Tricity	42,400	5.6	10,000	231	18	10	1.85**	USA
Katowice & GZM	38,700	6.9	11,000	165	19	5	0.35***	USA
Łódź	31,800	3.1	4,500	139	15	6	1.65	Germany
Poznań	31,500	9.9	11,900	174	17	7	1.42	USA
Lublin	10,500	4.6	2,100	80	5	0	1.00	Poland
Bydgoszcz	10,200	0.1	100	51	4	0	1.13	France
Szczecin	8,900	3.2	1,300	71	5	2	0.88	Denmark
Rzeszów	7,500	4.7	1,500	53	4	1	0.98	Poland

* in terms of employment
** LQ for Gdańsk only = 2.17 (and 1.13 for Gdynia and Sopot jointly)
*** LQ for Katowice only = 2.16

Source: ABSL business services centers database.

The sector as local specialization

$$LQ = \frac{\dfrac{\text{headcount at business services centers in a given location}}{\text{employment in a given location}}}{\dfrac{\text{total headcount at business services centers in all locations under analysis}}{\text{employment at all locations under analysis}}}$$

This section of the report identifies Polish cities where the business services sector demonstrates clear local specialization by using the location quotient (LQ) methodology as in previous editions. The LQ compares the share of employment in the sector within a specific location to the average share across all Polish cities hosting business services centers and is based on ABSL data as of the end of Q1 2026. An LQ value above 1.0 indicates over-representation, while values above 1.25 are generally considered evidence of strong local specialization. The methodology remains consistent with last year's edition. Employment data is sourced from the most recent version of the Statistics Poland BDL (Bank Danych Lokalnych) database. From 2022 onward, due to adjustments made by Statistics Poland (GUS), data on employment registered by company headquarters are now drawn from the BDL dataset. As a result, LQ values from previous years are not directly comparable. These changes had the most notable impact on the values for Tri-City, which were revised upwards, and Warsaw, which were revised downwards.

To improve accuracy, this year's report differentiates between Katowice and the broader Katowice & GZM area, and between Gdańsk and the rest of the Tricity (Sopot & Gdynia).

At the end of Q1 2026, Kraków remained the strongest local specialization in the business services sector, with an LQ of **3.48.** It was followed by Wrocław at **2.76,** Gdańsk at **2.17,** Katowice at **2.16,** and Poznań at **1.42,** while Lublin had an LQ of exactly **1.00.** In contrast, Warsaw, Rzeszów, and Szczecin had LQ values **of 1.0 or below, indicating an average or below-average** representation of the business services sector relative to their total employment base.

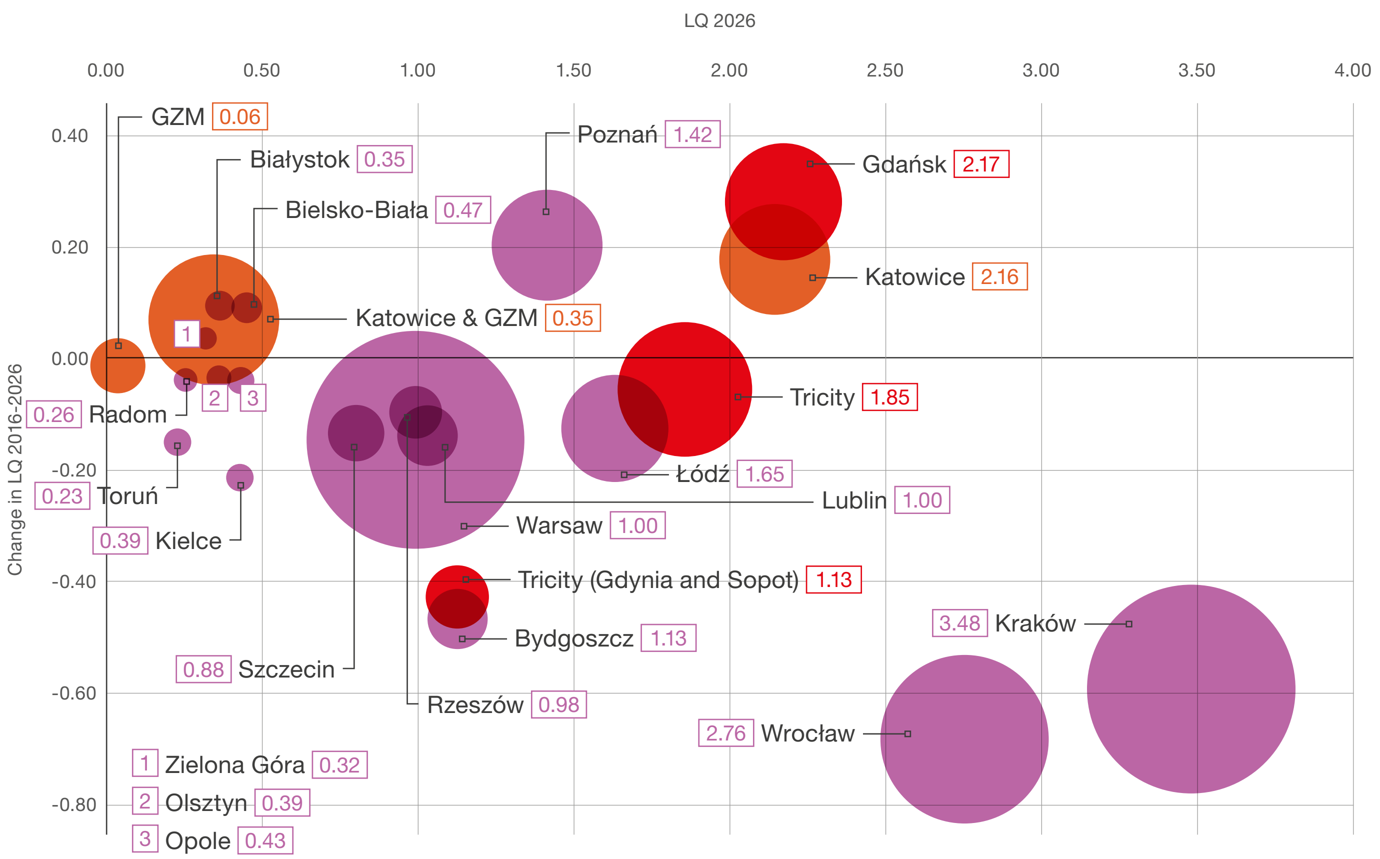
The bubble chart below shows the specialization of various Polish cities and metropolitan areas as business services centers in our sector, represented by the 2026 LQ and its change from **2016 to 2026.** Larger bubbles indicate cities with more full-time employees (FTEs) engaged in the sector.

Once again, Kraków and Wrocław emerged as the most specialized cities, with LQ values of **3.48 and 2.76,** respectively. Their role as established sectors' hubs is clearly confirmed. Other strong performers included Gdańsk **(2.17)** and Katowice **(2.16),** both of which demonstrated high specialization. They are followed by Tricity **(1.85),** Łódź **(1.65),** and Poznań **(1.42)** – all above the national average but below Tier 1 intensity levels. In contrast, despite being Poland's largest business hub, Warsaw had an LQ of **1.00.** It is a result of a highly diversified economic structure. Lublin also remained at **1.00.** Rzeszów **(0.98)** stayed just below the threshold.

Bydgoszcz **(1.13)** and Tricity, Sopot, and Gdynia (1.13) showed moderate specialization, though both recorded a **decline in relative specialization over time.** Cities such as Szczecin **(0.88),** Kielce **(0.39),** and Opole **(0.43)** remained below the national benchmark, indicating weaker specialization.

Changes in specialization over time vary significantly. Some cities, such as Gdańsk **(+0.28),** Katowice **(+0.18),** Poznań **(+0.19),** and Białystok **(+0.11),** showed clear gains in LQ, suggesting increasing specialization in the sector. Conversely, the largest hubs, that is Kraków **(-0.59)** and Wrocław **(-0.68),** experienced **declines in relative specialization,** reflecting faster growth of other sectors within their economies. Similar downward trends were observed in Warsaw **(-0.14),** Szczecin **(-0.10),** and secondary Tricity locations **(-0.43),** indicating either stagnation or relative dilution of the sector's weight.

FIGURE 1.36 | **The sector as a local specialization of cities and metropolitan areas** (LQ – Location Quotient)



Source: ABSL's analysis based on ABSL's centers, database, and GUS data on the population of cities.

Grzegorz Mucha
Head of Shell Kraków

> **The GBS sector in Poland has entered a phase of maturity. Today, centres compete not on cost or scale, but on capabilities, productivity, and their tangible impact on business decision-making.**

This shift is clearly reflected in the transformation of service portfolios – from traditional back-office functions to specialised and expert roles, including data analytics, digital, cybersecurity, advanced finance, support for commercial activities and supply chains, and risk management. In this new model, end-to-end thinking, value generation, and accountability for measurable business outcomes are becoming critical. Within the sector itself, the share of knowledge-intensive jobs continues to grow, reaching 59% by the end of Q1 2025, while the proportion of purely operational and transactional roles is declining.

One of the key drivers of this transformation is technological disruption – from earlier waves of process automation (RPA) to the current rapid development of artificial intelligence (AI). Repetitive tasks are increasingly being taken over by digital tools, reducing routine work while simultaneously increasing demand for professionals who combine business expertise with data analytics, risk awareness, and advisory capabilities. As a result, companies are investing in digital skills development and expert career paths, while limiting hiring in simple, transactional process areas.

Shell in Kraków provides a clear example of this evolution. Established in 2006, the centre celebrates its 20th anniversary this year and illustrates the scale of this transformation. It has become a mature and trusted business partner, enabled in part by continuous innovation and adaptability. The Kraków hub has developed a broad portfolio of functions – from finance and HR to customer operations and logistics, as well as trading, creative services, data science, digital, and advanced analytics. Its scale – over 4,600 employees – is supported by strong local leadership, with more than 500 experienced leaders managing both local and global teams.

However, the key indicator is no longer “how many” roles, but “what kind” of roles. The year 2025 marked a turning point: for the first time, highly specialised and managerial positions account for over 50% of all roles in Kraków. This confirms a structural shift towards a high-complexity, high-accountability competence hub with a growing influence on business decisions. Today, Shell Kraków office is the company’s second-largest location in Europe after its London headquarters, playing a critical role in the delivery of its global strategy.

This reflects a broader trend: Poland is increasingly moving beyond its perception as an operational delivery location, and is becoming a place where global companies establish competence hubs that work alongside headquarters and co-create decisions of international importance. The ability to combine human and digital capabilities, along with the willingness to set new standards of competitiveness, is becoming a key differentiator.

The strengthening position of Poland as an attractive and strategic location is further evidenced by the fact that in 2026, the Shell Eco-marathon – a prestigious international competition focused on innovation and sustainable mobility – is being held in Poland for the second time. This is a clear signal that global companies perceive the country as a strong destination for investment, development projects, and international-scale events.

For the business services sector in Poland, the conclusion is clear: in the face of increasing cost pressures and adverse demographic trends, competitive advantage is built through specialisation, productivity, and skills development. Mature organisations, such as Shell Kraków, demonstrate that Poland can not only provide operational support but also create significant added value within global decision-making chains.

OFFICE MARKET IN POLAND

The Polish office market is undergoing a profound structural transformation. What has long been classified as an emerging or developing market is gradually maturing into a developed one, and this shift is clearly reflected in supply dynamics across the country's major cities. Rather than a pipeline-driven expansion, the market is now defined by selective development, deliberate stock reduction, and a sharper focus on quality over quantity of space.

This transition is most visible in Warsaw, where in 2025, more office space was withdrawn from the market than newly delivered. Over 160,000 m² of outdated buildings were removed through conversions, demolitions, and change of use – primarily into residential schemes – while new completions reached only 88,700 m². In the last five years alone, more than 540,000 m² of aging Warsaw stock has been transformed or removed, and a further 180,000 m² is expected to follow. The trend is also increasingly visible in regional cities as well, where older buildings that fail to meet modern tenant requirements are being progressively withdrawn, deepening the polarisation between prime and secondary assets.

As a result, Warsaw's vacancy has fallen to 9.1%, aligning the capital with the European average. In the prime central buildings, vacancy stands at just 6%. The volume of office space under construction remains low, meaning supply constraints will persist for several years. Companies seeking premium space already face waiting times of two to three years, and landlords are firmly in control of negotiations. Asking rents are expected to increase following these market conditions.

Across regional markets, cities such as Kraków, Tricity, and Poznań continue to attract strong occupier interest, while Wrocław, Katowice, and Łódź are contending with elevated vacancy in older buildings even as modern, well-located space remains scarce. The regional pipeline remains limited, with most new completions expected only after 2026. Owners of high-quality assets are strengthening their negotiating positions. In contrast, owners of older properties face growing pressure to invest in ESG-driven upgrades, repositioning, or functional conversion to remain competitive.

The occupier market continues to be shaped by the hybrid work model. High renegotiation volumes exceeding 50% of demand in Warsaw and many regional

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cities reflect both ongoing uncertainty about long-term space needs and a market reality where better alternatives are simply unavailable. For tenants, this means fewer relocation options, the need to plan moves 18–24 months in advance, and a growing emphasis on space optimization and operational cost reduction.

Flexible office space is becoming a strategic component of corporate real estate planning, with flex supply in Poland exceeding 430,000 m². The ability to combine long-term leases with shorter flex agreements is helping tenants manage risk in a supply-constrained market. Looking further ahead, the advancement of AI and process automation will reshape demand patterns, reducing the need for repetitive-task roles while driving demand for spaces that support analytical and collaborative work. Modern, intelligently managed buildings will continue to gain value, while assets that fail to keep pace with technological and ESG standards will require substantial investment to remain competitive. Poland's office market is entering a new, more mature chapter aligned with the most developed real estate markets in Europe.

TABLE 1.10 | **Major markets summary, Q1 2026**

City	Existing office supply (m²)	New completions (m²)	Vacancy rate (%)	Space under construction (m²)	Demand (m²)	Asking rents (EUR / m² / month)	Flex space (m²)
Katowice	742,100	0	22.1	34,500	10,300	12.50-16.95	16,000
Kraków	1,851,100	8,400	18.4	57,200	16,700	14.00-19.50	70,000
Lublin	224,600	0	10.5	8,500	1,400	12.00-14.25	3,000
Łódź	641,300	0	19.6	7,200	11,700	13.00-15.00	15,000
Poznań	673,200	0	13.8	72,800	5,700	15.00-19.00	13,000
Szczecin	191,600	2,000	7.9	0	600	12.00-15.00	3,000
Tricity	1,075,000	12,700	10.8	30,200	49,500	14.00-16.00	31,000
Warsaw	6,277,700	42,900	9.5	118,000	133,800	12.50-29.00	235,000
Wrocław	1,361,800	24,100	22.0	3,000	25,500	13.00-17.00	45,000

Source: Colliers.

Office statistics for 2025

13.0 million m²
Total office supply in Poland

460,000 m²
Space under construction in 2025 YE

17.0%
Share of demand generated by BPO & SSC centers in Warsaw

EUR **29.00**
Highest asking rents in Warsaw (m² / month)

38.0%
Share of demand generated by BPO & SSC centers in Warsaw and regions

EUR **19.50**
Highest asking rents in regions (m² / month)

1,550
Number of lease agreements in 2025

425,000 m²
Office space leased by BPO / SSC companies in 2025

1.57 million m²
Volume of lease agreements in 2025

47,200 m²
Absorption in 2025

13
Number of lease agreements over 10,000 m²

13.1%
Vacancy rate in the 9 major markets in Poland

9
Number of developed office markets

Katowice

The total office stock in Katowice at the end of Q1 2026 amounted to 742,100 m². Projects completed in the last five years constitute 23% of the existing resources.

Existing office buildings are clustered around the main traffic arteries, such as Chorzowska, Korfantego, and Murckowska streets, as well as Górnośląska and Roździeńskiego avenues.

No new projects were delivered to the market in 2025 and Q1 2026, and already-constructed office buildings postponed their opening dates, remaining in the "under construction" phase as they await their tenants. At the beginning of Q2 2026, around 34,500 m² of office space was in the final stage of construction, with completion timelines difficult to estimate. At the same time, developers significantly reduced the pipeline of planned projects due to the existing oversupply of vacant office space on the market. In response, many investors decided to change the function of their projects, shifting the focus toward residential use.

In 2025, total demand in Katowice reached the level of 55,600 m², which means it has increased by 17% compared to 2024. The largest share of the market was new agreements at 76%. Renegotiations constituted 20% and expansions 3% of the total lease volume. The average transaction size was 926 m², 38% higher than in 2024. In Q1 2026, tenant activity reached 10.300 m².

Among the largest deals signed between Q1 2025 and Q1 2026, notable are a new agreement by Tauron in. KTW II (9,800 m²), a new agreement signed by Warta in Grundmanna Office Park A (8,600 m²), and another new transaction by Sopra Steria Polska in Grundmanna Office Park A (4,000 m²). During this time, no deal above 10,000 m² was recorded.

The supply of flexible office space in Katowice is dynamically growing. The market operates about 16,000 m² of coworking space, with both foreign and Polish operators present, such as Ace of Space, City Space, DL Space, and Regus.

The vacancy rate at the end of Q1 2026 was 22.1% and noted a gradual decrease in past quarters. Approximately 164,000 m² of space is available for rent on the market.

Rental rates in the best buildings in the city range from EUR 12.50 to 16.95 m²/month in central zones and from EUR 10.00 to 12.80 m²/month in non-central zones.

Kraków

At the end of Q1 2026, the total office stock in Kraków exceeded 1.85 million m². The city is the second-largest office market in Poland after Warsaw and has been developing rapidly for years. Buildings completed in the last five years represent around 16% of the existing supply.

In 2025, around 11,900 m² of modern office space was delivered to the market, marking a record low supply. The new openings included Stella Office (9,900 m²) and a tenement house in Długa 18 street (2,000 m²). In Q1 2026, Inter-bud has finished its project – Fabryczna Office Park B7 (7,700 m²).

At the beginning of Q2 2026, approximately 57,200 m² were under construction, with planned completions in 2026 and 2027, including Tischnera Green Park (24,000 m²), Wita B and C buildings (19,000 m²), and Soneta (8,700 m²).

In terms of the office take-up registered in 2025, Kraków remained a leader among regional cities. Total gross demand amounted to 269,500 m², a level similar to 2024. Renegotiations accounted for the largest share among all contracts signed in 2025 at 63%. New contracts made up 31% of the total annual demand, and expansions 6%.

The lease agreements concluded in 2025 shaped the average transaction size at 1,370 m², 12% less than in 2024. In 2025, there were five lease agreements in Krakow that were signed for space exceeding 10,000 m². The largest transactions signed between Q1 2025 and Q1 2026 include a renewal of Shell in DOT Office Park A-C (22,900 m²), renegotiation of Motorola

Solutions in Green Office I and III (17,900 m²), as well as renewal of Aptiv in Enterprise Park A (14,300 m²). In Q1 2026, tenant activity reached 16,700 m².

The supply of flexible office space in Krakow is increasing, with nearly 70,000 m² available by the end of Q1 2026, offered by At Office, chilliflex, City Space, Cluster Offices, Quickwork, Regus, and other operators. At the end of Q1 2026, the vacancy rate decreased by 0.6 p.p. to 18.4%, which translated into almost 341,000 m² of available space.

Asking rents for office space have recorded an upward pressure in 2024 and remained stable in 2025, while their range differs depending on the office zones. In modern A-class projects, they reach EUR 14.00–19.50 m²/month in the central zone and EUR 10.00–13.50 m²/month in non-central zones.

Lublin

Lublin is the seventh-largest regional office market in Poland and the largest hub for modern offices in the eastern part of the country. At the end of Q1 2026, the total resources of modern office space amounted to 224,600 m² across 50 modern office buildings.

Buildings completed in the last five years represent about 17% of the existing supply. In Q1 2025 and Q1 2026, the developers completed the Zelwerowicza Office (3,700 m²). At the beginning of Q2 2026, two projects were in active construction, including Zwiazkowa 14 (6,000 m²0 and the renovation of Pałac Potockich (2,500 m²).

The total volume of lease transactions in Lublin in 2025 amounted to 19,000 m², which is twice the demand registered in 2024. As much as 28% of the contracts signed were defined as new agreements, 65% of the office space leased was through renegotiations, and expansions accounted for 7%.

The average size of lease transactions in 2025 was approximately 530 m², down 16% from 2024. Among the largest transactions in the Lublin market between Q1 2025 and Q1 2026, there were a renewal of a confidential tenant in Gray Office Park A (5,550 m²), a renewal of Generali Towarzystwo Ubezpieczeń in Spokojna 2 (1,400 m²), and a new agreement by a confidential tenant in Witosa I (1,310 m²).

In Q1 2026, the tenant activity was registered at the level of 1.400 m². The market for flexible office space in Lublin is in the initial stages of development. Two major players are present – Regus in the Zana 39 building and Loftmill in the CZ Office Park.

At the end of Q1 2026, the vacancy rate in Lublin decreased by 1.1 p.p to 10.5%. Currently, there are 23,600 m² of vacant office space in Lublin, across both Class A and Class B/B+.

Lublin is a competitive market compared to other regional cities due to favorable rental conditions. Rents for office space have remained at a similar level for several quarters. In Class A modern projects, tenants pay EUR 12.00 to 14.25/m²/month in the central zone and EUR 9.50 to 12.00/m²/month in areas outside the city center.

Łódź

By the end of Q1 2026, the supply of modern office space in Łódź amounted to 641,300 m². Buildings completed in the last five years represent around 9% of the existing supply.

Within the city center, three separate office hubs are becoming increasingly distinct: NCŁ, the vicinity of Piotrkowska street, and the junction of Mickiewicza and Piłsudskiego avenues and the vicinity of Marszałków on Piłsudskiego avenue covering Śmigłego-Rydza avenue and Kopcińskiego streets. The remaining office projects are in the north-western part of the city (Teofilów) and the south-eastern zone (Dąbrowa).

In 2025 and in Q1 2026, no new office projects were delivered to the market. At the beginning of Q2 2026, 7,200 m² of office space was under construction, with a completion timeline set for the end of 2027. The total gross demand in Łódź in 2025 was 51,700 m², a 13% decrease from 2024.

The major part of total tenant activity in 2025 comprised new agreements – 47%. Renegotiations accounted for 21%. Owner-occupier transactions made up 27%. Expansions accounted for 4%.

The average size of lease transactions in 2025 decreased by 15% compared to 2024, amounting to 795 m². In Q1 2026, tenant activity reached 11,700 m². Among the largest transactions signed between Q1 2025 and Q1 2026 in Łódź were an owner-occupier transaction by Samorząd Województwa Łódzkiego in Brama Miasta II (14,200 m²), a new agreement of City Space in React (3,500 m²), and a renewal of Commerzbank in Ogrodowa 8 Office (5,500 m²).

The supply of flexible office space in Łódź is stable, estimated at about 15,000 m². Among the active operators are Avestus Flex, chilliflex, City Space and Memos. At the end of Q1 2026, the vacancy rate decreased significantly by 3.1 p.p., reaching 19.6%, which translates into 126,000 m² of available space.

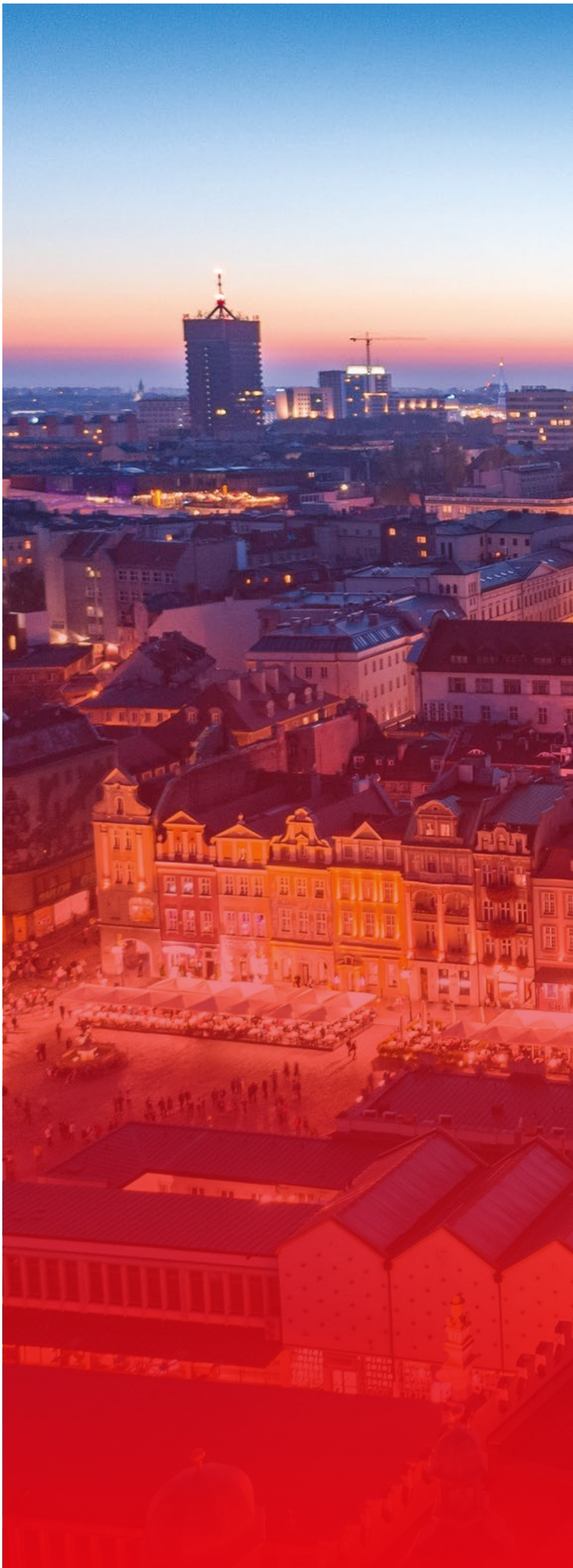
Compared to other cities, Łódź is a competitive market – asking rents in prime properties amounted to EUR 13.00-15.00 m²/month in the central zone and EUR 9.00–12.00 m²/month in non-central zones.

Poznań

The total office stock in Poznań at the end of Q1 2026 amounted to 673,200 m². Buildings completed in the last five years represent around 15% of the existing supply.

In the past year, developers completed two office projects – Dymka 188 (2,400 m²) and Bukowska 144 (2,500 m²).

At the beginning of Q2 2026, 72,800 m² of office space was under construction, with completion scheduled for the end of 2027. This volume includes three large-scale projects – an office building named Industrial by TMT (9,300 m²), planned for 2026; the AND2 office tower (37,800 m²); and another phase of the Nowy Rynek complex – building C (25,700 m²), planned to be delivered in 2027 and 2028.



Notable planned investments include the Stara Rzeźnia project, which is being developed by Vastint. The city's development will also be significantly influenced by a multi-stage investment by BPI Real Estate Poland and Revive in the center of Poznań on the site of former military barracks, which plans to combine residential, service, and office functions as well as the revitalization of historic buildings in the Cavallia complex.

The total volume of lease transactions in 2025 amounted to 71,800 m², a 13% decrease from 2024. Renegotiations dominated the demand structure with 53% of the lease volume. New contracts reached 37%. The share of expansions made up 10% of the total annual demand. In Q1 2026, tenant activity totaled 5,700 m².

The average size of lease transactions in 2025 in Poznań was 890 m², which is 12% less than in 2024. Among the largest agreements signed from Q1 2025 to Q1 2026 were a renewal and expansion of Rockwool GBS in Nowy Rynek D (9,700 m²), a renewal and expansion of Grant Thornton in Malta Office Park F (4,200 m²), and a renewal of Miele Global Services in Business Garden Poznań B7 (2,700 m²).

The flexible office space market in Poznań is in its initial stages of development, with a total supply estimated at 13,000 m² offered by operators such as Biurcoo, Business Link, Concordia Design, eN Studio, and Regus. At the end of Q1 2026, the vacancy rate stood at 13.8%, which translated into 93,200 m² of available space.

Rent rates for office space recorded an increase after being stable for several quarters. Tenants at modern A-class projects have to pay rents of EUR 15.00–19.00 m²/month in the central zone and EUR 12.00–13.50 m²/month in non-central zones.

Szczecin

The existing modern office space in Szczecin totals 191,600 m², the lowest among the eight regional cities. Szczecin is a market that is relatively early in its development.

Buildings completed in the last five years represent only 3% of the existing supply. The supply develops cyclically—usually, after a period rich in new investments, there is a decrease in developer activity, a natural period needed for the absorption of existing office space. In 2025, no new office projects were completed. In Q1 2026, the office part of Hangar by Marina Developer was delivered (2,000 m²), and no other projects are under construction.

The vast majority of office space in Szczecin (about 80%) is located in the city center around Al. Wyzwolenia, Al. Niepodległości, and in the area of Brama Portowa. This is where the city's office and commercial resources are concentrated. A new location is the southern part of the city – Gumieńce, where large office projects such as Cukrowa Office and Szczecin Business Plaza have been recently completed.

In Szczecin, there is a moderate level of interest from office space tenants. Gross demand in the past year, as recorded by official sources, was only 11,500 m². In Q1 2026, tenant activity was registered at 600 m². In 2025, renegotiations and lease extensions reached up to 34% annual demand, while new agreements accounted for 32% of annual demand. Owner-occupier transactions made up 34%.

The largest transactions in the period from Q1 2025 to Q1 2026 included an owner-occupier transaction by Unibaltic in Wojska Polskiego 83 (2,400 m²), a new agreement of Pekao in Sky Garden (1,800 m²), and a renewal of Macrobond in Oxygen (1,700 m²). The average size of lease transactions concluded in 2025 increased to 670 m², up 16% from 2024. The flexible office space market in Szczecin is in its initial stages of development, with operators offering services such as BeIn Offices, Biuro Aloha, and Marina cowork. The vacancy rate increased to 7.9% in the end of Q1 2026, which translates to 15,100 m² of available space. This is the lowest rate among all regional cities.

Rents for office space have remained at a similar level for several years. In Class A modern projects, tenants in the city center must pay EUR 12.00 to 15.00 m²/month, while in areas outside the city center, the range is EUR 10.00 to 12.00 m²/month.

Tricity

The total stock in Tricity amounts to 1,057,000 m², which places Tricity in third place among all regional cities. Buildings completed in the last five years represent around 20% of the existing supply.

The largest amount of office space is available in Gdańsk (75%), followed by Gdynia (22%) and Sopot (3%). The modern stock is concentrated along the route of Szybka Kolej Miejska, Droga Gdyńska, and al. Grunwaldzka (Wrzeszcz, Oliwa). Office projects are also located in the vicinity of the Gdańsk airport and in the center of Gdańsk.

In 2025, no new office buildings were completed in Tricity. In Q1 2026, Torus delivered the Punkt office building, offering 12,700 m² of modern space.

At the beginning of Q2 2026, approximately 30,200 m² were in active construction with delivery dates in the next two years.

The volume of transactions registered in Tricity in 2025 exceeded 113,800 m², a minimal 2% decrease from 2024. Renegotiations dominated all transactions, comprising 47% of annual tenant activity, while the share of new contracts rose to 44%. Expansions accounted for 7% and owner-occupier transactions for 2%. In Q1 2026, tenant activity was the highest among regional cities and reached 49,500 m².

The average size of lease transactions in 2025 was approximately 1,355 m², a 27% increase compared to 2024. Among the largest transactions in the market from Q1 2025 to Q1 2026 was a renewal of a confidential tenant from the logistics sector in Olivia Prime, Point and Tower (13,800 m²), a renewal and expansion of a confidential tenant in Olivia Star (12,200 m²), and a renewal of Adtran in Tensor Y (6,800 m²).

The flexible office space market in Gdańsk is rapidly developing, with approximately 31,000 m² of flex space offered by operators such as chilliflex, Collab, Mind Dock, O4, Quickwork, Regus, and Spaces. The vacancy rate decreased by 10.8% the end of Q1 2026, translating to 116,100 m² of available space. The vacancy rate in Gdańsk was 8.3%, and in Gdynia, it was 19.9%.

In the class A buildings, rents for office space have increased in the past year and amount to EUR 14.00–16.00 m²/month in central zones and EUR 11.50–13.00 m²/month in non-central zones.

Warsaw

Warsaw is the largest office market in Poland with almost 6.28 million m² of office space. At the beginning of Q2 2026, only around 118,000 m² were under construction and renovation, with delivery deadlines set for 2026–2029. A further 200,000 m² scheduled for 2027–2031 is in the planning phase.

In 2025, the Warsaw market grew by 88,700 m² of office space. Among the buildings completed in the capital were The Bridge (47,000 m², Ghelamco) and the first office building within the mixed-use T22 complex – Office House (27,800 m², Echo Investment). Approximately 90% of the new supply was delivered in the City Center West subzone.

In Q1 2026, four buildings were added to the modern stock – the modernization process of V Tower and Przemysłowa 26a has been finished, as well as Studio A by Skanska and Vena by PHN were granted permit usage. Additionally, in total 42.9600 m² of new office space was delivered to the capital city market.

The Warsaw market is undergoing a dynamic transformation. Buildings completed within the past five years account for around 13% of the existing stock. During the same period, almost 500,000 m² of office space in 48 buildings was withdrawn from the Warsaw market for refurbishment or change of use. In 2025 alone, 166,500 m² were excluded from modern office stock (including Danone HQ, Pekao Tower, Saski Point, Myhive Mokotów: Two, Three, Four).

The volume of transactions registered in Warsaw in 2025 exceeded 794,100 m², a 7% increase compared to 2024. New agreements accounted for 40% of the total annual demand in Warsaw, while renegotiations represented 51%, expansions 6%, and space for owner use 4%. Q1 2026 ended with reasonable tenant interest of 133,800 sq m.

Lease agreements concluded in 2025 shaped the average transaction size to be comparable to the previous year, about 1,110 m², an increase of 4% compared to 2024. Seven office space deals for over 10,000 m² were registered. The largest transactions from Q1 2025 to Q1 2026 included a renewal of Polkomtel at Multimedialny Dom Plusa (22,700 m²), a renewal and expansion of AstraZeneca at Postępu 14 (20,800 m²), and a renewal of a confidential tenant (Citi PLC) at Generation Park X (18,000 m²).

There is significant interest in flexible office spaces in the Warsaw market. Their supply continues to grow year on year, reaching over 235,000 m². Among the main Warsaw flex space operators are WeWork, Regus, Spaces, New Work, and CiC. The vacancy rate in Warsaw decreased to 9.5% at the end of Q1 2026, which translated to 597,100 m² of available space.

Rental rates for office space have seen a rise in the following year after increases in recent years. In central zones, rents amounted to EUR 12.50–29.00 m²/month, while in non-central locations they were lower at EUR 12.00–18.00 m²/month.

Wrocław

Wrocław, with its office space inventory totaling 1.36 million m² by the end of Q1 2026, ranks as the second largest regional office market in Poland. Buildings completed in the last five years represent around 15% of the existing supply.

Several areas in Wrocław are recognized for their high concentration of office space. Most resources (40%) are located in the Central Business District, which is divided into the strict city center and surrounding central areas. Other key office hubs include the Western Business Area and the Southern Business Axis along ul. Powstańców Śląskich.

In 2025, no new office space was delivered to the Wrocław market. The Q1 2026, however, has ended with the largest new supply volume among regional markets – two office buildings were delivered, Swobodna SPOT (14,600 m²) and The Park Wrocław II (9,500 m²). At the beginning of Q2 2026, only 3,000 m² of modern office space were under construction.

In 2025, the gross demand for office space in Wrocław was 179,600 m², marking a 23% increase compared to the previous year. Renegotiations dominated the contract structure, accounting for 57% of the total demand, while new agreements made up 33%. Expansions accounted for 10% of demand and owner-occupier deals for 1%. In Q1 2026, tenant activity reached 25,500 m².

The average size of lease transactions concluded in 2025 was about 840 m², a decrease of 28% compared to 2024. Among the largest transactions signed from Q1 2025 to Q1 2026 were a renewal of a confidential tenant from the business services sector in Business Garden Wrocław (15,000 m²), a renegotiation of a confidential tenant from the business services sector in two buildings of the Wrocław Business Garden complex (13,000 m²), as well as a renewal of Align Technology in Wrocławski Park Biznesu Bierutowska Park III (12,600 m²). The flexible office space market in Wrocław is rapidly developing. In 2026, its supply increased to about 45,000 m², with numerous operators present, including Ace of Space, Business Link, CitySpace, Concordia Design, Loftmill, Quickwork, Ready Flex, Regus, and Spaces.

At the end of Q1 2026, the vacancy rate increased by 22% due to new completions delivered recently, which translated into almost 300,000 m² of available space.

Office space rents have been under upward pressure in the past year. In modern A-class projects, tenants pay EUR 13.00–17.00 m²/month in central zones and EUR 11.50–13.50 m²/month in non-central zones.

TABLE 1.11 | **Secondary markets summary, Q1 2026**

	Total stock (m²)	**Vacancy rate** (%)	**New completions 2025** (m²)	**Under construction** (m²)	**Asking rents** (EUR / m² / month)
Białystok	79,000	10.0	0	7,100	10.00-16.00
Bydgoszcz	160,000	17.0	0	0	10.00-16.00
Kielce	77,000	7.0	4,500	0	8.00-14.00
Olsztyn	73,000	9.0	0	6,500	8.00-16.00
Opole	81,000	6.0	0	7,300	8.00-15.00
Radom	53,000	8.0	0	1,000	6.00-13.00
Rzeszów	136,000	9.0	12,000	11,200	7.00-17.00
Tarnów	19,000	6.0	0	0	6.00-13.00
Toruń	108,000	12.0	7,900	10,400	8.00-16.00

Source: Colliers.

Commercial real estate investment in Central and Eastern Europe: Poland consolidates leadership as regional recovery broadens

Grzegorz Sielewicz
Chief Economist, Colliers

After two years of profound adjustment marked by repricing, limited liquidity, and cautious investor sentiment, commercial real estate investment activity in Central and Eastern Europe has firmly shifted into a new phase. The year 2025 represented a clear turning point, as postponed decisions translated into executed transactions, while the first months of 2026 confirm that the recovery is no longer isolated to a handful of prime deals.

That said, the revival is neither uniform nor speculative. Capital is returning selectively, favoring markets and assets where income durability, financing availability, and transparent pricing intersect. Within this framework, Poland has emerged as the regional anchor market, while other CEE countries are following along differentiated, locally specific trajectories.

CEE in 2025: recovery driven by realism, not exuberance

Total investment volumes across the six core CEE markets reached EUR 11.6 billion in 2025, representing a 31% year-on-year increase. This rebound was driven less by global capital flows and more by domestic and regional investors, who adapted quickly to higher interest rates, structurally higher capex requirements, and more conservative growth assumptions.

A defining feature of the year was the dominance of CEE capital, which accounted for 64% of total investment volumes, offsetting the still-limited engagement of Western European institutions. This shift materially improved market resilience and transaction liquidity, particularly in markets with sufficient depth and asset availability.

Poland: the largest, deepest, and most diversified market in CEE

Poland remained the largest commercial real estate investment market in Central and Eastern Europe in 2025, closing the year with approximately EUR 4.5 billion in transaction volume. This leadership was not only quantitative but also structural: Poland offered the broadest mix of asset classes, deal sizes, and risk profiles across the region.

Industrial and logistics assets continued to provide a stable liquidity backbone, offices gradually regained strategic relevance, and retail parks delivered resilient income profiles amid strong domestic consumption fundamentals. Crucially, domestic investors reached a record level of engagement, deploying close to EUR 860 million – the highest amount of local capital ever recorded in the Polish market.

This breadth differentiates Poland from other CEE markets. While individual countries recorded strong niche performances, only Poland was able to absorb both large portfolio transactions and single-asset deals across multiple sectors, reinforcing its position as the region's primary capital allocation destination.

Czechia: exceptional strength, cyclical normalization

Czechia delivered the strongest investment performance in its history in 2025, coming very close to Poland in absolute volumes, driven almost entirely by domestic funds and private capital. The country's well-developed fund ecosystem allowed investors to execute decisively even amid global uncertainty, positioning Czechia as a core liquidity provider for the region.

However, the exceptional nature of the 2025 result also sets a high base for comparison. Initial indications from early 2026 suggest a moderation of activity, reflecting both the limited availability of large-scale assets and the natural absorption of record volumes already completed. While Czechia remains among the most resilient and institutionally mature CEE markets, replicating 2025-level volumes appears increasingly unlikely in the near term.

Other CEE markets: selective recovery, sector-led momentum

Beyond Poland and Czechia, investment activity across the wider CEE region has been improving unevenly but constructively.

» **Hungary** recorded a recovery in volumes driven primarily by offices, hotels, and manufacturing-linked logistics assets. Investor interest has been supported by strong tourism metrics and growing industrial demand tied to EV and nearshoring supply chains, though persistently higher interest rates and fiscal uncertainty continue to constrain leverage-driven strategies.

» **Romania** remained below its long-term average in investment volumes, yet occupier markets, particularly logistics, are among the strongest in the region. With inflation easing and financing conditions gradually improving, Romania is positioned for a later-cycle recovery, rather than immediate acceleration.

» **Slovakia** benefited mainly from retail transactions and cross-border inflows of Czech capital. While its market size remains limited, selective opportunities in retail and office repositioning attracted interest as pricing adjusted and competition remained relatively low.

» **Bulgaria** demonstrated stable investment activity ahead of euro adoption, with investor confidence improving notably in Prague-like fashion within Sofia's prime office and mixed-use assets. The market remains small, but institutional interest is broadening as currency risk diminishes.

Taken together, these markets reinforce a key theme of the current cycle: CEE is not recovering in unison, but through differentiated, locally-anchored paths, with Poland providing scale and liquidity, while others contribute targeted sectoral opportunities.

Poland entering 2026: momentum confirmed

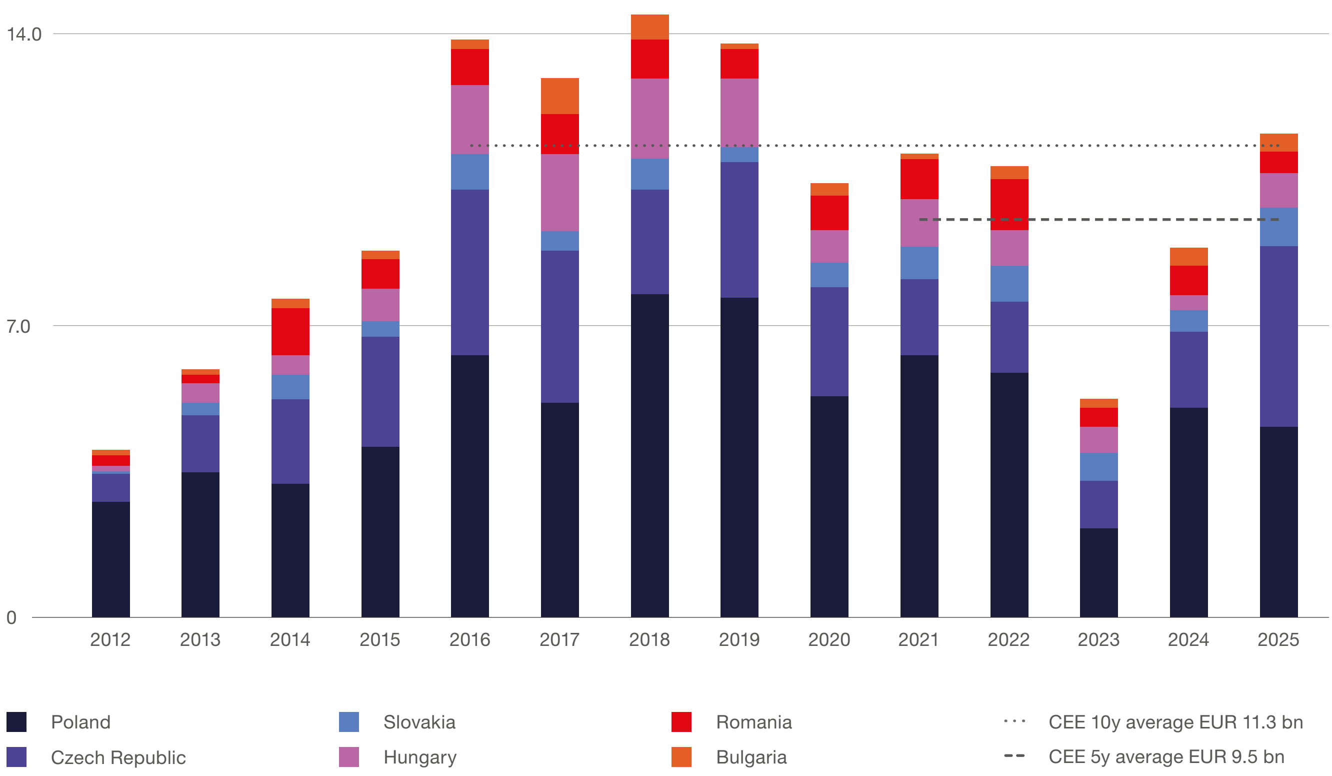
Poland started 2026 with a strong signal of continuity rather than volatility. The first quarter alone delivered approximately EUR 1.0 billion in transactions, the highest quarterly result since 2022 and a 40% year-on-year increase. Importantly, this was underpinned by deal depth: 26 transactions covering 54 assets.

Industrial and logistics assets accounted for 44% of the volume, retail for 32%, and offices for 20%, aligning closely with regional preferences but executed at a scale unmatched elsewhere in CEE. Sale-and-leaseback structures and portfolio transactions continued to dominate capital deployment, reinforcing Poland's role as a preferred market for long-term, income-driven strategies.

Offices, financing, and market discipline

Across CEE, offices are no longer priced on the expectation of yield compression, but increasingly on rental growth potential, location quality, and ESG

FIGURE 1.37 | **CEE Investment volumes by country** (in EUR billion – history)



Source: Colliers.

repositioning viability. Warsaw and Prague stand out as markets where constrained new supply and improving tenant demand support this logic most clearly.

Financing conditions have also shifted. While debt remains more expensive than before 2022, banks are once again active lenders for grade-A, cash-flow-secure assets, and competition among lenders has improved pricing visibility. At the same time, real estate debt has itself become an increasingly relevant investment strategy across CEE.

Where the region stands today

By mid-2026, Central and Eastern Europe will no longer be in a repair phase, but neither has it entered a new expansionary cycle. Instead, the region operates within a disciplined recovery framework, defined by selective liquidity, realistic pricing, and growing differentiation between markets and assets.

In this landscape, Poland clearly consolidates its role as the region's investment benchmark – the largest, most liquid, and most diversified market. Czechia remains a key pillar, though its exceptional 2025 performance is already normalizing, while the rest of CEE contributes incremental, opportunity-driven growth.

The defining feature of the current phase is not speed, but credibility. Capital is returning where value is demonstrable, and in Central and Eastern Europe, that dynamic increasingly works to Poland's advantage.

2

TALENT

Introduction

As Poland's business services sector matures, talent remains its most critical asset and a key challenge. This chapter expands on Chapter 1 by examining the sector's transition from a labor-driven model to one focused on capability, productivity, and work design.

This analysis reflects a labor market in transition. Although talent pressure has eased due to cyclical factors and organizational maturity, the main challenge now is securing specialized skills and deploying them within more complex, technology-enabled models. Demographic shifts, hybrid work, international mobility, and rising employee expectations are also redefining work structures and service provision.

The rapid advancement of generative AI and agentic technologies is accelerating this shift. Instead of only reducing labor demand, these technologies are reshaping roles, raising skill requirements, and revealing a widening gap between individual productivity gains and their effective integration at the organizational level.

Using insights from the ABSL 2026 survey and the ABSL centers database, this chapter analyzes workforce structure, demographics, tenure, turnover, and talent availability, as well as evolving employment models and the increasing role of international talent.

It also examines organizational responses, including work model redesign, targeted development, diversity and inclusion strategies, and the growing importance of managerial capabilities.

The chapter highlights a structural change in the sector's talent model, moving from scale to capability. Growth now depends less on headcount expansion and more on productivity, expertise, and the integration of human and AI-driven work. Contributions from strategic partners, including Mercer, Randstad, and OPI – National Research Institute, offer additional perspective and help position Poland within global labor market trends.

> **The labor market is not disappearing – it is reorganizing around new tasks.**
>
> **David Autor**
>
> Professor of Labor Economics, MIT

ABSL

Chapter content developed by: **ABSL**

Key talent facts & takeaways

The sector is shifting focus from expansion to capability. Growth now relies more on productivity, expertise, and technology integration than on increasing headcount.

Talent constraints are moving from scarcity to skills mismatch. While overall pressure has eased, shortages in advanced and digital skills persist.

AI is transforming work, but value capture is not keeping pace with adoption. Productivity gains are emerging at the team level but are not yet fully integrated into operating models.

Execution, rather than technology, is the main bottleneck. Competitive advantage depends on effectively integrating AI into workflows and scaling productivity improvements.

Workforce maturity is increasing structurally. Employees aged 35+ now account for 51.3% of the workforce, with rising tenure and a dominant share of specialist roles.

Demand is increasing for experienced, high-skill talent. Automation is reducing reliance on junior roles and raising the need for domain expertise and process ownership.

Employment growth is becoming more selective. The proportion of centers planning expansion has decreased from over 79% in 2021 to 54.8% in 2026, reflecting a move toward efficiency-led growth.

Hybrid work has become the standard. Competitive advantage now depends on how well hybrid models are executed.

Labor markets are re-localizing. Recruitment strategies focus on local talent pools despite global delivery models.

International talent continues to be a key capability driver. Foreign employees, who make up approximately 16.5% of the workforce, provide access to scarce skills and support global service models.

Talent in Poland demonstrates above-average readiness in AI compared to global benchmarks. This is a strong signal and a clear competitive advantage

Attrition has stabilized at moderate levels. Voluntary turnover (7.4%) and low involuntary exits (2-4%) indicate a more balanced and less overheated labor market.

Compensation dynamics are stabilizing and becoming more structured:

- » Salary growth is expected to be approximately 5%.
- » 97% of salary increases are performance-driven.
- » Promotion-related salary increases are standardized at approximately 13 to 15%.
- » These trends are strengthening the alignment between pay and productivity.

Entry-level compensation remains competitive but limited. Salaries of approximately 5,800 to 7,100 PLN support cost positioning but may restrict access to top talent.

Compensation systems remain underdeveloped. Approximately 87% of firms lack structured graduate pay frameworks, leading to inconsistencies and weakening employer positioning.

Transparency and wage convergence are reshaping competition. Regional pay gaps are narrowing, and greater transparency is increasing employee bargaining power and shifting the focus toward fairness rather than absolute pay.

Adjusting working models

The 2026 survey confirms that hybrid work is now the dominant model. **It is no longer a transitional phase but an established approach that balances cost, productivity, and retention.**

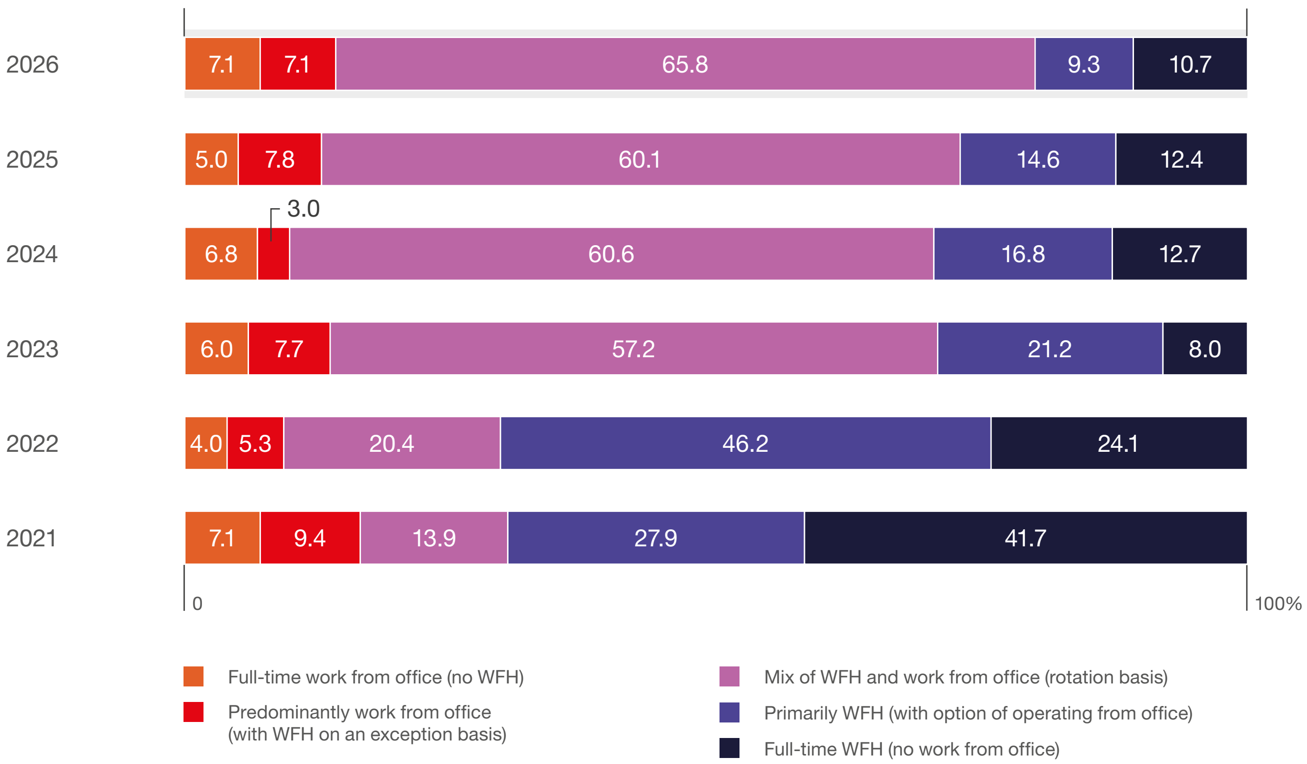
Two- and three-day office models are the most common (38.2% and 33.8%, respectively). **This standardization marks a transition toward a market norm, reducing differentiation while increasing predictability.**

Fully remote work declined from 8.5% to 4.3%. Organizations are phasing out fully remote arrangements **in favor of structured hybrid models.** Hybrid work increased to 65.8% in 2026, up from 13.9% in 2021; remote work fell to 9.3%. **The sector has shifted from remote-first to hybrid-first operations.** Fully remote roles now represent only 10.7% of the internal workforce. **Remote work is no longer a scalable default but rather a niche exception.**

Work design now focuses on coordinating presence rather than offering location choice. Respondents' declarations show a gradual adjustment toward **three days in office** (40.6%). **Management is tightening control to reinforce productivity, culture, and execution.** Two-day office models remain relevant but are now secondary. **Flexibility is maintained, though within stricter operational boundaries.** Fully on-site work remains low at approximately 14%. A complete **return-to-office model is unlikely.**

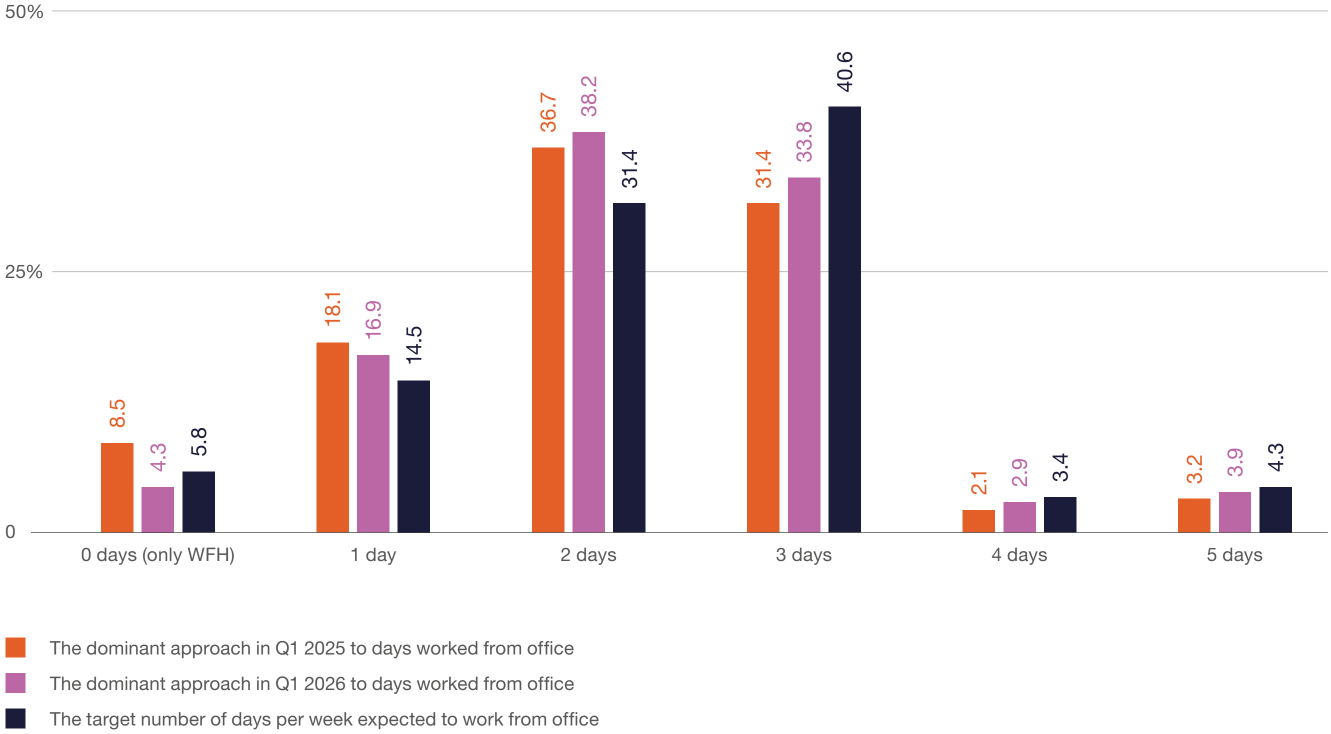
Hybrid work is now the standard. **The competitive advantage now depends on how effectively hybrid work is managed.** For leaders, the priority is execution. **Aligning hybrid work with process design, team coordination, and performance management. The focus should alter from flexibility as a benefit to hybrid as an operating model that directly supports productivity, knowledge transfer, and delivery quality.**

FIGURE 2.1 | **Proportions of internal workforce in various working models** (2021-2026, %)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=211).

FIGURE 2.2 **The dominant approach to days worked from the office** (number of days, %)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=207).

Return to office & recruitment strategy

We examine how return to office (RTO) affects operations and recruitment in Poland. Hybrid work remains the dominant model. The increased office presence brings mixed outcomes.

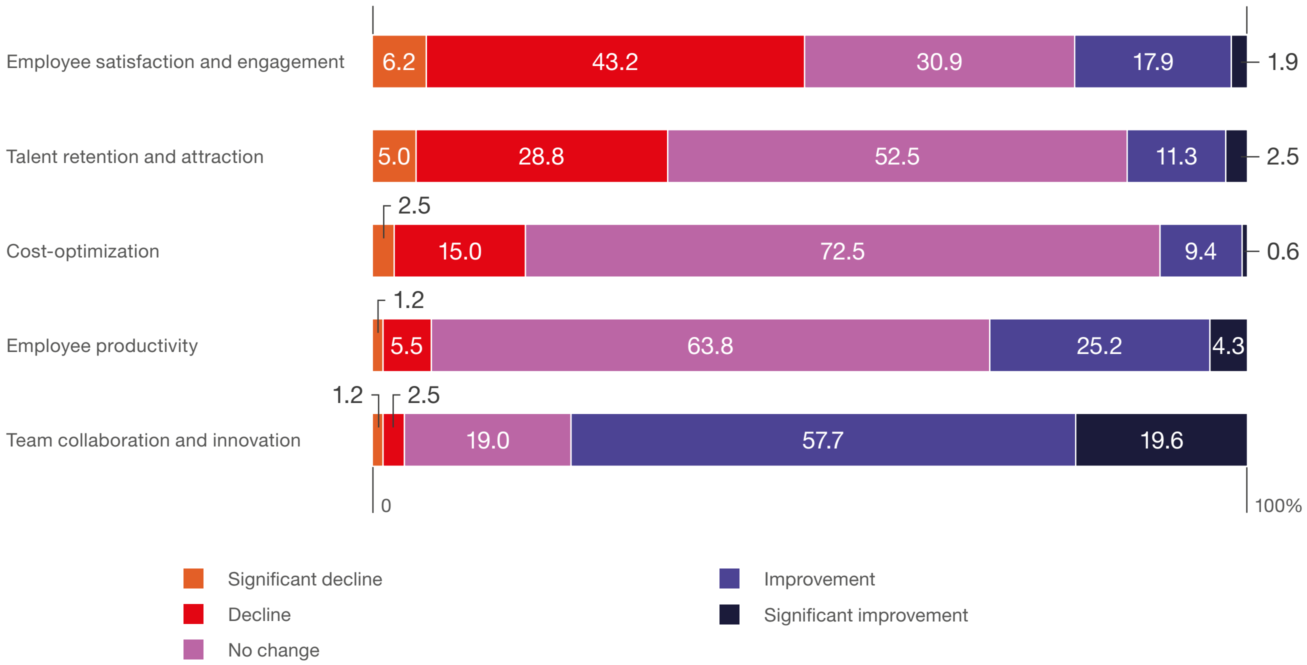
In-office presence enhances team dynamics. 57.7% of respondents have noted improved collaboration, and 19.6% have noted significant improvement. In-person work also facilitates knowledge sharing and cross-functional cooperation.

RTO has a negative effect on employee satisfaction and talent outcomes, however. Nearly half (49.4%) report lower engagement, and most firms see no improvement (52.5%) or a decline in talent attraction and retention. Office requirements are increasingly at odds with expectations for flexibility.

The impact on productivity and costs remains limited. Most organizations report no significant change, though 29.5% observe some productivity gains, primarily in coordination-intensive functions.

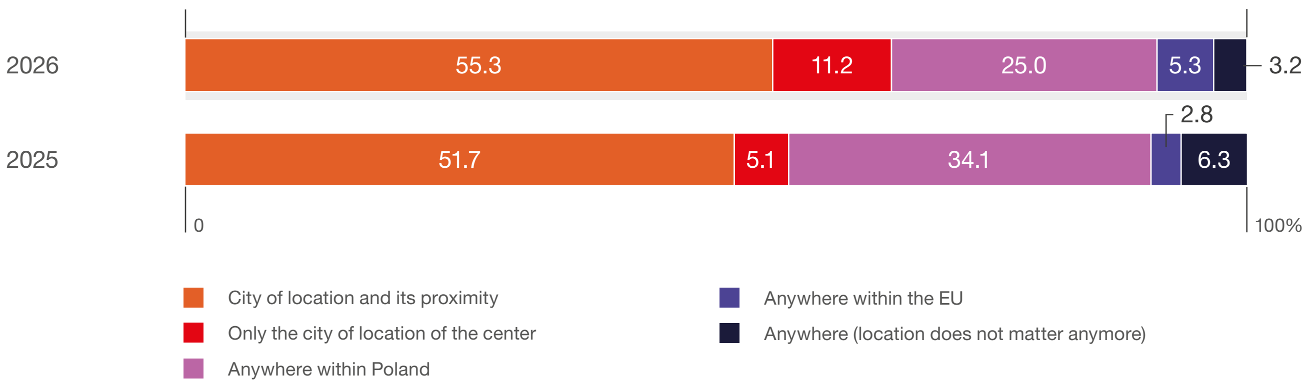
RTO is also changing recruitment practices. Firms are sourcing talent locally; 55.3% focus on the city or nearby areas, and 11.2% exclusively on the city. Broader national and international sourcing is declining.

FIGURE 2.3 **Impact of return to office on the selected aspects of centers' operations** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=163).

FIGURE 2.4 **Main recruitment strategy** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=188).

Workforce structure, age, tenure, and diversity

Employment by age group, job position

The sector is transitioning from scale-driven models to capability-driven operations, as evidenced by changes in workforce demographics and job structures.

By 2026, employees aged 35 and above accounted for 51.3% of the workforce, up from 29.0% in 2019, a 22-percentage-point increase. The majority of employees now fall within the 27-44 age group (74.5%), while those aged 26 or younger comprise only 11.4%. These trends reflect a structural shift toward mid- and senior-level experience, driven by greater process complexity and an increased demand for domain expertise.

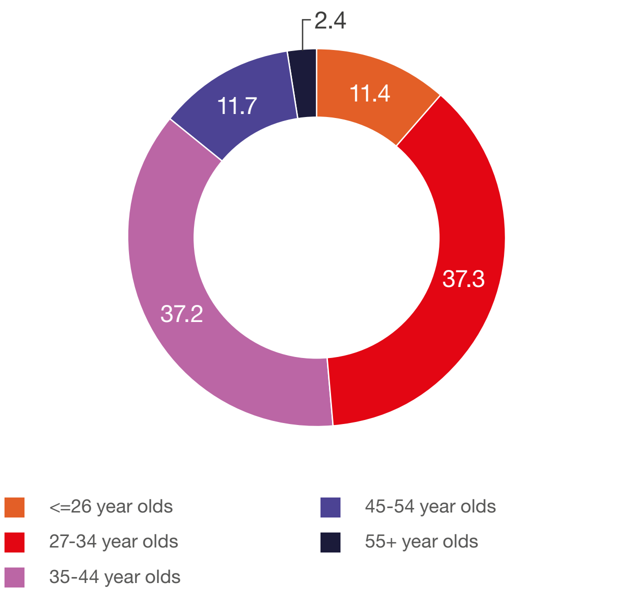
A similar transformation is evident in job structure. The proportion of junior roles declined from **31.2% in 2020 to 23.4% in 2026.** The share of specialists increased from **51.2% to 58.2%,** making them the predominant workforce segment. Management layers have remained stable at 14.6%, indicating controlled organizational scaling. Director-level positions increased from **2.5% to 3.8%. This points to enhanced governance and greater integration into high-value decision-making processes.**

The primary drivers of these changes are increased process sophistication and automation. As routine, low-complexity tasks are automated, demand shifts toward roles that require analytical skills, experience, and comprehensive process ownership. Consequently, the need for entry-level positions declines, while reliance on specialists and senior professionals grows.

As a result, the employment model resembles that of mature knowledge-based industries, where value creation relies more on expertise, integration capability, and decision support than on workforce scale.

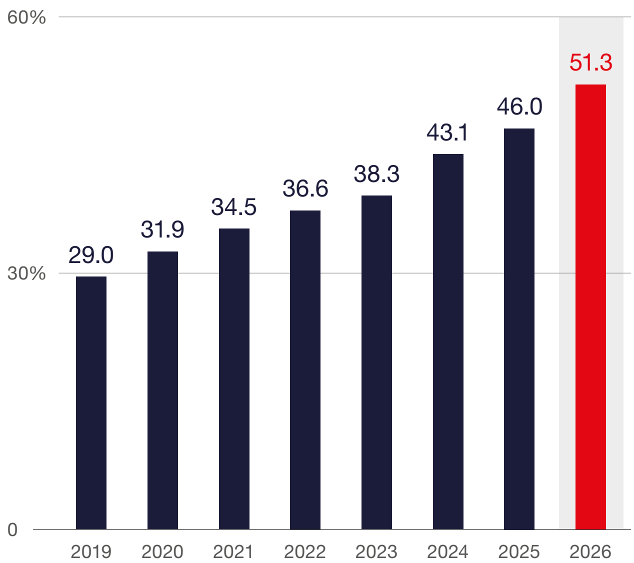
This represents a fundamental structural change in the operating model. Talent strategies should prioritize the retention and development of experienced professionals, while operating models must facilitate greater process ownership and deeper integration with core business functions. Centers in Poland are evolving from primarily cost-efficient units to embedded capability hubs within global value chains.

FIGURE 2.5 **The employment structure of business services centers according to the age of employees** (%)



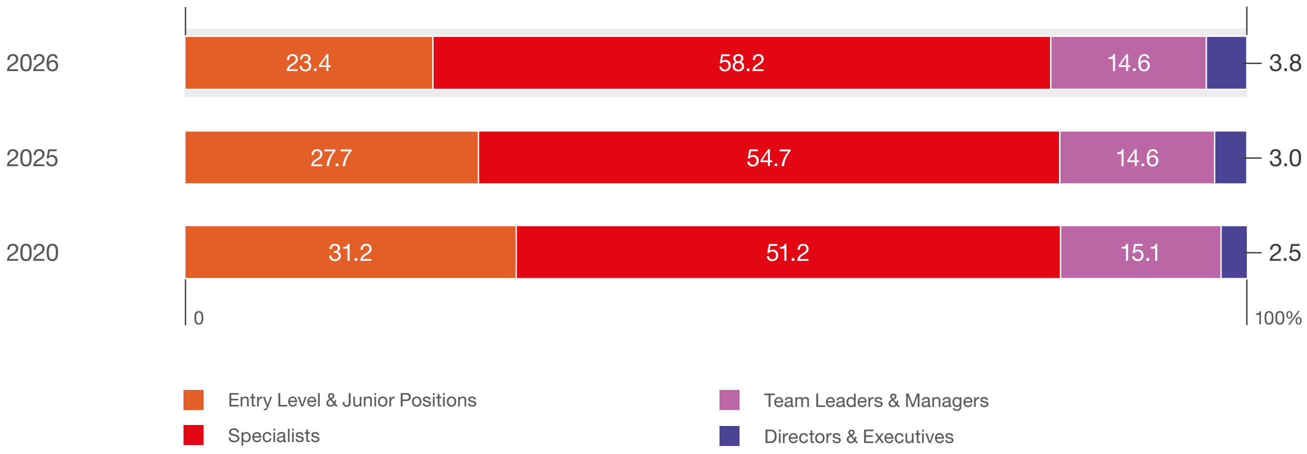
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=180). The results are employment weighted.

FIGURE 2.6 **The share of 35+-year-olds in the sector's employment** (2019-2026, %)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=180). The results are employment weighted.

FIGURE 2.7 **Employment structure of business services centers by job category** (2020, 2025, 2026, %)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=191). The results are employment weighted.

Tenure

Employee tenure in business service centers offers insight into the sector's development and workforce dynamics. Recent survey results show a **balanced mix of early-career and experienced employees.**

In 2026, employees with 3 to 5 years of service make up the largest group (32.7% of total employment, up from 27.5% in 2025). This trend illustrates more employees advancing beyond onboarding and gaining operational expertise. These tenure levels often correspond with specialized skills and increased responsibilities.

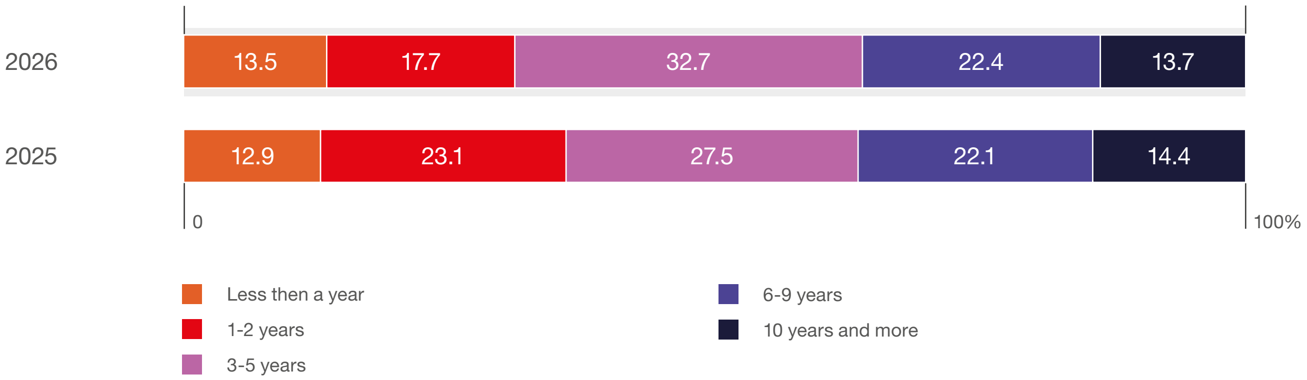
Employees with 6 to 9 years of tenure represent 22.4% of the workforce, a figure that has remained stable year over year. Along with the 3 to 5-year group, they form a core group of mid-tenure professionals who bring experience and a strong understanding of organizational processes and client needs.

The proportion of employees with shorter tenures is more varied. Those with less than one year of experience account for 13.5% of employment, a slight increase from the previous year. Employees with one to two years of tenure declined from 23.1% in 2025 to 17.7% in 2026. This change may reflect both employee progression into longer tenure categories and more cautious hiring.

Employees with 10 or more years of service make up 13.7% of total employment, a proportion that has remained stable. They are not the largest group, but their presence is vital for maintaining institutional knowledge, leadership continuity, and internal expertise.

As services become more complex, retaining employees beyond the early tenure phase will be essential to maintaining a competitive advantage.

FIGURE 2.8 | **Employment structure by tenure** (%)



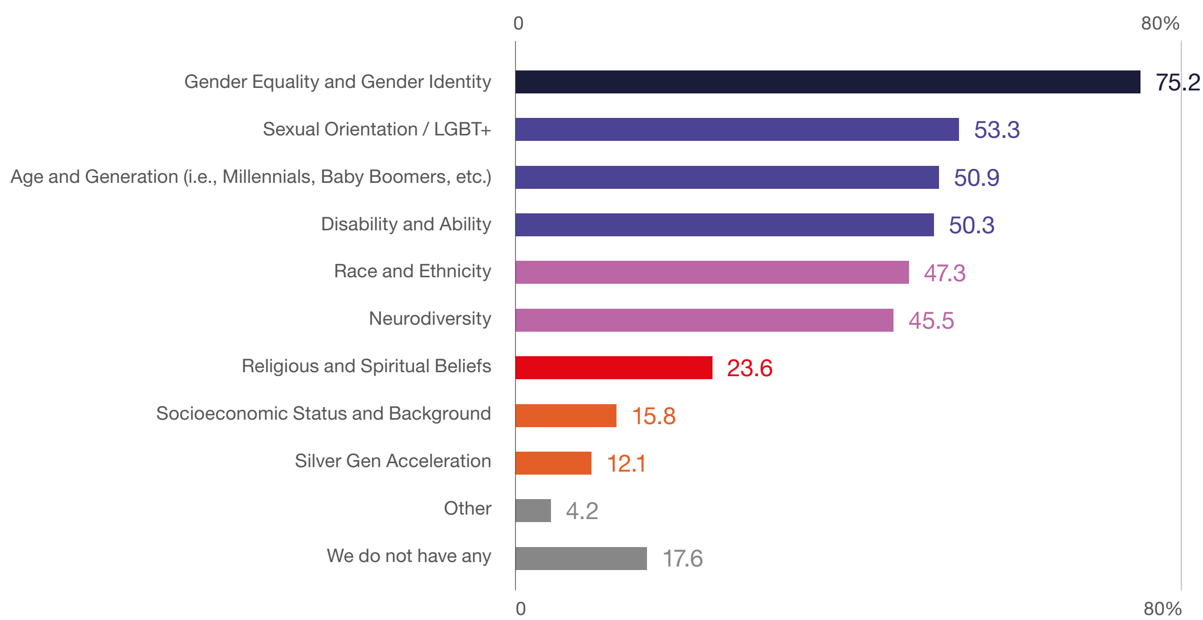
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=184). The results are employment weighted.

Diversity and inclusion

The 2026 survey identifies the range of D&I focus areas. Gender equality and gender identity are the most frequently addressed dimensions (75.2%), followed by sexual orientation/LGBT+ (53.3%), age diversity (50.9%), and disability (50.3%). This reflects a broad approach to inclusion that extends beyond traditional gender issues.

Other focus areas include race and ethnicity (47.3%) and neurodiversity (45.5%), highlighting strong recognition of cognitive diversity in knowledge-based roles. In contrast, religion (23.6%), socioeconomic background (15.8%), and older employees (12.1%) remain less represented. 17.6% of organizations report having no formal D&I programs. This points to uneven progress. Qualitative responses highlight additional initiatives in wellbeing, life-stage support, cultural diversity, and mentoring. Together, they signal a gradual shift beyond compliance-driven categories.

FIGURE 2.9 | **Diversity & inclusion policy / program focused** (% of respondents)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=165).

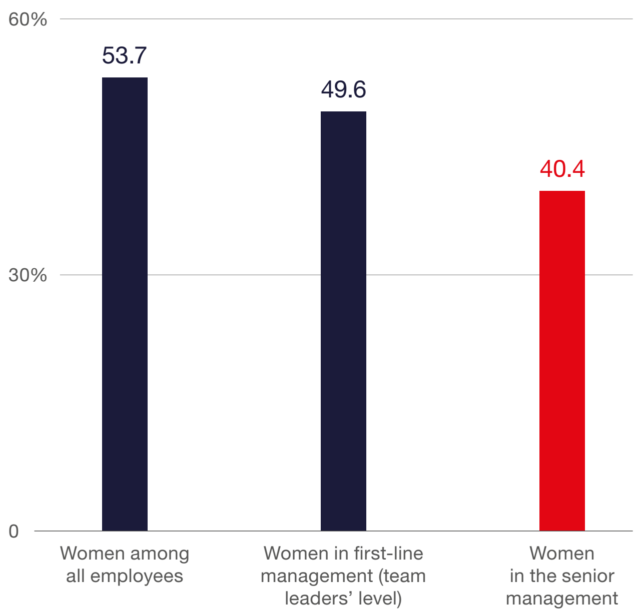
Women in the sector

Women account for 53.7% of total employment, indicating overall gender balance. Representation remains near parity at first-line management (49.6%), but declines at senior levels, where women hold 40.4% of positions.

These are strong outcomes and very favorable for the sector in comparison to other industries. The sector compares favorably to the broader labor market, offering a more balanced and inclusive employment structure. This is a clear competitive advantage, both in attracting talent and in supporting workforce stability.

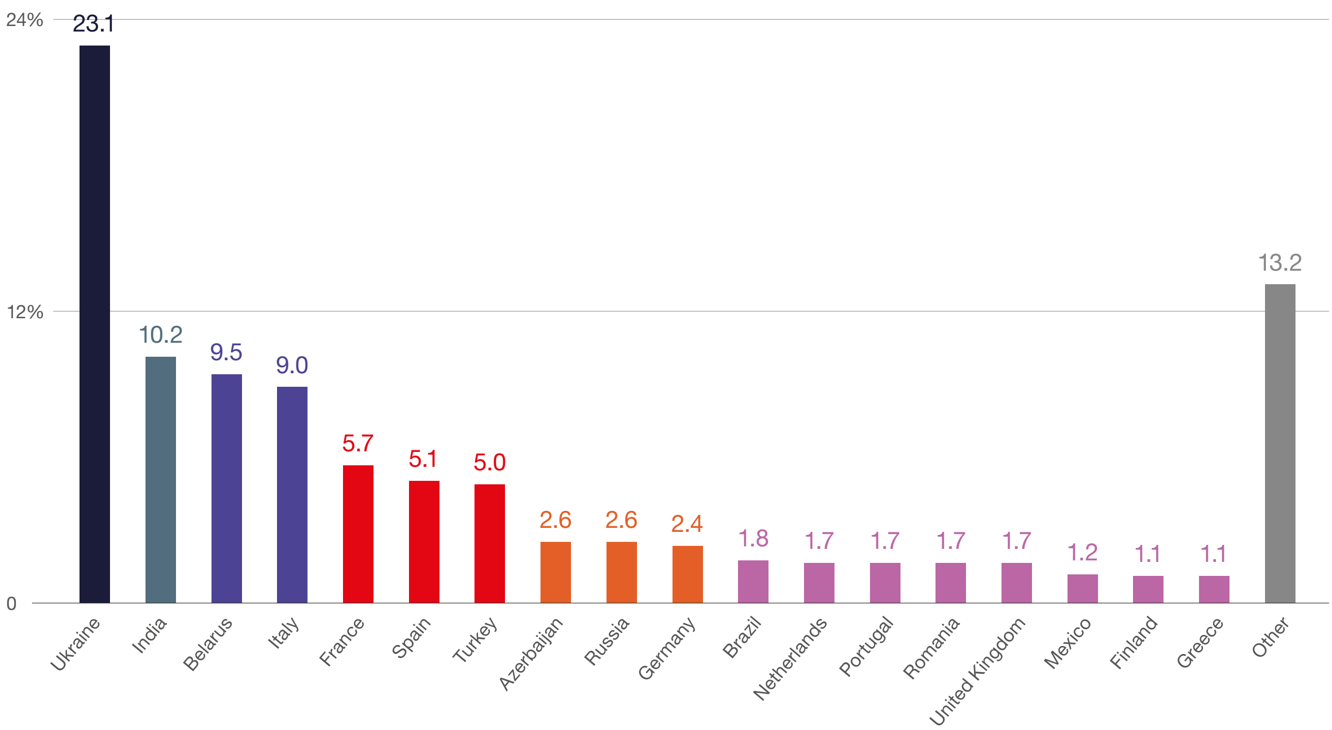
The key limitation is no longer entry-level balance, but retention and advancement of women into senior roles. Strengthening this pipeline serves not only as a diversity objective but also as a way to expand the sector's leadership capacity and sustain its long-term competitiveness.

FIGURE 2.10 | **The share of women in employment** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=190).
The results are employment weighted.

FIGURE 2.11 | **Countries of origin most often declared by foreigners employed in business services centers** (% of indications)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=172, the total number of indications 666).

International talent mobility

The sector is fundamentally international in character. Approximately **95% of centers employ foreign workers.** Foreign nationals account for at least 10% of staff in 51.1% of centers, **representing around 82,600 employees** (16.5% of total employment). These proportions are shaped by several factors, including migration from Ukraine, the relocation of business functions both to and from Poland, and growing demand for specialised skills that remain scarce in the domestic labour market.

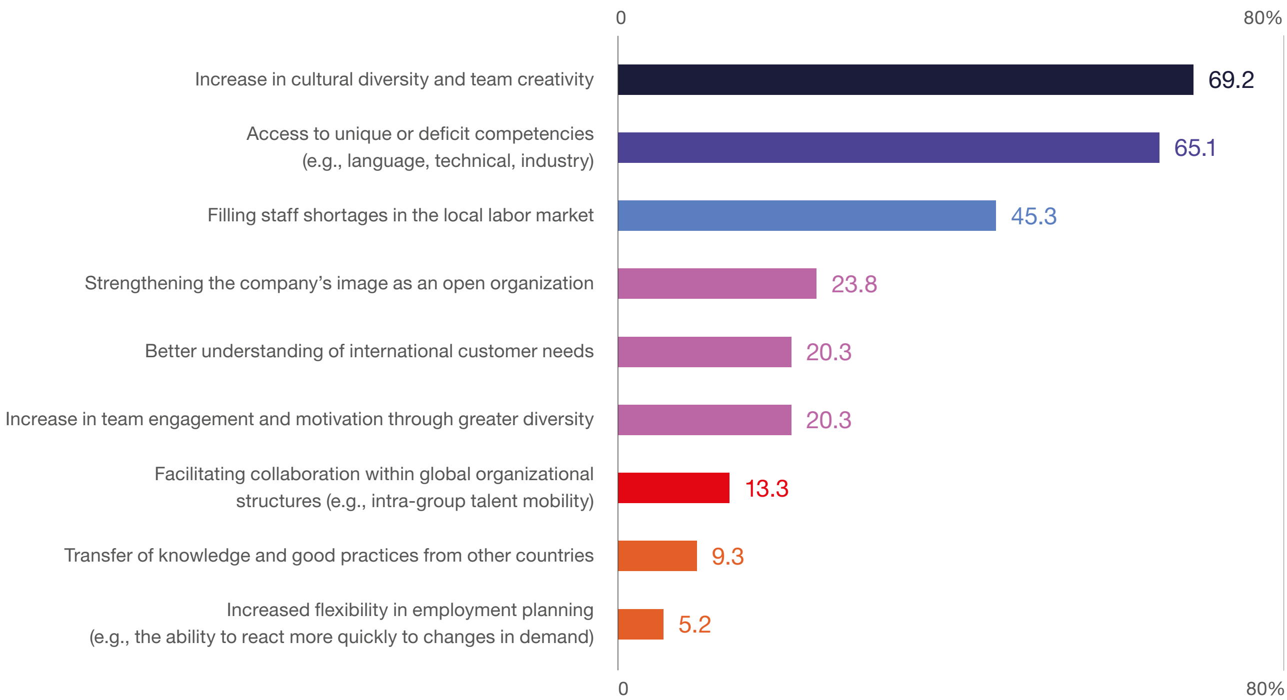
The share of non-Polish citizens was calculated only for respondents that also participated in the previous edition of the report. After eliminating outliers and ensuring data comparability, the year-on-year share of foreign workers increased from 14.5% to 16.5%.

Employees come from 57 countries, with the largest groups from Ukraine (23.1%), India (10.2%), and Belarus (9.5%). There is also a growing presence of Western and Southern European nationals, including employees from Italy (9.0%), France (5.7%), and Spain (5.1%). This diversity reflects the global business services model, where linguistic skills and cultural proximity still matter, and the rising demand for specialized expertise.

Looking from that perspective, **international hiring addresses capability gaps and enhances skill depth.** Reported benefits include increased **cultural diversity and creativity (69.2%), access to scarce skills (65.1%),** and mitigation of **labor shortages (45.3%).** Additional advantages are improved alignment with global clients (20.3%) and stronger international positioning (23.8%).

> **The foreign workforce is now a core driver of capability scaling, especially in knowledge-intensive roles and globally integrated operations.**

FIGURE 2.12 | **Benefits gained (or perceived) from employing foreign workers** (% of respondents)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=172).

Employee turnover

Staff turnover indicates a transition from a tight to a more balanced labor market, more of an employer- than employee-market.

In 2025, voluntary turnover declined to 8.2% from 18.3% in 2022, due to slower hiring, macroeconomic uncertainty, and reduced competition for talent. Firms have shifted their focus from headcount growth to productivity and optimization. The employee market has shifted clearly to employers' market conditions, which are cyclical.

Further automation and AI could reinforce this trend by reducing demand for routine roles and increasing the need to retain experienced, specialized employees. At the same time, the entry requirements, in particular for junior roles, increased.

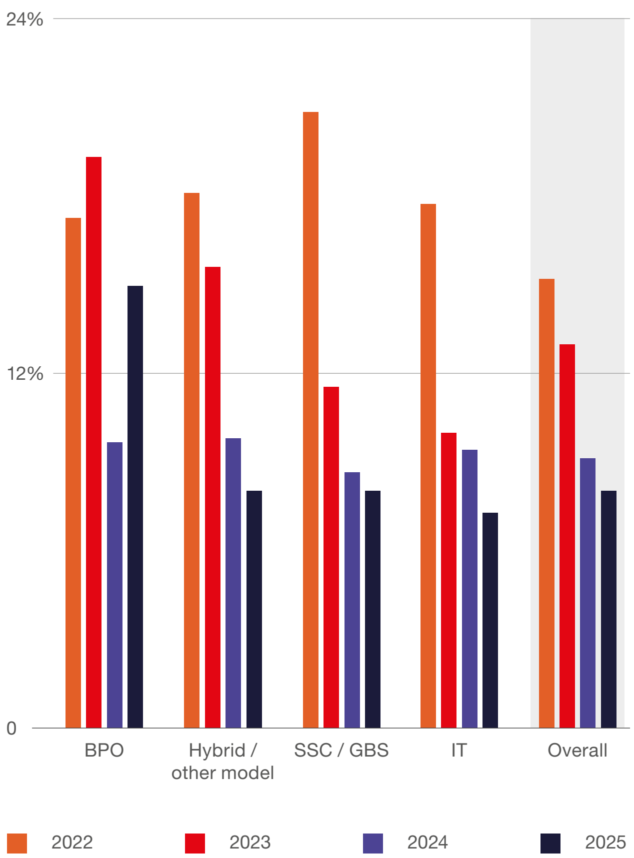
Differences between center types persist but are limited. Voluntary turnover ranges from 7.4% in IT to 15.0% in BPO, reflecting the transactional nature of BPO compared to the specialized, longer-cycle work in IT and SSC/GBS.

Involuntary turnover is at 4.1%. There is no widespread downsizing despite weaker conditions. Variation is moderate, with higher rates in BPO (5.3%) and lower in IT (2.7%).

The IT segment has stabilized after the post-pandemic adjustment, with turnover patterns now aligning with the rest of the sector.

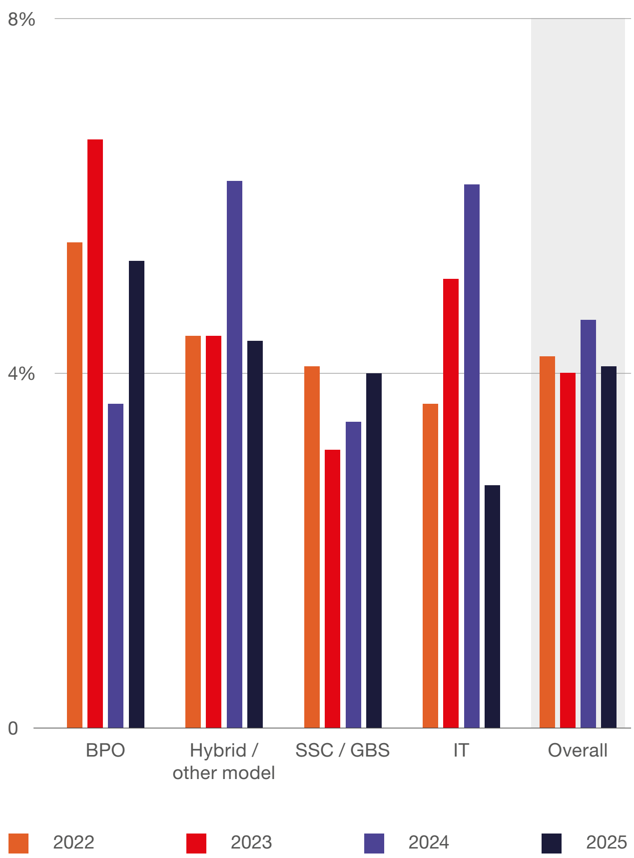
The sector has entered a more stable, lower-mobility phase. Talent competition is less intense, and workforce strategies now focus on retention, productivity, and skill depth. This could change rapidly in the second half of the year as we observe signs of AI-related recruitment in IT across more advanced markets.

FIGURE 2.13 **Voluntary turnover rate by center type** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=163).
The results are employment weighted.

FIGURE 2.14 **Involuntary turnover (initiated by the company) rate by center type** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=153).
The results are employment weighted.

Talent pool availability and development activities

Perceived talent constraints have materially eased. The share of firms reporting no barrier increased to 25.4% (from 1.9% in 2022), while those identifying talent shortages as a critical issue declined to 0.5% (from 21.2%). Talent availability is now assessed primarily as a moderate limitation.

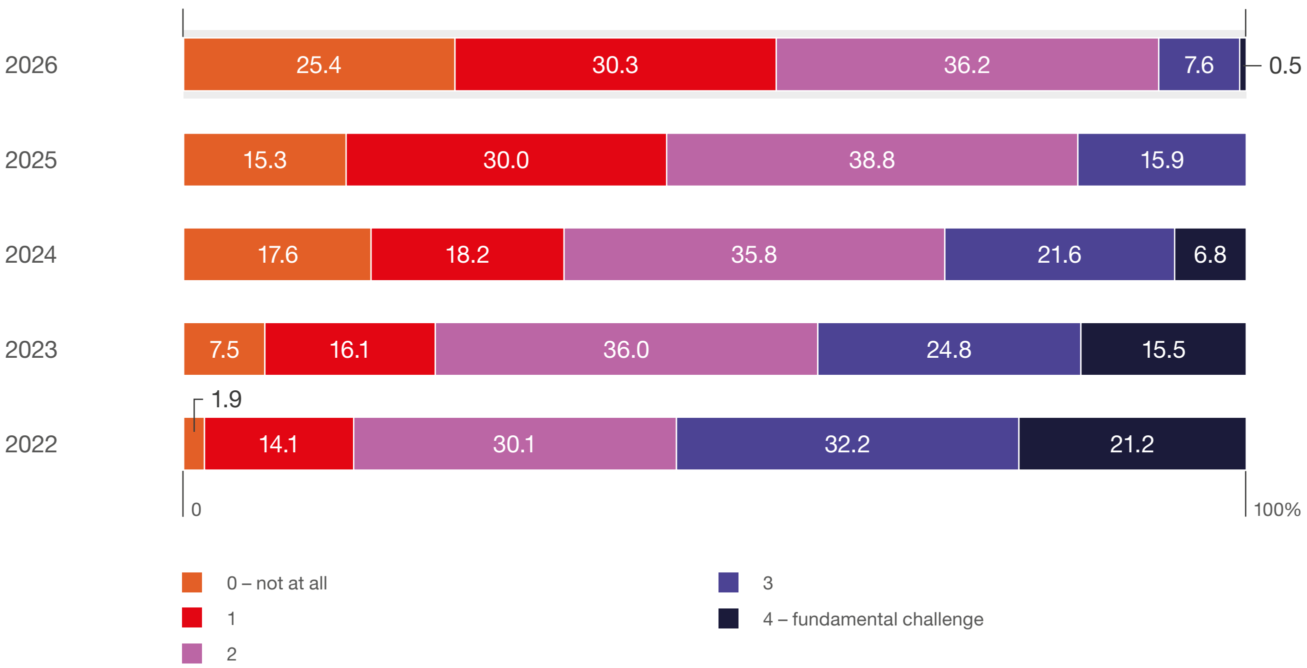
This is mainly attributed to greater organizational maturity (59.6%), which has improved internal development, retention, and reduced dependence on external hiring. Stabilized labor market conditions (49.2%) have increased candidate availability following the post-pandemic hiring surge. Automation and AI (35.5%) are reducing demand for routine roles and altering skill requirements. Expanded sourcing models, including remote work (37.2%) and foreign hiring (27.9%), have broadened access to talent beyond local markets.

Additional factors include improved HR processes, stronger employer branding, lower turnover, increased inflows of workers (notably from Ukraine), and more cautious hiring amid slower growth.

As a result, the primary challenge has shifted from entry-level labor availability to securing specialized, high-skill talent for advanced, knowledge-intensive operations.

> **The skills needed for many jobs are changing faster than people can learn them.**
>
> Ginni Rometty

FIGURE 2.15 | **Availability of a talent pool in Poland as a barrier to center operations and growth** (%)

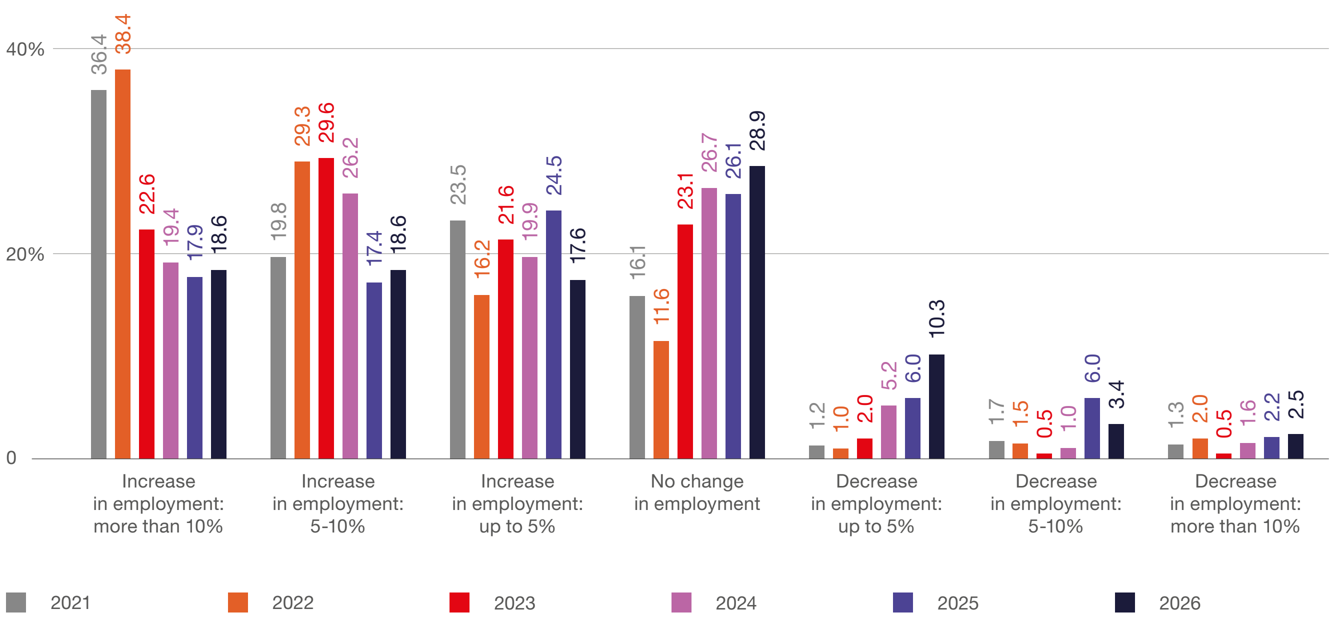


Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=185).

FIGURE 2.16 **Reasons for the declining perception of talent access challenges in Poland's sector in recent years** (% of respondents)

Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=183).

FIGURE 2.17 **Centers' plans regarding changes in headcount by Q1 2027** (share of centers in %), **compared with the previous reports' results**



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=204).

Employment plans

Workforce planning is evolving toward a more mature, efficiency-oriented model. Although **54.8% of centers continue to expect employment growth**, an increasing proportion anticipates **stable headcount (28.9%)**, and overall expansion is becoming more moderate. The proportion of centers planning growth has decreased from over 79% in 2021 to 54.8% in 2026, indicating a significant alteration in trajectory.

This transition results from **slower labor market dynamics, improved talent availability, reconfigured business models, and enhanced internal capability development, all of which reduce the need** for ongoing large-scale hiring. Concurrently, automation and AI, and agentic AI in particular, are transforming workforce requirements, particularly by decreasing demand for standardized roles.

Consequently, growth, to a lesser extent, relies on headcount expansion and is more closely associated with productivity improvements, greater **service complexity, and enhanced technological capabilities. The rising proportion** of centers planning selective workforce reductions marks a shift toward more disciplined and adaptive workforce management.

The sector's growth model is therefore transforming. Expansion is now driven primarily by the capacity to deliver **higher-value, knowledge-intensive services within global networks.**

randstad

Global validation: from talent shortage to skills mismatch

Randstad's global data confirms that leading service hubs are transitioning from **talent scarcity to skills mismatch,** a change already visible in Poland.

The recent easing of talent pressure is partly cyclical, due to post-pandemic over-hiring and slower global demand. However, structural changes are more significant. Demand is now driven by **specialization, advanced competencies,** and **AI-driven role redesign,** rather than overall labor availability.

Poland holds a **strategic middle position** in this transition because it:

- Combines a highly skilled workforce with a **strong work ethic,**
- Remains competitive, but is increasingly chosen **for complex, capability-driven work,**

In global markets, several consistent patterns emerge:

- **Shift to capability over capacity:** location decisions now prioritize skill mix and expertise over cost alone.
- **Rising role complexity:** AI is raising expectations at all levels, especially for junior roles.
- **Fragmented AI productivity gains:** efficiency improvements are driven by individuals but are not yet fully embedded at large scales.
- **Renewed demand for experienced talent:** competition is intensifying in high-skill segments.
- **Offshoring remains strong:** global uncertainty, especially in the US, is reinforcing demand for locations such as Poland.

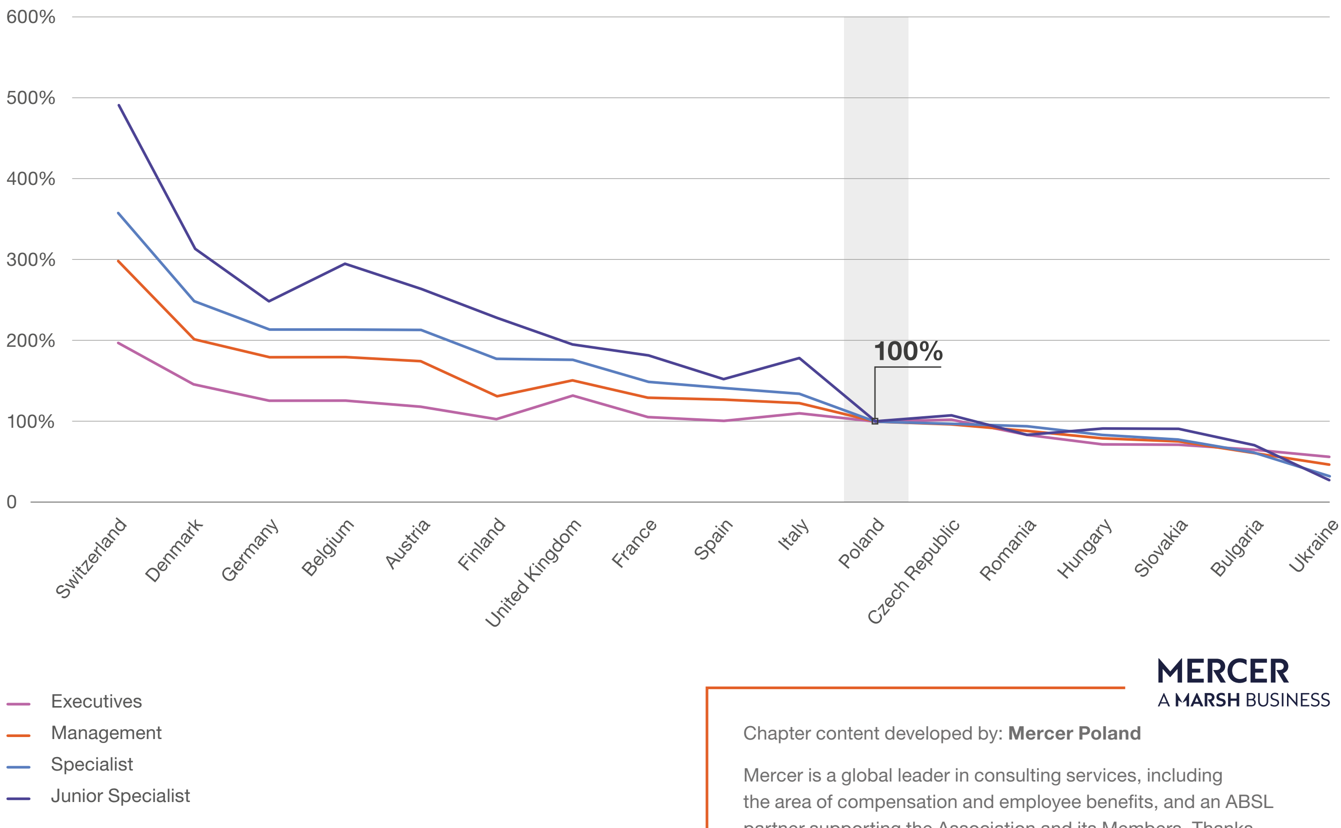
> **The main problem is no longer access to talent; it is the ability to deploy the right skills in AI-enabled operating models.**

LABOR MARKET

Salaries at Business Services Centers

FIGURE 2.18

Comparison of actual annual gross base salary between Poland and European countries at different job levels (%)



Salaries in Poland are still competitive in comparison to Western European countries. Pay gap is significant especially at the lower job levels.

Source: Mercer 2025 compensation surveys.

MERCER
A MARSH BUSINESS

Chapter content developed by: **Mercer Poland**

Mercer is a global leader in consulting services, including the area of compensation and employee benefits, and an ABSL partner supporting the Association and its Members. Thanks to the Total Remuneration Survey (TRS), which is industry-wide and nationwide, and one of the largest and most comprehensive salary reports, Mercer effectively advises entities from the SSC and BPO sectors in areas such as job evaluation, designing compensation systems and pay scales, as well as analyzing the structure and levels of remuneration.

TABLE 2.1

Comparison of actual monthly gross base salary in BPO / SSC / IT / R&D sector in Poland and other countries in the region in EUR

	Job Level	Base Salary Mean	Base Salary Median
Poland	Senior Manager / Manager	6,280	6,285
	Team Leader	4,043	3,930
	Senior Specialist	3,322	3,256
	Junior Specialist	1,940	1,890
Bulgaria	Senior Manager / Manager	4,648	4,483
	Team Leader	3,219	2,887
	Senior Specialist	2,662	2,562
	Junior Specialist	1,633	1,581
Czech Republic	Senior Manager / Manager	6,257	6,032
	Team Leader	3,947	3,782
	Senior Specialist	3,797	3,665
	Junior Specialist	2,113	2,054
Hungary	Senior Manager / Manager	6,474	6,439
	Team Leader	3,654	3,569
	Senior Specialist	3,097	3,016
	Junior Specialist	1,792	1,708
Romania	Senior Manager / Manager	5,704	5,755
	Team Leader	4,008	3,842
	Senior Specialist	3,253	3,183
	Junior Specialist	1,700	1,687
Estonia	Senior Manager / Manager	5,992	5,777
	Team Leader	3,946	3,805
	Senior Specialist	3,369	3,294
	Junior Specialist	2,070	1,966

Currency exchange rates

1 PLN = **0.237082 EUR** 1 BGN = **0.508015 EUR** 1 RON = **0.196246 EUR** 1 HUF = **0.041223 EUR** 1 CZK = **0.041223 EUR**

Sources: Mercer 2025 Poland SSC Industry Survey, Mercer 2025 Bulgaria TRS Survey, Mercer 2025 Czech Republic TSR Survey, Mercer 2025 Hungary TRS Survey, Mercer 2025 Romania SSC Industry Survey, Mercer 2025 Estonia TRS Survey.

FIGURE 2.2

Base salary movement in the region (%)

Salary movements across Central and Eastern Europe are moderating after a peak in 2023 driven by inflation and talent shortages. Overall, the labour market is shifting towards a more balanced environment, with easing wage pressure across most roles.

	Job Level	2023 vs 2022	2024 vs 2023	2025 vs 2024
Poland	Senior Manager / Manager	7%	6%	6%
	Team Leader	7%	9%	3%
	Senior Specialist	11%	6%	5%
	Junior Specialist	11%	9%	6%
Bulgaria	Senior Manager / Manager	7%	9%	8%
	Team Leader	13%	8%	4%
	Senior Specialist	9%	10%	9%
	Junior Specialist	14%	10%	8%
Czech Republic	Senior Manager / Manager	7%	2%	5%
	Team Leader	8%	4%	6%
	Senior Specialist	9%	7%	4%
	Junior Specialist	6%	9%	1%
Hungary	Senior Manager / Manager	18%	10%	10%
	Team Leader	21%	15%	8%
	Senior Specialist	27%	14%	9%
	Junior Specialist	21%	11%	9%
Romania	Senior Manager / Manager	5%	9%	6%
	Team Leader	7%	6%	12%
	Senior Specialist	14%	5%	11%
	Junior Specialist	16%	6%	10%
Estonia	Senior Manager / Manager	10%	8%	3%
	Team Leader	9%	12%	6%
	Senior Specialist	8%	8%	10%
	Junior Specialist	7%	13%	7%

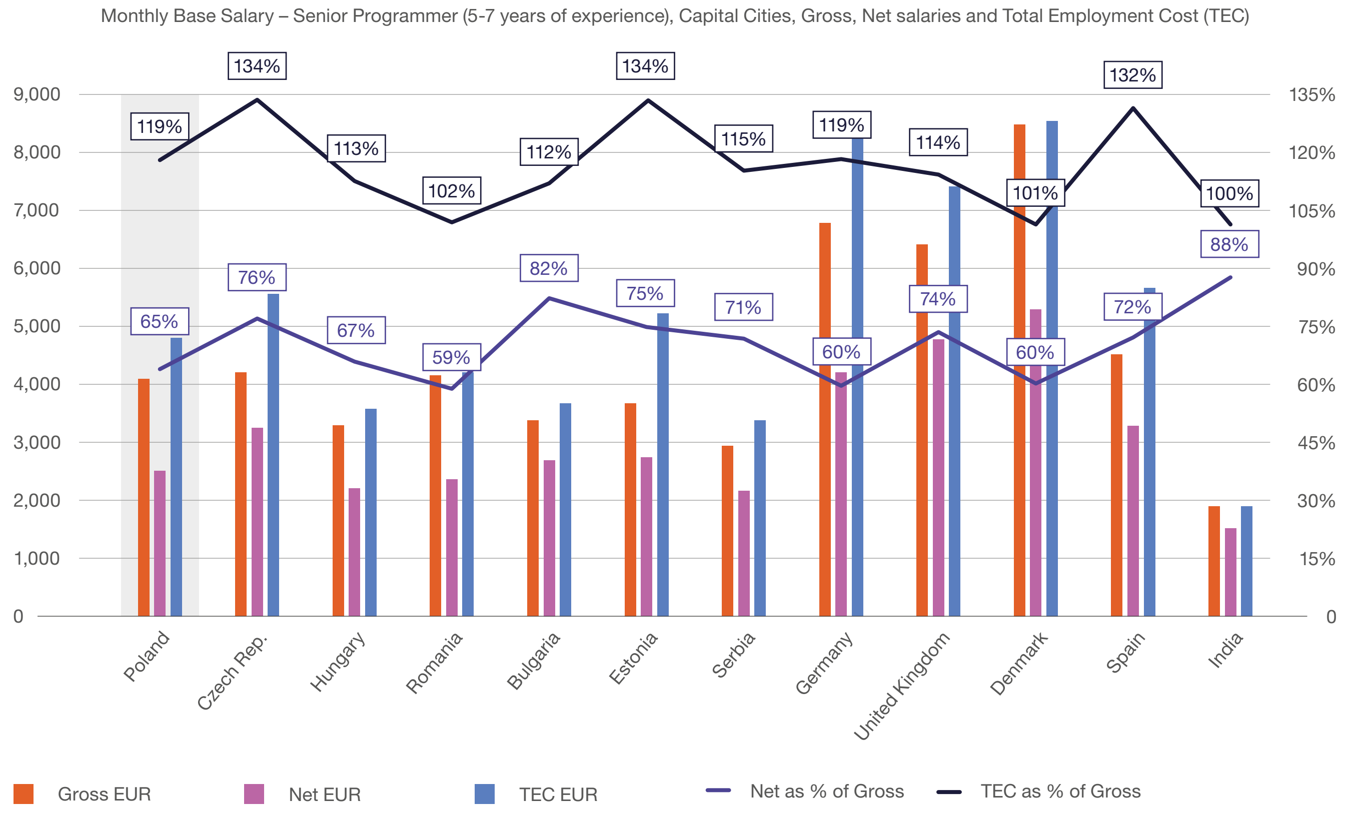
Sources: Mercer 2025 Poland SSC Industry Survey, Mercer 2025 Bulgaria TRS Survey, Mercer 2025 Czech Republic TSR Survey, Mercer 2025 Hungary TRS Survey, Mercer 2025 Romania SSC Industry Survey, Mercer 2025 Estonia TRS Survey.

Base salaries are significantly diversified across Europe. The salaries observed in Eastern Europe are still very competitive against those in Western European countries. In the example below, we have compared base salary of a Senior Programmer (experienced professional, typically with 5-7 years of experience) in capital cities of selected countries. Besides the differences in gross salaries, it is also interesting to see how these vary in terms of net salary and total employment cost (TEC).

Senior Programmer's earnings are higher in the Czech Republic than in Poland, especially in terms of net salary. The total employment cost in Poland is much lower, compared to the Czech Republic, where the employer is required to contribute to social security, on top of gross salary (34% of gross salary). Even though gross salary in Romania is quite in line with the Polish one, the net earnings are much lower, given high tax burden in Romania, which is more than 40% of gross salary.

FIGURE 2.19

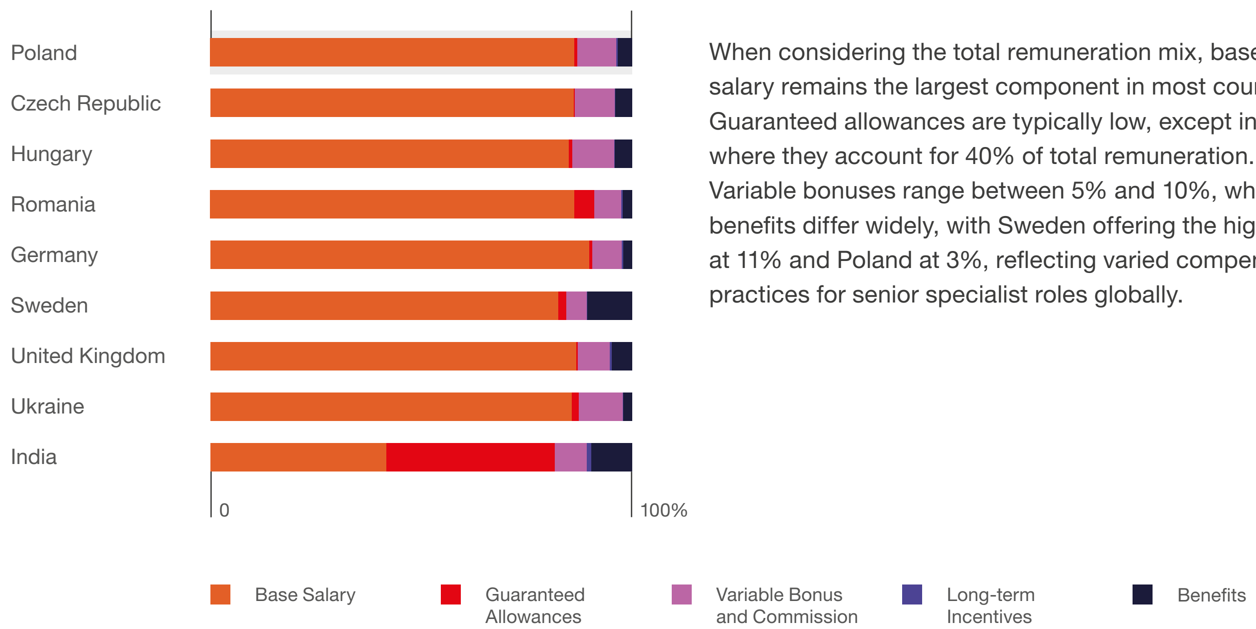
Comparison of actual monthly gross and net base salaries in selected countries in Europe. What is the Total Employment Cost?



Source: Mercer 2025 compensation surveys.

FIGURE 2.20

Percentage of total remuneration into base salary, guaranteed allowances, variable cash payments, long-term incentives and benefits (%)

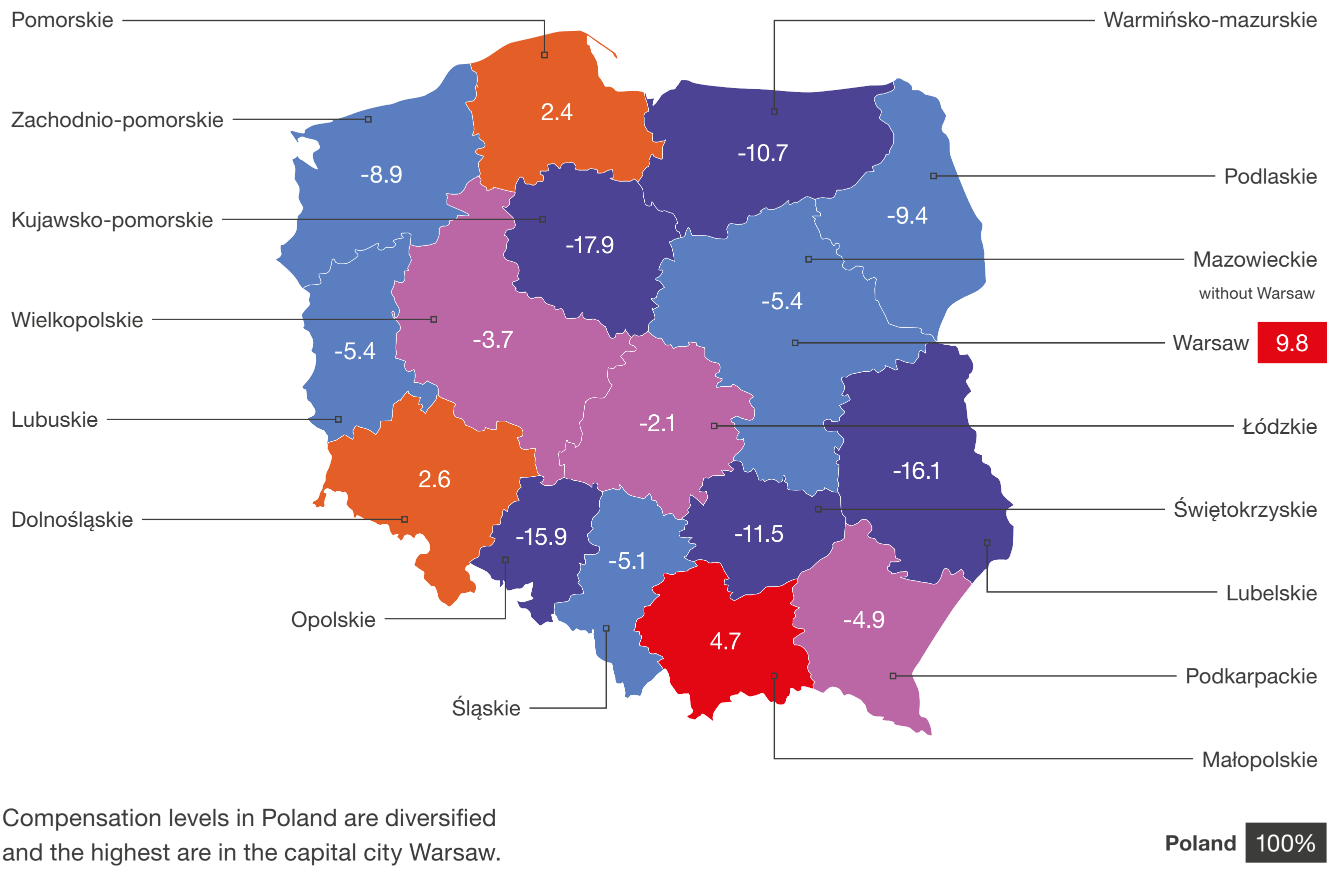


When considering the total remuneration mix, base salary remains the largest component in most countries. Guaranteed allowances are typically low, except in India where they account for 40% of total remuneration. Variable bonuses range between 5% and 10%, while benefits differ widely, with Sweden offering the highest at 11% and Poland at 3%, reflecting varied compensation practices for senior specialist roles globally.

Source: Mercer 2025 Remuneration Surveys.

FIGURE 2.21 **Regional pay differentials in Poland** (%)

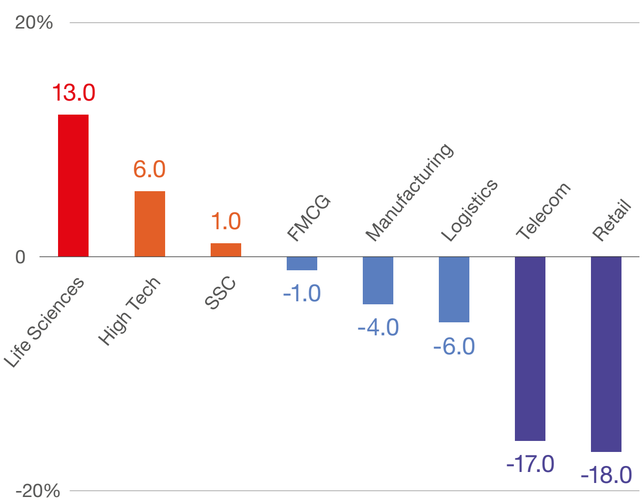
Comparison of average annual base salary in regions in Poland, where average Poland is 100%.
Table is based on the analysis of actual remuneration of employees in Poland in 2025.



Compensation levels in Poland are diversified and the highest are in the capital city Warsaw.

Source: Mercer 2025 Remuneration Surveys.

FIGURE 2.22 **Salary differentials by industry in Poland** (%)



The sectors that have been the strongest and have consistently positioned themselves well above the market average in terms of compensation are primarily the Life Science sector, with a 13%, and the High Tech sector, with a 6% above the market. On the other hand, sectors such as Logistics, Telecom and Retail, as in previous years, have reported earnings below market median. The Shared Services industry maintains a strong and stable position slightly above market value.

Source: Mercer Salary Reports 2025.

TABLE 2.3

Actual monthly gross base salaries in BPO / SSC / IT / R&D sector in Poland in EUR

Table is based on the analysis of actual remuneration of over 105,000 employees
from 255 SSC organizations in Poland surveyed in 2025.

Monthly gross base salaries	Mean	Median
Head of Center	12,488	12,289
Manager	5,675	5,629
Team Leader	4,043	3,930
Senior Specialist	3,322	3,256
Specialist	2 503	2,400
Junior Specialist	1,940	1,890

Currency exchange rates
1 PLN = **0.237082 EUR**

Manager	team up to 50 people (Team Leaders manager)
Team Leader	5-15 subordinates
Senior Specialist	minumum 4 years of experience
Specialist	2-4 years of experience
Junior Specialist	up to 2 years of experience, entry level position

Source: Mercer 2025 Poland SSC Survey.

FIGURE 2.23

Hot jobs in the sector

Roles the most difficult to fill or retain in organizations in BPO / SSC / IT / R&D sector in Poland in 2025

IT, Telecom Infrastructure & Internet	Engineering & Science	Sales, Marketing & Product Management	Data Analytics / Warehousing & Business Intelligence	Finance
Professionals	Professionals	Professionals	Professionals	Professionals

Less than a half (35%) of organizations in BPO / SSC / IT / R&D sector in Poland report they have difficulty in hiring or retaining talent in certain roles.

Source: Mercer 2025 Poland SSC Survey.

Pay increase in selected categories of services in Poland

TABLE 2.4

Actual salary increases awarded in BPO / SSC / IT / R&D sector in Poland in 2025

The most common salary review dates in Poland are: March (32.7% of organizations surveyed) and February (29.5% of organizations surveyed). Individual performance is the most common criterion for a salary increase (96.8% of organizations surveyed).

	25th Percentile	Median	Average	75th Percentile
Head of Center	5.0%	6.0%	5.6%	6.5%
Managers	5.0%	6.0%	5.7%	6.5%
Specialist	4.9%	6.0%	5.8%	6.5%
Junior Specialist	4.6%	6.0%	5.7%	6.5%
Overall Budget	**5.0%**	**6.0%**	**5.8%**	**6.7%**

Source: Mercer 2025 Poland SSC Survey. Based on all responses, not including zeros.

TABLE 2.5 | **Typical salary increase when promoting to higher level**

	25th Percentile	Median	Average	75th Percentile
Management	10.0%	14.0%	13.5%	15.0%
Team Leader	10.0%	13.7%	15.0%	15.0%
Specialist	10.0%	13.8%	15.0%	15.0%
Junior Specialist	10.0%	13.5%	15.0%	15.0%

Source: Mercer PL Shared Services Spot Poll – November 2025.

TABLE 2.6 | **Starter salaries in BPO / SSC / IT / R&D sector in Poland in 2025** (EUR)

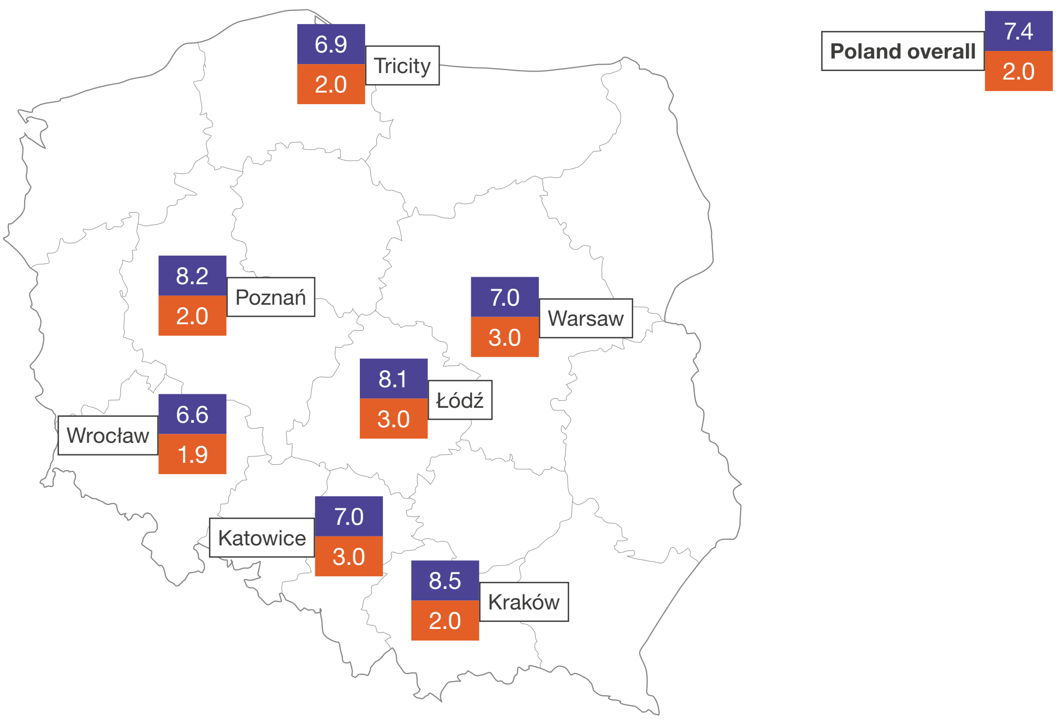
Majority of surveyed organizations (87.4%) does not provide a starting pay scale for university graduates.
Typical monthly starter salary for university graduates in their first job in EUR

	EUR
Minimum	1,387
Average	1,458
Maximum	1,683

Currency exchange rates
1 PLN = **0.237082 EUR**

Source: Mercer 2025 Poland SSC Survey.

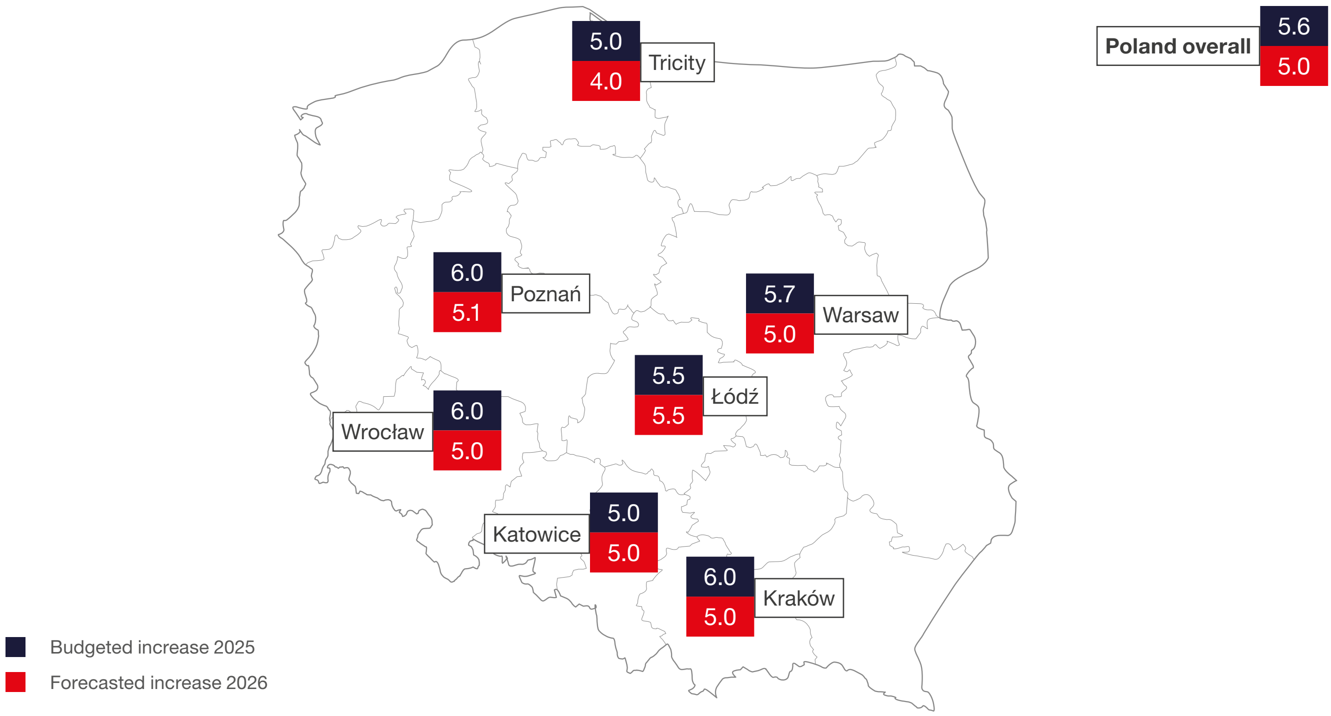
FIGURE 2.24 | **Turnover in BPO / SSC / IT / R&D sector in Poland recorded over 12 months**
(1st October 2024 – 30st September 2025 time period, median)



Voluntary turnover
Involuntary turnover

Source: Mercer PL Shared Services Spot Poll – November 2025.

FIGURE 2.25 | **Budgeted and forecasted salary increase in BPO / SSC / IT / R&D sector for 2025 and 2026 by regions** (%)



Source: Mercer PL Shared Services Spot Poll – November 2025.

Language bonuses

FIGURE 2.6 | **Language allowances** (%)

63%

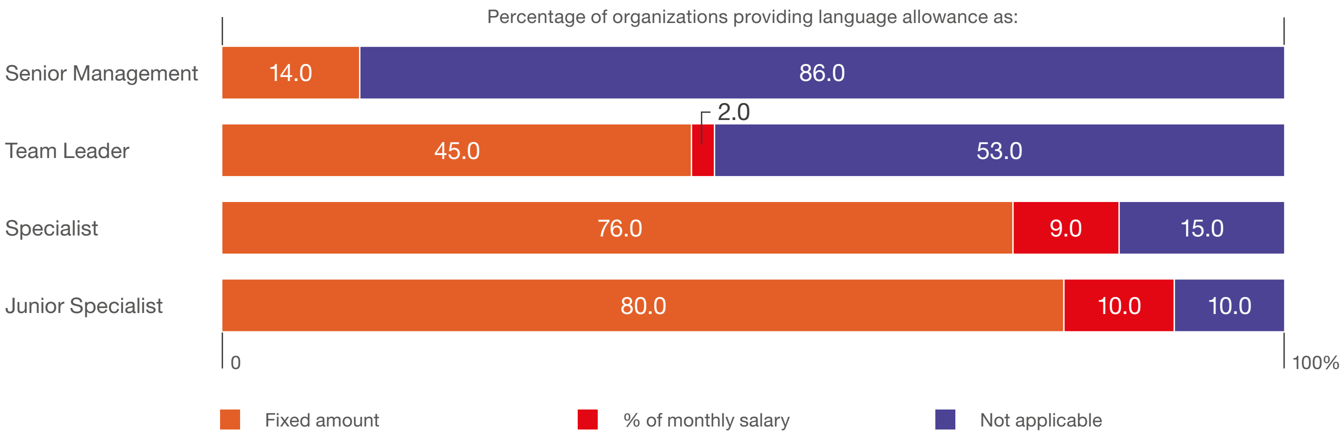
of organizations in BPO / SSC / IT / R&D sector in Poland differentiate salaries depending on foreign language knowledge.

40%

of organizations differentiate the language allowance depending on the level of language knowledge.

65%

of organizations clearly communicate policy on language allowances.



Source: Mercer PL Shared Services Spot Poll – November 2025.

FIGURE 2.27 | **Monthly language allowance depending on the foreign language**

More than 1,500 PLN (356 EUR)

Danish, Dutch, Finnish, Norwegian, Swedish

1,500 PLN – 1,000 PLN (356 EUR – 237 EUR)

Arabic, Czech, French, German, Greek, Hungarian, Romanian, Slovak, Turkish

Less than 1,000 PLN (237 EUR)

Italian, Portuguese, Russian, Spanish

Source: Mercer PL Shared Services Spot Poll – November 2025.

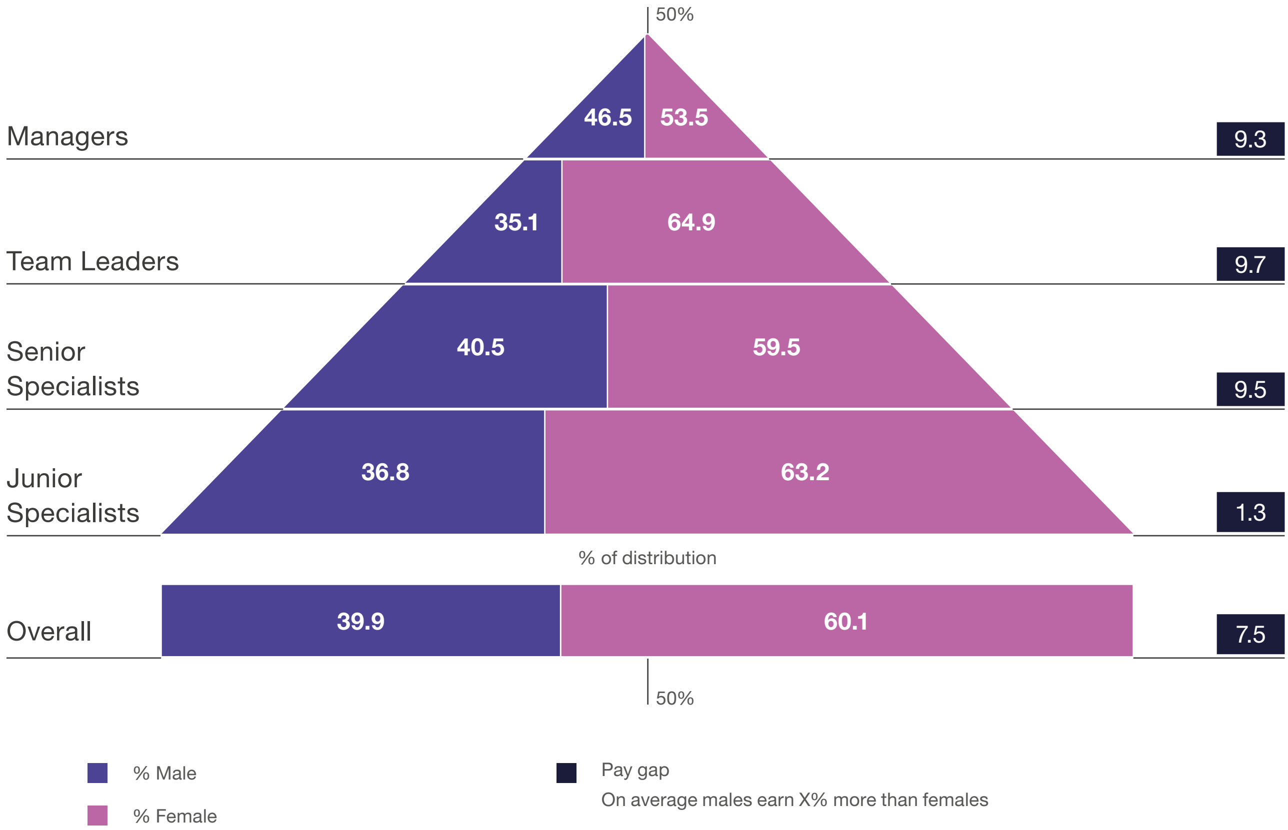
Currency exchange rates
1 PLN = **0.237082 EUR**

Diversity and Inclusion

In the BPO / SSC / IT / R&D sector in Poland, females continue to represent the majority, making up 60% of the total workforce. Notably, team leaders have the highest female representation at nearly 65%, while at the managerial level, the gender distribution is more balanced, with males occupying 46.5% and females 53.5% of roles. The average gender pay gap is 7.5%, with entry-level positions showing a relatively small gap of 1.3%, whereas senior specialists experience a significantly higher gap of 9.5%.

Data in Figure 2.28 are based on actual data for over 105,000 employees employed in 255 organizations in the sector.

FIGURE 2.28 | **Gender distribution by employee grade in BPO / SSC / IT / R&D sector in Poland** (%)



Source: Mercer 2025 Poland SSC Survey.

The New Era of HR in the Age of AI

The role of AI in HR is evolving rapidly, as shown in the *Mercer Global Talent Trends 2026* report, based on a survey of around 12,000 C-suite executives, HR leaders, investors, and employees. AI is no longer just a tool – it has become a key element in redesigning work to deliver strong and sustainable performance improvements. However, AI alone is not enough. Work needs to be intentionally redesigned with a human-centered approach and supported by skills intelligence.

63% of executives believe that redesigning work with AI and automation will deliver the highest return on people initiatives. Only 32% feel their workforce can effectively combine human and machine capabilities.

Talent scarcity is a major challenge. 54% of the C-suite identify it as the main macro factor shaping people strategies, and 59% of HR leaders say attracting talent with critical digital skills will be the biggest workforce challenge in 2026.

Although AI is widely used in HR – 57% of teams use chatbots and 52% automate benefits enrollment – only about 25% report significant value from these tools. This marks a gap between AI adoption and actual return on investment. To close this gap, HR must move beyond traditional service delivery and take on the role of a system designer, coordinating collaboration between humans and machines.

HR transformation is vital. 98% of executives plan changes to organizational design, and 99% expect AI-related workforce reductions within two years. The future of HR will focus on managing integrated human and digital workforces. It is expected to improve people analytics (a top priority for 48% of HR leaders) and embed AI-driven strategies that align talent, technology, and business outcomes.

HR reinvention is no longer optional – it is essential. Currently, only 8% of the C-suite see HR as a fully embedded strategic function. However, organizations with such HR functions report significantly higher resilience (76%) and talent competitiveness (78%) compared to the overall average (62%).

To achieve this, HR must shift from a traditional, siloed model to a more flexible, integrated operating model that brings HR and IT closer together. This is critical because AI is blurring the boundaries between technology and talent management, requiring HR to share responsibility for AI governance and ethics.

Future HR functions will focus on designing outcome-driven systems where humans and machines work together seamlessly, enabling agility and continuous transformation.

Talent intelligence has become a key differentiator in this new landscape. 57% of the C-suite see improving people analytics as a major driver of ROI. Only 27% believe their HR teams effectively advise on workforce risks and opportunities.

High-growth companies are twice as likely to act on talent insights as on financial data, highlighting the competitive advantage of data-driven talent strategies. AI-powered talent marketplaces, predictive workforce planning, and dynamic skills assessments help organizations identify skill gaps and redeploy talent efficiently.

This approach not only helps address talent shortages but also supports more personalized employee experiences and fair access to AI tools. This is especially important, as 35% of employees say that they may leave if they feel disadvantaged by unequal access to AI.

In the end, using AI-powered talent intelligence will be critical to maintaining productivity and driving business growth in the human-machine era.

In conclusion, transforming HR from a traditional support function into a strategic capability is essential for organizations that want to succeed in an AI-driven future. By redesigning work to combine human intelligence with AI, HR can build workforce systems that improve performance, agility, and resilience.

This transformation requires moving beyond small improvements toward bold, outcome-focused models that integrate HR, IT, and finance, supported by a unified workforce data system. As HR takes a leading role in ethical AI governance and talent intelligence, it will help connect people strategies with business value and prepare organizations for talent shortages and rapid change.

The time for meaningful HR transformation is now – those who act will shape the future of work and business success.

Source: Mercer Global Talent Trends 2026 report.

Pay transparency, European Union directives

For simplicity, the provisions of the Polish Pay Transparency Act can be understood as addressing two partially independent areas of HR management. The first concerns gender-based pay discrimination and its elimination or reduction. The second concerns pay transparency – employees' access to information about remuneration.

Poland's business services sector already has well-organized HR processes and relatively high transparency. It is closer to meeting the directive's objectives than many other sectors. As a result, employee expectations for pay transparency and clear communication are higher.

The draft of Polish regulations suggest several key conclusions about their potential impact on Polish organizations:

First, transparency may lead to the disclosure of average pay levels both internally and externally.

Employees will have the right to request information from employers about the average remuneration of women and men performing the same work or work of equal value. In addition, employers will not be able to prohibit employees from disclosing their own pay, or the average pay figures referred to above, when such disclosure is intended to exercise the right to "equal treatment." These developments may strengthen employees' positions in pay negotiations, including job candidates, increase the role of line managers in pay decisions, and create pressure to eliminate pay differences, sometimes through pay increases to avoid difficult conversations. Consequently, compensation may lose some of its motivational power, increasing the need for alternative motivation methods and for building an attractive work environment and conditions.

Second, social aspects of pay recognition, a sense of value, and perceived fairness will become critically important.

Employers should not abandon pay differentiation entirely. Instead, they should ensure that any differentiation is fair, transparent, and linked to objective evaluation and employee recognition. Perceptions of fairness will matter more than strict compliance with formal transparency requirements. Information symmetry will change the nature of conversations during annual reviews, pay decisions, promotions, and similar processes.

ABSL

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THE GREAT WORKFORCE ADAPTATION

How leaders are closing the confidence gap and redesigning work for growth

Poland's business services sector is rapidly redefining how work is structured and delivered, as talent, technology, and work design converge in new ways. The sector is shifting away from headcount-driven growth toward a model shaped by transformation, agility, and technological maturity.

This transition away from headcount-driven growth carries significant economic weight. As a primary engine for the future of work, the sector in Poland comprises 2,179 centers, 1,303 companies, and 500,500 specialists, making it a critical contributor to the nation's GDP. This ecosystem has evolved into Europe's most significant hub for specialized global business services (GBS), IT and R&D centers, managing mission-critical processes for over 280 of the world's largest companies.

As the sector moves beyond relying on headcount for growth, pressure on productivity is intensifying. The latest analysis from The Hackett Group shows that while GBS workloads are forecast to grow by 15% this year, staffing growth is projected at just 10% – a 5% productivity gap that must be bridged through technology to achieve more with fewer people.

This reflects a broader change in how global delivery models are designed. According to Deloitte, since 2020, cost reduction as a primary driver has declined by half, from 70% to 34%, as organizations increasingly prioritize productivity, performance, and outcomes.

Chapter content developed by:
Randstad Polska and Randstad Enterprise

Randstad Polska is part of Randstad N.V., a global talent leader with the vision to be the world's most equitable and specialized talent company. As a partner for talent and through our four specializations – Operational, Professional, Digital and Enterprise – we provide clients with the high-quality, diverse and agile workforces that they need to succeed in a talent scarce world. We help people secure meaningful roles, develop relevant skills and find purpose and belonging in their workplace. Through the value we create, we are committed to a better and more sustainable future for all.

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A structural turning point

Workloads are expanding faster than workforce growth – forcing a shift in how work gets done. To understand its impact, this analysis draws on the 2026 ABSL Talent Report – a comprehensive census of more than 200,000 employees across Poland – and Randstad's 2026 Workmonitor, a global labor market report based on insights from 27,000 workers, 1,225 employers, and 3 million job postings across 35 markets. Together, these sources reveal eight critical signals reshaping the market:

1. **Growth-hiring disconnect – growth no longer requires headcount**

   ABSL research reveals that, while 39.0% of employers in Poland are using automation to offset rising costs, fewer than one in five (18.6%) plan to increase headcount by more than 10% by Q1 2027 – signaling a clear decoupling of growth and hiring.

2. **Execution gap – investment does not translate into impact**

   ABSL's research shows 80% of employers in Poland have increased investment in automation or digital tools, but 57% report no significant workforce impact – signaling that the focus must shift from investment to integration.

3. **AI visibility gap – employee insight outpaces leadership recognition**

   A 32-point disconnect has emerged: According to the Workmonitor research, 64% of talent in Poland report AI productivity gains, compared to 32% of employers – a wider gap than global levels. Employees are already using AI in their day-to-day work, but these gains are not yet fully visible.

4. **Workforce maturity – a shift to specialist-led models**

   With 51% of the workforce aged 35+, specialist roles dominate Poland's employment structure, positioning it as a high-value hub. As entry-level roles decline, a more experienced workforce is driving greater stability than in other global markets.

5. **Targeted recruitment shifts – talent pools are narrowing**

   66.5% of firms now prioritize hiring within the city of location or its immediate proximity, according to ABSL, narrowing talent pools and intensifying competition for local talent.

6. **Flexibility friction – retention risk from RTO mandates**

   Return-to-office mandates are creating measurable workforce risk. ABSL reports that 33.8% of businesses in Poland report declining talent attraction and retention, while 49.4% report reduced employee satisfaction and engagement.

7. **The reskilling mandate – AI drives role disruption**

   ABSL research also shows that nearly a third (32.2%) of employers in Poland expect up to half of their workforce to require reskilling or role redefinition by 2030 – signaling the scale of AI-driven workforce transformation.

8. **The cost-value gap – strategy overtakes cost efficiency**

   With 89.0% of employers in Poland citing rising wages and regional instability as key threats in ABSL's study, the focus is shifting from cost efficiency to strategic value creation.

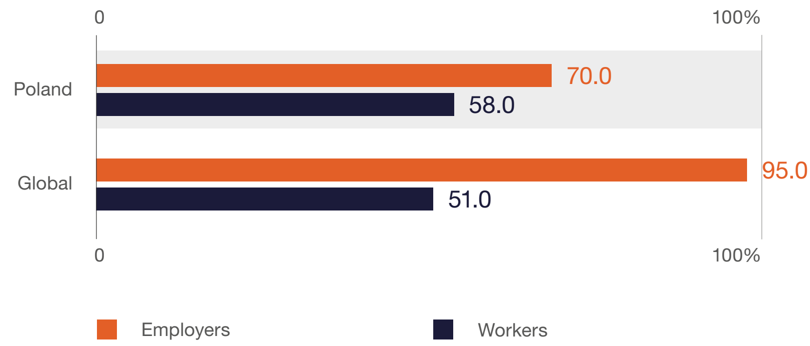
Together, these signals point to a fundamental shift in how work is designed, delivered, and experienced.

> **A clear disconnect is emerging between business ambition and workforce experience.**

Bridging the talent confidence gap

Randstad's 2026 Workmonitor research shows that while 95% of employers globally expect growth, only 51% of workers share that optimism. In Poland, the pattern differs: Employer confidence is lower at 70%, while

FIGURE 2.29 | **Percentage who expect company growth in 2026** (%)



Source: Randstad Workmonitor research, 2026.

worker optimism is slightly higher at 58% – creating a more balanced, yet still misaligned, outlook.

Closing this gap requires rethinking how work is designed, managed, and experienced. Increasingly, leaders are acting as architects of change, and three core pillars are shaping what Randstad calls the Great Workforce Adaptation:

1. **AI agility – closing the gap between adoption and outcomes**

   76% of talent in Poland say they feel confident using the latest technology, compared to 69% of talent globally – yet 52% of talent in Poland believe AI adoption will benefit companies more than themselves, compared to 47% of talent globally, highlighting a gap between capability and perceived personal impact.

2. **Manager-led trust – the direct supervisor as a stability anchor**

   69% of talent in Poland say they have a strong relationship with their managers, slightly below the global average of 72% – reinforcing the manager's role as a trust anchor.

3. **Autonomy premium – independence as a core retention driver**

   34% of talent in Poland have left roles due to a lack of independence, compared to 25% of talent globally – highlighting rising expectations for flexibility, ownership, and control over work, particularly as the sector shifts toward more knowledge-intensive, higher-value roles.

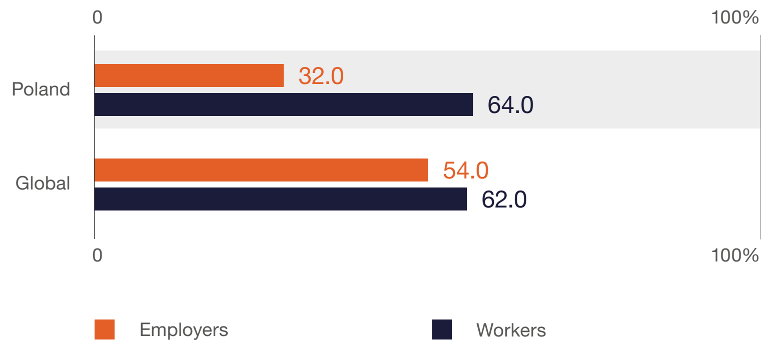
Together, these insights point to a clear path forward. By embracing a transformation mindset, organizations can move beyond traditional headcount models to unlock sustainable, capability-led growth – aligning how work is designed, how skills are developed, and how leaders operate. The organizations that do this fastest will define the next phase of global delivery.

Trend 1: AI agility – closing the gap between adoption and outcomes

> **Transformation is no longer top-down; it's bottom-up. Talent is leading, not the organization.**

Globally, AI investment is outpacing adoption – but in Poland, talent is adopting AI faster than organizations. Employees are already integrating AI into daily workflows and realizing productivity gains that leaders are not yet recognizing. According to Randstad's 2026

FIGURE 2.30 | **Percentage who say AI improves productivity** (%)



Source: Randstad Workmonitor research, 2026.

Workmonitor research, 64% of talent in Poland report that AI improves productivity, compared to just 32% of employers – a far wider gap than 62% of talent and 54% of employers globally. This disparity highlights a growing disconnect between workforce experience and leadership perception.

Businesses are investing heavily in AI and automation, yet these investments have not produced a visible impact on the workforce. Although 80% of employers in Poland have increased investment in digital tools, 57% report no significant impact on the workforce, according to ABSL. The lack of visible workforce impact reveals an additional challenge: even where capability exists, organizations are struggling to integrate and scale AI effectively.

AI is reshaping how work gets done. It is no longer confined to specific initiatives or technical teams – it is being applied directly at the task level by employees across functions, often outside formal structures. Productivity gains are emerging in a fragmented, often untracked way, challenging traditional models of oversight, measurement, and performance management.

Poland is facing a more pronounced dual AI gap: Productivity is being generated but not fully recognized, while investment is increasing without delivering consistent results. As AI becomes embedded in task execution, closing this gap will require organizations to better align how work is performed, measured, and improved.

The AI perception gap

In Poland, a clear gap is emerging between workforce experience and leadership perception:

- **Higher digital confidence:** 76% of talent in Poland feel confident using the latest technology, compared to 69% of talent globally.
- **AI perception gap:** Double the percentage of employees in Poland expect AI to impact more than half of tasks (60%), compared to 30% of employers – a significantly wider gap than 53% of talent and 58% of employers globally.
- **Economic pressure is accelerating adoption:** 47% of talent in Poland are taking on second jobs to manage costs, compared to 40% of talent globally.

Organizations continue to invest in automation and AI at scale, yet many do not see a measurable impact on the workforce. The challenge lies not in a technology gap, but in a lack of visibility and integration – a challenge that will define the next phase of transformation.

The productivity paradox

The result is a structural disconnect between how productivity is created and how it is captured. Employees are using AI to work more efficiently; however, without formal recognition or integration, the value created remains fragmented and inconsistently applied. In many cases, this adoption is happening outside formal workflows. Workmonitor data shows that 64% of talent in Poland report AI is improving their productivity, while only 32% of organizations recognize this impact – compared to 62% of talent and 54% of organizations globally. This gap reveals a disconnect between how work is performed and how it is managed.

This gap between individual adoption and organizational integration creates systemic inefficiency: Productivity gains are realized at the individual level but are not scaled across teams or embedded into operating models. Over time, this limits the return on AI investment and slows the shift toward more efficient, capability-led organizations.

Closing this gap requires a fundamental shift in focus. Leaders must move beyond technology investment to understand how work is performed – how employees are using AI at the task level, where time is being saved, and which practices are driving real efficiency.

To turn individual productivity gains into repeatable workflows and consistent performance, organizations must create mechanisms to identify, validate, and scale these practices – from capturing task-level automation to standardizing high-impact processes.

Without this shift toward capturing and scaling AI-driven productivity, organizations risk allowing productivity gains to remain invisible – or not captured at all – reinforcing the very gap they are trying to close.

What this means for leaders

For Poland's business services sector, the risk is not a lack of capability, but a failure to capture and scale what already exists. As employees increasingly use AI to optimize their own work, productivity gains risk remaining informal, fragmented, or disconnected from enterprise performance.

Organizations must create structured ways for these practices to surface – enabling employees to share how they use AI and translating those behaviors into repeatable workflows. This requires making AI usage visible, standardizing high-impact workflows, and enabling teams to share and scale what works. Without this, efficiency gains will remain invisible or inconsistently applied.

The scale of expected workforce change is also significant. With a growing share of organizations anticipating large-scale reskilling by 2030, the sector will need to move beyond task automation toward full role redesign – aligning skills, work design, and performance expectations to an AI-enabled operating model.

How leading organizations are responding

Leading organizations can close the gap between individual productivity and enterprise performance by making AI-driven work more visible, structured, and scalable.

- **Standardize task-level gains.** Identify how employees are already using AI to save time and translate those practices into repeatable workflows across teams
- **Make productivity visible and shared.** Create transparency into how automation improves day-to-day work, ensuring gains are recognized not just at the organizational level, but by employees themselves.
- **Embed AI into how work is designed.** Move beyond experimentation to redesign roles and workflows around augmentation, making AI a consistent part of how work gets done.
- **Align performance to new ways of working.** Update how productivity is measured to reflect AI-enabled efficiency, ensuring gains are captured, reinforced, and scaled.

As organizations work to make productivity more visible and scalable, a second challenge becomes critical: Ensuring that these changes are understood, trusted, and adopted by the workforce. This places a new demand on managers – not just as operators of performance, but as architects of trust in an AI-enabled workplace.

Trend 2: Manager-led trust – the direct supervisor as a stability anchor

> **The manager is now the anchor of stability amid constant change.**

In an unpredictable environment, the direct manager has become the primary source of stability. As operating models evolve and expectations shift, managers translate change into something employees can understand, trust, and act on. Execution now depends less on structure and more on the manager.

While organizations continue to invest in technology and redesign work, employees rely on their immediate managers to make sense of those changes in day-to-day work. In many cases, the manager relationship matters more to employees than the organization itself. But according to Randstad's 2026 Workmonitor research, 69% of talent in Poland say they have a strong relationship with their manager, compared to 72% globally.

Trust is what enables consistent execution. However, this reliance is increasing even as managers' expectations are expanding. Managers are no longer responsible only for delivering outcomes – they are expected to create clarity, maintain engagement, and navigate the human impact of constant change. This creates a growing gap between organizational expectations and manager capability.

The trust dynamic

Randstad Workmonitor data highlights both the strengths – and the risks – of this dynamic for employers in Poland:

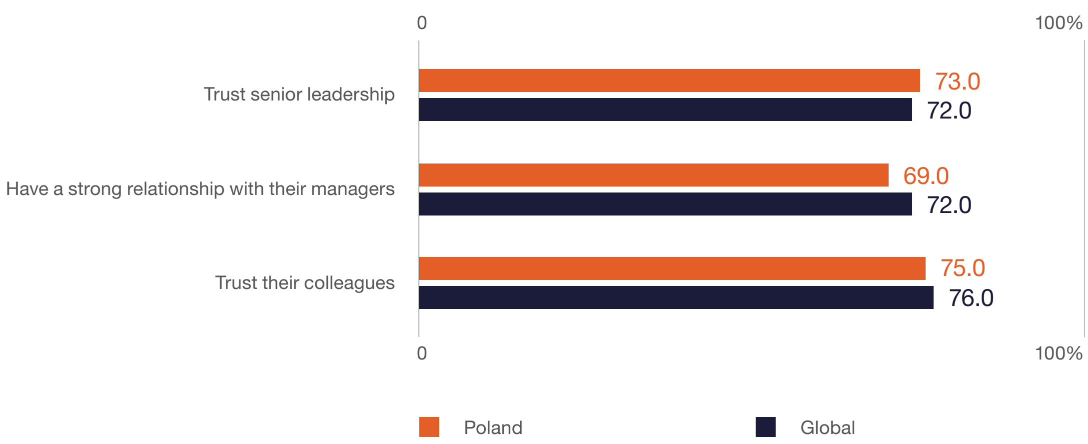
» **High foundational trust:** 72% of talent believe their manager has their best interests in mind.

» **Manager proximity advantage:** Employees report high trust in their managers (72%) and peers (75%).

» **Hybrid resilience:** Only 62% of Polish employers report challenges with hybrid collaboration, compared to 81% of employers globally.

» **Multigenerational reliance:** 77% of talent believe that working with colleagues from different generations broadens their perspectives, and 68% want to see management spend more time improving team collaboration.

FIGURE 2.31 | **Worker perceptions about trust** (%)



Source: Randstad Workmonitor research, 2026.

At the same time, gaps remain in how organizations fully leverage these strengths. While most employers recognize the importance of a multigenerational workforce, fewer actively treat it as a driver of performance, limiting the impact of collaboration.

Together, these dynamics reinforce the manager's role as the central connector between strategy and workforce experience – and highlight the risk if that connection weakens.

What this means for leaders

For Poland's business services sector, manager effectiveness is becoming a primary driver of operational consistency and retention. As work becomes more fluid and less structured, the manager-employee relationship plays a central role in maintaining alignment and performance.

At the same time, this shift exposes a clear risk for organizations. Without the right support, managers become bottlenecks – expected to absorb change without the tools or capabilities to implement it effectively. This includes strengthening capabilities in coaching, communication, and decision-making to help managers translate change into day-to-day execution.

Organizations must therefore invest in the manager role not just as a delivery function, but as a critical layer of the operating model – responsible for enabling trust, stability, and execution in an evolving workplace.

How leading organizations are responding

Employers can strengthen the manager role to create consistency, trust, and alignment at scale.

- **Redefine the manager role around experience, not oversight.** Expand expectations beyond task delivery to include coaching, communication, and team-level alignment – ensuring managers actively shape how work is understood and experienced.

- **Operationalize flexibility at the team level.** Equip managers to define how hybrid work functions in practice, creating clear team-level norms that reduce ambiguity and improve collaboration.

- **Activate multigenerational collaboration.** Structure knowledge exchange across generations – combining digital fluency with experience to strengthen decision-making and adaptability.

- **Align manager metrics to trust and team performance.** Shift performance measures toward engagement, retention, collaboration, and team effectiveness – reinforcing the manager's role as a driver of consistency and trust.

As organizations strengthen manager-led trust to stabilize performance, a new tension emerges: Even with strong leadership, traditional work models are no longer aligned with what talent expects. This shifts the focus from stability to autonomy – and from managing work to redesigning it.

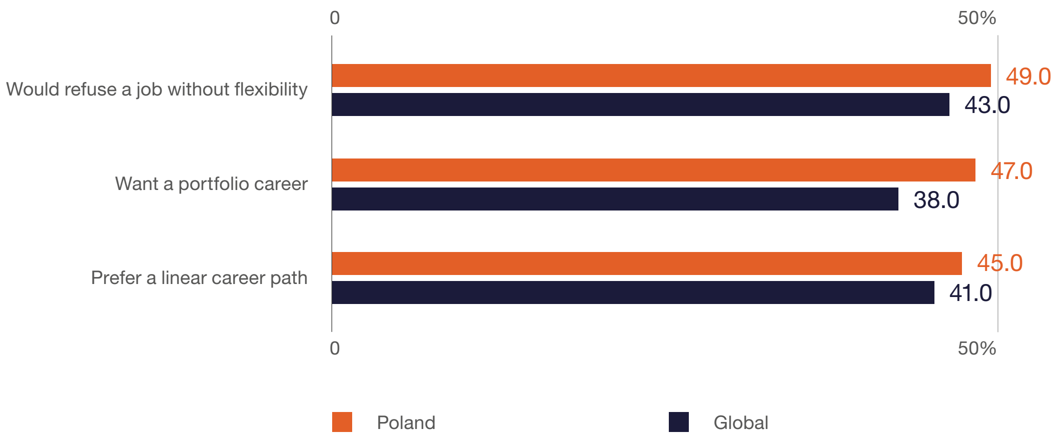
Trend 3: The autonomy premium – independence as a core driver of retention

> **Autonomy is becoming a primary driver of retention. Organizations must adapt or risk losing talent to more flexible work models.**

Talent expectations are reshaping what drives retention and how success is defined at work. The traditional career ladder is giving way to rising expectations for autonomy and choice in how work is structured and fits into individual lives.

Rather than viewing careers as linear progressions within a single organization, talent increasingly expects choice, variety, and ownership in how work is structured and experienced. As a result, organizations are still structured for stability, while talent is making decisions based on autonomy and choice. In fact, according

FIGURE 2.32 | **Worker preferences for autonomy** (%)



Source: Randstad Workmonitor research, 2026.

to Randstad Workmonitor research, 49% of talent in Poland would refuse a job without flexibility.

While many employers support new ways of working in principle, far fewer enable real ownership over when and how work gets done – creating a widening gap between workforce expectations and existing operating models.

This shift goes beyond when and where work happens. Increasingly, employees expect greater influence over the work itself – including the projects they take on, how they contribute, and how their careers evolve.

Autonomy is no longer a preference – it is a condition of retention. As a result, retention is no longer driven by compensation or career progression, but by how effectively organizations enable autonomy and meaningful choice in how work is done.

The autonomy shift

Workmonitor data highlights how strongly this move toward independence is reshaping workforce expectations in Poland:

» **The portfolio pivot:** 47% of talent in Poland want a portfolio career, switching sectors and jobs throughout their careers, while 45% prefer a traditional linear path – globally, 38% of talent prefer portfolio careers, and 41% prefer a linear path.

» **The autonomy premium:** 34% of talent have left a job due to a lack of independence, nine points higher than the global average (25%).

» **Flexibility as a requirement:** 49% of talent in Poland would refuse a job without flexibility in location or hours, compared to 43% of talent globally.

» **Work-life balance as a retention driver:** 51% cite work-life balance as a primary reason for staying, outweighing pay and job security, compared to 46% of talent globally.

Together, these dynamics make the shift clear: talent is prioritizing independence, choice, and alignment with personal priorities – not just stability – and making career decisions accordingly.

What this means for leaders

For Poland's business services sector, autonomy is becoming a defining factor in competitiveness. As the workforce becomes more experienced and selective, organizations that fail to enable independence and choice in how work is structured risk losing talent to more flexible work models.

This shift presents a clear opportunity. Organizations that embed autonomy into how work is designed – rather than treating it as a benefit – can strengthen retention, increase engagement, and unlock more diverse forms of contribution. This includes enabling internal mobility, expanding project-based work, and giving employees greater input into how work is assigned and experienced.

This requires moving beyond standardized career models toward more dynamic, experience-based approaches – aligning work with how employees want to live, not just how organizations need to operate.

How leading organizations are responding

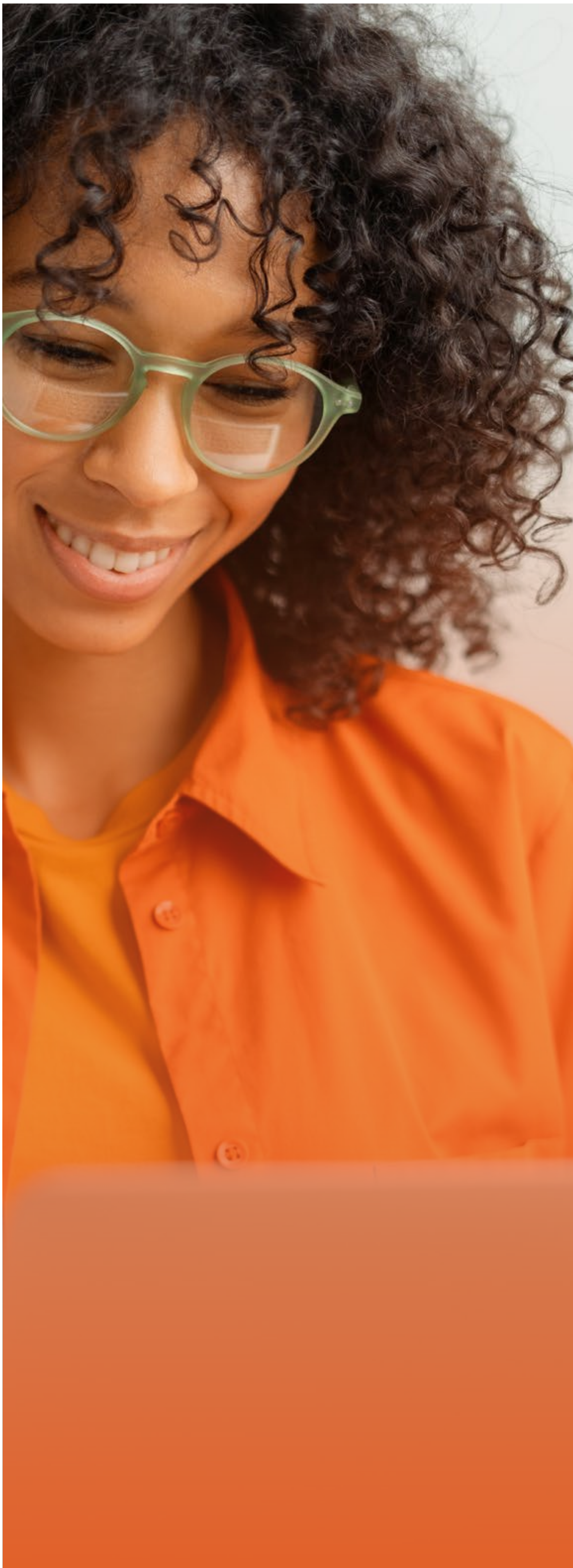
Organizations can redesign work to embed autonomy while maintaining performance, accountability, and cohesion.

- **Enable internal mobility and portfolio careers.** Create internal marketplaces and project-based work models that allow employees to move across roles, teams, and assignments – providing variety and independence without leaving the organization.
- **Shift to outcome-based performance models.** Measure success by outputs and impact rather than time or presence – enabling more flexible, adaptable ways of working.
- **Embed flexibility as a core design principle.** Make flexibility in location, hours, and work structure a standard part of the operating model, not a negotiated benefit.
- **Personalize career paths at scale.** Move away from rigid, one-size-fits-all career progression toward individualized growth paths that reflect different life stages and priorities.

The path forward

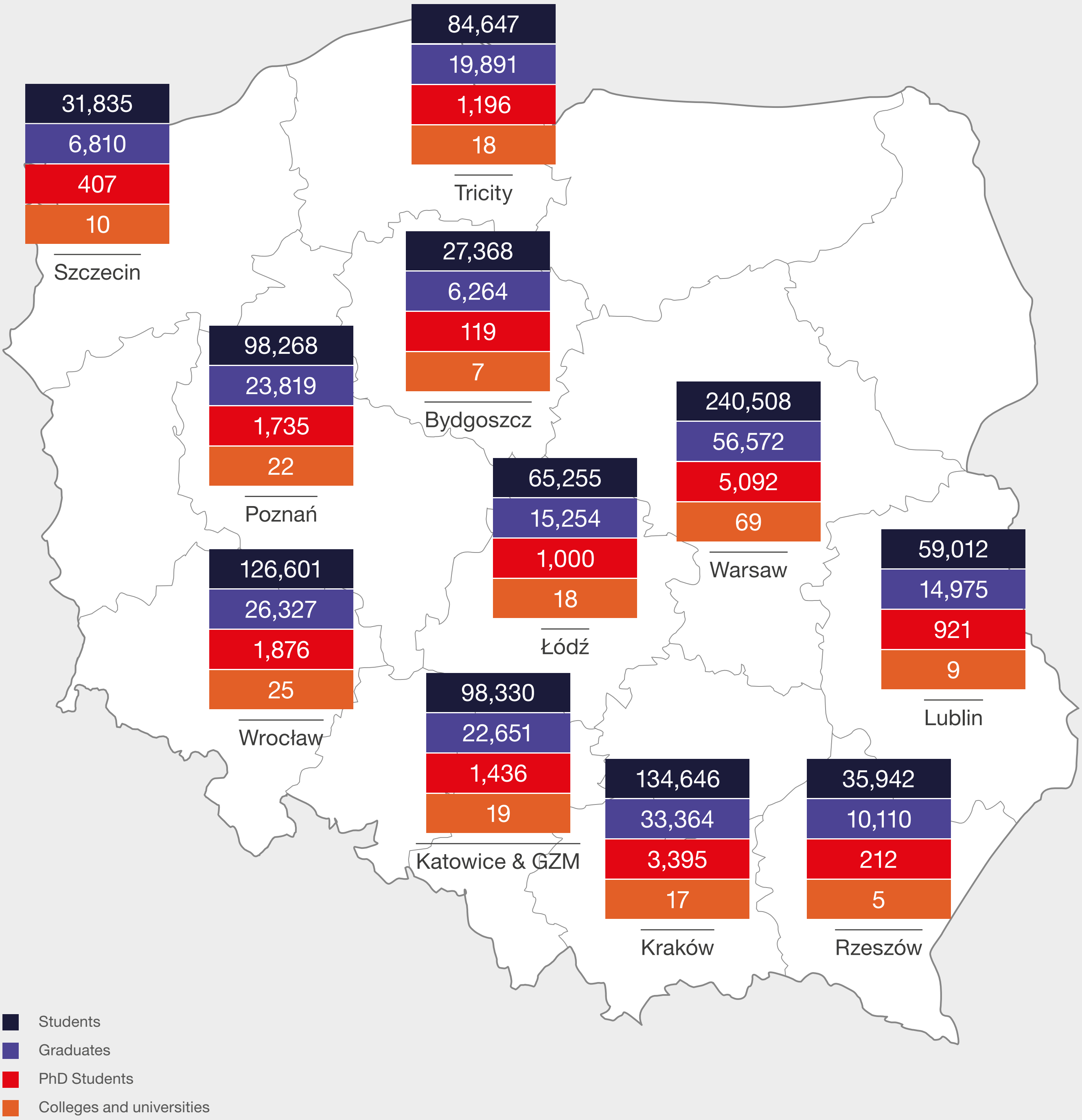
The Great Workforce Adaptation is reshaping Poland's business services sector. Businesses that align technology, leadership, and work design with how work is actually experienced – making productivity visible, strengthening manager-led trust, and enabling autonomy – will be best positioned to close the confidence gap and drive sustainable growth. Those that do will define the next generation of global delivery.

To learn more about these trends, access the Randstad 2026 Workmonitor research.



Educational potential

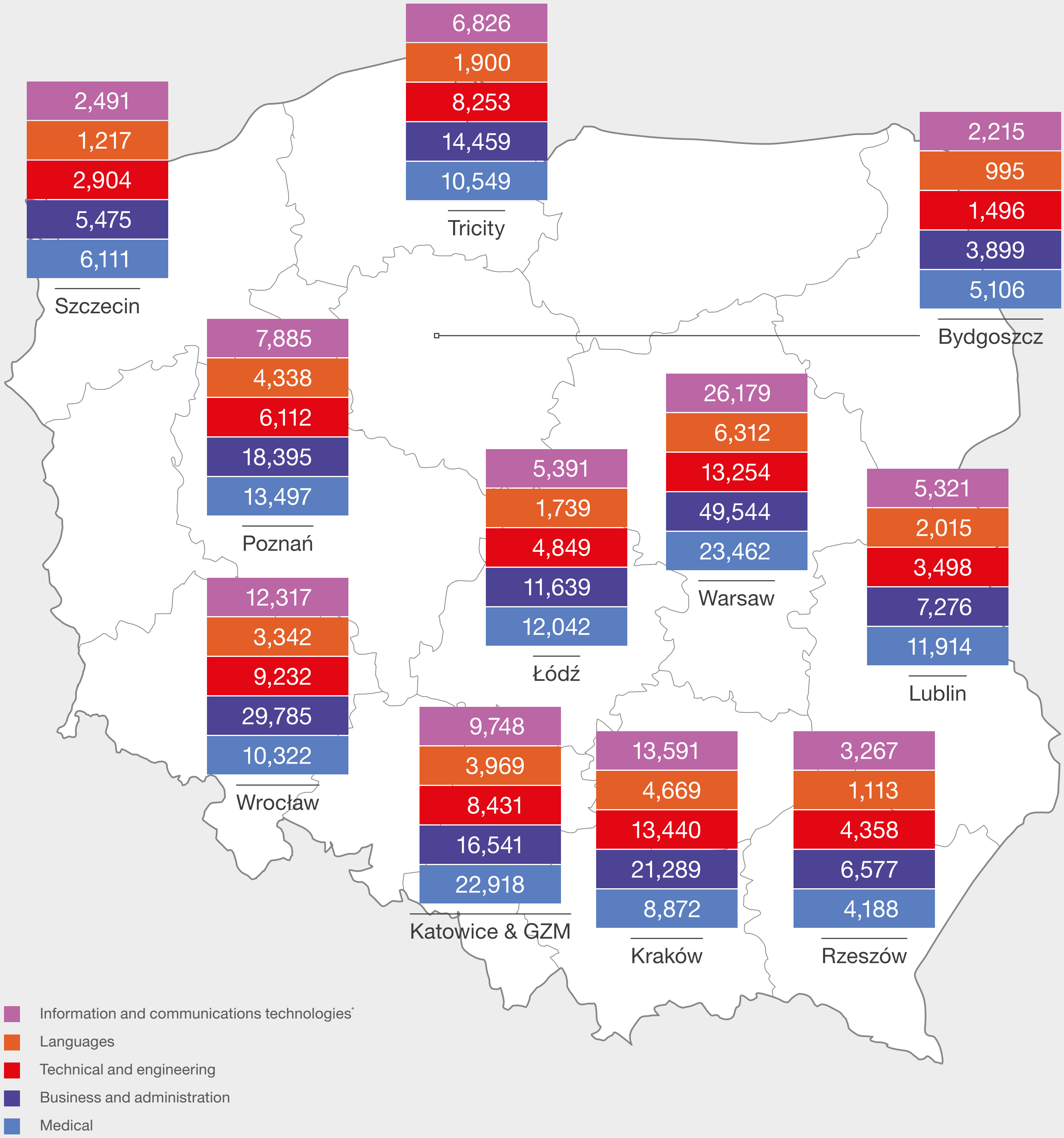
FIGURE 2.33 | **Number of students, graduates, and universities in selected locations in Poland**



Note. The student and graduate numbers are based on the actual location of the unit (faculty).
The college and university numbers are based on the address of the home institution in selected cities.

Source: Prepared by ABSL on the basis of data received from the National Information Processing Institute at the National Research Institute.

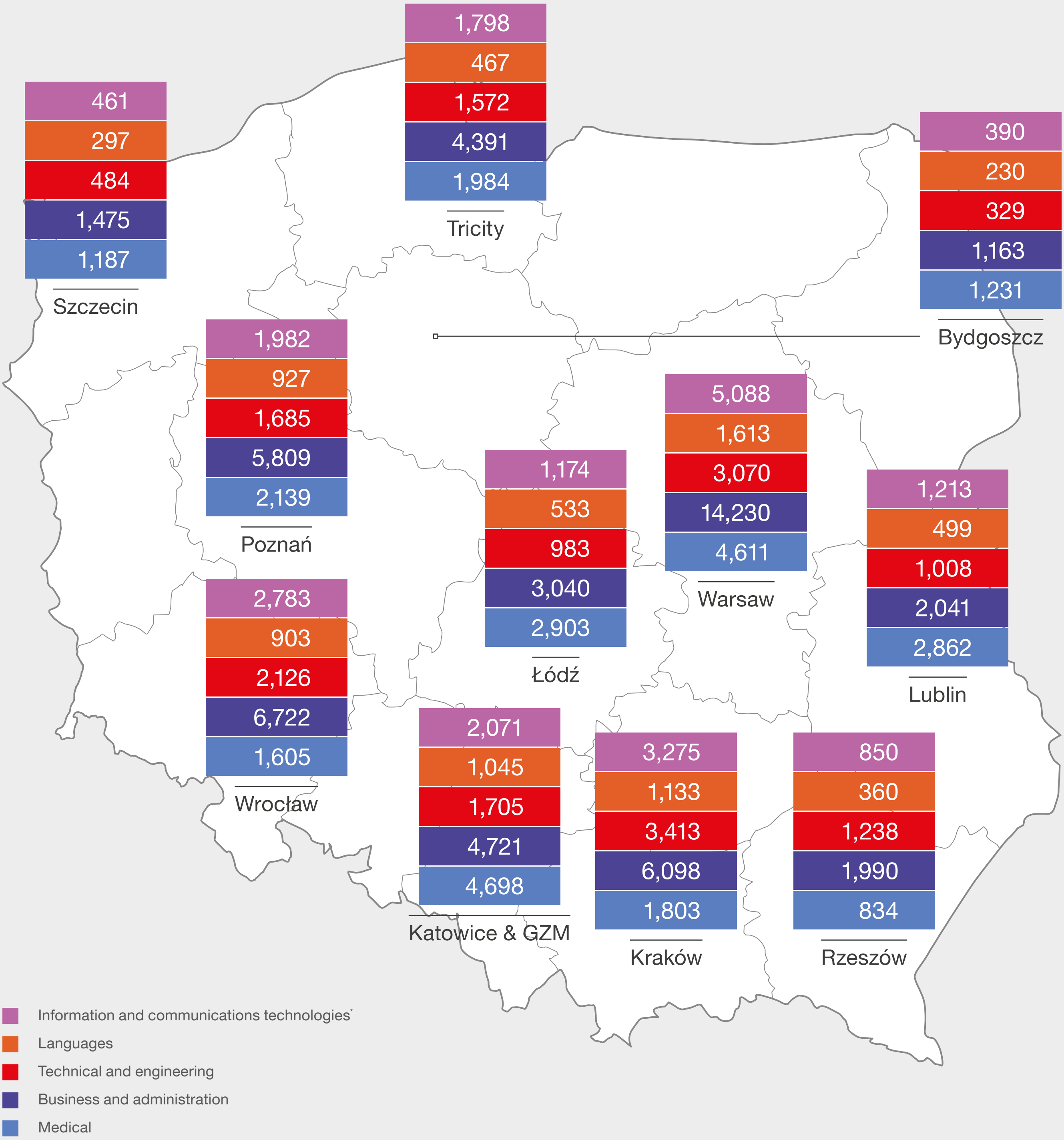
FIGURE 2.34 | **Students of selected courses: language, business and administration, ICT, engineering and technical, medical**



Note. The data is based on the actual location of the unit (faculty).
* Together with a subgroup of interdisciplinary programs and qualifications covering information and communications technology.

Source: Prepared by ABSL on the basis of data received from the National Information Processing Institute at the National Research Institute.

FIGURE 2.35 **Graduates of selected courses: language, business and administration, ICT, engineering and technical, medical**



Note. The data is based on the actual location of the unit (faculty).
* Together with a subgroup of interdisciplinary programs and qualifications covering information and communications technology.

Source: Prepared by ABSL on the basis of data received from the National Information Processing Institute at the National Research Institute.

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TABLE 2.7 | **Foreign students by country of origin**

	Number of students
Ukraine	46,796
Belarus	10,649
Turkey	4,541
Zimbabwe	2,889
India	2,724
China	2,643
Azerbaijan	2,227
The Czech Republic	1,817
Hungary	1,407
Norway	1,392

TABLE 2.8 | **Foreign graduates by country of origin**

	Number of graduates
Ukraine	9,232
Belarus	2,718
Zimbabwe	1,278
Azerbaijan	958
India	791
Turkey	766
China	691
The Czech Republic	496
Uzbekistan	462
Kazakhstan	402

Source: Prepared by ABSL on the basis of data received from the National Information Processing Institute at the National Research Institute.

> **AI is the new electricity, but it requires people who know how to use it.**
>
> Andrew Ng

Summary – key observations on Talent

Workforce maturity is reshaping the operating model

The sector is experiencing a demographic change toward a more experienced workforce. Employees aged 35 and older constitute the majority. Increased tenure and more specialist roles depict a move from scale-driven delivery to capability-based operations, where value relies on expertise, process ownership, and integration with core business functions.

Hybrid work is a structural standard, but no longer a differentiator

Hybrid work is now the standard. Two- and three-day office schedules are the market norm. Competitive advantage depends on effective management of hybrid work, not flexibility alone. Office presence supports collaboration and onboarding, but return-to-office policies can hinder talent attraction, retention, and engagement if not clearly aligned with business objectives.

Talent constraints are shifting from scarcity to skills mismatch

Perceived talent shortages have declined due to better candidate availability, lower turnover, and broader sourcing. The main challenge has shifted to accessing specialized, high-skill talent for advanced, knowledge-intensive, and AI-enabled processes.

Employment growth becomes more selective and productivity-driven

The sector is shifting from headcount-led expansion to a focus on efficiency, automation, and internal capability building. Growth now depends more on productivity, service complexity, and technology than on workforce size.

AI is reshaping work, but value capture remains the key gap

As AI becomes more deeply embedded in tasks, skill requirements adjust and demand for routine roles declines. However, many organizations still struggle to translate adoption into measurable value. Productivity gains are often fragmented and are not fully embedded in operating models.

The core challenge is integration and embedding AI into workflows and scaling its impact.

International talent is a core enabler of capability scaling

The sector has been highly international. Foreign employees make up a significant portion of the workforce. International hiring helps to reduce capability gaps and strengthens global service provision. Multicultural teams drive innovation, adaptability, and alignment with international clients, which supports Poland's role as a global business services hub.

Labor markets are stabilizing, with localized pressure points

Voluntary turnover has decreased to moderate levels, and involuntary turnover remains low. The labor market is more balanced. Talent pressure is now localized to certain cities and skill segments, reflecting macroeconomic and structural changes in the workforce.

Compensation is becoming more structured and performance-linked

Salary growth is stabilizing at moderate levels; therefore, cost predictability improves. Pay increases are more often tied to individual performance.

Promotion-related increases become more standardized, facilitating internal mobility and making career progression more predictable. However, relatively high entry-level salaries may limit flexibility in attracting top-tier talent. Gaps remain in early-career compensation. Many organizations still lack structured graduate pay frameworks, leading to inconsistencies and weakening their positioning as employers for junior talent.

Cost competitiveness is narrowing, shifting the focus to value creation

Mercer data show that Poland maintains a cost advantage over Western Europe, with regional differences informing location strategies. However, wage convergence and rising expectations are narrowing this advantage. Competitiveness is shifting from cost efficiency to capability depth, productivity, and service sophistication.

Pay transparency and fairness are emerging as structural forces

Regulatory changes and evolving employee expectations are accelerating the move toward pay transparency. Organizations are preparing to disclose salary ranges internally and externally. As transparency grows, employee bargaining power increases, and perceived fairness becomes key to engagement and retention.

Managers are becoming the key execution layer in transformation

As operating models evolve, managers' roles are expanding. They are now responsible for translating change, maintaining alignment, and sustaining trust, making their effectiveness central to organizational performance in a more complex environment.

HR is evolving into a strategic system architect

Human resources are moving from an administrative function to a central role in workforce system design. This includes managing human-AI collaboration, enabling reskilling, leveraging talent intelligence, and supporting complex governance and regulatory requirements.

A skills-first, AI-enabled talent model is emerging

The sector is progressively adopting a skills-based approach to workforce management. Traditional role-based structures are being replaced by flexible, task- and capability-focused models. Internal mobility, continuous learning, and AI-enabled workforce planning are now central to long-term competitiveness.

Leadership pipelines require strengthening to support the next phase of growth

Poland's role in the provision of global business services is growing, but its representation at top decision-making levels remains limited. Gender balance at entry and mid-levels is not yet reflected in senior leadership. Strengthening leadership pipelines, global exposure, and inclusive career progression is a key priority.

Conclusion

The sector is undergoing a fundamental change from a model focused on labor availability and cost efficiency to one centered on capability, productivity, and integration of human and technological resources, in particular genAI and agentic AI.

Poland remains strong in global business services, but future competitiveness will depend more on deploying skills, scaling AI-driven productivity while managing a complex, evolving workforce than on access to talent alone. According to Randstad, talent in Poland demonstrates above-average readiness in AI compared to global benchmarks. This is a strong signal and a clear competitive advantage.

Particularly, demographic trends and the future supply of graduates, as highlighted by OPI data, will further shape this trajectory.

Strategic workforce planning must therefore extend beyond short-term labor market conditions toward a systemic, forward-looking approach to talent that involves external stakeholders, such as the education system and academia.

3

TECHNOLOGY AND AI

Introduction

Technology has shifted from enabling efficiency in the business services sector to driving operating model transformation. The sector is moving from automation-led optimization to AI-enabled process redesign and enhanced decision-making focused on value creation. This change, however, is uneven. Although automation and generative AI are widely adopted, their impact varies across functions, organizations, and process complexity.

As of the end of Q1 2026, the sector remains in transition. Automation is mature but not fully scaled by any means. AI adoption is broad, but its application is still limited. Productivity gains are evident but have yet to deliver structural cost transformation. The main challenge is now integrating technology across processes, data, and organizational structures. This requires transformation, and the introduction of agentic AI systems could prove pivotal.

> **A year spent in artificial intelligence is enough to make one believe in God.**
>
> Alan Perlis
>
> Purdue University

The current chapter of the report examines how these trends are reshaping the sector in Poland. It analyzes the current state of automation and AI adoption, including IPA, machine learning, generative AI, and emerging agentic systems. The chapter also assesses their impact on productivity, cost structures, workforce composition, and operating models.

The chapter also explores the evolving technology stack, including cloud, data infrastructure, and development ecosystems, as well as the organizational capabilities needed to scale AI effectively. It highlights the gap between technological potential and actual implementation, which is influenced by data constraints, legacy systems, specialized talent, key AI-related skills shortages, and governance requirements. The chapter concludes with our first attempt to estimate the labor-related effects of AI by 2030.

Chapter content developed by: **ABSL**

Before presenting the data and empirical evidence, it is important to anchor the analysis in the broader body of research on AI and its economic impact. The following section synthesizes key findings from leading academic, policy, and industry studies to establish how AI affects productivity, work, and business models. This provides a conceptual framework for interpreting the survey results and scenario analysis that follow.

How AI creates value and why the impact is uneven

Artificial intelligence is widely recognized as a **general-purpose technology (GPT)** with the potential to transform productivity, labor markets, and firm organization. Unlike earlier digital innovations, its economic impact is shaped by technological capability, **task exposure, adoption rates, complementary investments, and organizational readiness** (Filippucci et al., 2024). Research from the OECD, IMF, and academic sources concurs that AI's effects are significant but conditional: substantial at the micro level, yet slower, uneven, and more uncertain at the macro level.

From Automation to Agentic AI: A Shift at the Technology Frontier

The literature describes a clear **technological progression.** Initial automation, through robotic process automation (RPA) and intelligent process automation (IPA), targeted structured, rule-based processes and improved efficiency in repetitive tasks. Subsequent advances in **machine learning and deep learning** expanded automation to include prediction, classification, and pattern recognition. Generative AI (GenAI) now extends automation and augmentation to language, coding, and knowledge work, reaching previously non-codifiable domains. The emerging stage of agentic AI enables coordination of multi-step workflows across systems, shifting the focus from task execution to **process orchestration.** This evolution indicates a transition from **efficiency gains to operating model redesign,** although the latter remains in development.

A central finding in the literature is that AI influences the economy through **three primary channels: substitution, augmentation, and recomposition of tasks.** Substitution occurs in routine, rule-based activities, where automation reduces manual work. Augmentation is evident in complex tasks, with AI enhancing human abilities in analysis, writing, coding, and decision support (Brynjolfsson et al., 2025; Noy & Zhang, 2023). The most significant effect is recomposition, in which jobs and processes are restructured as tasks move between humans and machines (Gmyrek et al., 2023). This leads to changes in the nature of work. AI produces **measurable productivity gains at the task level,** particularly in standardized knowledge work. Studies of customer support, programming, and professional writing report improvements in speed, quality, and consistency, often with stronger effects for less experienced workers (Brynjolfsson et al., 2025; Peng et al., 2023). These findings show that AI can serve as a **capability diffuser,** embedding best practices into workflows and reducing performance dispersion. However, these gains are **heterogeneous and context-dependent,** with performance declining when AI is applied outside its effective domain or used without adequate oversight (Dell'Acqua et al., 2023).

From Productivity Gains to Structural Change: The Missing Transmission Mechanism

At the macro level, translating these gains into **aggregate productivity growth remains uncertain and is likely to be gradual.** Multiple studies identify a persistent gap between firm-level improvements and economy-wide outcomes, attributed to slow diffusion, sectoral heterogeneity, and reallocation frictions (Acemoglu, 2024; Filippucci et al., 2024). In Europe, productivity effects are expected to depend significantly on **adoption rates, regulatory environments, and labor market structures** (Misch et al., 2025). These findings reinforce the perspective that AI is not an automatic growth engine, but a technology whose benefits require active realization.

From a labor market perspective, the literature rejects both the narrative of mass job destruction and the notion of negligible impact. Instead, it identifies a **gradual and differentiated adjustment process.** AI exposure is high in clerical, administrative, and cognitively intensive occupations; however, exposure does not imply full automation (Eloundou et al., 2024; Gmyrek et al., 2025). Most jobs are expected to be transformed rather than eliminated, with growing demand for tasks related to supervision, integration, exception handling, and decision-making. Nonetheless, significant risks persist, including **job polarization, skill mismatches, and uneven distribution of gains** (Cazzaniga et al., 2024).

These effects can be particularly significant for the business services industry. Our sector is highly exposed to AI due to its mix **of standardized processes and a growing share of analytical and knowledge-based work.** Evidence from centers shows that automation reduces the number of routine tasks and increases the complexity, autonomy, and skill requirements of the remaining work (Kowalik et al., 2023). This moves the sector from **labor arbitrage to capability arbitrage,** where value creation relies more on expertise, data, and integration capability than on cost efficiency.

A critical theme in the literature is that while AI **adoption is widespread, value capture remains uneven.** Many firms have implemented AI tools, yet relatively few have scaled them across processes and functions. The primary barriers are organizational, not technological, and include **data quality, legacy systems, lack of integration, insufficient skills, unclear governance, and weak change management** (OECD/BCG/INSEAD, 2025). Consequently, AI tends to improve individual tasks without immediately transforming entire operating models.

The literature observes that productivity gains from AI generally precede cost reductions. AI increases output per worker and accelerates workflows, ultimately leading to lower headcount or operational costs. This lag reflects the time required to adjust organizational structures, contracts, and management practices. Therefore, early AI adoption is associated with higher productivity and does not yield immediate cost savings, consistent with current trends in many service sectors.

Despite its potential, AI presents several structural risks. Its benefits are likely to be **distributed unevenly,** favoring firms and regions with stronger capabilities and superior data infrastructure. Excessive reliance on AI can introduce **quality risks, bias, and decision errors,** particularly outside well-defined tasks. Increased automation and monitoring may diminish **job quality and worker autonomy** in certain roles. The concentration of AI capabilities among a limited number of providers raises concerns regarding **market power and dependency.** Furthermore, governance requirements such as data protection, model validation, and regulatory compliance may slow adoption and increase costs, especially in regulated sectors.

In summary, the current literature presents a balanced perspective on AI. It is a **powerful yet conditional technology capable of driving** significant productivity gains and transforming business models, provided there are complementary investments, organizational redesign, and workforce adaptation. In business services, the impact of AI will depend more on integration, scaling, and alignment with evolving service models than on the technology itself.

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Key takeaways & key technology facts

74.1% of centers have adopted Intelligent Process Automation (IPA), with only 9.2% lacking implementation plans. Automation is now standard; competitive advantage lies in scaling and integration.

Automation adoption is moderate and uneven, averaging 24.4% with a median of 20.0%. Most centers fall within the 10-30% range, while a few exceed 40%, reflecting a two-speed adoption pattern.

Automation provides stable, incremental returns. Over two-thirds of centers meet expectations, while few exceed them.

RPA has achieved diminishing returns. It delivers stability, not transformation.

84.4% of centers use GenAI, and over 85% view it as an opportunity. Competitive pressure is driven by adoption speed, not disruption risk.

AI impact is mainly productivity-driven at this stage. About 68% report productivity gains, while only 36% report cost-efficiency improvements. AI is increasing output per FTE before reducing costs.

AI adoption is already meaningful, with around **20% of processes AI-enhanced,** while the majority remains human-driven. This level of adoption is relatively advanced compared to typical market benchmarks, where scaling beyond pilot use cases remains limited.

AI deployment is focused on high-volume, standardized processes (15-25% penetration), with less than 5% adoption in complex or regulated areas. Complexity remains a major barrier to wider adoption.

Agentic AI adoption is emerging but has not yet scaled. GenAI (84.4%) and IPA/RPA (76.5%) dominate current use. The sector is shifting from task-level augmentation to workflow-level orchestration.

AI adoption is already saturated at the tool level but remains shallow at the process level. The bottleneck has moved from access to execution.

Agentic AI is the first technology in the current stack capable of redesigning work models, not just improving them. Its role will be pivotal. At this point, it is an introductory phase, however.

AI is changing work composition before affecting headcount. 38.0% of centers report a shift to higher-value tasks, while 23.3% note reductions in routine roles. Transformation is mainly compositional.

Employment impact is expected to emerge gradually. Short-term effects are limited, but over 50% of respondents anticipate workforce contraction by 2030. The adjustment is delayed but structural. Most of the contraction is likely in low-complexity, low-value processes.

AI usage is widespread among employees, with nearly half of organizations reporting that over 50% of staff use AI tools regularly. The main challenge is achieving depth and consistency of use.

AI capability development is uneven. Many organizations have trained less than 25% of their workforce, highlighting a persistent skills gap. Scaling talent is now a critical challenge.

Key barriers to AI scaling are operational. Data quality (57.3%) and **legacy system integration (55.1%)** are primary challenges, followed by **cost (45.4%)** and **skills (40.5%).** The main problem is execution.

AI governance is becoming standard, with over 85% of organizations implementing or developing formal frameworks. Control and compliance are essential for scaling.

AI development strategies are hybrid. About 46.5% of centers combine in-house and external solutions, while 40.6% focus on internal capabilities. Competitive advantage to a growing extent relies on proprietary AI integration.

AI-specific hiring remains limited, with over 50% of organizations reporting no dedicated AI recruitment. Transformation is driven mainly by upskilling, not by new hiring models.

Reskilling needs are significant. Most organizations expect 25–75% of their workforce will require adaptation by 2030. Workforce transformation is systemic rather than marginal.

Technology adoption beyond AI is selective. Advanced analytics (63.9%), NLP interfaces (55.1%), and **cloud (48.3%)** are the most common, while experimental technologies remain marginal. The sector is consolidating around an AI-centric stack.

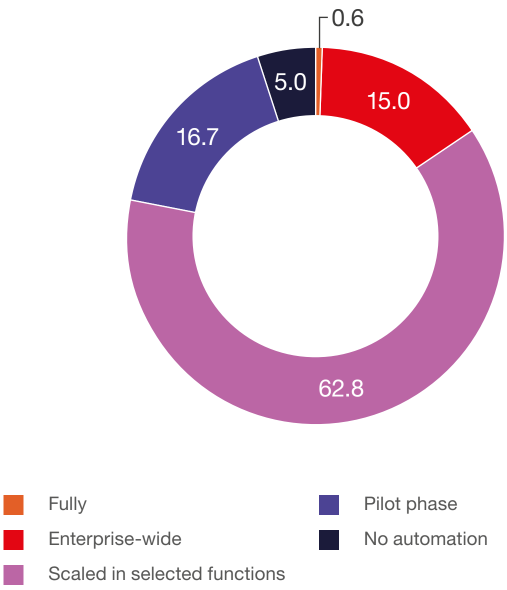
The technology bottleneck is internal. Leadership (54.4%) and **talent (45.0%)** are the main enablers of adoption, outweighing infrastructure or regulatory constraints. Transformation is driven by execution.

Automation has matured, but has not transformed the sector

Robotic / intelligent process automation

By now, RPA in the sector in Poland is **widely deployed but rarely fully scaled.** 62.8% of respondents have automation **scaled only in selected functions,** 16.7% are still in pilot, and just 15% reached enterprise-wide rollout, with virtually no one fully automated (0.6%).

FIGURE 3.1 **Extent of process automation using RPA / workflow automation tools (excluding AI)** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=180).

Current automation rate

Automation has **matured beyond experimentation but is still fragmented.** The main challenge is no longer adoption but **scaling within the organization and integrating processes end-to-end.**

The automation rate is steadily increasing, but at a slow pace overall.

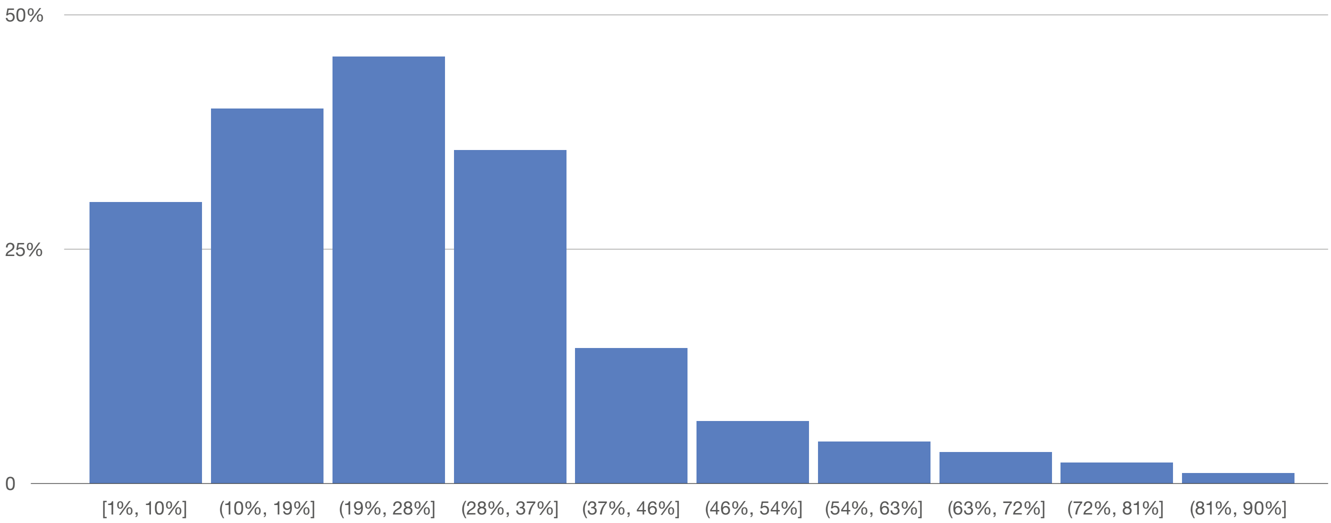
Automation is **gradually increasing, but the distribution matters more than the average.** The mean rises from 19.6% (Q1 2024) to approximately 24.4% (Q1 2026), and the median from 15% to 20%, confirming steady progress. However, quartiles show **no movement at the bottom (Q1 = 10%) and top (Q3 = 30%),** meaning the bulk of centers remain stuck in the same adoption bands. At the same time, strong right-skew (skewness 1.27) and a high maximum (90%) indicate a **small group of leaders pulling the average up. So, the automation rate is uneven in the sector.**

At the same time, laggards are not catching up, and leaders are not pulling further ahead.

When we look at the distribution, it is **heavily concentrated in the 10-30% range,** with the highest density around approx. 20-30%, and a clear **long right tail** extending to high automation levels. Only a small share of centers, however, exceed 40%, and very few exceed 60-70%.

Automation used at a large scale is still not the norm, and the market is split between a large middle group progressing gradually and a small set of outliers or leaders pushing much further.

FIGURE 3.2 | **Distribution of automation rates at the end of Q1 2026** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=166).

TABLE 3.1 | **Evolution of automation rate reported 2024-2026**

	Q1 2026	Q1 2025	Q1 2024
Q1	10.0%	10.0%	10.0%
Median	**20.0%**	**17.5%**	**15.0%**
Mean	**24.4%**	**22.4%**	**19.6%**
Q3	30.0%	30.0%	30.0%

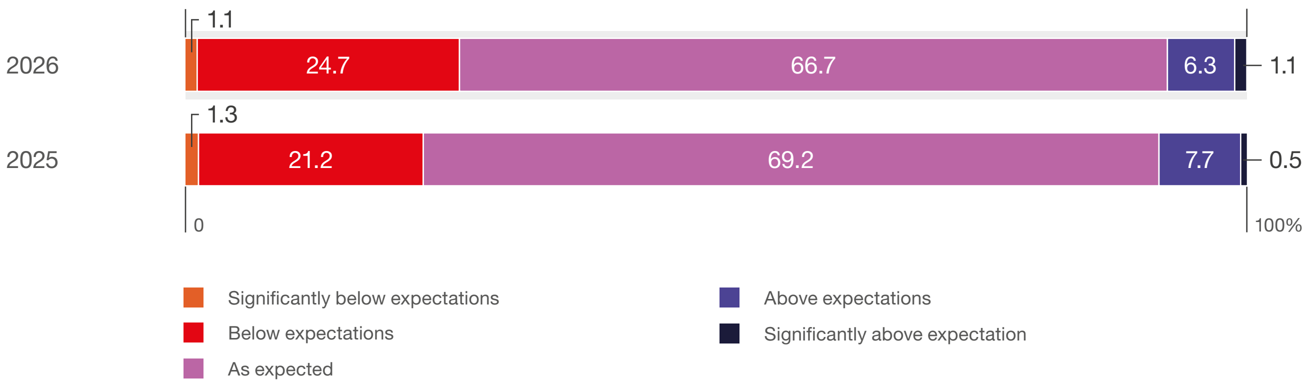
Source: ABSL BI based on the survey results from 2026, 2025, and 2024.

Results of automation

Automation is generally meeting expectations, but not exceeding them. Approximately two-thirds of centers report results as expected (69.2% in 2025, 66.7% in 2026). About a quarter of respondents state outcomes are below expectations (21-25%), and only a small percentage see outperformance (7-8%). Automation provides steady, **incremental value instead of significant breakthroughs. Execution quality, including case selection,** scaling, and integration, remains the main differentiator. From 2025 to 2026, the share of results meeting expectations declines slightly (69.2% to 66.7%), **below expectations increases** (21.2% to 24.7%), and **above expectations decreases** (7.7% to 6.3%), with only a marginal increase in “significantly above” (0.6% to 1.1%).

Early gains may be harder to sustain as automation scales. As expectations rise and more complex use cases are addressed, underperformance becomes more common and upside surprises less frequent.

FIGURE 3.3 | **Extent to which implemented automation has delivered expected results** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=188).

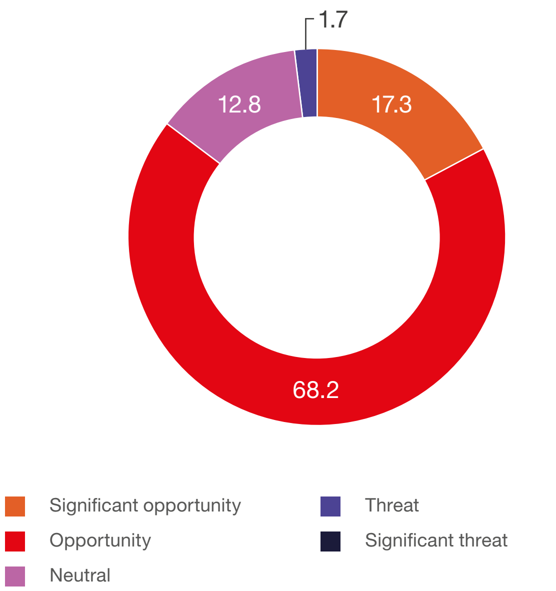
AI – threat or opportunity?

Perception has been overwhelmingly positive and remains so. 68.2% see GenAI as an opportunity and 17.3% as a significant opportunity, while only 1.7% view it as a threat and virtually none as a significant threat (12.8% neutral). This means the competitive pressure comes from adoption, not disruption risk. Most respondents are leaning in, so the risk of falling behind is low.

> **By far, the greatest danger of Artificial Intelligence is that people conclude too early that they understand it.**
>
> **Eliezer Yudkowsky**
>
> Machine Intelligence Research Institute

Survey responses indicate that GenAI is perceived primarily as an opportunity. Its main impact lies in automating repetitive tasks, boosting productivity, and improving decision-making through better use of data. By reducing transactional work and increasing process efficiency, GenAI helps lower operational costs and improve service quality. It enables business centers to move toward more knowledge-intensive, analytical, and strategic activities, supporting innovation and faster response to business needs. In many organizations, **GenAI is also expected to strengthen the role of centers as AI competency hubs and drivers of enterprise-wide transformation,** while gradually reshaping workforce skills and reducing reliance on purely transactional roles. This will require leaders’ attention to fully utilize the opportunities.

FIGURE 3.4 **Perception of GenAI development as a threat or opportunity for your center** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=179).

Use of AI by processes and functions

Year on year, AI adoption is increasing. AI adoption is widespread across functions such as HR, finance, IT, and customer operations, but it is concentrated in high-volume, standardized processes (mostly 15-25%).

Outside this core, adoption drops rapidly, with most functions at 5-15% and many complex or regulated areas below 5%.

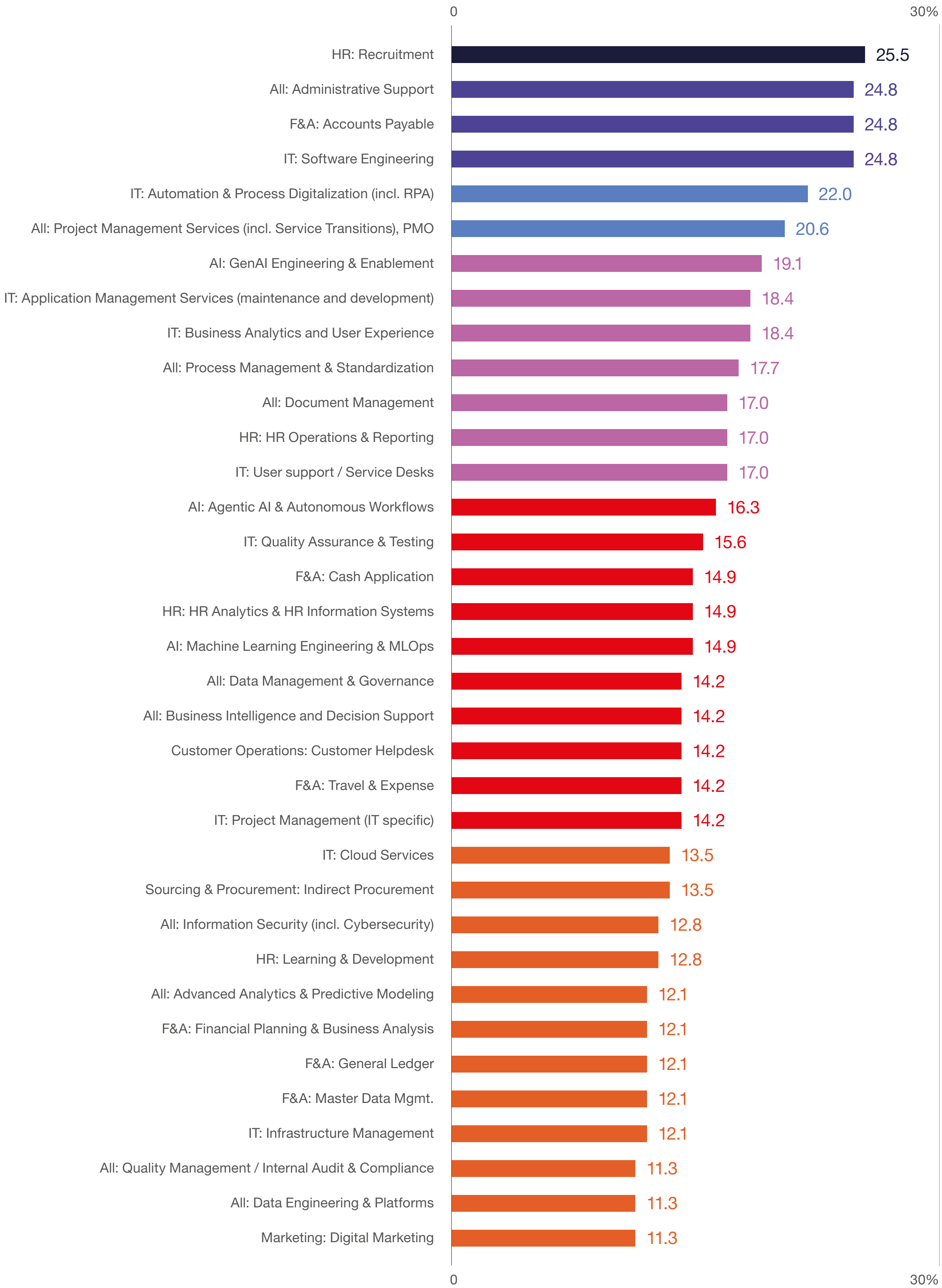
Building on this, AI adoption is highest in **high-volume, standardized, and IT-related functions such as** recruitment (25.5), administrative support and accounts payable (approx. 25), software engineering (24.8), and automation or digitalization (22.0). Functions like PMO, application services, analytics, and process management follow (approx. 18-21). In the mid-tier (approx. 12-17), adoption is evident in HR operations, service desks, QA, data, and FP&A. In contrast, **complex, regulated, or judgment-intensive areas such as** legal, risk, treasury, advanced healthcare, and industry-specific processes remain low (mostly below 7, many below 3). For CXOs, this indicates that AI deployment is driven by scalability and standardization, with value realized first in repeatable, data-rich processes. Decision-heavy and regulated domains remain **largely untouched,** leading to slower, more limited adoption.

Only about one-fifth of processes (19.5-20.4%) are currently AI-enhanced, while nearly four-fifths (79.6-80.5%) remain human-only. Despite widespread discussion of rapid AI adoption, actual implementation remains limited and has not yet reached a transformational scale. The next phase will focus on accelerating AI diffusion and integrating it into core processes, especially in complex, high-value functions where productivity and competitive advantage are greatest.

AI usage is already **broadly embedded in the workforce.** The largest group of companies (28%) reports that **51-75% of employees use AI regularly,** with another 16.8% reporting that more than 75% of employees do so. At the same time, a meaningful share is still in earlier stages (around 30% below the 25% usage threshold).

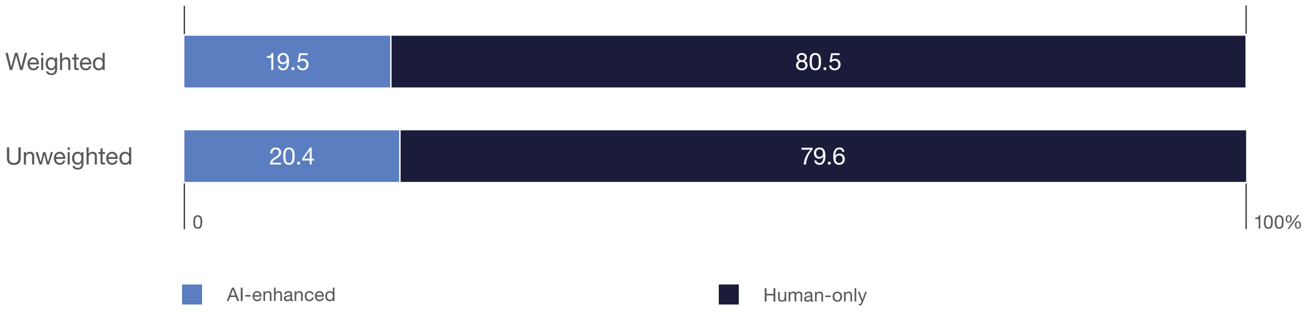
This signifies a clear transition point. AI is no longer niche, but not yet universal. Most organizations have reached mass adoption, but full penetration remains ahead, meaning the next phase is to deepen usage and consistency across teams, not just to onboard new users.

FIGURE 3.5 **Current use of GenAI across processes** (%)



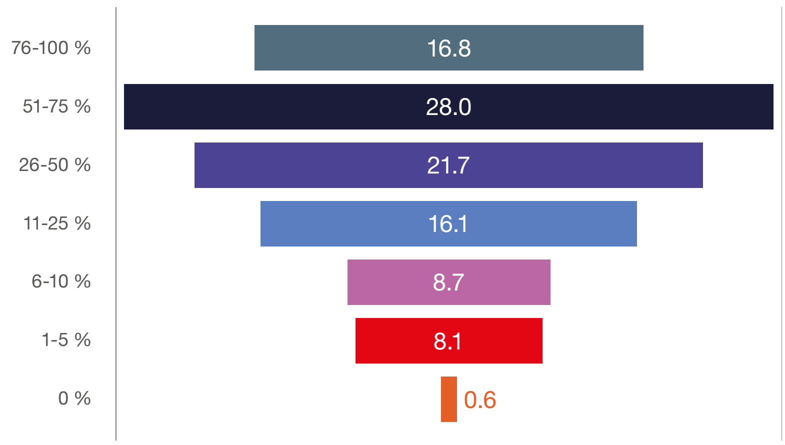
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=141).

FIGURE 3.6 **Share of AI-enhanced vs. human-only processes** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=188).

FIGURE 3.7 **Share of workforce regularly using AI tools** (at least weekly) (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=161).

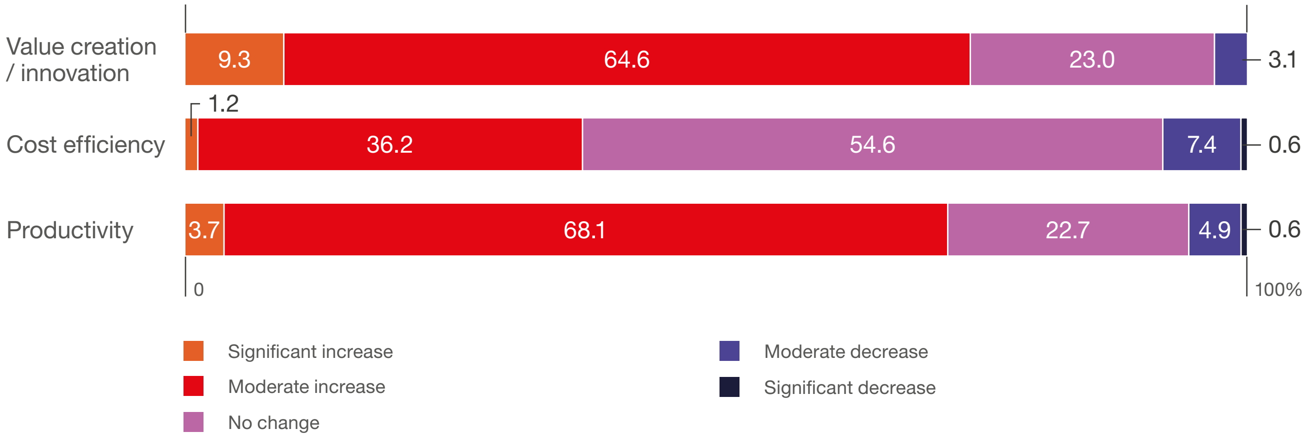
Productivity first, cost later. The current phase of AI impact

The impact of AI is already apparent, although it remains largely incremental and uneven. Productivity (68.1%) and value creation (64.6%) primarily demonstrate moderate improvements, with few substantial gains. In contrast, **cost efficiency yields more varied outcomes. Only 36.2% report moderate improvement, while a majority (54.6%) observe no change to date.** We have to bear in mind that cost advantages within centers are tied to full-time equivalents (FTEs) and headcount adjustments, given the significant share of employee costs in the overall cost structure.

These findings suggest that AI is currently providing operational improvements and not driving cost transformation. Efficiency gains have not yet resulted in widespread reductions in cost bases. It seems that **cost transformation lags productivity because organizational structures, contracts, and governance frameworks adjust more slowly than task execution.**

The return on investment is tangible but remains limited, primarily enhancing productivity and quality rather than delivering structural savings. Consequently, expectations regarding cost reduction should remain conservative in the near term.

FIGURE 3.8 | **Extent to which AI adoption has changed productivity, cost structure, and value creation** (%)

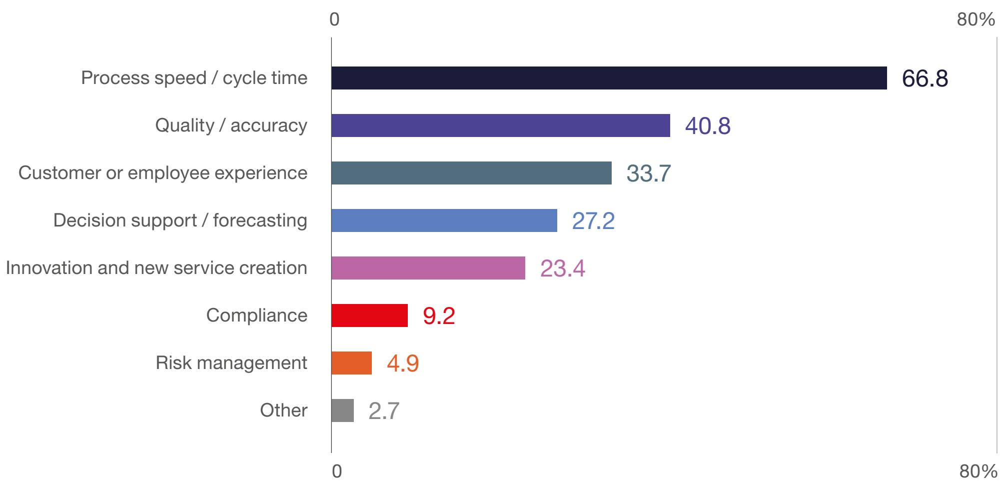


Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=163).

Value from AI is **concentrated in operational performance.** The biggest gains come from process speed (66.8%) and quality/accuracy (40.8%), followed by customer/employee experience (33.7%) and decision support (27.2%). Innovation (23.4%) is present but secondary, while risk and compliance remain marginal.

AI is currently delivering **tangible, execution-level improvements,** not yet transformational value. Most impact is in making processes **faster, more accurate, and smoother.** Higher-level strategic benefits are still emerging.

FIGURE 3.9 | **Areas that have generated the biggest value gains from AI adoption** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=184).

AI is currently reshaping work before it reshapes headcount.

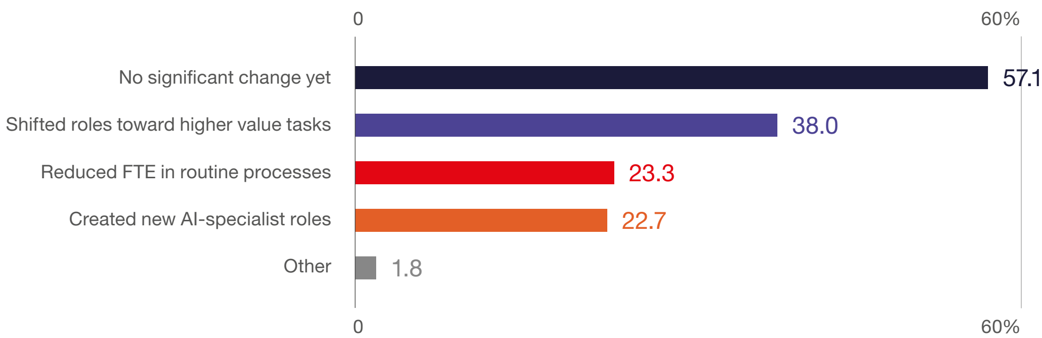
The primary effect is reallocation and upskilling, not downsizing. The structural workforce impact is coming, but it is still in transition and not fully realized.

The impact on the workforce is **visible but still in its early stages.** A majority of respondents (57.1%) report no significant change yet, but among those who see effects, the dominant pattern is **role upgrading.** 38.0% report shifts toward higher-value tasks, alongside more limited FTE reductions in routine work (23.3%) and creation of new AI roles (22.7%).

In the next 12 months, employment is expected to be largely **stable (59.7%).** Only modest declines (23.3%) and limited growth (16.9%) are predicted. However, by 2030, the outlook changes materially. **Over half expect contraction (54.2%),** while only 17% see expansion and 28.8% stability.

In the short term, AI is absorbed through productivity gains and role redesign, with no major headcount changes. Nevertheless, structurally, over the medium term, efficiency effects dominate, leading to a smaller, more skilled workforce. The implication is evident. Workforce transformation needs to start now, even if the visible impact on employment comes later.

FIGURE 3.10 | **Impact of AI adoption on the workforce to date** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=163).

FIGURE 3.11 | **Impact of AI-driven changes in your center on other group entities and/or external clients** (%)

Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=137).

Our centers are no longer just delivery units. They are becoming transmission hubs of transformation, influencing how the wider organization operates, what clients demand, and how value is created.

AI impact is **obviously extending beyond the center itself into the broader organization and clients.** The strongest effects are in the **driving process (59.9%) and technological innovation (51.1%),** followed by **reducing demand for routine work (41.6%)** and **knowledge spillovers (35.8%).** A third also sees **changing skill demand on the client side (34.3%).** Only a minority (24.8%) reports no external impact.

The next inflection point: from augmentation to integration

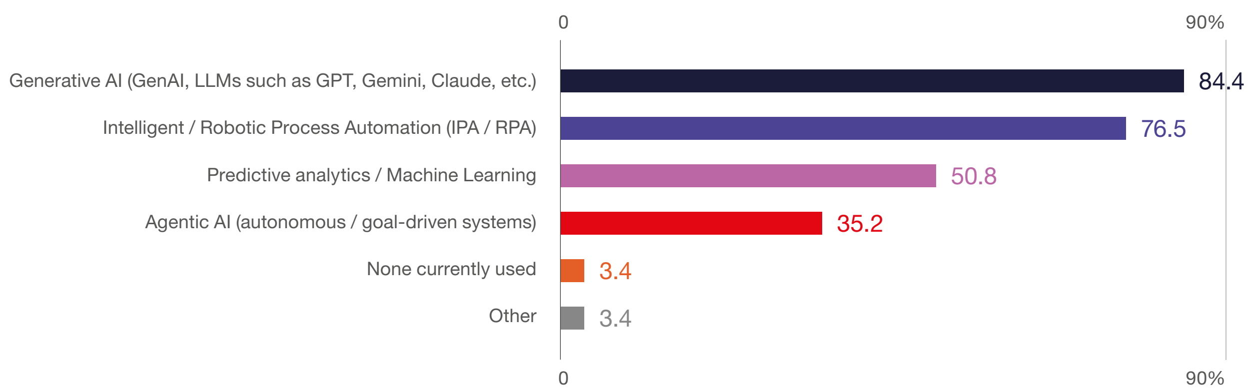
Generative AI and automation currently dominate the technology landscape. GenAI tools are used by 84.4% of centers, with 76.5% adopting IPA/RPA and 50.8% applying predictive analytics. According to respondents, 35.2% have begun implementing more advanced agentic AI systems. However, at this stage, the impact will be limited as they are only in the introductory phase for obvious reasons.

Centers are prioritizing mature, productivity-focused tools that can be deployed with minimal disruption, while gradually exploring more autonomous, decision-oriented solutions.

Firms are developing core capabilities in GenAI, automation, and analytics. At the same time, they are addressing challenges related to data, data quality, compute power, process maturity, and data and AI governance. This approach is creating a two-speed environment: leading centers are adopting advanced capabilities and moving toward agentic solutions, while others focus on incremental productivity improvements. The key inflection point will come as agentic AI scales, shifting business services from augmentation to orchestration and enabling end-to-end automation that will reshape business services models, cost structures, and workforce needs.

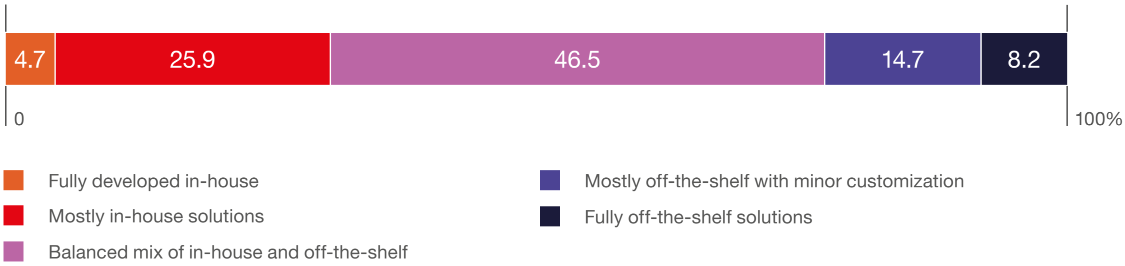
Unlike RPA and GenAI, agentic AI is not about doing tasks better. It is about eliminating the need for predefined workflows altogether.

FIGURE 3.12 | **AI technologies currently used in organizations** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=179).

FIGURE 3.13 **Reliance on in-house development vs. off-the-shelf AI solutions** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=170). AI platforms, automation tools, and generative AI applications used in operations are included.

The results show that AI deployment strategies in business services are mainly hybrid. Nearly half of centers (46.5%) use a balanced mix of in-house development and off-the-shelf solutions, 40.6% favor in-house capabilities. Only about 23% rely primarily on off-the-shelf tools. Leading centers view AI as a strategic capability that requires internal development, customization, and integration. For the ABSL sector, this marks a shift toward building proprietary AI competencies. Future competitiveness will depend on combining external platforms with strong in-house engineering, data, and domain expertise.

AI Governance

AI governance is already **well established and becoming standard.** 53.2% of companies have a fully implemented policy, with another 32.7% in development and only a small minority without one (8.8%). This means over **85% of organizations are actively formalizing AI governance.**

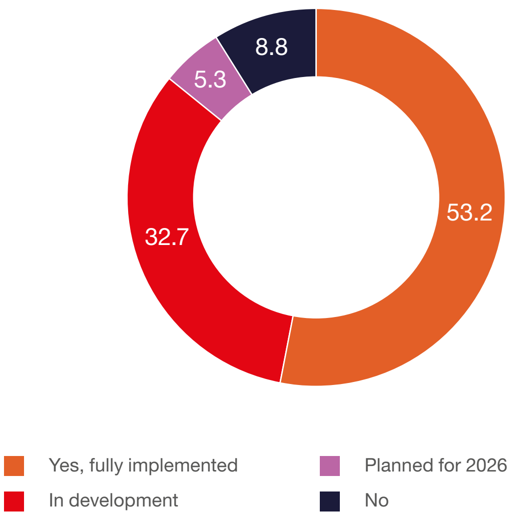
AI leadership is **present but not yet localized.** Nearly half of organizations (49.1%) rely on a **global AI lead,** 24.3% have a regional or local role (14.5% regional, 9.8% local), and 26.6% have no dedicated function at all.

AI is still largely **centrally driven.** There is limited empowerment at the local/center level. **Execution will depend on moving from global oversight to local ownership,** where real deployment, scaling, and value capture happen.

This creates a clear implication for local leaders. The objective is not to define an AI strategy, but to **secure ownership of implementation and process transformation,** where real value is generated. In practice, **this means competing for a seat at the table by taking responsibility for end-to-end deployment, measurable outcomes, and integration into core operations.**

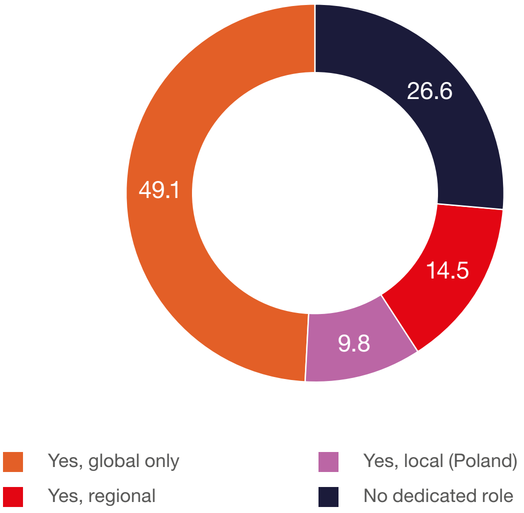
49.4% of respondents operate under HQ-driven models, while a significant 32.4% already use hybrid/joint governance. Fully autonomous local setups are rare (2.9%), and 15.3% remain undefined. Control still sits with headquarters, but there is a clear move toward **shared governance models,** which will likely become the norm as AI scaling requires both central standards and local execution.

FIGURE 3.14 **Does your company have an internal AI governance or ethics policy?** (%)



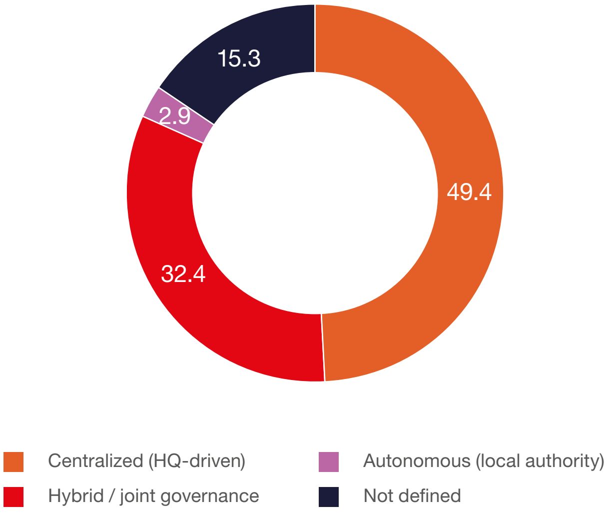
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=171).

FIGURE 3.15 **Is there a designated AI officer or AI transformation lead?** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=173).

FIGURE 3.16 **Collaboration with headquarters on AI governance** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=170).

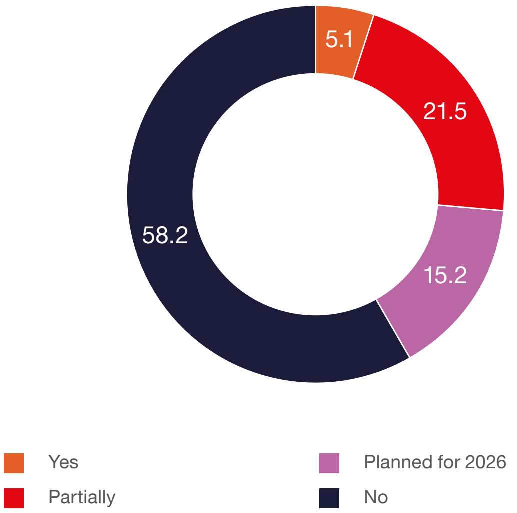
KPI systems have not yet caught up with AI adoption. A majority (58.2%) have not redefined performance metrics, with only 5.1% fully updated, 21.5% partially updated, and 15.2% planning to make changes. This shows an evident lag between **operational deployment of AI and management measurement frameworks.**

This is potentially a critical gap. Without adapting KPIs, organizations risk **mis-measuring productivity, value, and performance in AI-enabled work.** The implication is that the next phase of transformation is not technology, but **how performance is defined and governed.**

The real bottleneck: execution, not strategy

The main barriers to AI adoption are rooted in data and technology integration. Data quality (57.3%) and integration with legacy systems and existing technology stacks (55.1%) are the dominant constraints, followed by cost (45.4%) and skills (40.5%). Softer factors such as trust, regulation, and resistance remain secondary (approximately 15–27%).

FIGURE 3.17 **Redefinition of performance metrics or KPIs due to AI use** (%)



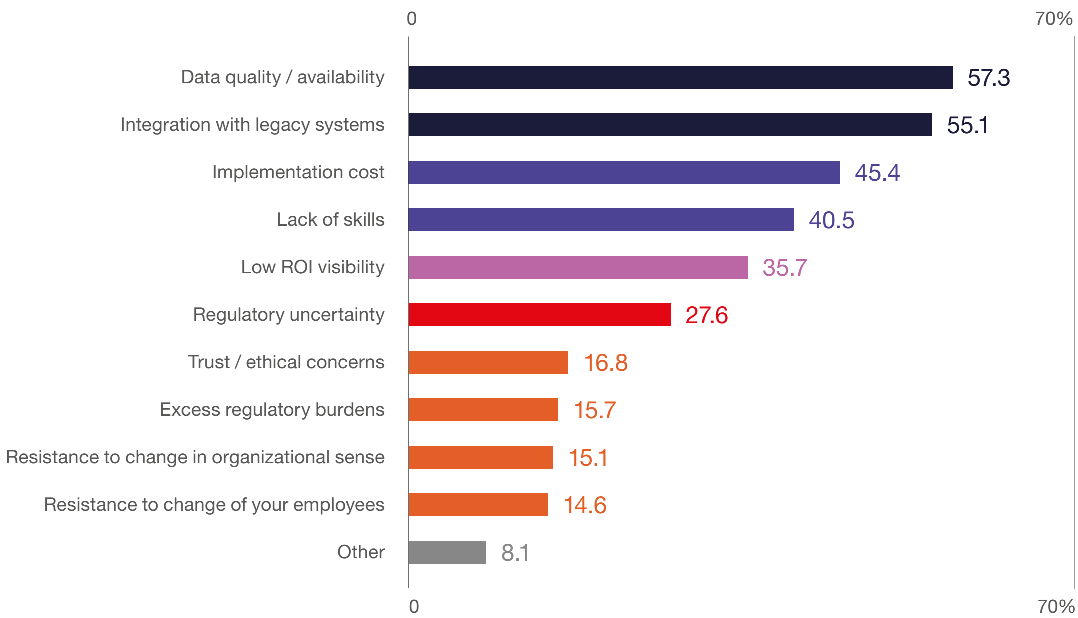
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=158).

The challenge is not conceptual, but architectural and executional. The bottlenecks are fixable but systemic, stemming from data readiness, legacy complexity, and integration challenges **across fragmented IT environments.**

The challenge is not "why AI," but how to scale its use and utilize its efficiency gains. This requires a structured sequence: **starting with business processes, moving through high-quality, governed data, and only then to the effective deployment of AI technologies.**

A critical role is played by control and governance, which must be anchored at the headquarters level, where strategic direction is set. Given that AI adoption is largely HQ-driven, **central functions need to define standards, ensure data quality, and coordinate architectural decisions across the entire organization, often spanning many locations and regulatory environments.**

FIGURE 3.18 | **Main barriers to scaling AI adoption in organizations** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=185).

Reskilling is systemic, not marginal

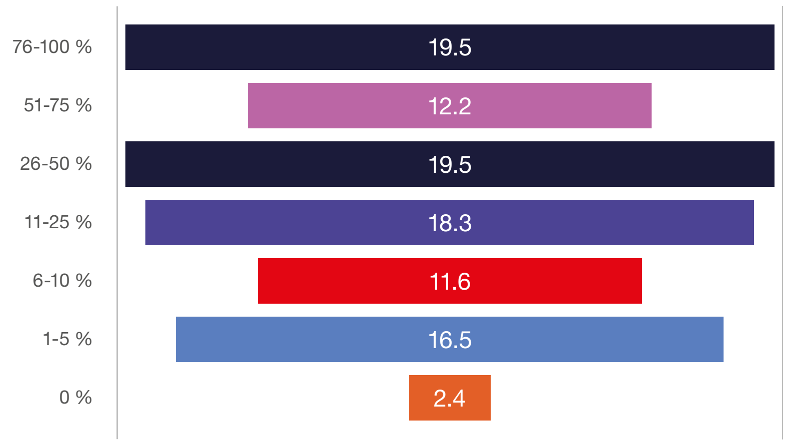
Training is widely underway but unevenly distributed. Nearly **20% of organizations have trained 76-100% of their workforce,** while a comparable share remains at **26-50% or below,** and a meaningful portion is still under **25%.**

This dispersion matters. Uneven capabilities across teams limit the ability to scale new tools and processes consistently, reducing the overall impact of the transformation. The next step is not to initiate training, but to scale **it systematically to reach the majority of employees and ensure consistent capability.**

Recruitment for AI-specific roles is **still emerging, not mainstream.** Only 15.6% of respondents are already hired for such roles, and another 21.6% plan to be. The majority (62.9%) are not yet recruiting in this way.

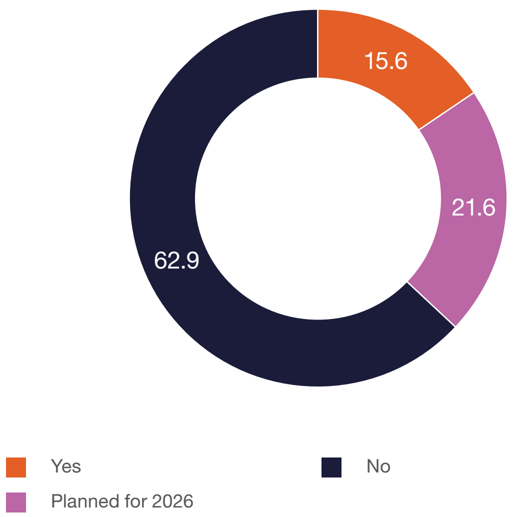
Most organizations are **still relying on upskilling existing teams instead of systemic reshaping of the talent model.** Nonetheless, a visible pipeline is forming. The transition to dedicated AI roles is coming, but it is **not yet standard practice in the sector.**

FIGURE 3.19 | **Share of workforce trained in AI tools or prompt engineering** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=164).

FIGURE 3.20 | **Recruitment for AI-augmented roles (e.g., AI trainer, model validator, automation architect)** (%)



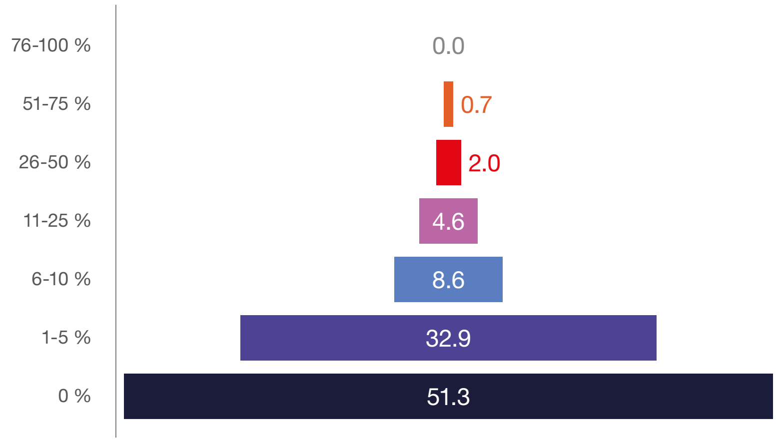
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=167).

AI-augmented hiring is **still at a very early stage.** Over half of organizations (51.3%) report no **AI-related hires,** and another 32.9% limit AI use to 1-5% of recruitment. Only a small minority exceed 10%. AI is being adopted operationally, but it has **not yet led to a structural change in hiring.** The talent model is therefore still largely traditional.

AI hiring is **skewed toward experienced talent.** The majority of roles target professionals with 3-5 years (35.6%) and 5+ years (32.2%) of experience. Entry-level hiring remains limited (13.8%). This indicates strong demand for immediately deployable AI capabilities and a relatively limited focus on entry-level pipeline development.

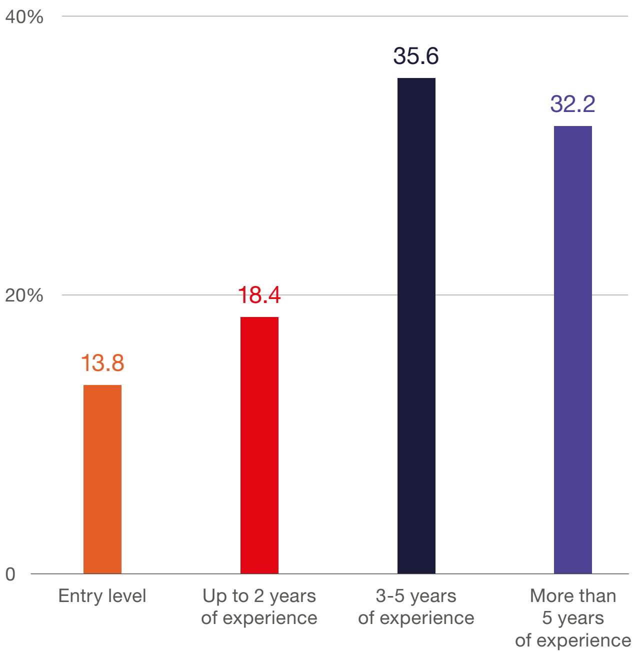
Respondents' expectations are **positive but moderate.** Nearly 60% of centers anticipate productivity gains (46.9% below 10% and 12.9% above 10%), while 31.3% expect no change, and only a small minority foresee declines (approx. 9%). There seems to be broad **confidence in productivity improvements, but without expectations of a sudden, dramatic step change. To some extent,** AI is seen as a reliable **enhancer.**

FIGURE 3.21 | **Percentage of new recruitments in AI-augmented roles** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=152).

FIGURE 3.22 | **Distribution of recruitment offers for AI-related roles by required experience in the past 12 months** (%)



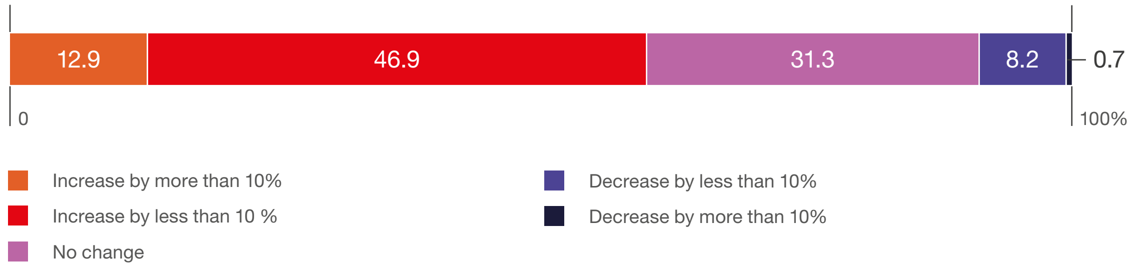
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=116).

The shift is not toward isolated AI experts, but toward **orchestrators of change,** people who can translate AI into workflows, products, and operating models. The scarce profile is not just "AI engineer," but **someone who can embed AI into the business at scale.**

The emerging roles are not purely technical. They sit at the interface of technology, process, and business.

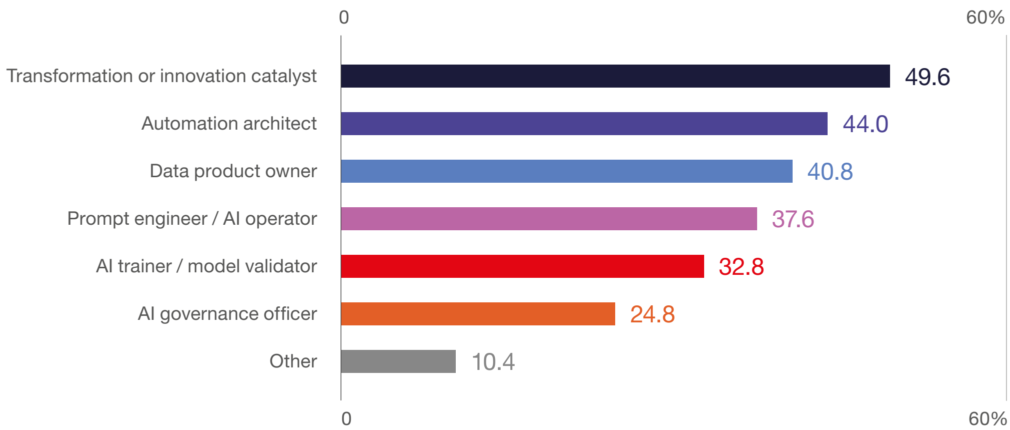
The most common roles are transformation/innovation leads (49.6%) and automation architects (44%), followed by data product owners (40.8%) and AI operators/prompt engineers (37.6%). More specialized roles, such as model validators (32.8%) and governance officers (24.8%), are present but secondary.

FIGURE 3.23 **The expected change in productivity (e.g., output per FTE) due to the introduction of AI by the end of Q1 2027** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=147).

FIGURE 3.24 **New roles that have emerged (or will emerge)?** (%)



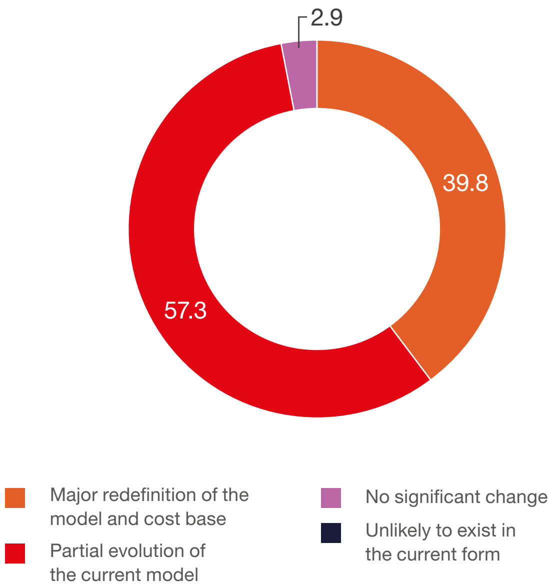
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=125).

Expectations

Most respondents anticipate incremental change. 57.3% expect a partial evolution of the current model, 39.8% foresee a major redefinition, and almost none expect no change. Respondents expect AI to mainly improve cost structures and efficiency within existing models, instead of replacing them by 2030. However, with about 40% preparing for deeper redesign, a distinctive divide is emerging. Some organizations will pursue structural changes in service provision and pricing, while others may lag. The practical approach is to target measurable efficiency gains first and identify areas where a more fundamental redesign is warranted.

AI will require planned, multi-year workforce transformation, not one-off training programs. From that perspective, reskilling must be treated as a core strategic capability, integrated with hiring, role design, and operating-model changes.

FIGURE 3.25 **How do you expect AI to affect your center's overall business model and cost-driven delivery structure by the end of 2030?** (%)

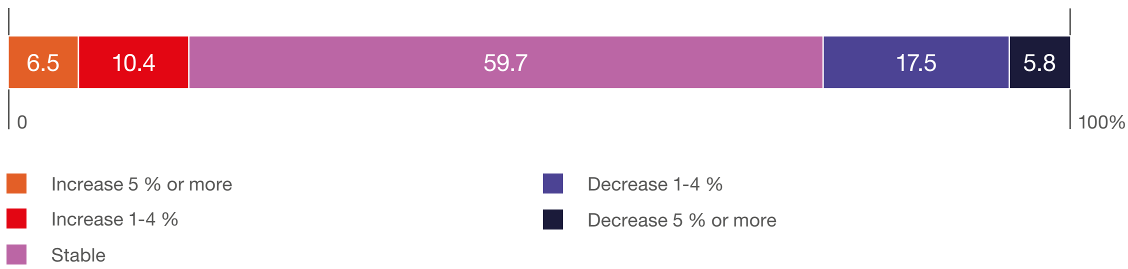


Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=171).

Reskilling needs are **broad but not universal.** The largest group of respondents (32.2%) expects 26-50% of the workforce to require reskilling or role changes, with another approximately 37.5% expecting more than half (51-75% or 75%+). Only a small minority (6.6%) sees a limited impact (up to 10%). This points to a **system-wide adjustment** that affects a substantial share of employees but not necessarily the entire organization.

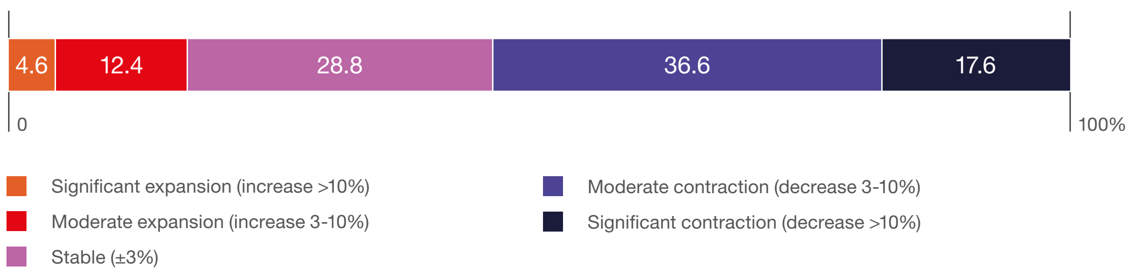
Reskilling is **concentrated on practical, execution-focused capabilities:** process automation (68.3%), AI operation/prompt engineering (66.1%), and data analytics (60.6%) dominate. Softer or supporting skills, namely communication (26.1%), project management (23.9%), and AI governance (13.9%), play a secondary role. This shows that organizations are prioritizing **skills that directly translate into deployment and productivity gains.**

FIGURE 3.26 **Expected impact of AI on employment levels within the next 12 months** (by the end of Q1 2027) (%)



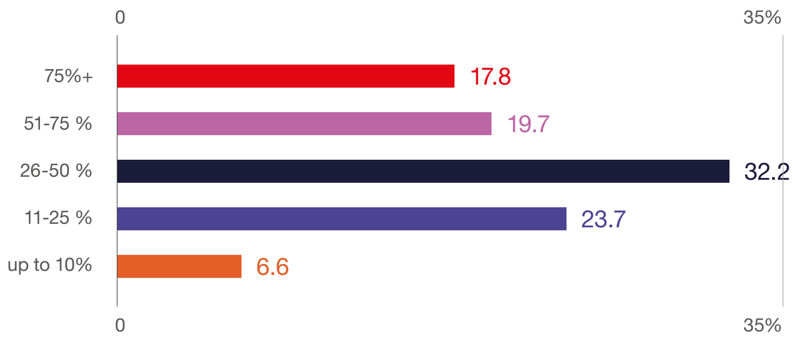
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=154).

FIGURE 3.27 **Expected overall impact of AI on employment in the center's sector in Poland by the end of 2030** (%)



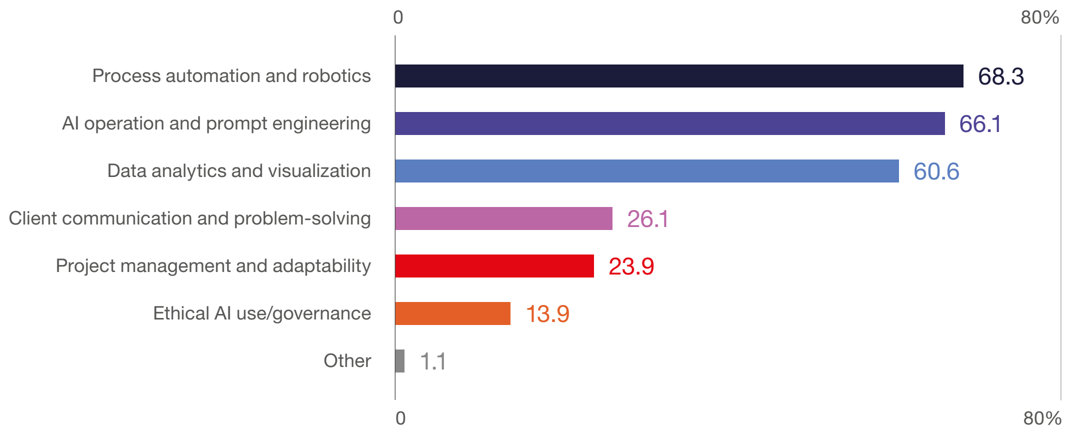
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=153).

FIGURE 3.28 **Share of the workforce that will require reskilling or role redefinition due to AI, by 2030** (%)



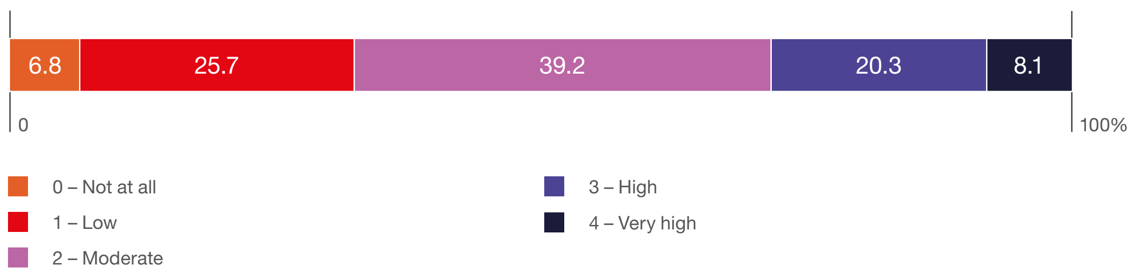
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=180). Reskilling refers to learning new skills to adapt to AI-enabled work, while role redefinition refers to changing job content and responsibilities as AI automates.

FIGURE 3.29 **Main skill areas targeted by reskilling initiatives** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=180).

FIGURE 3.30 **How likely is your headquarters to locate new AI-intensive functions in Poland?** (0-4 scale) (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=148).

Poland is a credible, though not yet leading, destination for AI-intensive work. There is an interest, but a strong commitment is limited. Securing new AI mandates will rely more on proven capabilities, talent, and readiness than on cost. Expectations are cautiously positive: 39.2% of respondents rate the likelihood as moderate, 28.4% as high or very high, and 32.5% remain skeptical.

Strengthening the talent pipeline in advanced technologies should be one of our priorities. Poland benefits from a strong and adaptable workforce; however, the next phase requires much closer alignment between business needs and education systems. This includes deeper collaboration between companies and universities, more targeted development of AI- and data-related skills, and faster scaling of specialized training programs. Building this pipeline is not only a long-term investment but a necessary condition for increasing Poland's credibility as a location for AI-intensive work and securing a larger share of future mandates.

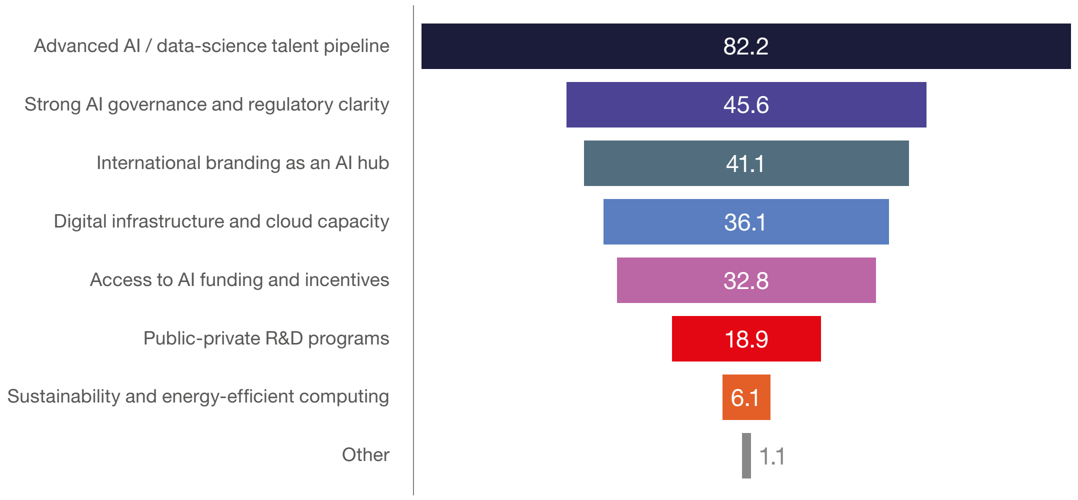
Location decisions for AI work are talent-first, as talent is the decisive factor. If Poland can sustain and scale its talent base, it remains highly competitive; if not, other advantages will not compensate.

An overwhelming 82.2% point to the AI/data science talent pipeline as the key enabler, far ahead of everything else. Secondary factors, such as governance clarity (45.6%), international positioning (41.1%), and infrastructure (36.1%), matter but are clearly supporting conditions. Funding (32.8%) and R&D programs (18.9%) play a more limited role, while sustainability plays a marginal role.

AI is CAPEX-heavy globally, but talent-constrained locally. The investment decision has already been made upstream (cloud, models, platforms). The location decision is downstream – where can we deploy it productively?

We will not become a global champion for several objective reasons, but at the level of individual firms and process transformation, we have a great deal to offer – and a great deal to do.

FIGURE 3.31 | **Three capabilities Poland should build to remain competitive in the AI era** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=180).

In this context, the competitiveness of AI-intensive services depends on two distinct but interconnected factors: access to scalable, high-performance digital infrastructure and the availability of talent capable of deploying and operating AI at scale.

In Europe, large-scale data center investment remains concentrated in the FLAP markets, that is, Frankfurt, London, Amsterdam, and Paris. These locations function as core infrastructure hubs, providing hyperscale capacity, dense cloud ecosystems, and low-latency connectivity required for compute-intensive AI workloads.

Poland operates within this architecture in a complementary but increasingly important role. While it is not yet a primary infrastructure hub, it is emerging as a leading location for **AI deployment, integration, and operationalization,** supported by strong talent and growing digital capacity.

These patterns reflect the structural dynamics of AI. Compute-heavy workloads tend to cluster in established infrastructure hubs, while implementation, scaling, and process integration are more geographically distributed. This creates a dual-layer model in which infrastructure and execution are increasingly decoupled.

For Poland, this is both a threat and an opportunity. The country is unlikely to replicate the scale of FLAP markets in the near term. However, it can strengthen its position as a **high-value execution and deployment hub** by linking talent and advanced service capabilities to access to European infrastructure.

For business services, this implies a transition to a network-based operating model, where competitiveness depends not only on hosting infrastructure but also on the ability to **connect, deploy, and scale AI solutions across distributed systems.**

> **I do not like it, and I am sorry I ever had anything to do with it.**
>
> **Erwin Schrödinger**

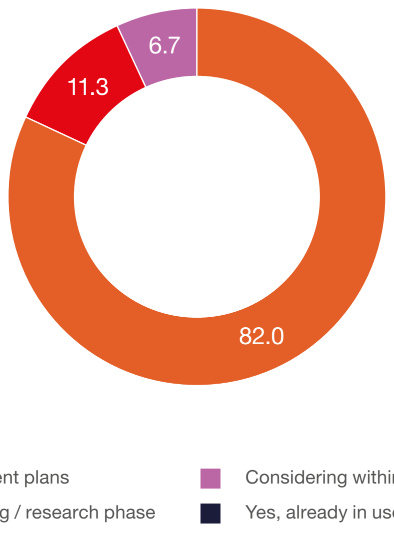
Beyond AI

Quantum computing is still outside the sector's operational horizon in Poland. The focus remains on scaling AI, where returns are tangible today. **Quantum seems to be long-term and experimental.** 82% of organizations have no current plans; only 11.3% are in the exploration phase, 6.7% expect to adopt it in the next 2-3 years, and virtually none already use it.

The environment surrounding the sector is, however, gradually changing. The Poznań Supercomputing and Networking Center (PCSS) has become a key quantum computing hub in Poland and Europe, with the launch of the PIAST-Q quantum computer in June 2025. This is the first installation within the European EuroHPC Joint Undertaking (EuroHPC JU), positioning Poznań as a leading European center in this field.

Adoption beyond AI is **focused on immediately applicable, complementary technologies:** advanced analytics (63.9%), natural language interfaces/chatbots (55.1%), and cloud (48.3%) dominate. IoT and digital twins are niche (12%), blockchain and quantum remain marginal. A quarter (24.5%) reports no additional technology.

FIGURE 3.32 | **Is your organization exploring or already using quantum computing or quantum-inspired technologies?** (%)

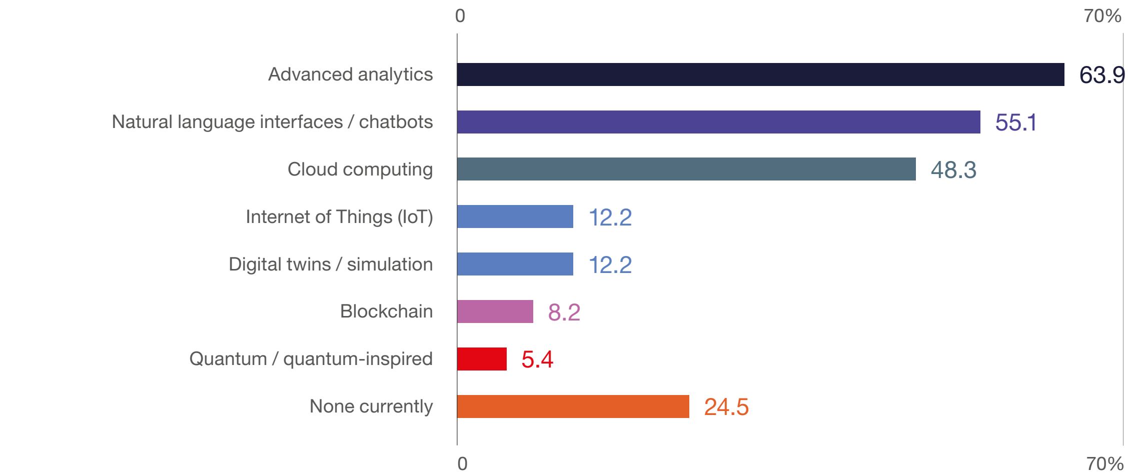


Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=150).

One in four centers is not yet adopting any advanced technology beyond AI. That implies the market is **bifurcated.** One group is building a broader digital stack around AI; another is still treating AI as the main, perhaps only, transformation agenda. This split likely reflects differences in scale, maturity, mandate, and sector exposure. Larger or more advanced centers are probably moving toward **platformized transformation;** others remain in a narrower automation-and-AI phase.

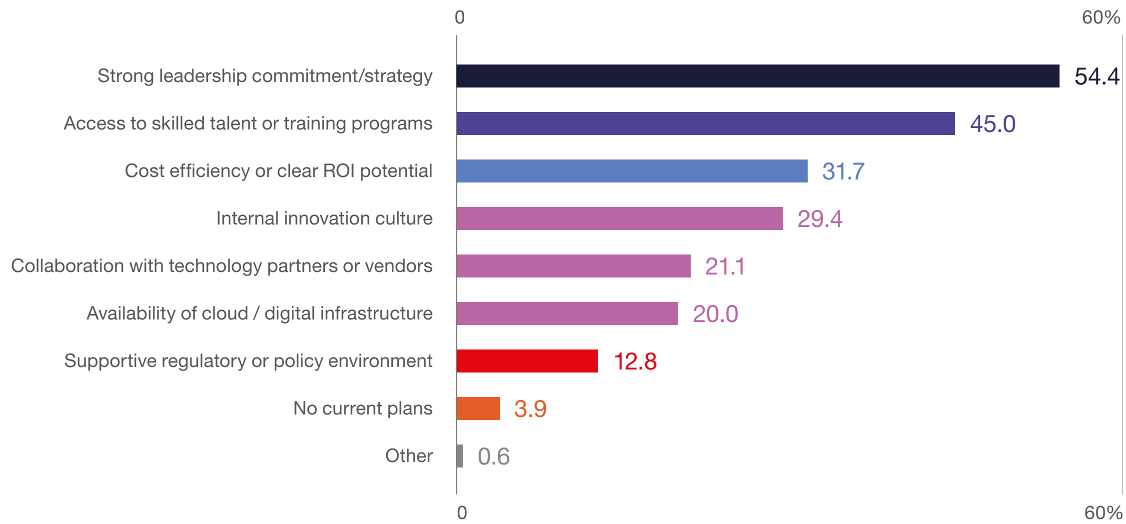
Internal factors primarily drive adoption. Strong leadership (54.4%) and access to skilled talent (45.0%) dominate, followed by ROI clarity (31.7%) and innovation culture (29.4%). Infrastructure (20.0%), partners (21.1%), and regulation (12.8%) play supporting roles. This shows that most organizations already have access to the necessary technology stack, but success depends on **strategic intent and execution capability.** Scaling advanced technologies is less about acquiring tools and more about **aligning leadership, talent, and business cases,** or in other words, the bottleneck is internal readiness, not external availability.

FIGURE 3.33 | **Beyond AI, which advanced technologies is your center adopting or considering?** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=164).

FIGURE 3.34 | **The main enablers for adopting these technologies** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=180).

> **With artificial intelligence, we are summoning the demon.**
>
> **Elon Musk**
> X, SpaceX, TESLA

Impact of AI on headcount from the perspective of 2030

The ABSL approach assesses the labor impact of AI through a bottom-up, process-level framework. The sector's employment structure is mapped across the two key dimensions – process complexity and value creation (as introduced in Chapter 1) and then adjusted using scenario-based transformation matrices that reflect automation, augmentation, and task reconfiguration.

This approach provides a robust **assessment of workforce transformation,** moving beyond basic extrapolation of productivity trends.

The methodology is based on four core assumptions:

AI adoption is uneven, with the strongest impact in standardized, rule-based, data-rich processes,

Process complexity and value moderate employment effects,

Organizational adoption lags technological potential,

New tasks and roles partially offset displacement.

AI's impact is measured through relative structural shifts using scenario-specific weighting matrices, and not by direct changes in absolute employment levels.

Given the rapid and unpredictable development of AI, a single baseline scenario is presented to illustrate the underlying mechanism. With that, we would like to provoke discussion among leaders and not give a definite answer.

AI impacts employment through three complementary channels: substitution, augmentation, and job creation. Technologies such as **RPA and IPA** primarily drive substitution in low-complexity, rule-based processes by automating repetitive tasks and reducing the need for manual execution. **Machine learning (ML)** and **GenAI** augment work in medium- and high-complexity activities. They enhance analytical capabilities, improve decision support, and raise productivity without fully replacing human roles.

> **At the same time, AI enables the creation of new jobs and functions, particularly in areas such as AI supervision, model governance, data engineering, process orchestration, and transformation management.**

The emergence of **agentic AI** has clearly accelerated this by enabling end-to-end workflow execution and coordination across systems, increasing demand for roles that design, oversee, and integrate autonomous processes. As a result, the net impact of AI is not a simple reduction in employment, but a structural reconfiguration of work, with job destruction, job augmentation, and new job creation occurring **simultaneously.**

The scenarios do not assume the emergence of Artificial General Intelligence (AGI) before 2030. They are based on an advanced yet bounded AI trajectory in which human judgment remains critical, and transformation occurs through the gradual recomposition of work.

The scenario distinguishes between current AI systems and emerging agentic capabilities. Today's **GenAI** mainly improves productivity at the task level by supporting content generation, analysis, and decision preparation. This results in incremental efficiency gains and partial automation, especially in low- and medium-complexity processes. **Agentic AI, still in early adoption, enables more autonomous, multi-step workflow execution and system coordination.**

Our baseline scenario anticipates **a gradual expansion of agentic capabilities in selected processes, leading to greater work recomposition, particularly in the operational middle layer.**

The base scenario introduces a **clear structural gradient within the value chain.** It nonetheless assumes broad, deliberate adoption of AI.

Low-complexity work is significantly reduced (0.10-0.50)[1], as automation becomes widespread in standardized processes. Mid-complexity activities show mixed dynamics (0.50-1.10), combining efficiency-driven compression with selective augmentation. High-complexity, high-value segments expand more visibly (up to 1.30), capturing the scaling effect of AI on expert work, new services, and increased demand for advanced capabilities.

Our baseline scenario represents a **balanced transformation. Automation** at the lower levels of complexity, consolidation and augmentation in the middle, and expansion at the top.

Net impact on jobs by 2030: approximately **-10 to -15%.**

AI leads to a **controlled structural reset of the sector's labor model, and not as a sudden and extremely disruptive employment shock.**

[1] 0.10 means that 90% of jobs will be eliminated, 1.15 means that 15% more jobs in comparison to the present state will be created.

TABLE 3.2 **Base scenario – AI impact matrix with respect to 2030**

	Low Value	Medium Value	High Value
Low Complexity	0.10	0.25	0.50
Medium Complexity	0.50	0.90	1.10
High Complexity	0.90	1.10	1.30

Source: ABSL BI.

As a point of reference, in the ABSL Strategic Foresight in 2023, we predicted a potential 33% contraction in FTEs in Poland due to AI by 2030. In hindsight, we underestimated the potential for job creation versus job destruction, as well as the barriers and bottlenecks to AI adoption.

This conceals a deeper transformation:

Low-complexity work is systematically eliminated,

Mid-layer delivery is compressed to a certain extent through productivity gains,

High-complexity, high-value work expands as new jobs are created.

AI reduces the need for execution scale and increases demand for expertise, judgment, and domain-specific capabilities. The sector is not losing relevance; it is **moving up the value chain,** with fewer FTE delivering more sophisticated outcomes.

Our estimates of impact vs. survey perception

Survey responses suggest a significantly more pessimistic outlook:

54.2% of firms expect contraction,

17.0% expect expansion,

28.8% expect stability.

This contrasts with the scenario analysis, which suggests a **more moderate and structurally balanced outcome.**

The difference reflects what each approach captures. The **survey reflects perception under uncertainty,** often overweighting visible automation risks and short-term disruption. Our **model accounts for structural constraints and offsets,** including implementation challenges, demand effects, and the expansion of high-value work.

These perspectives are not contradictory; they describe different layers of the same transition.

While firms anticipate disruption, the model indicates that this results in **reallocation instead of collapse.**

The core challenge for CXOs is not reducing headcount but **managing the transition.**

It implies that:

Reskilling must accelerate significantly,

Operating models need redesign, not optimization,

Centers must reposition from execution engines to AI-enabled capability hubs.

> **Success will favor those who upgrade quickly but thoughtfully, not those who reduce headcount most quickly.**

The scenario presented reflects the sector's transformation from traditional GBS to GBS 2.0 and, ultimately, to GenBS. In the GBS phase, value came from scale, standardization, and cost efficiency. GBS 2.0 brought greater integration, end-to-end process ownership, and a stronger focus on operational value. GenBS advances this by embedding AI into workflows and redesigning them, moving the focus from labor arbitrage to capability arbitrage, where competitive advantage depends on combining advanced analytics, domain expertise, and AI-enabled execution.

This trajectory aligns with survey results in Part 4, where the ABSL Transformation Cube shows ongoing progress in virtualization and personalization, while automation advances unevenly. The GenBS transition assessment further indicates that although more organizations are adopting AI-enabled, integrated models, the sector as a whole remains in a transitional phase. This supports the scenario logic: transformation is in progress but not uniform, with outcomes driven mainly by the speed and depth of adoption.

> **It is important to emphasize that the preceding analysis estimates the impact of AI under *ceteris paribus* (*"holding other factors constant"*) conditions.**

The net forecast for full-time equivalent (FTE) employment in the sector in Poland should also consider the following factors:

1. **Demand-side growth effects,** such as the expansion of global business services, increasing complexity of outsourced processes, and Poland's strategic position within nearshoring and EU-aligned business models,
2. **New investment inflows and reinvestment decisions,** which can increase employment independently of productivity gains, particularly in higher-value and knowledge-intensive functions,
3. **Structural adjustments in client demand,** including increased requirements for analytics, compliance, cybersecurity, and AI governance services, which generate additional employment even as automation advances,
4. **Organizational and adoption frictions,** such as regulatory constraints, risk management requirements, and limitations in change management, which delay the full realization of technological potential,
5. **Labor market dynamics,** particularly talent availability, wage pressures, and reskilling capacity, which condition both the pace and direction of workforce transformation,
6. **Task creation and role evolution,** as AI adoption leads to new categories of work related to supervision, integration, orchestration, and governance of intelligent systems; and finally,
7. **Macroeconomic and geopolitical conditions,** including growth in key export markets, fragmentation dynamics, and investment cycles, which may amplify or mitigate technology-driven employment effects.

The measure of intelligence is the ability to change.

Albert Einstein

Poland's competitive position will depend on its ability to attract and scale AI-intensive functions from global headquarters. This will require not only cost competitiveness, but also strong capabilities in talent, data, and execution.

Summary – key observations on technology

Technology and AI: From Efficiency to Operating Model Transformation

AI has shifted from marginal enhancement to the primary driver of operating model redesign. The sector now competes on capability and intelligence, leveraging data, domain expertise, and AI-enabled execution.

This transition is underway but uneven. Automation and generative AI are widely adopted, yet their impact is limited to specific processes. The sector is moving beyond experimentation, but full-scale transformation is still ahead. Organizations are advancing at varying speeds.

By 2030, AI will reshape delivery models, pricing, and value creation. This transformation will be gradual and execution focused. The key differentiator will be the ability to scale and integrate AI across processes, data, and organizational structures.

A new operating model aligned with the GenBS concept is emerging, defined by knowledge-intensive, AI-enabled, and integrated service provision. While not yet dominant, this approach is being adopted by more centers, though others remain in earlier stages of transformation. More on this in Part 4.

Productivity and Business Model Transformation

AI is already delivering measurable productivity gains in the sector, primarily through faster execution, improved quality, and enhanced decision support. The dominant impact at this stage is operational rather than structural. AI increases output per FTE before it reduces cost per FTE.

Value creation is gradually shifting upward. As repetitive tasks are automated, centers are reallocating resources toward more analytical, knowledge-intensive, and decision-oriented activities. This is reflected in the growing importance of medium- and high-value processes within the overall employment structure.

However, the transformation of business models remains incomplete. Most organizations are still improving efficiency within existing frameworks. A clear divide is emerging between centers moving toward value- and outcome-based models and those remaining focused on cost-driven delivery.

The next phase of transformation will depend on the ability to move beyond process optimization toward end-to-end redesign of services, supported by deeper AI integration.

Adoption and Technology Landscape

AI adoption is broad but remains uneven in depth and scale. While a large majority of centers use GenAI and automation tools, actual process coverage remains limited, with most AI deployments concentrated in high-volume, standardized activities.

The sector is entering a scaling phase. The challenge is now how to industrialize AI by integrating it across processes, systems, and workflows. This requires addressing data quality, legacy systems, and organizational readiness.

> **A clear technological pattern is emerging. GenAI and IPA currently dominate, delivering productivity gains at the task level. Agentic AI is emerging as the next stage, enabling more autonomous, multi-step workflow execution.**

This marks a move from task-level augmentation to workflow-level orchestration. Agentic capabilities are still in their early stages and have not yet been deployed at scale, so the sector operates in a hybrid state, combining mature tools with emerging technologies.

Beyond AI, the technology stack is consolidating around advanced analytics, natural language interfaces, and cloud infrastructure. The key differentiator is now the ability to integrate these tools into a coherent operating model.

Workforce and Skills Transformation

AI's impact on the workforce is already visible, but mainly compositional. In the short term, it is augmenting and redefining roles. We haven't observed large-scale job displacements. It seems that at this stage, organizations are shifting work to higher-value activities and reducing routine tasks.

In the medium term, structural adjustment is expected. By 2030, employment will likely decline due to productivity gains and process transformation. This change will be gradual and persistent, not sudden.

AI affects employment by substituting routine tasks, augmenting existing roles, and creating new functions. Automation reduces demand for low-complexity work but increases demand for skills in data, AI integration, process design, and transformation management.

Reskilling is a central strategic requirement. Many workers will need to adapt, though not all roles will be equally affected. The transformation is systemic but differentiated, with the greatest impact in the operational middle layer.

New roles are emerging that are not purely technical. The most valuable profiles combine technological knowledge with business and process expertise, reflecting the need to embed AI into real operating environments.

Governance, Execution, and Strategic Positioning

AI governance is rapidly becoming a standard component of operating models, with most organizations implementing or developing formal frameworks. Governance is no longer only a compliance requirement, but a prerequisite for scaling AI safely and effectively. The main challenge is not strategic intent or technology availability, but execution. Data quality, systems integration, and skills remain the key bottlenecks, placing leadership and talent at the center of transformation.

Organizational models are evolving from centralized, HQ-driven approaches toward more distributed and hybrid governance structures. As strategic direction-setting remains centrally anchored, value is increasingly created where AI is deployed, integrated, and embedded in **processes.**

This creates a new strategic dimension of **process sovereignty.** The transition is no longer from execution to strategy in abstract terms, but from fragmented delivery toward ownership of end-to-end processes, workflows, and decision logic. In this model, centers that take responsibility for integrating AI into core operations across processes, data, and decision-making move beyond execution and, in doing so, become **strategic nodes within global operating models.**

> **Differentiation will not be driven by technology choices, but by the ability to deploy AI consistently, at large scale, and with measurable impact across processes and workflows.**

Final Perspective

The business services sector in Poland is experiencing a gradual and uneven transformation, not a sudden disruption driven by technology. AI is already reshaping work, value creation, and operations, though its full impact is still unfolding.

The critical change is from automation to orchestration, efficiency to capability, and scale to intelligence. Success will favor those who upgrade fastest, not those who focus solely on reducing headcount.

> **It is not the strongest species that survives, nor the most intelligent, but the ones most responsive to change.**
>
> Charles Darwin

4

BUSINESS TRANSFORMATION

Introduction

Chapter 4 examines how Poland's business services sector is transforming in response to structural shifts in the global economy, technological disruption, and changing corporate operating models. Drawing on ABSL 2026 survey data, the analysis focuses on how organizations are redefining their service scope, business services models, and strategic positioning within global value chains. **The sector continues to expand and upgrade its capabilities, but in a more selective, efficiency-driven environment than in previous years.**

The chapter shows that growth is becoming driven by **capability deepening and not by geographic expansion.** Organizations focus on expanding service portfolios, embedding more advanced functions, and strengthening their role within global business services platforms. At the same time, we observe a gradual transition from traditional, internally focused SSC models to more hybrid and open operating models that are increasingly interconnected with external partners, technology providers, and sector-specific ecosystems. The transformation is not uniform. Most firms are investing in automation, digital tools, and reskilling, but organizational readiness, integration challenges, and economic pressures constrain the pace and depth of change.

The central theme of the chapter is the **reconfiguration of operating models,** as centers gradually move from traditional, process-driven structures toward more data-, analytics-, and AI-enabled models. This transition is captured through ABSL's Transformation Cube and operating model evolution – a trajectory

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Chapter content developed by: **ABSL**

Key transformation facts

Service scope expansion is the dominant trend. Over 65% of centers are expanding portfolios. Upgrading within global networks continues.

Growth is driven by capability deepening rather than geographic expansion. Product development outweighs market expansion, which marks a shift toward strengthening existing platforms.

The sector is undergoing a structural change in operating models. 70% of centers expect to move beyond traditional GBS toward digital and AI-enabled models by 2030.

Transformation is widespread but evolutionary, not disruptive. Most firms anticipate momentous change, but within existing operating constraints.

AI adoption is accelerating, but remains constrained by organizational, integration, and ROI barriers, and not by technology availability.

The sector is entering a productivity-cost tension, where efficiency gains are insufficient to clearly outpace rising labor and operating costs, creating a structural competitiveness risk.

Innovation is widespread but uneven. A large share of firms act as followers rather than leaders, thereby limiting their capacity for frontier innovation.

The primary response to global uncertainty is transformation, not downsizing, driven by automation, reskilling, and a move toward higher-value services.

Perceived resilience is rising but may reflect delayed adjustment instead of fully tested readiness, with gaps in execution of business continuity frameworks.

Poland’s competitive position is shifting toward value-for-cost, and is pressured by rising costs, talent shortages, and intensifying global competition.

that is evolutionary in pace but structural in direction. It reflects a broader system-level change, in which centers move from executing internally defined services toward co-creating and integrating value across organizational and sectoral boundaries. The sector is not undergoing abrupt disruption, but rather a systematic reallocation of value from labor-intensive activities toward knowledge- and technology-intensive services. How many of our centers are already at the GenBS phase of development?

The broader context of this transformation is defined by rising labor and operating costs, persistence of existing but declining talent shortage, particularly in selected sectors or skill areas, geopolitical uncertainty, and accelerating technological change. These forces are reshaping the sector's growth model and competitive dynamics, exerting pressure on productivity and operational efficiency. The chapter, therefore, examines not only how organizations are transforming but also the extent to which these changes are sufficient to sustain competitiveness in a more demanding global environment.

Finally, the chapter assesses Poland's evolving position within the global business services landscape. The country continues to offer a strong value-for-cost proposition, supported by skilled talent and operational stability; however, its competitive position is challenged by cost pressures and intensifying global competition. Future success will depend less on scale and cost advantages, but more on the ability to generate productivity gains, develop advanced capabilities, and effectively integrate AI into operating models.

Transformation reality check

The business services sector in Poland is undergoing a broad-based transformation, but its nature is frequently misinterpreted. This is a controlled, capability-driven evolution. Most organizations are expanding service scope by investing in automation and upgrading their models, yet these changes are occurring within existing operational structures. Growth is no longer driven by geographic expansion or scale, but by deepening capabilities within established platforms and integrating more advanced, knowledge-intensive functions into global networks.

Beneath this gradual trajectory, a more fundamental shift is emerging. Operating models are being reconfigured toward data-, analytics-, and AI-enabled structures. **The sector faces pressure from rising costs, talent limitations, and intensifying global competition. Productivity gains remain moderate and often insufficient to offset these pressures and create a growing tension between cost dynamics and value creation.** As a result, **the sector has entered a transition phase in which transformation is not optional but necessary,** and **where the key challenge is no longer whether to transform, but how quickly organizations can realign their operating models, capabilities, and governance to remain competitive.**

It is also worth noting that we not only have the opportunity but, in fact, the necessity to redefine ourselves, experiment, and propose new models.

Adjustments in the growth model

Ansoff, product-market expansion matrix

The Ansoff matrix, also known as the product-market expansion matrix, is a management strategy tool that companies use to analyze and plan their growth strategies. Among its four strategic options, market penetration is considered the least risky. Diversification, involving the provision of new services in new markets, is the most complex and challenging.

The sector's growth model is **shifting from geographic expansion to capability deepening.** The dominant strategy is **to expand service**

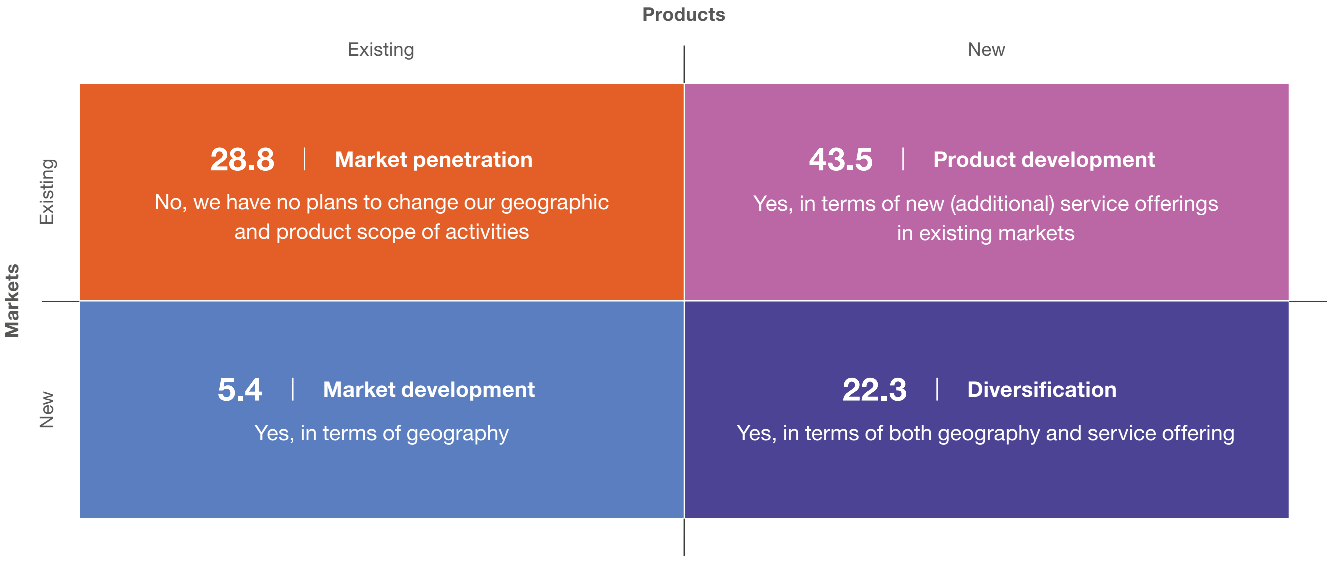
> **Always deliver more than expected.**
>
> Larry Page
> Google

offerings within existing markets (43.5%). Growth is increasingly driven by **broadening capabilities and strengthening existing client relationships.**

A significant share of organizations **(28.8%)** is pursuing **operational consolidation,** with no planned changes to market or service scope. This is a more **selective, efficiency-oriented approach to growth,** where optimization of existing platforms takes precedence over expansion.

Geographic growth is **marginal.** Only **5.4% of firms plan to enter new markets.** Diversification strategies are declining **(22.3%),** which may indicate the sector is moving away from **scale-driven expansion toward capability-driven development.**

FIGURE 4.1 | **Plans to expand the scope of activities over the next 12 months** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=184).

Changes in the scope of services

The analysis of the centers' service scope points to **expansion.** A majority of respondents (57.5%) declare that the scope of services delivered has expanded, and an additional 8.6% report a significant expansion. **Thus, over two-thirds of organizations experienced growth in their service portfolios.**

28.0% of respondents declared that their service scope remained unchanged. Reductions in service scope are reported rarely (4.3%), and only 1.6% experienced a significant reduction.

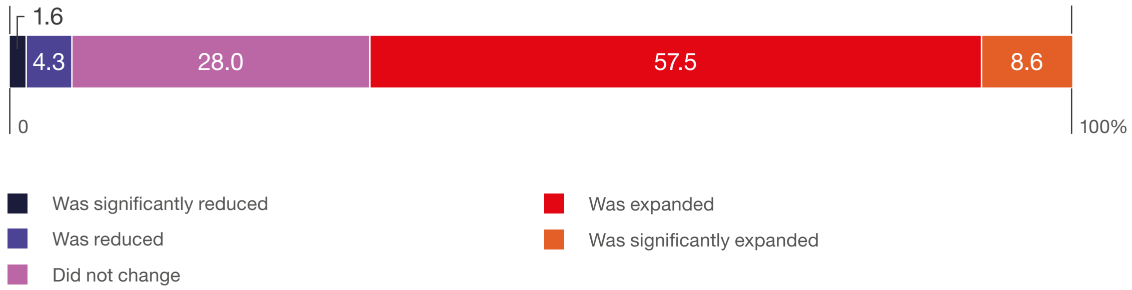
This is a critical signal. It confirms that the sector is not in a phase of consolidation or defensive adjustment but is actively **repositioning toward broader and more complex service delivery.**

The expansion of scope reflects a growing awareness that future competitiveness depends on taking on more advanced functions, integrating capabilities, and moving beyond narrowly defined roles within global organizations.

Reaction to industry-wide adjustments

Over the past twelve months, the sector has shifted into a **mode of controlled adjustment,** driven by a combination of cost pressure, geopolitical risk, and accelerating technological change. The response is not defensive restructuring, but **selective optimization and capability upgrading.** Organizations prioritize efficiency over expansion.

FIGURE 4.2 **Changes to the scope of services provided in 2025, compared to the previous year** (%)



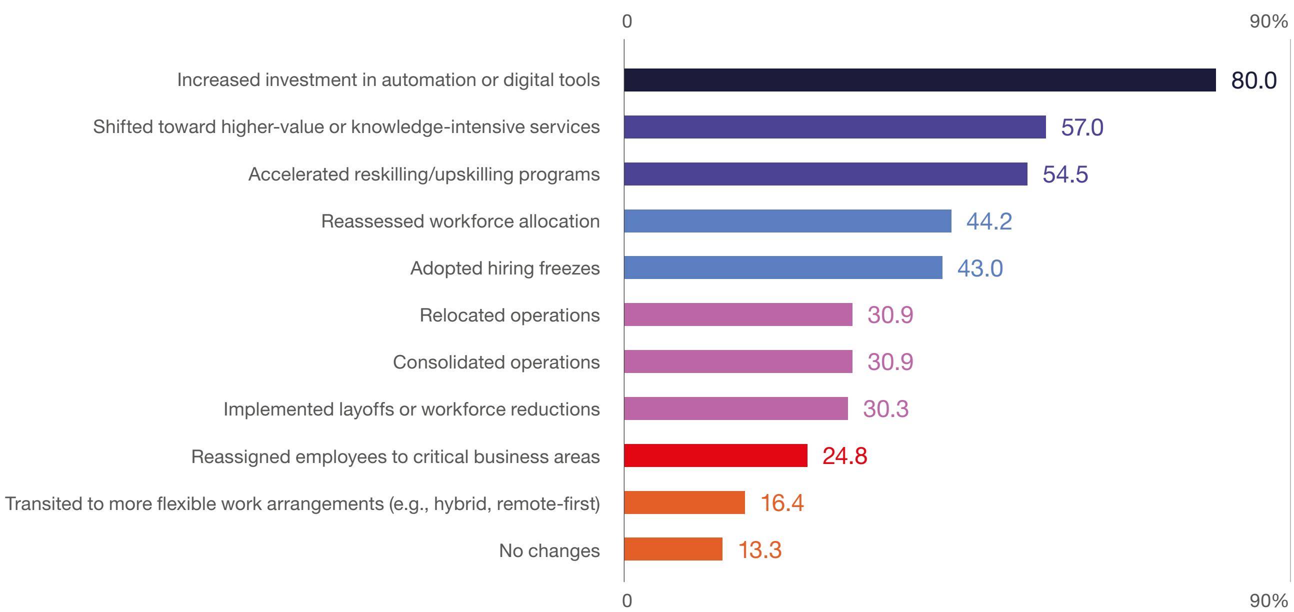
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=186).

The dominant response is **technology investment. 80.0% of firms increase spending on automation and digital tools.** This confirms that productivity improvement and operational resilience are pursued primarily through **technology-enabled transformation.** We observe a move toward more complex, knowledge-intensive services. At the same time, **57.0% of firms are moving toward higher-value services**, and **54.5% are accelerating reskilling.**

Workforce strategy reflects this transition. Talent shortages are a serious structural issue, but their severity is declining. Pressure on hiring has moderated, and firms concentrate on **internal optimization.** This is evident in workforce reallocation (44.2%) and hiring freezes (43.0%), which mark a more disciplined approach to headcount growth and a stronger emphasis on productivity.

More structural adjustments are present but not dominant. Around **one-third of organizations report consolidation, relocation, or workforce reduction.** There is targeted cost optimization. Changes in working models are marginal **(16.4%),** hybrid arrangements have largely stabilized and are no longer a primary adjustment lever.

FIGURE 4.3 **Changes implemented in response to industry-wide adjustments over the last 12 months in Poland and globally** (% of respondents)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=165).

Productivity vs costs balancing

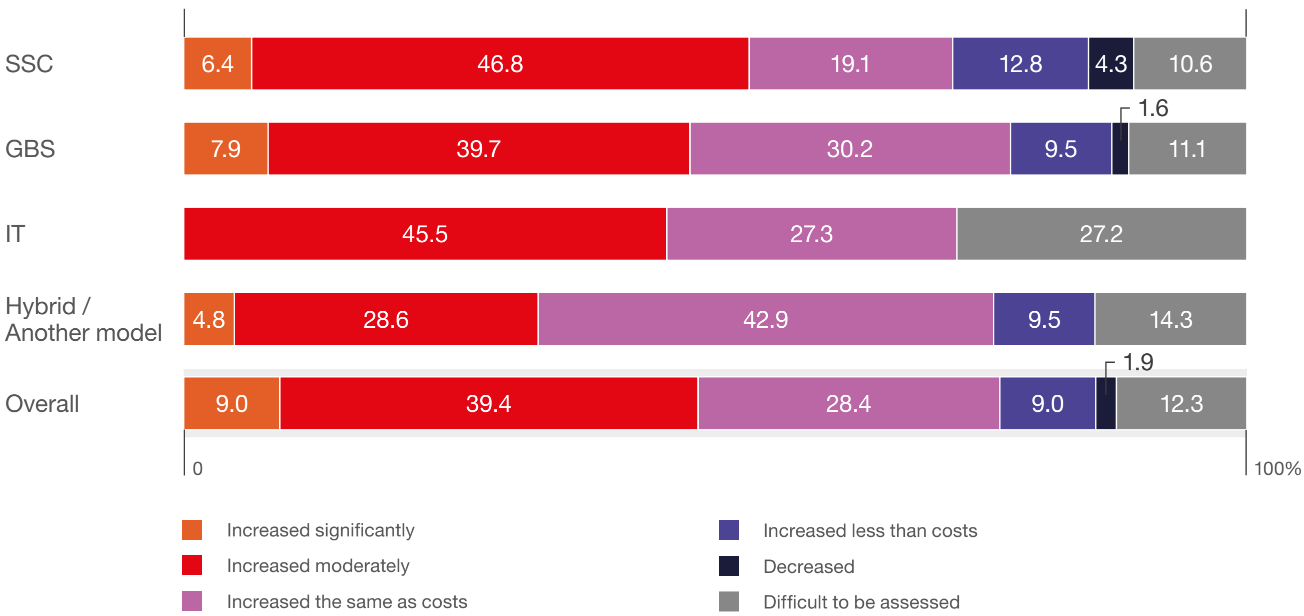
Productivity is the main driver of competitiveness. As labor and operating costs rise, the ability to achieve productivity gains that outpace cost growth will determine if Poland can maintain its value-for-cost position.

The data indicates this condition is not yet widespread. Most firms (39.4%) report only moderate productivity improvement. 28.4% see productivity growth that matches the rate of cost increases. **Only 9.0% achieve gains that exceed cost growth.** This shows that **most organizations are maintaining cost efficiency instead of building a deeper, long-term competitive advantage.**

Productivity gains are primarily incremental, driven by process optimization, selective automation, and organizational adjustments rather than by major transformations. Measurement challenges persist – 12.3% of firms are unable to assess productivity, especially in complex, project-based settings.

Differences in operating models support this trend. SSC and GBS centers report stronger productivity. Over half of SSCs see moderate or significant gains, likely due to better alignment of scale, standardization, and efficiency. Hybrid centers more often perceive changes in productivity as only keeping pace with costs (42.9%). In IT, productivity is harder to measure (27.3% are unable to assess it).

FIGURE 4.4 | **In relation to the cost increase in the services provided by your center, the productivity/efficiency** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=155). Due to the small number of responses, the chart does not show results for BPO and R&D centers. The responses of these centers are, however, included in the overall calculation.

Innovation rate and scope in the sector

To stay globally competitive, Poland's sector must continue to evolve toward higher-value, knowledge-intensive roles, particularly in front- and mid-office functions, while leveraging its strategic time zone, EU membership, and strong value-for-cost positioning.

The sector demonstrates **consistently high innovation activity,** but the latest results reveal that this innovation is **broad but** often **incremental rather than disruptive.**

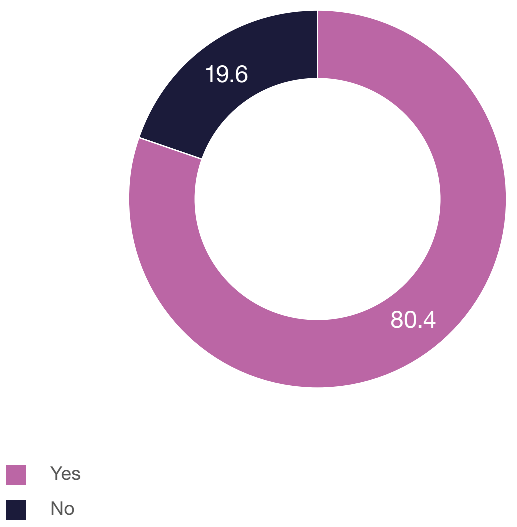
Product innovation in services involves:

introducing significant improvements in how services are provided,

adding new functions or features to existing services,

introducing completely new services.

FIGURE 4.5 **Have you introduced innovation(s) (integrated products / services) in the three preceding years (2023-2025)?** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=153).

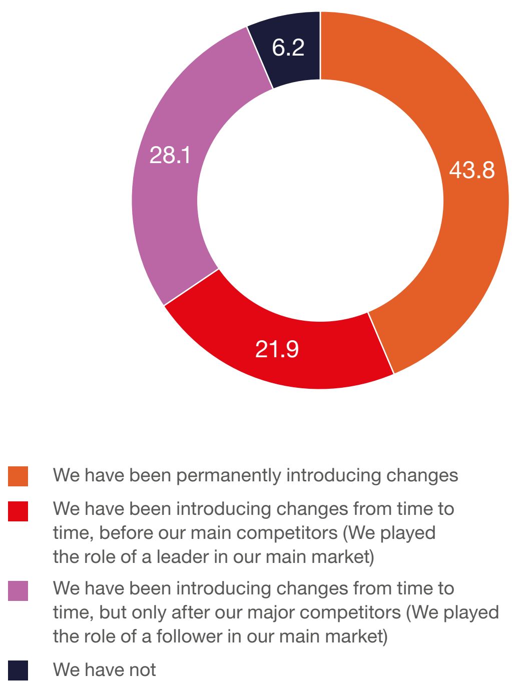
Business process innovation, in turn, refers to the introduction of new or improved processes within one or more business functions that significantly change previously used approaches.

In the latest survey, **80.4% of companies reported introducing innovations (integrated products/services) in 2023-2025, up from 74.4% in the previous edition.** This confirms that innovation activity is **widespread and structurally embedded in the sector,** and that it significantly exceeds national benchmarks.

According to Statistics Poland (GUS 2025, for 2022–2024), **32.8% of industrial enterprises and 26.6% of service enterprises** reported engaging in innovative activity, with large service firms (250+ employees) reporting **22.8% product innovation and 59.4% process innovation.**

Our sector shows above the mean innovation characteristics. It demonstrates a strong commitment to continuous improvement and adaptation.[1]

FIGURE 4.6 **During the last three years (2023 to 2025), have you introduced smaller or major changes in your product, product range, processes, or organization of business?** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=146).

[1] GUS (2025) *Działalność innowacyjna przedsiębiorstw w Polsce w latach 2022–2024*, GUS.

However, when examining the nature and **intensity of innovation,** the picture becomes more nuanced. **43.8% of firms report continuous (permanent) introduction of changes, and 21.9% position themselves as initiative-taking leaders introducing changes ahead of competitors. 28.1% function as followers,** adopting changes after market leaders. **6.2% report no meaningful changes**.

The sector is **highly active in innovation, but uneven in its strategic positioning.** A substantial share of firms is engaged in **continuous improvement and adaptation.** Yet, only a smaller group operates as true innovation leaders, while a large segment remains **reactive,** following global trends and not setting or creating them.

Poland's business services sector demonstrates above-average innovation intensity, with strong capabilities in process optimization, digital transformation, and service enhancement. The analysis indicates that the next stage of development will require a transition from **broad-based, incremental innovation toward more initiative-taking, leading-edge innovation strategies,** particularly in areas driven by AI, data, and integrated service models.

Our firms are entering a new phase of competition at the global technological frontier. Unlocking its full potential requires continued evolution of leadership, supported by collaboration, capability building, and shared learning.

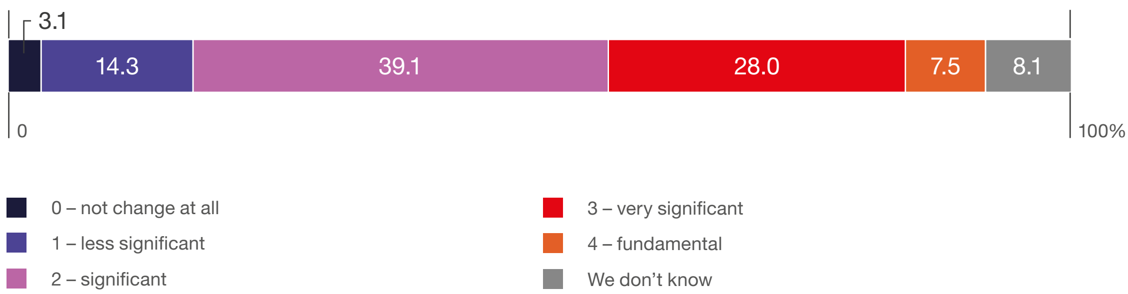
Depth of transformation

Most centers expect **meaningful changes to their business models within five years,** with about two-thirds anticipating significant transformation. However, few expect true disruption, and many organizations foresee only incremental change or remain uncertain about their future direction.

This reveals a gap between the recognized **need for transformation and the expected pace of change.** The sector understands its operating model must evolve, but it is not preparing for rapid, disruptive shifts. For CXOs, this poses a **strategic risk,** as transformation is viewed as gradual while key drivers such as AI, cost pressure, and competition are accelerating.

Current expectations may be **conservative compared to the actual pressure for transformation.** The main question is whether organizations are **underestimating the speed and scale of change, especially as they evolve** toward data- and AI-driven operating models.

FIGURE 4.7 **Expected significance of business model transformation of your center(s) in five years vs. the current model** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=161).

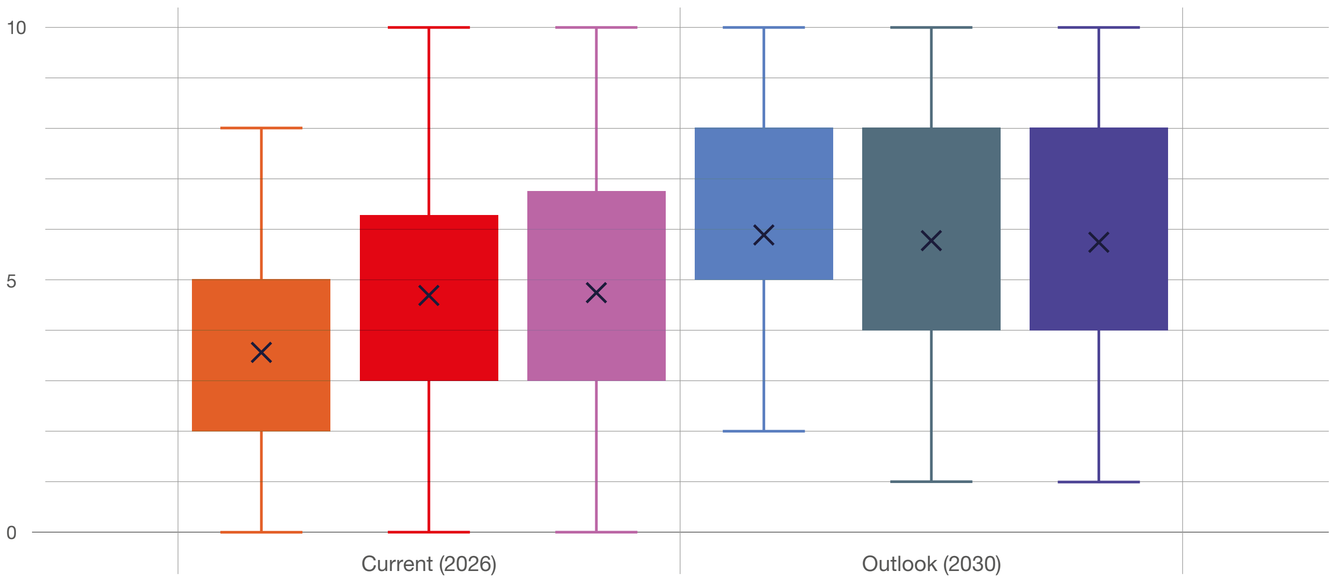
ABSL Transformation cube

> **Without deviation from the norm, progress is not possible.**
>
> Frank Zappa

Referring to the ABSL Transformation Cube, a core framework from ABSL Industry Foresight 2023, respondents were asked to assess their current **(Q1 2026)** and projected **(Q1 2030)** business models across three key dimensions: automation, virtualization, and service personalization.

The **2025 and 2026 results confirm a continuation of steady, incremental evolution rather than acceleration** in these areas. Managers still report **greater maturity in virtualization and personalization than in AI-driven automation,** with current automation levels remaining comparatively lower **(approx. 3.5 on average)** than those for virtualization and personalization **(approx. 4.7-4.8).** Nonetheless, they continue to express **clear but measured expectations of progress toward 2030,** with all three dimensions converging at higher levels **(approx. 5.8-5.9 on average).**

FIGURE 4.8 **How do you assess your current business model along the three dimensions of the ABSL transformation cube, and where do you see yourself in 2030?**



- **Degree of automation / depth of artificial intelligence** (0 – basic to 10 fully automated)
- **Degree of virtualization of your office / working model** (0 – basic to 10 fully virtual)
- **Degree of personalization (tailoring) of services on offer (the main product on offer),** 0 – basic personalization (standardized product) to 10 – full personalization (hyper-personalized product)
- **Degree of automation/ depth of artificial intelligence** (0 – basic to 10 fully automated)
- **Degree of virtualization of your office / working model** (0 – basic to 10 fully virtual)
- **Degree of personalization (tailoring) of services on offer (the main product on offer),** 0 – basic personalization (standardized product) to 10 – full personalization (hyper-personalized product)

Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=143).

Automation is **increasing, but not yet at a transformative scale.** AI-enabled workflows are being adopted; however, their depth remains constrained by integration, cost, and organizational readiness. Virtualization trends **are stable;** the hybrid model has reached equilibrium. Service personalization **deepens gradually,** marking sustained demand for tailored, client-specific solutions without a step change in business models.

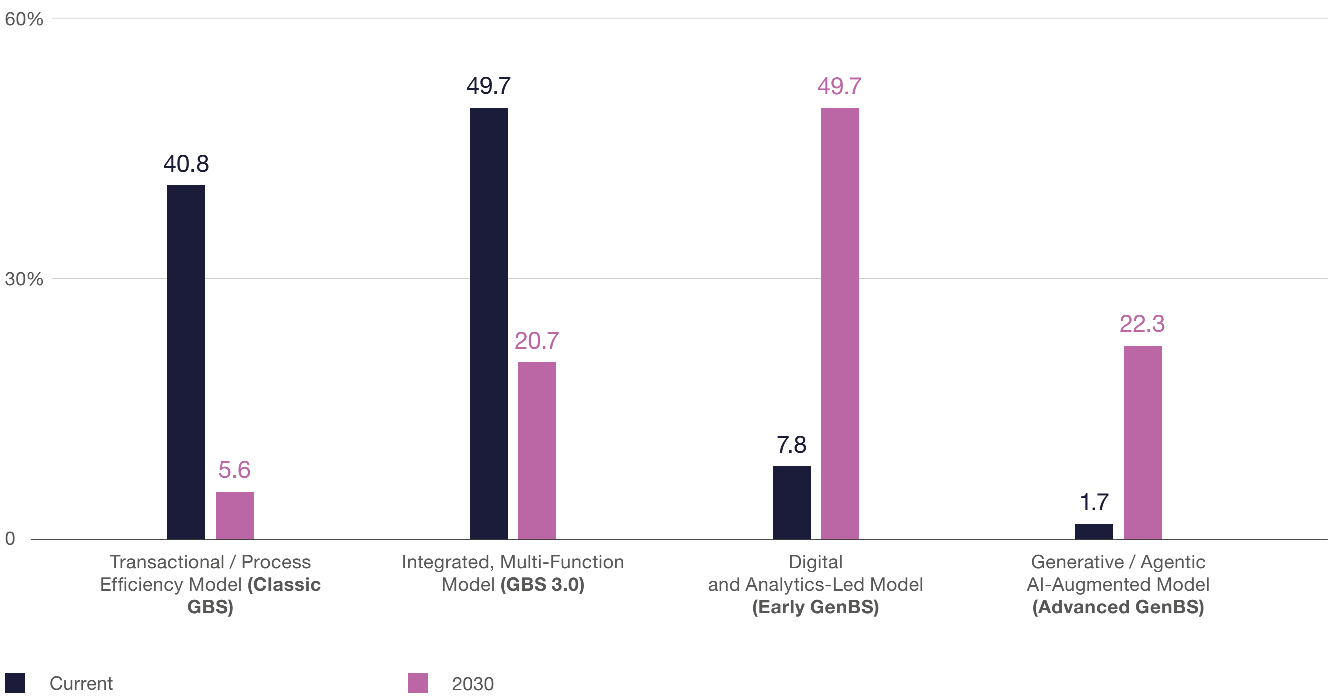
Looking ahead to 2030, companies anticipate a **more balanced progression throughout all three dimensions.** There is a move towards a business model that is **more automated, moderately more virtual, and more personalized – but still anchored in existing operating structures.**

The sector's current transformation path is **evolutionary and capability-driven, not disruptive.** We face practical challenges around legacy systems, delivery commitments, cultural barriers, and investment cycles. There is no indication so far of a rapid change toward fully autonomous or hyper-automated models.

On the way to GenBS

GenBS (Generative Business Services) is the next-generation operating model of the business services industry, defined by the deep integration of AI-native workflows, autonomous agents, data-intensive platforms, and domain-specialized expertise across both horizontal and vertical service lines. GenBS is an innovation-focused capability center that enables the parent corporation's transformation and fuels clients' transformation.

FIGURE 4.9 **Description that best fits your current operating model, and in 2030** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=178).

The distribution of operating models shows a **structural transition underway, not a smooth evolution.** The sector is anchored in legacy models. **40.8% of centers operate in a transactional (classic GBS) setup, and 49.7% operate in an integrated, multi-function GBS (GBS 3.0).** More advanced models are marginal, with only **7.8% in digital and analytics-led setups and 1.7% in AI-augmented models.**

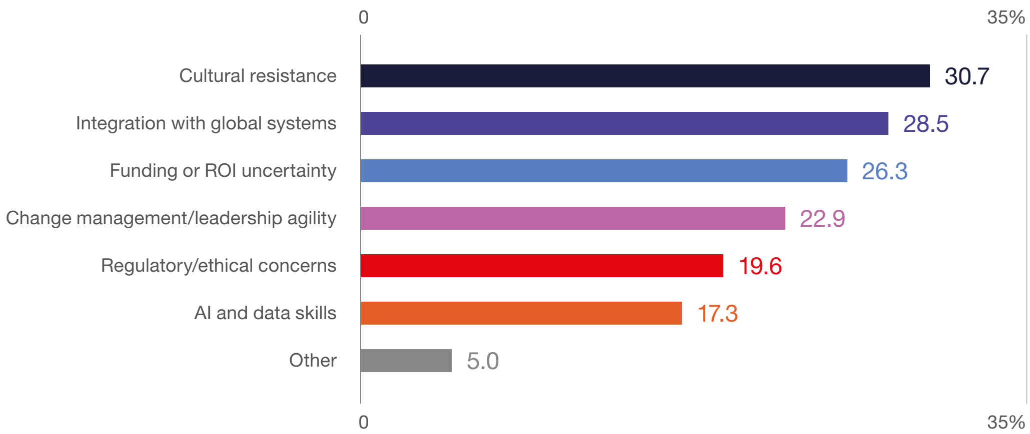
By 2030, however, according to our respondents, this structure **flips rather than shifts.** The transactional model nearly disappears (5.6%), and the integrated GBS model is **more than halved to 20.7%. GBS 3.0 is not the end state but a transitional phase.** At the same time, the **digital and analytics-led model becomes dominant, accounting for 49.7%. AI-augmented models scale to 22.3%,** moving from a niche to a material share.

This is not incremental, upgrading – it is **model substitution.** The sector is effectively reallocating from labor- and process-driven delivery to data-centric, **AI-enabled operating models. 70% of respondents expect to operate beyond traditional GBS structures by 2030.**

The results suggest that the traditional GBS model, aligned with integrated, multi-function GBS, will not disappear but will **lose its dominant position and become a transitional layer in the operating model stack.** As 70% of centers move toward digital, analytics-led, and AI-augmented models by 2030, the core logic of scale, labor arbitrage, and process integration faces structural erosion, as value increasingly moves toward data, algorithms, and automation. Thus, the centers will either **reposition as internal transformation and AI platforms** or gradually **lose strategic relevance and revert to cost-focused units,** with their future determined less by location and more by their ability to absorb and operationalize AI.

The barriers to GenBS transition are **not primarily technical; they are organizational and structural.** Gaps in AI and data skills (17.3%) and regulatory concerns (19.6%) are present but clearly secondary to **cultural resistance (30.7%), integration with global systems (28.5%), and funding/ROI uncertainty (26.3%),** which dominate the landscape. The transition is less about acquiring new capabilities and more about **reconfiguring how organizations operate, decide, and invest.** The prominence of change management and leadership agility (22.9%) further reinforces that the bottleneck sits at the management layer, not the execution layer. From a CXO perspective, this reframes GenBS not as a technology adoption problem, but as a **governance, capital allocation, and organizational alignment challenge,** where the ability to overcome internal inertia and integrate into global architectures will determine whether transformation materializes.

FIGURE 4.10 | **The key capability gaps limiting GenBS transition** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=179).

Resilience

Drivers of change in the sector

As in previous years, this survey examined a broad range of potential drivers of change through a PESTLE lens (political, economic, social, technological, legal, and environmental factors). Respondents were asked to assess the expected impact of these factors on business activities in Poland over the next twelve months (Q1 2027 perspective).

The results point out that economic pressure remains the most significant concern. **Rising labor costs in Poland and Central Europe are perceived as the most adverse factor** (nine out of ten respondents reported a negative impact). Similarly, **rising overall business costs, persistent talent shortages in selected sectors or skill areas, and the risk of macroeconomic destabilization are widely viewed as major challenges** for the coming year. Concerns about a potential global recession or financial crisis remain strong. They reinforce the perception that economic uncertainty impacts the centers' operations.

Geopolitical factors rank high on the risk perception list. Their impact, however, appears more differentiated than in previous years. The potential **escalation of the military conflict beyond Ukraine is still regarded as a significant concern.** Other geopolitical tensions – including conflicts in the Middle East or tensions in the Taiwan Strait – are perceived as neutral factors in the sector's short-term operational outlook.

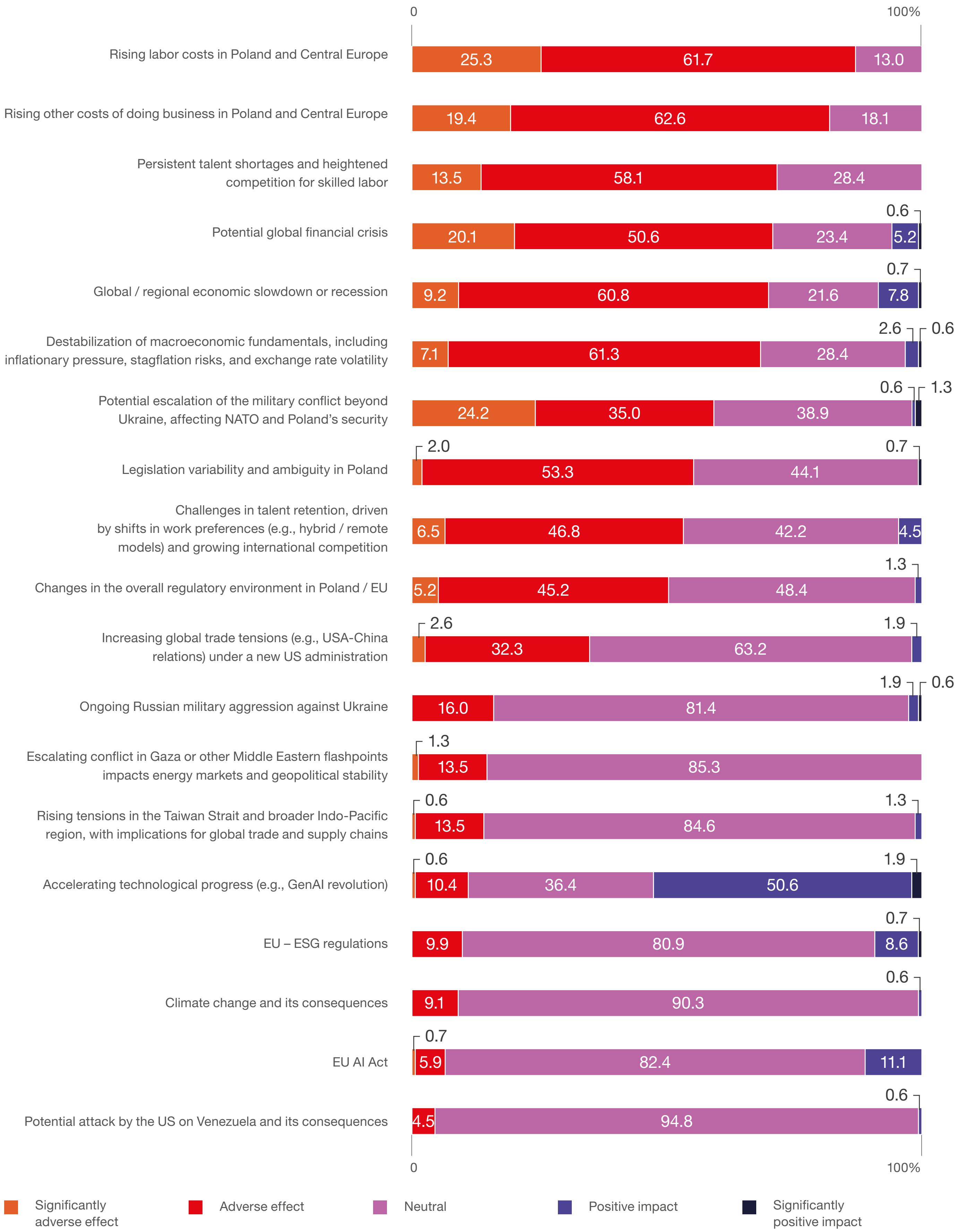
> **The biggest risk is not taking any risk.**
>
> **Mark Zuckerberg**

Regulatory developments present a more mixed picture. Changes in the regulatory environment in Poland and the European Union, as well as legislative variability, are viewed with caution, with a noticeable share of respondents expecting negative impacts. **At the same time, the EU AI Act and ESG-related regulations are seen as neutral or moderately positive.** Respondents view these frameworks as part of the evolving regulatory landscape and not as immediate operational threats.

Technological progress stands out as the only factor with a positive perception. Accelerating technological development – particularly the rapid adoption of genAI – is seen as a significant opportunity.

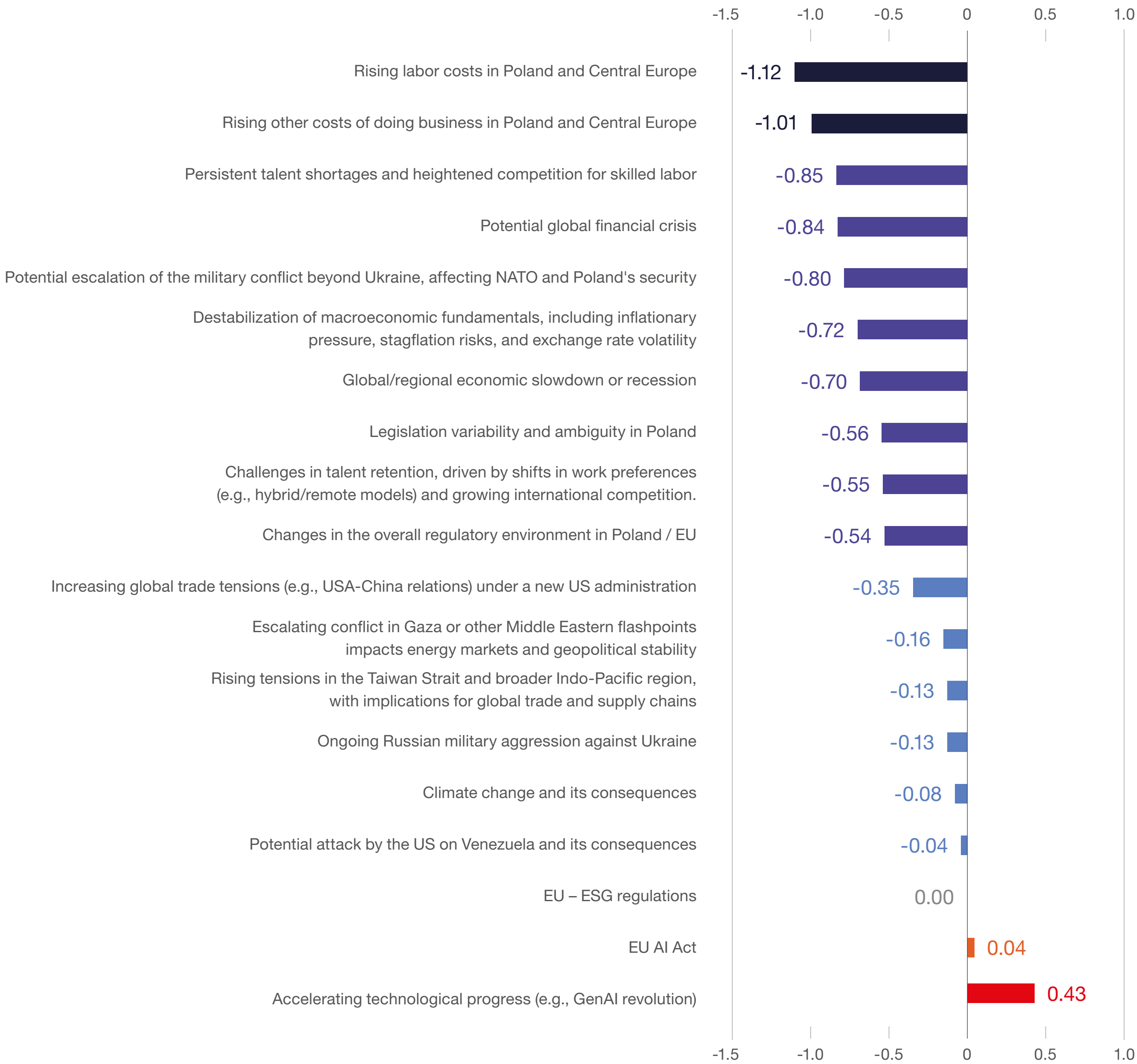
> **Environmental and sustainability-related factors, including climate change and ESG regulations, are treated primarily as neutral in the short-term business outlook. Organizations recognize the strategic importance of sustainability, but these factors are not yet viewed as immediate operational disruptors.**

FIGURE 4.11 | **Expected impact of the following factors on activity in Poland until the end of Q1 2027** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=160).

FIGURE 4.12 **Expected impact of the following factors on activity in Poland until the end of Q1 2027** (mean of indications)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=160).

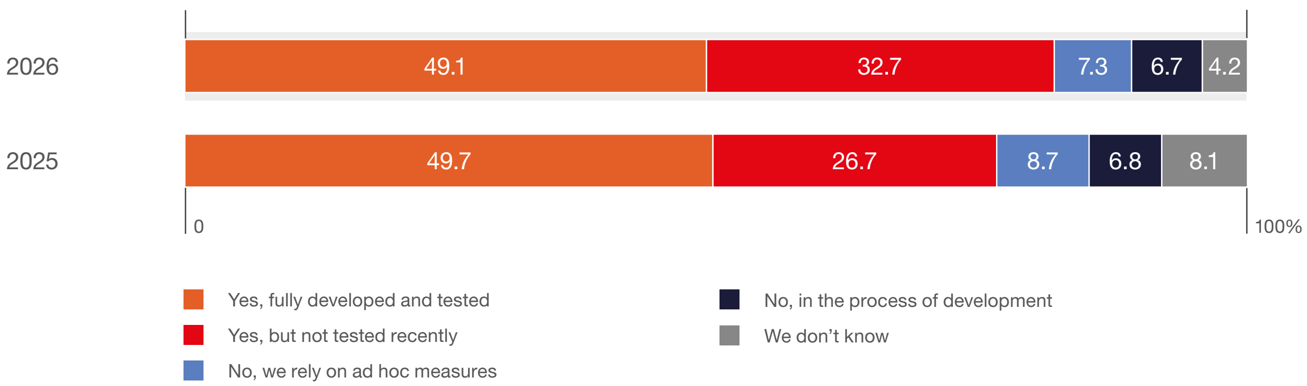
Business continuity plans

A majority (81.8%) of organizations have a business continuity plan to address geopolitical or macroeconomic disruptions, though only half (49.1%) have fully developed and tested frameworks. **32.7% had plans in place but had not assessed them recently,** which could undermine their practical resilience. 13.9% either had no plans or relied on ad hoc responses, revealing potential exposure to unmanaged risks.

Compared with the previous year, **the overall share of organizations with continuity plans has slightly increased.** Risk awareness strengthens.

The growing proportion of plans that have not been tested recently implies that many organizations may still be **adapting their resilience frameworks to evolving geopolitical and economic risks.**

FIGURE 4.13 | **Formalized business continuity plans to address geopolitical or macroeconomic disruptions** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=165).

Adaptation to recent geopolitical or macroeconomic challenges

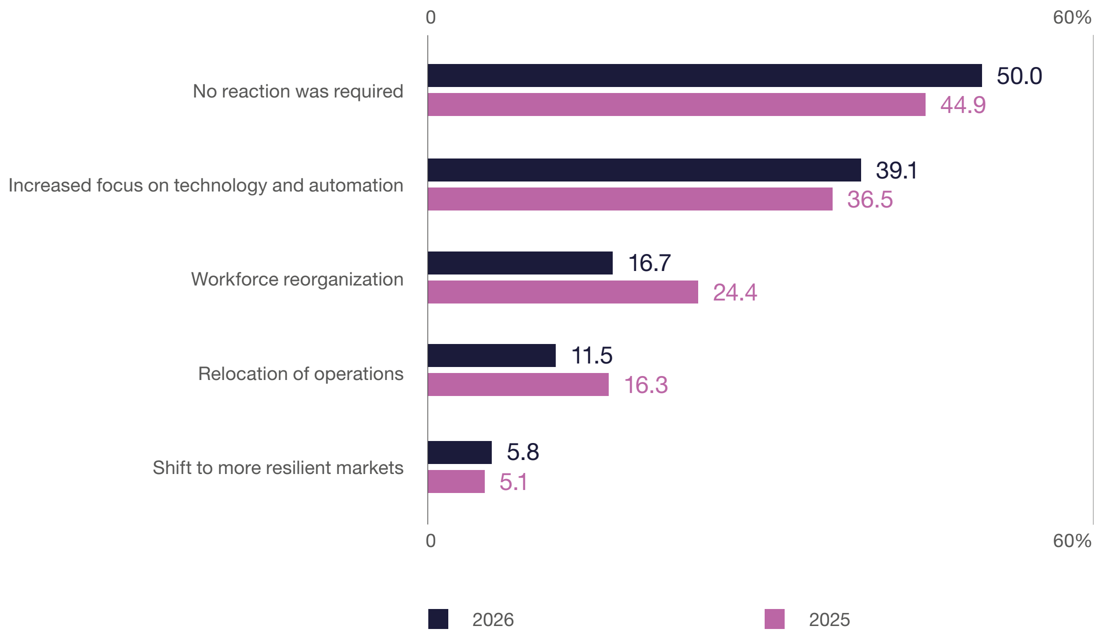
Policy uncertainty, geopolitical tensions, and economic volatility characterize the volatile market and geopolitical environment in which the sector operates. Continuous improvements and adaptive strategies are crucial for maintaining competitiveness and growth capacity.

Half of the respondents (50.0%) reported that no specific reaction was required in response to geopolitical or macroeconomic developments. This share has increased compared with the previous year. Many organizations perceive their current operational models as sufficiently resilient to withstand short-term external shocks.

Among companies that reported taking adaptive measures, **the most common response was an increased focus on technology and automation** (39.1%), reinforcing the **sector's ongoing shift toward digitalization and process optimization as key resilience mechanisms.**

Responses such as workforce reorganization (16.7%) and relocation of operations (11.5%) were reported less frequently than in the previous year. Companies may be relying more on technological and operational adjustments than on **structural changes to their business models.** Only a small proportion of respondents (5.8%) indicated a move toward more resilient markets. **Geographic repositioning is an uncommon response within the sector. The overall level of preparedness is high.**

FIGURE 4.14 | **Adaptations to recent geopolitical and macroeconomic challenges** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=156).

Poland's competitive position

The primary factors for selecting Poland

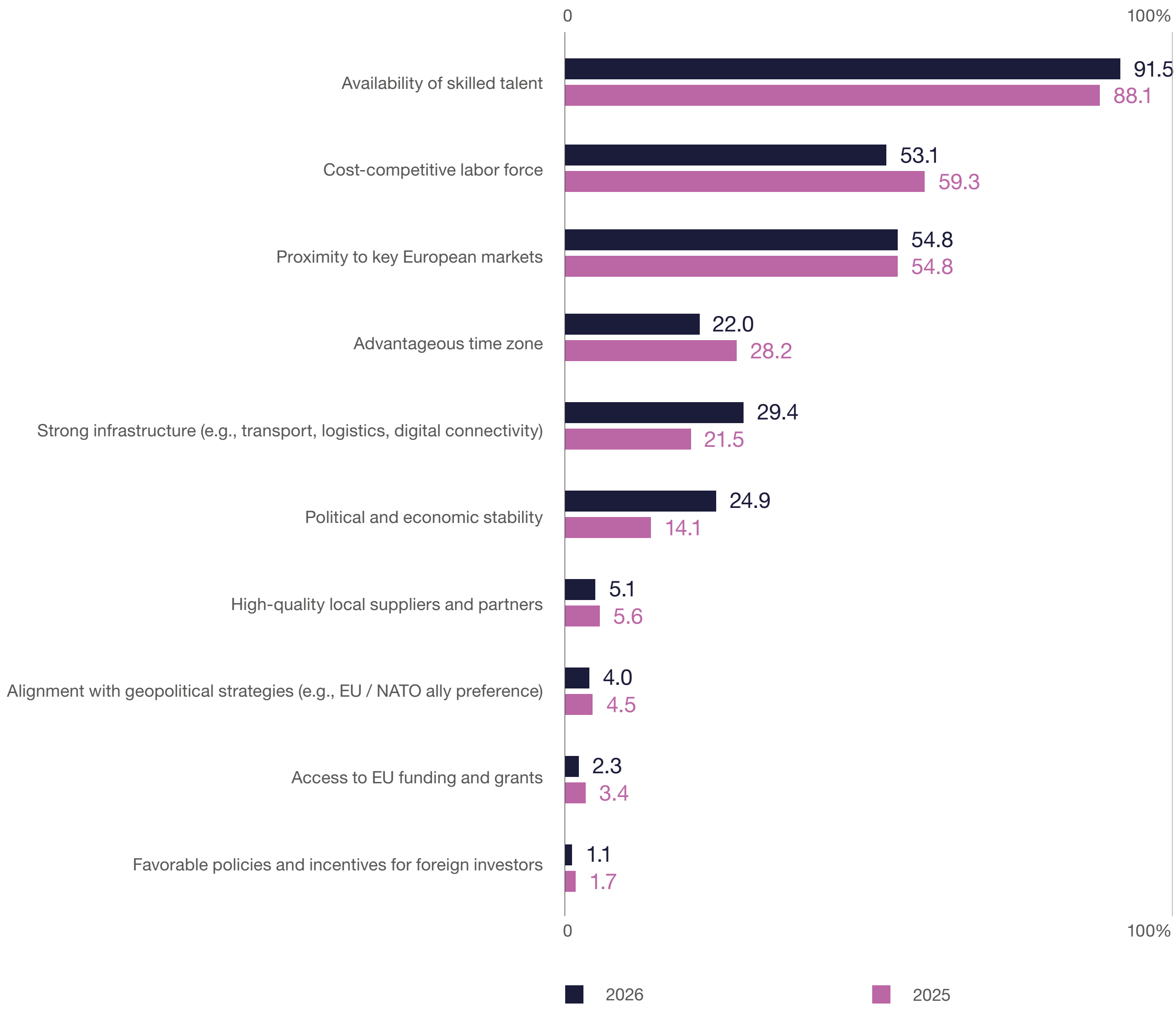
Poland remains a leading business services location, with its strong talent pool cited by 91.5% of firms as the main **factor.** This demonstrates that the sector's competitiveness is based on capabilities. Proximity to major European markets **(54.8%)** also strengthens Poland's position as a **nearshore business services hub within Europe.**

There is a shift toward a value-for-cost approach, as cost competitiveness has declined in importance (down to 53.1%). Poland now competes as a **quality-focused business services platform,** based on skilled talent and stable operations. Institutional factors, such as political and economic stability (24.9%) and infrastructure (29.4%), are also becoming more significant in investment decisions.

Other traditional location factors are losing importance. The relative decline of time zone advantages **(22.0%)** and limited emphasis on policy incentives or EU funding mean that **structural strengths, which are talent, capability, and operational reliability, now dominate the investment case. We could thus argue that Poland's attractiveness is no longer driven by cost arbitrage, but by its ability to deliver skilled talent and stable, high-quality operations.**

The risk is that, as costs rise, this model will require continuous productivity gains and capability upgrades to remain competitive with both offshore and emerging nearshore alternatives.

FIGURE 4.15 **The primary factors that make Poland an attractive destination for the shoring of activities** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=177).

Why Poland?

Proven scale with advanced capabilities & maturity

- One of Europe's largest and most mature business services ecosystems
- Strong presence of GBS/SSC + growing digital, analytics, and AI functions
- Ability to absorb and scale complex, multi-functional operations

Platform for transformation, not just delivery

- Increasing role of centers in automation, digitalization, and AI adoption
- Strong track record in process redesign and global capability building
- Transition toward data-driven and AI-enabled operating models (GenBS)

Talent depth with increasing specialization

- Large, highly educated workforce with strong technical and business skills
- Rapid shift toward more specialized and expert roles (not just transactional work)
- Strong capabilities in IT, finance, analytics, and process transformation

Value-for-cost, not low-cost

- Competitive cost base relative to Western Europe
- Higher productivity and service quality than lower-cost offshore locations
- Attractive "quality-adjusted cost" proposition for complex services

Resilience in a volatile environment

- Centers demonstrate operational continuity despite geopolitical shocks
- Transformation driven by automation and reskilling, not downsizing
- Increasing ability to adapt within global business services networks

Gateway between nearshore and global business services models

- Combines European proximity with global delivery competitiveness
- Positioned between offshore scale (e.g., India) and nearshore alternatives (CEE, Southern Europe)

Strategic location within the EU

- Full access to the EU single market and regulatory framework
- Proximity to major European business hubs
- Time zone alignment supporting real-time collaboration across EMEA

Operational stability and institutional strength

- Stable macroeconomic and regulatory environment within the EU
- Mature infrastructure and well-developed business ecosystem
- Strong integration into global corporate structures and governance

Challenges to Poland's competitive position

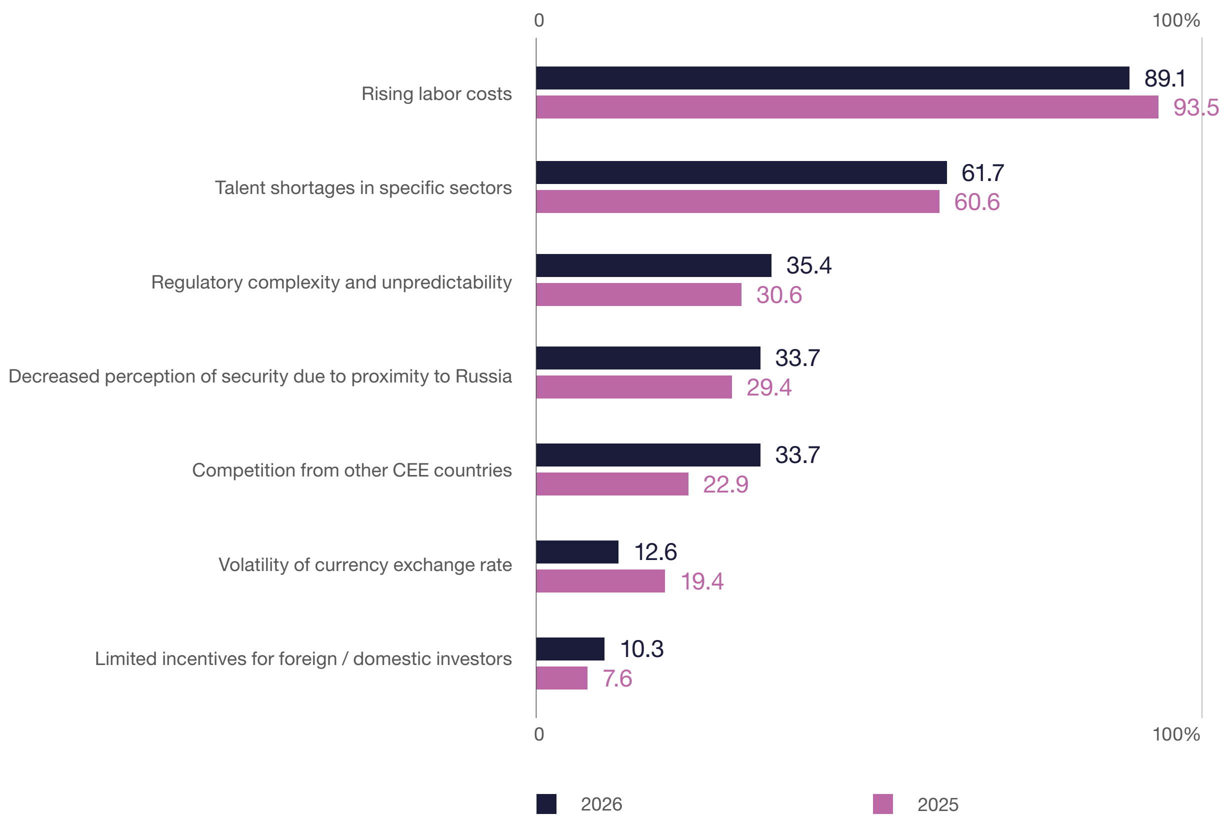
Structural factors play a greater role than cyclical ones in shaping Poland's competitive position. The sector's traditional strength in cost efficiency and standardized processes is exposed, as these activities are **highly mobile in today's global market.** The "comfort zone" noted in earlier ABSL analyses has become a tangible risk. Parts of the model are vulnerable to cost-based competition.

Cost pressure remains the main challenge. 89.1% of firms cite rising labor costs as their top challenge. Talent shortages are also evolving. The issue is now the **availability of advanced, specialized skills** for higher-value services.

Competitive pressure is intensifying. The proportion of firms citing regional competition has risen from 22.9% to 33.7%. Alternative nearshore locations are viable for certain activities. **Regulatory complexity and geopolitical risk** are also emerging as additional challenges, influencing investment decisions and perceptions of location stability.

> Traditional macroeconomic risks, such as exchange rate volatility, become less significant compared to structural factors. Poland's competitiveness now depends more on managing costs, attracting **advanced talent, and maintaining productivity growth than on macro conditions.**

FIGURE 4.16 | **Challenges that could limit Poland's attractiveness for shoring of activities** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=175).

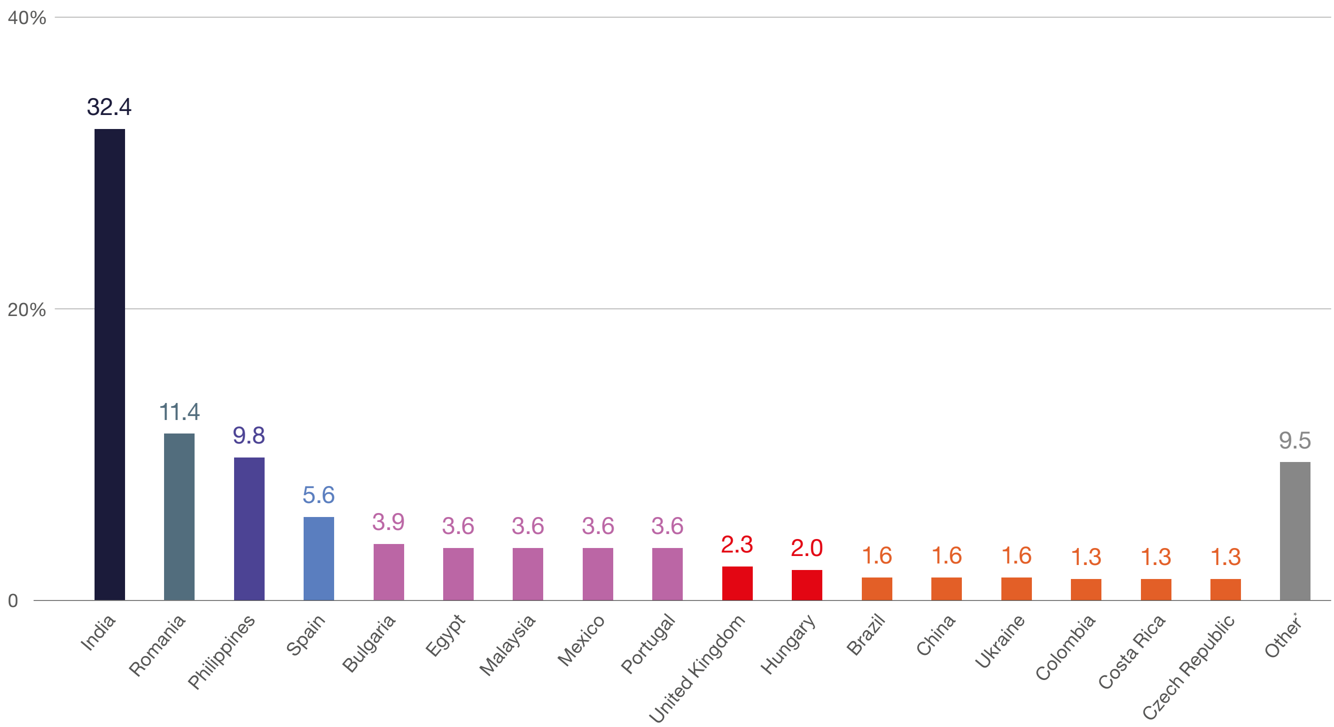
Poland's biggest competitors in attracting business services

The global business services landscape is dynamic. Companies constantly reassess location strategies. Poland registers strong organic growth in existing centers. At the same time, rising labor costs, talent shortages in specific sectors or skill areas, and increasing global competition are gradually reshaping the competitive environment.

When asked to identify Poland's biggest competitors in attracting new business service investments, **respondents once again pointed primarily to large global locations. India remains by far the most frequently mentioned competitor (32.4%). Its position is determined by scale, a mature service ecosystem, and a strong position in global outsourcing networks.** Among European locations, **Romania** has been identified as the strongest regional competitor (11.4%), followed by **Spain** (5.6%) and **Bulgaria** (3.9%).

Several non-European locations were also mentioned relatively frequently, including the **Philippines** (9.8%), **Egypt, Malaysia,** and **Mexico** (each 3.6%). Competition for business service investments is increasingly global. Companies evaluate both nearshore and offshore models.

FIGURE 4.17 | **Poland's biggest competitors in attracting business services** (%)



* Morocco, Serbia, Sri Lanka, United States, South Africa, Albania, Canada, Estonia, France, Germany, Indonesia, Luxembourg, Moldova, Pakistan, Russia, Singapore, Sweden, Tunisia, Turkey, United Arab Emirates

Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=125, number of indications = 306).

ESG imperative

ESG in the sector is **structurally centralized and execution focused. The ABSL 2026 survey shows that 57.3% of centers follow ESG strategies set by global headquarters.** Only **18.7% manage ESG locally,** and **16.7% coordinate at the regional level (CEE/EMEA).** ESG decision-making is **concentrated outside Poland,** with local centers primarily responsible for implementation.

Regulatory changes are reinforcing this model. The introduction of the **CSRD (2023)** standardizes reporting requirements and increases data granularity, shifting ESG from a voluntary or reputational activity to a **compliance-driven operational requirement.** For multinational organizations, this requires **scalable reporting systems,** with business services centers central to data aggregation, validation, and reporting.

From an operating model perspective, ESG is now part of the **data and process infrastructure.** Centers are tasked with **integrating ESG metrics into ERP and HRIS systems.** Ensuring data consistency and supporting auditability is more important than setting sustainability agendas. As a result, ESG in the sector is transitioning from policy to execution. A competitive advantage is based on delivering reliable, standardized ESG data.

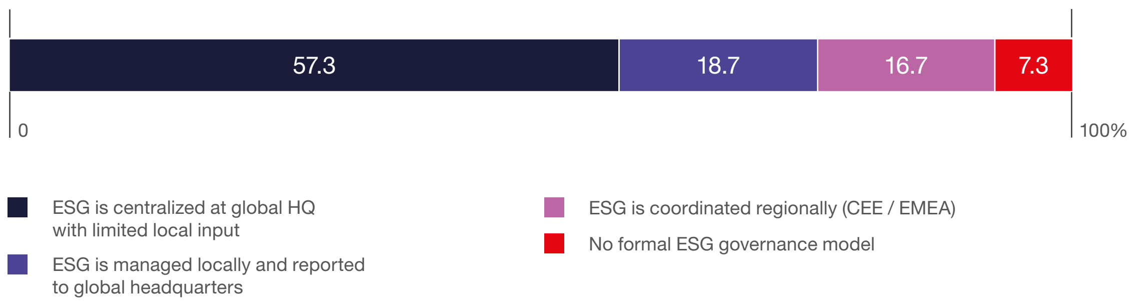
> ESG integration into core operations is still **limited and inconsistent. Although organizations are beginning to incorporate sustainability metrics into dashboards and performance systems, these efforts remain in the early stages and are not yet fully integrated into daily decision-making.** ESG remains an add-on to existing performance frameworks.

Progress is most evident in **data infrastructure.** Currently, 57.6% of organizations use **integrated ESG reporting systems, surpassing those relying on manual processes (25.9%).** There is a move toward system-based reporting. However, only **5.8% use analytics or AI tools** for ESG data management, revealing a gap between **data collection and analytical use.**

The structure of ESG metrics mirrors the sector's operating model. Measurement focuses primarily on workforce **indicators** such as retention, well-being, diversity, and skills, which directly impact productivity and service delivery. Environmental metrics, including energy and carbon, are tracked but remain secondary in performance management. Emerging areas such as AI energy use and **model sustainability receive minimal attention. ESG efforts are currently driven by immediate operational needs instead of long-term environmental goals.**

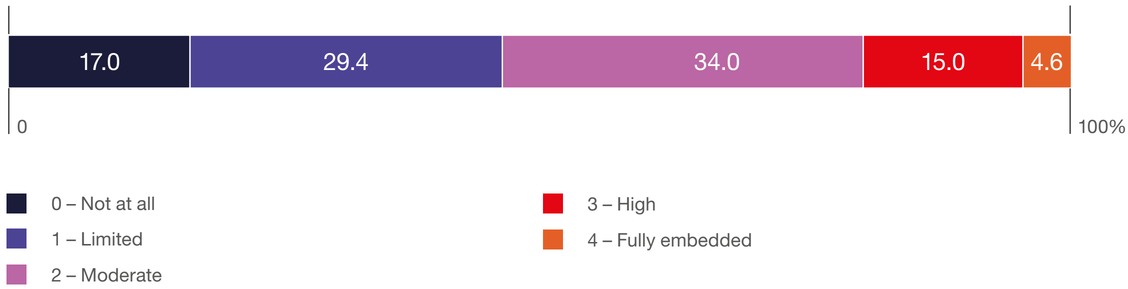
From a CXO perspective, ESG is becoming a data and reporting function rather than a driver of transformation. The main challenge now is integrating ESG into core management systems and decision-making processes, which remain underdeveloped in most organizations.

FIGURE 4.18 | **Company's ESG governance model in Poland** (%)



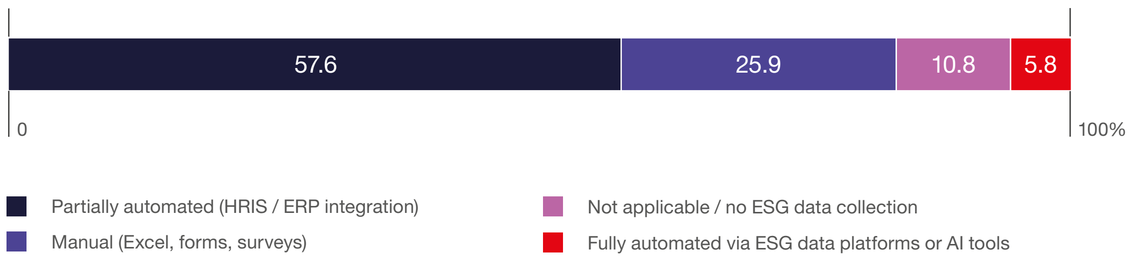
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=150).

FIGURE 4.19 | **Extent of ESG integration into operational KPIs or dashboards** (%)



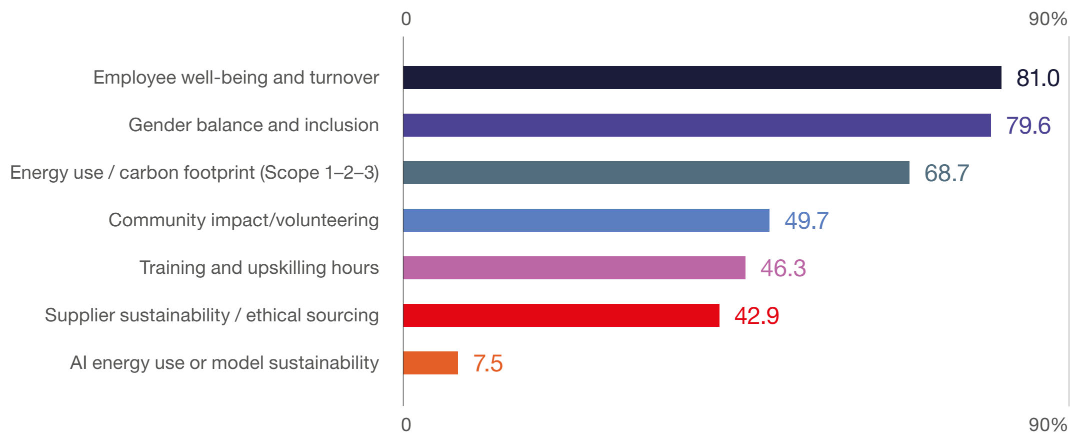
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=153).

FIGURE 4.20 | **ESG data collection and reporting** (%)



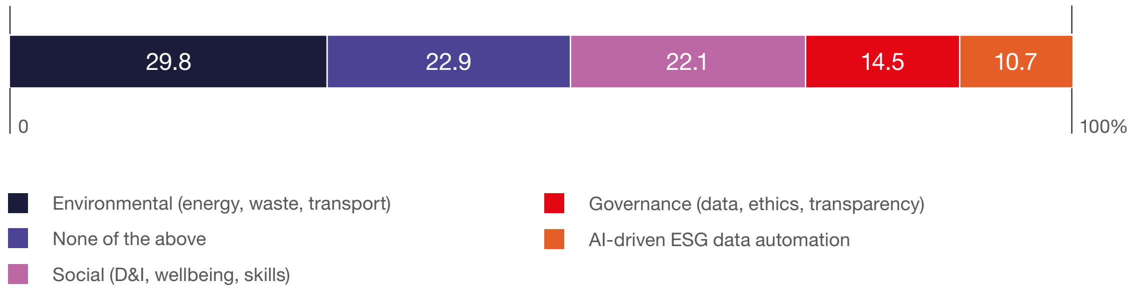
Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=139).

FIGURE 4.21 | **ESG metrics tracked at your center level** (% of respondents)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=147).

FIGURE 4.22 **ESG areas receiving the largest operational investment in 2026-2027** (%)



Source: ABSL 2026 annual survey (N=131).

Summary – key observations on transformation

Chapter 4 demonstrates that Poland's business services sector is experiencing a broad, controlled transformation that is evolutionary in pace and structural in nature. Most centers are expanding the scope of their services and upgrading their capabilities. However, growth is now driven by deeper integration into global networks and the adoption of more complex, knowledge-intensive functions.

The sector is entering a phase of operating model reconfiguration, marked by a gradual but decisive change from traditional, process-driven GBS structures to data-, analytics-, and AI-enabled models. This represents a structural reallocation of value, with 70% of centers expected to move beyond traditional models by 2030. The pace of this transition depends on organizational readiness, integration complexity, and capital allocation.

A structural tension exists between rising costs and productivity gains. While efficiency improvements are widespread, their impact on cost dynamics varies between organizations. This underscores productivity as a key driver of long-term competitiveness. In this context, further automation and digital transformation are essential to maintaining Poland's value proposition.

Innovation is **broad but uneven.** Many organizations are improving processes and services, but few lead in breakthrough innovation. The sector is defined more by **continuous adaptation than by pioneering advancements,** which may limit its ability to capture higher-value segments in the long term.

Despite a complex and volatile environment, the sector shows strong resilience and growing preparedness, continuing to adapt through transformation. Organizations are prioritizing automation, reskilling, and capability upgrades over downsizing or relocation. However, as more firms report no need for major adjustments, this perceived resilience may also raise concerns about the speed and depth of their response to structural changes.

Poland's competitive position is shifting from a **cost-based advantage to a value-for-cost model,** supported by skilled talent, strong capabilities, and integration with European markets. However, rising costs, talent shortages, and increasing global competition are putting pressure on this position. Competitiveness now depends less on cost differentials and more on **delivering productivity gains, advanced capabilities, and effective AI integration.**

The sector is in a **strategic transition phase.** Transformation is now an ongoing necessity. The main challenge is whether organizations can **accelerate the transition to advanced operating models, overcome internal bottlenecks, and achieve productivity gains that outpace cost growth.** The outcome will determine whether Poland strengthens its position as a high-value platform or loses ground globally.

The sector is no longer defined by cost alone, but increasingly by capabilities, productivity, and the ability to scale advanced services. We deliver value in complex processes and functions, maintaining a clear advantage over major competitors.

Poland operates today at full European scale, with a strong, well-organized business services system and a growing base of high-value capabilities. This creates a solid foundation for the next phase of development.

The strategic direction is unambiguous. It translates into strengthening capability depth, integrating AI into core operating models, and expanding toward more advanced, outcome-driven services.

The transformation is already underway. The question is not whether it will happen, but how fast and how effectively it will be executed.

Polish Investment
& Trade Agency
PFR Group

The Polish Investment and Trade Agency (PAIH) is an advisory institution within the Polish Development Fund Group (PFR) and serves as the first point of contact for exporters and investors seeking to expand internationally or develop operations in Poland.

We support entrepreneurs and business partners both from our headquarters in Warsaw and through a network of regional offices operating across the country. PAIH also maintains a global presence through dozens of Foreign Trade Offices located in key markets worldwide. Our mission is to strengthen the brand of the Polish economy, enhance the international recognition of Polish companies, support the global expansion of domestic enterprises, and facilitate the inflow of foreign direct investment into Poland.

PAIH supports investors considering the development of their operations in Poland by providing comprehensive assistance throughout the entire investment process. We offer guidance covering the key operational and strategic aspects of establishing and expanding investments on the Polish market.

We also help investors navigate the specifics of the Polish business environment by connecting them with potential business partners. This is supported by our extensive network of relationships with chambers of commerce, public institutions, industry associations, and business support organizations representing both modern services and technology sectors, as well as more traditional industries.

Our support also extends to companies already operating in Poland. PAIH acts as an advocate for investors, assisting businesses in addressing ongoing operational matters and challenges related to conducting business activities on the Polish market.

Our services include:

- location advisory,
- information and guidance on available investment incentives,
- preparation of market data packages,
- support in establishing business partnerships,
- organization of site visits,
- facilitation of contacts with central and local government authorities,
- aftercare services.

Our services are fully tailored to investors' individual needs and provided entirely free of charge.

In 2025, PAIH supported 64 investment projects with a combined value exceeding EUR 4 billion and a declared employment impact of 6,600 new jobs. Among them were 22 business services sector projects valued at EUR 400 million, with the planned creation of 3,700 jobs.

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